

THE

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MOTION PICTURE

FILMING TECHNIQUES

JOSEPH V. MASCELLI

CONTENTS

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CAMERA ANGLES 11

CONTINUITY . 67

CUTTING . . 147

CLOSE-UPS . 173

COMPOSITION 197

INDEX . 245

CREDITS. . . 250

INTRODUCTION

BY

ARTHUR C. MILLER, A.S.C

While production of motion pictures has changed considerably since I photographed *The Perils of Pauline* in 1914, some aspects - particularly those involving story telling - are still the same as they were half a century ago.

Motion pictures are faster paced for today's more sophisticated audiences. Television dramas now introduce the characters, set the scene and establish story line in a few minutes. To accomplish this, early films took a reel or more. Today's uses of the moving camera - especially helicopter shots - and wide-screen formats permit more continuous filming with fewer editorial cuts. Modern filming trends are moving away from the artificial effects, and toward more natural lighting and camera treatment, involving the audience more deeply with the screen story. That is good! Motion picture production was vastly different in 1908, when it was my good fortune as a boy of 14 to become assistant - or "camera boy" as he was then called - to Fred J. Balshofer, a pioneer motion picture producer, director and cameraman. Mr. Balshofer initiated many filming techniques - such as strict adherence to directional continuity - which

have become accepted production standards. The following year I went to work for Edwin S. Porter - who in 1903 had produced what is now considered the first story film - The Great Train Robbery. Early audiences recognized these story pictures as resembling stage plays - because of their continuity, which was a great advance over the animated movie snapshots presented until then.

This year marks the golden anniversary of the release of The Birth of a Nation, produced and directed by D. W. Griffith, the acknowledged originator of screen syntax - as we now know it.

Yet, despite the influence on cinematographers everywhere exerted by these outstanding pioneers - and by many competent cinematographers and directors of today and yesterday - not one of these masters of our

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craft has ever written in clear words just how the camera can be used to greater advantage in recording screen stories. The only way to learn to shoot better pictures was to serve an apprenticeship under a competent teacher - or to study films and try to figure out how they were made.

To my knowledge this is the first book that has attempted to translate the many intangibles of film making into definitive explanations. In my opinion, no one is more qualified to write this book than Joe Mascelli. Mascelli is a rarity. He combines the wide experience of a working camera man - who films both theatrical and non-theatrical pictures - with a vast knowledge of all phases of motion picture production, along with the desire to instruct and inspire. He is an astute student of motion picture

history - particularly cinematography - and has researched, studied and analyzed the work of motion picture photographers, from Billy Bitzer to Leon Shamroy. He has the unique ability to clarify shooting techniques for those who find the complexities of motion picture production mystifying. I believe that this book will be truly valuable to cinematographers of limited experience, and particularly to students studying motion picture production. By understanding and applying the principles presented in this book, the reader will be able to visualize a story in motion picture terms. For, above all, it is the power of visualization that makes the successful cinematographer.

Reading the script of THE FIVE C's was for me both interesting and thought provoking. I hope you find this book as stimulating and informative as I have.

PROLOGUE

In 1928, when Eastman Kodak introduced 16mm Kodacolor - a well known physicist remarked: "It's impossible - but not quite!~

On many occasions during the years devoted to preparation and writing of this book, I have felt that defining, explaining, clarifying and graphically illustrating motion picture filming techniques in an easy-to-understand way - is impossible - but not quite.

Most professionals instinctively know the right way to film the subject - but seem unable to explain just how they do it. They have learned what not to do, either from past experience or by serving as apprentices under capable technicians. However - although they are employing the rules constantly - few can explain the rules by which motion pictures are filmed.

Many cameramen - particularly those shooting non-theatrical pictures - become so involved in the technical aspects of movie making that they tend to forget that the primary purpose of a motion picture is to tell an interesting story! There is much more to shooting motion pictures than threading a roll of film in a camera, and exposing the picture correctly.

The aims of this book are to make the reader aware of the many factors involved in telling a story with film. and to show how theatrical filming techniques can be successfully applied to non-theatrical pictures. There is no need for tremendous budgets to shoot a motion picture properly! The same professional rules may be successfully applied to a docu

mentary film report.

The definitions, rules and recommendations in this book are not meant to be absolute. Most of these precepts have gradually developed through the years, and have become routine procedures. In a few cases, I have had to discover the hidden rule by which certain types of filming is accomplished. I have also had to invent names - such as Action Analysis and Triple Take Technique - for definition and explanation of shooting methods. The production of a motion picture, particularly a non-theatrical film, can be a highly personal undertaking. It is up to the individual to accept, change or twist the rule to fit his particular purpose. Filming methods are continuously changing. The so-called "new wave" has shattered many established techniques - with some success. The coming generations of film makers may find some of today's standard filming methods stifling, and even obsolete. Film production can use changes - but they should be changes for the better. Changes that involve the audience more deeply in the screen story are constructive and always welcome.

It is important, however, that ambitious movie makers first learn the rules before breaking them. Learn the right way to film, learn the acceptable methods, learn how audiences become involved in the screen story and what viewers have been conditioned to accept through years of movie going. Experiment; be bold; shoot in an unorthodox fashion! But, first learn the correct way. don't simply do it a "new" way - which, very likely, was new thirty years ago! - because of a lack of knowledge of proper filming techniques.

Learn to know your audience. Place yourself in the viewer's position.

Be truly objective in judging a new method or idea. Try it. If it plays _ if it is acceptable - and the audience comprehends and enjoys it - use it. If it simply confuses, teases or even distracts the audience from the narrative - discard it!

Experiences in both theatrical and non-theatrical film making has led me to the conclusion that the documentary - in-plant, military, industrial and educational- cameraman working with a small crew, often on remote locations, without a detailed script or other benefits of a studio production department, must have knowledge and experience reaching far beyond that of a technical nature. He must often act as a cameraman/director

and later edit his own film. His work may cover everything from conceiving and producing the picture - to putting it on the screen!

This book will, I sincerely hope, provide such individuals with greater insight into the many ways in which a movie narrative may be filmed _ with the assurance that the picture can be edited into an interesting, coherent, smooth-flowing screen story.

The serious student should also consider a sixth "C" - Cheating _ which can not be learned from this or any other book! Cheating is the art of rearranging people, objects or actions, during filming or editing, so that the screen effect is enhanced. Only experience will teach the camera man and film editor when and how to cheat. The secret of effective cheating is in knowing how to make changes without the audience being aware of the cheat. The only crime in cheating is in getting caught! A player's height may be cheated higher in a two-shot; or the corner of a lamp may be cheated out of a close-up; or portions of the event may be cheated out of the final edited picture- for a better screen result. The beginner may be either afraid to cheat, or he may cheat too much. The experienced technician knows exactly how far cheating can be carried before the viewer is aware of a change.

This volume is not intended to be a means to an end - but a beginning! My purpose is to make you aware of the many facets of movie making. With that attitude you may analyze any filming situation, and decide on the best procedures for the shooting job at hand. What I hope to do is help you think about motion picture production professionally!

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CAMERA ANGLES

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INTRODUCTION

the prerogative of choosing his own angles in

A motion picture is made up of many shots. accordance with his interpretation of the script.

Each shot requires placing the camera in the best position for viewing players, setting and action at he who usually makes final decision on viewpoint that particular moment in the narrative. Position and area, based on the director's wishes. Directors in the camera - the camera angle - is influenced vary in their approach to the camera angle ques by several factors. Solutions to many problems in tion: many will leave the final decision up to the • volving choice of camera angles may be reached cameraman once their request is made. Others [by thoughtful analysis of story requirements. With may be more camera-oriented and work more experience, decisions can be made almost intuitively. The camera angle determines both precise camera placement for each shot.

When shooting from script, the non-theatrical time the camera is moved to a new set-up, two cameraman and director may work in the same questions must be answered: What is the best manner. If working alone, however, the camera viewpoint for filming this portion of the event? man must call his own shots. When shooting documentary films off-the-cuff, he has the further A carefully-chosen camera angle can heighten responsibility of breaking down the event into dramatic visualization of the story. A carelessly individual shots, and deciding the type of shot picked camera angle may distract or confuse the required for each portion of the action. In either audience by depicting the scene so that its meaning, the experience of the cameraman, his knowing is difficult to comprehend. Therefore, selection edge of the problems and his visual imagination, of camera angles is a most important factor in will strongly influence the choice of camera angle.

constructing a picture of continued interest. Both theatrical and non-theatrical film makers

In most instances, theatrical film scripts designate type of shot required for each scene in a "story board" - a series of sketches of key incidents which suggest camera angle, camera and scripts in which all action and dialogue in an player movement, and compositional treatment. entire sequence is presented - but camera angles These sketches may be very simple - the merest are not indicated. In either case, the director has outlines; or very elaborate - in the case of high

II

CAMERA ANGLES THE FIVE C's

Theatrical film scripts designate type of shot required for each scene in a sequence.

Production designer may . . . sketches that suggest how camera will

be placed and moved. Director of photography is responsible for precise placement of camera.

budget theatrical films ~ in which detailed color from one player to another, as dramatic emphasis renderings of the scenes are closely followed by changes during a scene; travel alongside a galloping horseman as he escapes pursuers; move into a scene. A screen story is a series of continuous dramatic scenes, as story interest heightens; move changing images which portray events from a faraway from gruesome setting depicting death and variety of viewpoints. Choice of camera angle can destruction; see otherwise unseen microscopic position the audience closer to the action to view world; observe the earth from a satellite in orbit. a significant portion in a large close-up; farther The audience may be positioned anywhere away to appreciate the magnificent grandeur of a landscape to view anything from any angle - at the vast landscape; high to look down upon a vast expanse of the cameraman and film editor. Such construction project; lower to look up at the face is the power of the motion picture! Such is the of a judge. Camera angle can shift viewpoint importance of choosing the right camera angle!

12

THE FIVE C's CAMERA ANGLES

sequence may begin or end with a fade or dissolve; or it may be straight-cut with bracketing sequences.

Confusion arises when the terms scene and shot are used interchangeably. Individual shots in a script are referred to as scenes. But, a master scene script would require a number of shots to film the entire event. In such cases, a single scene number may be used and the shots designated by letters a, b, c, etc. While production personnel may consider a single take as a shot, they refer to the shot by scene number. For practical purposes, therefore, scene and shot are generally interchangeable.

A shot - or a portion of a shot - is also referred to as a cut. This term is derived from a portion of a shot which is cut out and used separately.

ing event into individual shots, and decid

ing type of shot (or each portion of action. such as a cut of a player's silent reaction removed

Knowledge of editorial requirements is valuable from a dialogue sequence.

uable when filming without a script.

TYPES OF CAMERA ANGLES

SCENE, SHOT & SEQUENCE OBJECTIVE

The terms scene, shot and sequence are some SUBJECTIVE

POINT-OF-VIEW

times misunderstood.

Scene defines the place or setting where the

OBJECTIVE CAMERA ANGLES

action is laid. This expression is borrowed from

The objective camera films from a sideline

stage productions, where an act may be divided

viewpoint. The audience views the event through

into several scenes, each of which is set in a

different locale. A scene may consist of one shot or

series of shots depicting a continuous event.

Shot defines a continuous view filmed by one

camera without interruption. Each shot is a take.

When additional shots of the same action are

filmed from the same set-up - because of tech

nical or dramatic mistakes - the subsequent shots

are called re-takes. If the set-up is changed in any

way - camera moved, lens changed, or different

action filmed - it is a new shot, not a re-take.

A sequence is a series of scenes, or shots, com

plete in itself. A sequence may occur in a single

setting, or in several settings. Action should match

in a sequence whenever it continues across sev

eral consecutive shots with straight cuts - so that

it depicts the event in a continuous manner, as in

This documentary shot - depicting con

real life. A sequence may begin as an exterior

struction of a freeway - is filmed from

scene, and continue inside a building, as the play

objective camera angle, sometimes refer

ers enter and settle down to talk or perform. A red to as "audience point of view."

13

CAMERA ANGLES

THE FIVE C's

theeyesofanunseen~a, sgemdrop

ping. Cammamen and directors 5ametimes refer

to this candid amma treatment as the adience

point of view. Since they do not present the event

horn the viewpoint of anyone within the scerle,

objective camera angles ax jxnpsrsonal. People

photographed appear unaware of the camera and

never look directly hto the lens. Should a player

look inadvertently into the lens, even with a side

ways glance, the same must be retaken -if objee

tive angle is maintained. Most m o m @m-

m e sa re Hmed hnn ubjedw camera a @ ~ .

S U B J E m W R A A N G L E S

The

audience parlidph fn the screen

exphmce. The viewer fs

placed in the picture, either on his own as an.

active participant, or by trading places with a per-

son in the picture and seeing the event through

his eyes. The viewer is also involved in the picture

when anyone in the scene boks directly kto the

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camera lens thus estddishing a pdrmer-

viewer eye-beye relationship. jlnnPj: leap ov& a fkF ' - ~ :j.i&-,

The subjecdve camera may -film the event ln pe- ram; j* +&-.&.a horse

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the fdhdag ways : ace.; fan d* a &quitah m go for a quiet

The cumera acts as the eyes of the audkm #a s.ldLint he park;-

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fies. When subjective .&Q& previously descrilh

are .preceded by ac1osetup d a pmoa lqokfng OR-

Cansera may act as eye of audience to screen, .the viewer will comprehend &at he is

place viewer aboard ahplane, If shot is

seeing what iih sawn playm sees. The shae,itsdf

preceded bg close-up of person hung out

- may & - w e d fn.pneci&i* same--warmer,b ut

win- viava udll~cmpehendth at he

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is seeing whut screen phgm ees. the-viewer is no longer cm .his own be has

CAMERA ANGLES

THEFIVEC's

traded positions with the on-screen player to view

the event as he sees it.

If an airplane pilot, jockey or mountain climber

is established in the scene, the following subjec

tive shot is what that person sees. The spectator

may experience the same sensations, because he

is seeing the scene through screen player's eyes.

In the Following examples, the subjective shots

will be the same _ providing the viewer is looking

at inanimate objects, empty settings, or events in

which people in the picture do lIOt relate directly

with the camera. A clock on the wall. an unoccu

pied room, an action ride, or people in the park

will all appear the same, regardless of whether

the viewer sees the scene directly, or through the

Tile scene following drat of an individual

eyes of a person in the picture.The thrilling mov

looking ott-screen will be interpreted by

ing camera ride is alw(/y.~ subjective, but static audience as what tluu: person sees. Tile

shots may be objective or subjective.,1 according to mall al,ove is looking up - at a building

the way they are edited. The clock, the room, or filmed from his point-of-view. Upward or the park scene may be interpreted as objective, downward points of view of a player may be simulated by similar camera angling.

unless a close-up of a player is shown looking off-screen. The audience will then understand that what they see is what the player sees in the scene.

It is a common mistake to think that

the camera

is

the same

as the player

is.

Difficulties do arise, however, when the camera replaces a player who must relate with other

Viewer may trade places with person in players in the scene. Whenever other players in picture if shot above is followed by point the scene look into the eyes of the subjective of-view shot of Operation. P.o.v. shots are player they must look directly into the lens.

best for training films because they place

The unexpected appearance of a player looking viewers in workers' positions.

directly into the lens startles the audience, be

Few shooting or editing problems are encountered because they suddenly become aware of the camera.

tered when a subjective shot is inserted in an It is as if the people being filmed detected the objective sequence; whether or not a person, with eavesdropping camera. Such treatment can prove whom the audience can identify is shown. very distracting, and may disrupt the story-telling.

15

CAMERA ANGLES

THE FIVE C's

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"Lady In The Lake" used subjective cam The audience is shocked when it is abruptly era, which traded place with detective switched from an unseen observer outside the window. He was seen by audience only when picture (looking at players who are seemingly introduced, and when reflected in mirrors.

unaware of the camera's presence), to a participant in the picture (directly relating with the players). The viewer may want to become emotionally involved in the story, but he may be uncomfortably surprised when required to become actively involved with the players!

A sudden switch from an objective to a subjective look-into-the-lens shot is startling in a dramatic film because the audience is unprepared for such treatment. Viewers cannot immediately adjust to active participation in the event. When the camera returns to objective filming, the audience will again have to re-orient itself. The subjective treatment is rarely successful when the audience is asked abruptly to trade places with a

16

THE FIVE C's CAMERA ANGLES

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player, with all the other performers in the scene. Entire cast had to look directly into lens looking directly at him. whenever relating with hero. The audience did not see Nero's reactions. Only his voice. If an entire sequence, or a complete picture is filmed subjectively, other difficulties arise. Since the camera replaces the player, it must behave like the player, and see what he sees through his eyes at all times. This necessitates continuous filming with a mobile camera, which looks about as the player moves. sits, stands or looks at another player. Normal editing techniques may not be used, because filming cannot be interrupted. The subjective player may be introduced in an objective shot; but when the camera replaces him,

the audience must view everything subjectively, as he sees it. While the person of the subjective player is no longer seen, his reflection may be visible in a mirror, a window or a pool of water. The camera must move to simulate the player's movements.

CAMERA ANGLES

THE FIVE C's

ments as he walks around. The player (camera) may enter a room, look about, sit down, converse with another player, look at his own hand lighting a cigarette, look down at an ash tray, turn his head to look at a ringing telephone. get up and walk out. The player, or players, in the scene must look directly into the lens when looking into the subjective player's eyes during dialogue exchanges, or otherwise relating with him.

Subjective camera is employed on rare occasions in dramatic theatrical feature films. In "Ship of Fools" narrator-player (at right above) relates with a fellow player; and directly with the audience below, to comment on story.

When heroine made love to hero- she had to perform with the camera lens!

The result of this continuous filming treatment is a great deal of useless footage between significant actions - which often cannot be edited out because continuity would be disrupted. Subjective player technique used in an entire theatrical picture, usually results in a dull effect, because it eliminates the player's face and does not show his reactions to other player's dialogue or actions. The audience is teased because they actually see only half of the normal interchange between players. player is mentally or otherwise unbalanced be

While subjective treatment may be interesting in case of drinks, drugs or illness. The audience the beginning, it becomes boring, if extended. will understand, in such cases, that the player. There are a few exceptions to the no-editing receives impressions, rather than a continuous rule. These permit orthodox editing of a subjective clear picture, of what is happening. The subjective sequence whenever the subjective player recalls the player may. therefore, see events through his an event in a flashback. Subjective flashbacks mind's eye as a series of individual images, in may be presented in fragmented fashion, because instead of a continuous happening. a person telling a story need relate only significant. Normal editing may be employed in these in highlights, not every single move or action. A substance, rather than continuous camera filming subjective sequence may also be edited whenever otherwise required. A direct cut may be made to a

18

THE FIVE C's CAMERA ANGLES

ringing telephone, rather than a pan to simulate the viewer personally. The narrator in a television a head turning. A series of related or unrelated or documentary film may step into the foreground, images, sharp or distorted, may be shown as while the event transpires behind him, to explain individual subjective shots, rather than as a consequence of what is happening. He may interview people in continuous unbroken scene. involved, or simply step out of the picture and let Subjective sequences, which may be edited, can the event proceed. The players in this case perhaps be successfully inserted in objectively-filmed picture as if the narrator were not present - unless features if they are properly introduced, so that they are called for an interview. A further refinement audience comprehends what is going on. Such mention of this technique presents the performers scenes will work better with inanimate objects, "frozen" in their positions - perhaps in silhouette empty settings or other scenes not involving live - when the scene opens. They hold their attitudes players. A story told in flashback may show an while the narrator introduces the story. when he old house, a climb up a staircase, entry into a walks off, they come to life. They may freeze room and the discovery of a body. This would be again at the end, if an epilogue is presented. A excellent if treated subjectively, because it does variation may be used in which one of the players not show other players who would have to look comes forward to introduce the story. He may into the lens to relate with the subjective player. also step forward at intervals to recap what is Into-the-lens subjective filming should be reserved happening; and then rejoin his fellow players and for mentally-unbalanced sequences to involve the continue with the performance. viewer more closely with the subjective player's condition. These will be more effective if distorted, blurred, or shaken. A fight sequence could be very effective because the audience would - in

a sense - receive blows, and fall down and look up into the lights, etc.

The camera act., > as the eye of the unseen audience. A person on-screen looks into the lens to set up a performer-viewer eye-to-eye relationship. A typical example is the television newscaster who speaks directly into the lens. Eye contact creates a personal relationship between performer and viewer, because each is looking directly at the other. This treatment evolved from radio broadcasting, in which the announcer speaks directly to the listener. Camera may act as eye of unseen audience. A personal relationship may be set up in a scene. Newscaster looks directly into lens to set up performer-viewer eye-to-eye relationship. In a dramatic film by having the narrator, or a person on-screen, step forward, look directly into the lens. In a motion picture or television screen is used to introduce the event, the players or the setting; speaking directly to him. This subjective treatment is used to explain or interpret what is happening. This treatment is ideal for documentary films. It generally works best at beginning and end of a scene whenever a personal relationship between person on screen and viewer is desirable. Or, the story may be interrupted at intervals to sum up what has transpired, or to introduce a new story element. Such subjective treatment lends itself equally well to mysteries, historical documentaries, modern news stories, industrial or military subjects. The man or woman promoting the sponsor's product in a television commercial speaks directly into the lens for greater attention, and to attract the viewer. The weird happenings in an ancient castle may be described by the old caretaker, who then exits.

19

CAMERA ANGLES

THE FIVE C's

the scene as the players enact the drama. On behalf of the audience. A company president, a general in battle may be interviewed in a close-up space. A scientist, a test pilot, a man) all be interviewed there treatment. Current events may present eye during their work, and speak directly to the witnesses, who tell their stories directly to the audience.

television audience. An automotive engineer may When filming news interviews, care should be relate his experience in developing a new car. An taken to prevent the doubt-too, in which the astronaut may look directly into the lens, and person being questioned shifts his look back and describe his feelings while orbiting the earth in a space capsule.

An off-screen narrator taking the audience for a typical tour of a factory may logically stop a worker on an assembly line, and question him in

Look into lens may be better handled if reporter and person being interviewed are filmed over-the-shoulder, After introduction, camera may Cut - or zoom in - to close-up of individual looking into lens as

Television interviews Should avoid the following: questioned: by off-screen reporter, "double-look" - at both interviewer and Opening remarks of reporter - when both camera looks. Person being interviewed arc look at each other - may be filmed should look at reporter, or directly later in a point-of-view close-up without looking into lens as soon as introduced. Back-and-forth need for interviewee. This is a time-saver for both looks (very distracting). When interviewing very important persons.

20

CAMERA ANGLES

THE FIVE C's

Look from interviewer to camera lens. The subjective effect inserted in an otherwise objectively filmed picture is weakened when audience attention is startled, because the players in the picture are divided. The viewer is distracted whenever there is suddenly looking at the lens. A sequence, the interviewee looks back and forth. The person or an entire picture, filmed in this manner can be very annoying to audience. Its successful use in a dramatic motion picture should be limited to flashbacks or special effects. The subjective camera is, of course, properly rehearsed. The look-into-the-lens is most effective whenever orthodox editing, rather than continuous filming, can be employed. The interviewee should be positioned for an over-the-shoulder shot. The Subjective shots from the audience viewpoint, camera may employ a zoom lens, which may in which the camera acts as the collective eye of the audience, can be successfully used in both dramatic and non-dramatic films in a variety of

remain off-screen at the side of the camera, and ways. The subjective treatment is excellent when direct his questions so that the person answering ever the camera performs as a participant in an may speak more easily into the lens. Two-shots, event to place the viewer in-the-picture. Such in which reporter-intervtcwcc face each other in shots may be inserted intoobjectively-filmed se profile and sneak glances at the lens now and quences, because the viewer trades places with then, should always be avoided! the performer momentarily, or employs the cam
To sum lip the eubicctioe camera: era lens as his own personal eye - and the people
Its employment from a particular player's view in the picture do not look into the lens.This is the point, in which the viewer is asked to trade places important difference that makes the audience with the screen performer, and relate with other viewpoint shot acceptable, and the particular players, is questionable. An occasional shot of this playcr viewpoint, in which the other players look at the lens,nnacceptahte.

While subjective shots in which the camera takes the place of an unseen audience have lim ited usc in theatrical films, they offer opportuni ties for experimenting in non-theatrical and tele vision films. Use of subjective shots for news events and documentaries is successful because it brings the key persons into direct relationship with the viewer, on a person-to-person basis.

The subjective camera must be employed with discretion, or it may shock or intrude on the audi ence in a way that will destroy their emotional attraction to the subject. Properly employed, how ever, this technique may result in greater audi ence involvement because of added personal rela tionship it sets up. Agreat deal of careful thought

Scenic shot may he ohjective or subjective should be given switches -from objective to sub - according to way sequence is edited. If jective filming, particularly if the camera replaces presented alone, scene will be seen subjec a player in the picture. No difficulty will be en tively by viewer through camera lens act countered with subjective shots where the rela ing as his eyes. If scene is preceded by a tionship is between a newscaster, an interviewee close-upofplayerlooking off-screen,viewer or a performer and viewer; or where the camera

will accept its point-of-view shot and see

scene objectively from player's viewpoint. acts as the collective eye of the audience.

21

CAMERA ANGLES

THE FIVE C's

POINT-OF-VIEW CAMERA ANGLES the off-screen player. The viewer does not see the event through the player's eyes, as in a subjective

Point-of-view, or simply p.o.v., camera angles

shot in which the camera trades places with the

record the scene from a particular player's view

screen player. He sees the event from the player's

point. The point-of-view is an objective angle, but

viewpoint, as if standing alongside him. Thus,

since it falls between the objective and subjective

the camera angle remains objective, since it is an

angle, it should be placed in a separate category

unseen observer not involved in the action. An

and given special consideration.

on-screen player looking at the player whose view

A point-of-view shot is as close as an objective

point is depicted, looks slightly to the side of the

shot can approach a subjective shot - and still

camera - not into the lens.

remain objective. The camera is positioned at the

side of a subjective player - whose viewpoint is Point-of-view shots may be used whenever it is

being depicted - so that the audience is given the desirable to involve the viewer more closely with

impression they are standing cheek-to-cheek with the event. The audience steps into the picture, so

to speak, and sees the players and the setting from

the viewpoint of a particular player - by standing

beside him. This creates a stronger identity with

the screen player in the action, and provides the

viewer with a more intimate glimpse of the event.

Point-of-view shots often follow over-the-shoulder

shots, when a pair of players face each other

and exchange dialogue. The over-the-shoulder

shot sets up the relationship between the two players, and the p.o.v. shot moves the audience into the player's position. Each player may be seen from the opposing player's point-of-view.

Any shot may become a point-of-view shot if it is preceded with a shot of a player looking off screen. The audience will accept the following shot as being from the player's viewpoint. The

An over-the-shoulder close-up prepares the audience for point-of-view close-up. Audience players, an object, a distant scene, a vehicle, etc. sees each player from the other player's

Thus, an objective shot, which is - in essence point of view.

the audience's own point of view, may become the point of view of a particular player by inserting a close-up of the player looking off-screen. Anyone in the scene who looks at the player must look slightly to one side of the camera (which side is dependent upon the action axis drawn from the off-screen player to the on-screen performer).

It is easier for the audience to identify with the hero in a dramatic picture, or the reporter/narrator in a documentary film, if viewers see people and objects as the screen player sees them, rather than as a bystander on the sidelines. Objective camera treatment is maintained in point-of-view shots, so that the audience is never startled - as in subjective shots, where the other players look

22

CAMERA ANGLES

THE FIVE C's

Viewer may interpret above scene - of aerial tanker boom making connection
of mid-air refueling - as either subjective or point-of-view shot. This shot is subjective, because viewer is made to feel that he is in boom operator's vicarious position, performing the task. It would be a p.o.v. shot if preceded by a close-up

of the operator looking off-screen. Subjective and point-of-view shots involve audience more intimately with event than do objective scenes.

directly into the lens. Yet, the event is presented because a person cannot see himself as he looks in an intimate manner, because it is seen from a point-of-view shot be particular player's viewpoint. Switching back and comes a straight objective shot, as soon as the forth from objective to point-of-view camera an player is included.

glances not jarring because both angles are actually objective. Don't have a player point off-screen, to a wall

There are two important don'ts to be observed: clock for instance, and then walk out in the same when filming point-of-view shots; direction. Always walk a player off-screen in a

Don't show a player looking off-screen, then cut direction different than to which pointed, unless a to what he sees - and pan the camera around and direct relationship exists between player's move end up on the player. This will jar the audience, ment and the object.

23

CAMERA ANGLES THE FIVE C's

SUBJECT SIZE, SUBJECT ANGLE era from the subject, or lens focal length, do not

& CAMERA HEIGHT determine the type of shot filmed. The camera distance, and the area photographed, would vary

A camera angle is defined as the area and view greatly in filming a close-up of a baby human and point recorded by the lens. Placement of the camera a baby elephant! The shot should be defined with era decides how much area" will be included, and regard to the subject matter, and its in/eye size in viewpoint from which the audience will observe relation to the over-all picture area. A head close the event. It is important to remember the relationship up would, therefore, depict a head - whether of relationship between camera angle and audience.

baby human or of baby elephant - full-screen.

Every time the camera is shifted, the audience is The shot definitions which follow should not repositioned, and observes the event from a fresh be considered in absolute terms. They should be viewpoint. Three factors determine the camera

used to describe requirements in general terms.

angle:

SUBJECT SIZE

SUBJECT ANGLE

CAMERA HEIGHT

SUBJECT SIZE

The image size, the size of the subject in relation to the over-all frame, determines the type of shot photographed. The size of the image on the film is determined by the distance of the camera from the subject, and the focal length of lens used to make the shot. The closer the camera; the larger the image. The longer the lens; the larger the image. The converse is also true: the further away the camera; the shorter the lens, the smaller the image.

Image size may vary during a shot. These

Image size may vary during the shot by moving

players may walk toward camera as scene

the camera, moving players, or employing a zoom

progresses. Or, camera may move closer

lens. The camera may pan or dolly so that the

to them or they may be filmed with a

subject is brought closer to or further away from zoom lens. A 10119 shot. may thus graduate

the lens. The players may move toward or away into a close-up in a single take.

from the camera. The zoom lens may be varied in

focal length as the scene progresses. Thus, a long

shot may graduate into a close-up, a close-up be

come a long shot, in a single shot.

Many cameramen and directors think only in

terms of long shot, medium shot and close-up in

a by-the-numbers progression. Such elementary

thinking falls far short of the many types of shots

that may be filmed. Relative terms have different

meanings to different people. What one camera

man would consider a medium shot, may be a

medium close-up to another. Distance of the ear-
~The area covered is also dependent upon lens focal
length.

24

CAMERA ANGLES

THE FIVE C's

Extreme long shots may depict vast area (from great distance, to impress audience with grandeur or scope of undertaking. Such shots establish geography of setting. A wide-angle static shot is best, but a pan shot may be employed if it increases in interest as pan progresses.

EXTREME LONG SHOT (ELS) vantage point, such as a high camera platform,

An extreme long shot depicts a vast area from the top of a building, a hilltop or a mountain at a great distance. It may be used whenever the peak; or from an airplane or helicopter. A large audience should be impressed with the huge scope ranch, a farm, a city skyline, an industrial complex of the setting or event. An extremely wide angle shot, an oil field, a mountain range, a military static shot is usually more adaptable for extreme base; or a mass movement such as a cattle drive, long shots than is a panning camera movement. a ship convoy or a moving army, may be very The pan should be employed only when it is impressive as opening shots to introduce a scene or increase in interest, or reveals more of the setting sequence or to begin a picture. Such massive shots or action, as it progresses. The static shot should set the scene for what follows by putting the audience be used whenever a map type shot, which establishes the proper mood, and providing them with the geography of the locale, is desirable. the over-all picture before introducing characters Extreme long shots are best filmed from a high and establishing story line. Whenever possible,

25

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CAMERA ANGLES

THE FIVE C's

An extreme long shot of test base under construction may serve to introduce sequence or begin picture. Such scenes establish setting and open picture on grand scale.

extreme long shots should be filmed to open up about, and when seen in closer shots as the scene the picture on a grand scale, and capture audience sequence progresses. Players' entrances, exits and interest from the start. movements should be shown in long shot when ever their location in the setting is narratively

LONG SHOT (LS)

significant. Following the players around in close

A long shot takes in the entire area of action. shots may confuse the audience as to their where

The place, the people, and the objects in the abouts in relation to the setting and the other

scene are shown in a long shot to acquaint the players. It is therefore wise to re-establish the

audience with their over-all appearance. A long scene in a long shot whenever considerable

shot may include a street, a house. or a room, or player movement is involved.

any setting where the event takes place. The long Long shots are generally loosely composed, so

shot should be employed to establish all elements that players are given sufficient room to move

in the scene, so that viewers will know who is about, and the setting may beshown to advantage

involved. where they are located as they move in its entirety. While this may seem to dwarf the

26

THE FIVEC's CAMERA ANGLES

doors, in a series of rooms. Such a picture will

appear closed in and lacking in spaciousness.

Exterior long shots will open up the picture at

intervals and furnish "air" for a breather.

Long shots are kept to a bare minimum in tele

vision films because of limited size of picture

tubes, and inability to resolve a great deal of

detail. In this case medium long shots. which

cover the players full length but do not depict the

setting in its entirety, may be substituted. Such

scenes are sometimes referred to as f1111 shots.

MEDIUM SHOT (MS or MED)

A medium shot may be better defined as an

intermediate shot because it falls between a long

Long shots establish area of action and shot and a close-up. Players are filmed from above

players' positions. Players' entrances, exits the knees, or from just below the waist. While

and movements should be covered in long several players maybe grouped in a medium shot,

s1lot umencucr their location in setting is

the camera will be close enough to record with

narratively significant.

clarity their gestures. facial expressions and

movements. Medium shots are excellent for tele

vision filming, because they present all action within a restricted area in large size figures. Medium shots generally comprise the bulk of the theatrical films, because they place the audience at a middle distance, excellent for presenting events after the long shot has established the scene. Because it has many narrative uses, a great deal may be said for the long shot. Long shots deride size of objects - such as this jet airliner - and dwarf players, who will be seen to advantage in later medium shots and close-ups. In the long shot, the long shot is on the screen for a very short time and players can be seen to individual advantage in subsequent shots. Long shots lend scope to a picture, because they play up the size of the setting. Even a sequence taking place in a house should open with an exterior long shot to establish the location. This is excellent for presenting events after long shot has established scene. This is particularly important when an entire film takes place in- has established scene.

27

CAMERA ANGLES

THE FIVE C's

The author confers with Producer-Director Irvin Berwick on a two-shot for "Street Is My Beat," or hero and his buddy."

be depicted in a medium shot. One or more play There are numerous variations of the two-shot. The most widely used, but not always the most movement, so that enough of the setting is shown pictorially interesting. is that in which both play

to keep viewers constantly oriented. The story ers sit or stand facing each other with their pro
 may move into medium shots after the long shot. files to the lens. Young people with clean-cut pro
 It may return to a medium shot after close-ups, to files and good necklines will generally photograph
 re-establish the players. well. Older persons with jowls, puffy faces or
 The most dramatically interesting medium shot double chins should seldom be filmed in profile.
 is the two-shot, in which two players confront The main problem with the profile two-shot is
 each other and exchange dialogue. The two-shot that neither player can dominate the composition
 originated in Hollywood, and is known in France, if each is equally well lighted. Dominance is
 Italy and Spain as the "American-shot." A famous achieved through dialogue, action or favorable
 director has stated: "Regardless of the size of the lighting, which captures audience attention at the
 picture, whether it boasts a cast of thousands or a expense of the less favored player. The players
 28

CAMERA ANGLES

THE FIVE C's

Bob Jones University Unusual Films stu

may move about, or even change positions as the

dent camera crew line up two-shot for

scene progresses; and dramatic interest may "Wine OfThe Morning."

switch from one to the other, if required.

Two-shots may be angled and played in depth,

so that nearest player is turned slightly away other. One is dreamily looking away, while the
 from the camera and the farther player positioned other seems to be trying to get his attention.

so that he is filmed in a three-quarter angle. Or, Two-shots may grow or progress out of medium

one player may appear in profile and the other in or long shots. A player may break from a group,

a three-quarter angle or facing the camera. Tele and join another player; or two players may pull

vision employs an unusual variation of the two out and move into a two-shot. Player and/or

shot in which both players face the camera: the camera movement should be employed whenever

nearer player looks off screen while the farther possible to bring players together in a two-shot in

player looks at the nearer player's back. This a casual way. Two-shots should not be filmed with

allows both players to be filmed facing the cam both players standing flat-footed toe-to-toe, unless

era, in a single shot. Although it saves additional the script requires such treatment. This may occur

camera set-up, it is dramatically inadequate be in a dramatic confrontation between hero and vil

cause the players do not truly relate with each lain, in which neither will back away.

29

CAMERA ANGLES cs

THE FIVE

TYPICAL

TWO SHOTS

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Unique staging of two-shot by use of mirror. Player on right dominates scene because of larger image size, better position, three-quarter angling and lighting. Player in mirror captures audience interest because of reverse image, odd positioning and rear look toward foreground player. Typical profile boy-girl seated two-shots. Neither player dominates the scene from composition or lighting standpoint. Each player dominates in turn, as he or she speaks or performs an action, and captures audience attention. Eye appeal is lessened in a profile shot.

Although players' heights and positioning vary in this shot, they are compositionally balanced. Profiled player on left is higher and well modeled with light. Player on right makes up for his lowered position by being angled toward camera, so that both eyes and front and side of his face are seen.

30

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THE FIVE C's CAMERA ANGLES

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Player on right dominates scene because of Profile two-shot with one player seated and more favorable positioning and lighting. the other standing. The standing player dominates the scene because he is compo

sitionally stronger - on the right side and higher in the frame.

Player on right is favored in this two-shot because of better position and lighting.

Although positioned lower in frame, player on left dominates this two-shot because he is more favorably angled to lens, and his features are sharply chiseled with light and shadow. A face angled three-quarters to lens displays front and side, both eyes; and finer modeling than one filmed in profile.

Player on left dominates scene because he is slightly angled toward camera, and given more dramatic lighting. Player on right is turned away from camera and is, therefore, compositionally less interesting.

31

CAMERA ANGLES

THE FIVE C's

thus eliminating the background. Positions of hands, or fingers, which may appear in the insert, should match positions in the preceding shot.

Theatrical wide-screen projection may cut off important portions of the insert, or make them otherwise illegible. It is important to bear this in mind whenever filming a 35mm picture in wide screen ratio. The insert, in such instances, should be photographed loosely, so that nothing of importance is near top, bottom or side of the frame.*

DESCRIPTIVE SHOTS

Professional production personnel employ many descriptive terms in script writing and during

Two-shots may be employed in documentary filming to identify further the type and/or content of films - such as this shot of engineer's tent of a shot. A moving shot may be designated studying plans for construction project. as a pan shot, if the camera revolves upon its

vertical axis to follow the action; or as a dolly,

CLOSE-UP (CU)

crane or boom shot, whenever the camera is

A close-up of a person is generally designated mounted on anyone of these camera platforms to

in the script according to image size. A medium film the event. A moving shot may be further

close-up films a player from approximately midway

between waist and shoulders to above the head;

a head and shoulder close-up, from just below

the shoulders to above the head; a head close-up

includes the head only; a choker close-up includes

a facial area from just below the lips to just above

the eyes. Many cameramen and directors have

their own ideas of what area should be filmed for

a close-up. However>when a particular close-up is

not specified, it is generally safe to film a head

and shoulder close-up. (NOTE: The CLOSE-UP

is so significant that it is covered in detail in a

separate chapter.)

INSERTS

Full-screen close-ups of letters, telegrams,

Camera is mounted on crane to follow

photographs, newspapers, signs, posters or other

players across bridge. Dolly or crane

written or printed matter, arc called inserts. For

mounted camera may also be varied in

reasons of economy, inserts are usually filmed height; or moved toward or away from

after principal production shooting is completed. subject as scene progresses.

When a vertical subject does not fill the horizontal

frame, so that portions of background or setting

*Many theatre screens cut off the sides of "squeezed"

may be seen, it may be best to film the insert

'scope-type films; and may cut the top or bottom, or

during regular production. Generally, inserts are

hoth, or "non-squeezed" Hat films shot in various aspect

filmed so that they overlap the frame slightly, ratios.

CAMERA ANGLES

THE FIVE C's

defined by the type of shot at the beginning and end of the move: such as dolly. from a medium shot to a close-up. A shot in which the camera tracks along to film moving players is called a follow shot or a tracking shot. A low-shot is one in which the camera is angled upward at the subject, while a high shot is just the opposite, with the camera looking down. A reverse shot is a scene made from the reverse direction of a previous shot.

A cut-in shot is one that cuts directly into a portion of the previous scene, generally a cut-in close-up of a person or object. A cut-away shot is a secondary event occurring elsewhere - a few feet away, such as in the case of a cut-away

close-up of someone just off camera; or miles away. Camera films follow shot or tracking shot whenever it moves to follow action of traveling away, if the story is switched to another locale. A traveling player.

Reaction shot is a silent shot, ordinarily a close-up, of a player reacting to what another player is saying or doing. Reaction shots are filmed as separate scenes if observation only is involved. They are

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Number of players photographed - such as

This three-shot - also defines type of scene.

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three-shot, or sometimes a group-shot when all

A pan shot (Short for panoram) is em

players are included in a single shot.

played when camera revolves upon its ver

tical axis to follow action in horizontal. Such descriptive terms are usually employed in .

plane, such as airplane landing. combination with the type of shot being filmed,

so that they aid in further identifying what is

cut from portions of a dialogue sequence when required. A tracking shot of several players may

two or more players speak and listen alternately. be described as a wide-angle, low-angle dolly

The lens used for a particular type of shot may shot. Definitions vary throughout the industry.

be mentioned, such as a under-angle, telephoto or Most important is that their meaning is the same

zoom shot. The number of players in a scene may within the group producing the film, so that

also define the shot, such as a two-shot or a everyone understands requirements thoroughly.

33

CAMERA ANGLES

THE FIVE C's

SUBJECT ANGLE

All subject matter has three dimensions. Even

flat objects, such as paper, have thickness. People,

furniture, rooms, buildings, streets, all have

height, width and depth. All are solid, whether

they have rounded or flat surfaces, or combinations

of both. Their solidity is most pronounced

when viewed so that two or more surfaces are

seen. Whenever an object presents only a single

surface to the eye or the camera it is said to be

flat - because its depth is not apparent. A building

viewed straight on shows only its height and

width, not its depth. It has the appearance of a

false front, or a cardboard cut-out. The same

building viewed from an angle, so that a side is

Facial modeling is best when subject is

seen, appears three-dimensional. A person viewed turned forty five degrees - so-called three

in profile lacks roundness. The modeling of a face quarter angling - to the camera. Front and

11

The cameraman must record a three-dimensional player movement; overlapping subject matter; sional world on a two-dimensional film surface. linear and aerial perspective; use of short focal The solution generally lies in angling the camera length lenses, etc. The most effective method to in relation to the subject, so that a depth effect record depth, however, is by choosing the proper is recorded. There are many ways to achieve camera angle. Angles are the most important depth in filming; with lighting, camera and factor in producing illusion of scenic depth.

THE FIVE C's

CAMERA HEIGHT

While camera height is as important as camera distance and subject angle, it is often disregarded.

Theatrical cameramen are very careful about lens height in relation to subject matter..Many non theatrical cameramen merely adjust the tripod so that the camera is at convenient height for looking through the finder. They completely overlook the subject's special requirements!

Artistic, dramatic and psychological overtones

Angling camera in relation to subject pre may be contributed to the story-telling by adjusting this war scene with greater conflict, angling the height of the camera to the subject. Audiences because of diagonal pattern of horsemen, hence involvement and reaction to the event depicted soldiers in foreground, guns and swords.

Position of camera in relation to subjects

viewed from eye-level, or above or below subject. and setting greatly influences composition of scene.

LEVEL ANGLE

A level camera films from the eye-level of an observer of average height, or from the subject's eye-level. A level camera views a setting or an object so that vertical lines do not converge.

Shots filmed with a level camera are generally less interesting than those filmed from an upward or downward angle. A level camera is required. However, whenever eye-level views are filmed, or vertical lines must remain vertical and parallel to each other. A level camera does not distort verticals, so walls and sides of buildings, or objects, will remain true.

Objective shots, which present the view as seen by an observer, should be filmed from the eye-level.

Dynamic angling of this jet fighter produces more dramatic effect than would of an average person - about five and one-half feet high. It is important, however, that close-ups

have resulted from level angle shot.

It is important, however, that close-ups have resulted from level angle shot.

CAMERA ANGLES

THE FIVEC's

Point-of-view close-ups are filmed from the subject's eye-level when the players who are relating with each other are approximately the same height. They are filmed from the opposing player's height when a difference in height exists, or when one player is seated and the other standing, or when an adult relates with a child. The camera must be angled upward and downward on a pair of back-and-forth p.o.v. close-ups, in these instances. Such angling need not be precisely from the opposing person's head position. The angle

Objective shots - which present uttering and players as seen by a sidelines observer - should be filmed from eye-level of average person, about five and one-half feet high.

of a person be filmed from the subject's eye-level, whether standing or sitting, so that the audience sees the person on an eye-to-eye basis. It is necessary, therefore, when moving in from a long or medium shot to a close-up, to adjust the camera height to the particular subject being filmed.

Many non-theatrical cameramen ignore the A. ~eated per, ~on filmed from cameraman's standing eye-level results in high downward angle shot of top of head, half-closed eyelids and distorted view of subject. A paradox about camera height is that inexperienced cameramen tend to film from their own eye-levels rather than from subject's eye-level. This works well for shots of standing people, but results in

downward angling on seated persons. A subject's eyes, plus the intimate relationship desired between viewer and screen player, are completely lost from a high downward angle which records top of head, half-closed eyelids and a distorted view of the player. Just as an individual may be judged by "how he looks you in the eye," much of the appeal of a player in a dramatic film, or a person in a documentary film, is expressed through the eyes. It is imperative that cameramen understand this significance, and strive to position the lens at the subject's eye-level when filming objective close-ups.

36

CAMERA ANGLES

THE FIVE C's

may be cheated to prevent distortion, but it should not. All these up-and-down angles are very simulate the up-or-down look that occurs under slight, however, and usually may go unnoticed. these conditions. While level angles are not as pictorially inter

Subjective close-ups, in which the subject looks resting or dramatic as higher or lower angles, they directly into the lens, are always filmed from the eye-level of the person photographed. A higher or lower camera will cause the person to look up or down in order to look into the lens - and thus of reference. They present an easily identifiable create an awkward relationship with the viewer. viewpoint, because the audience sees the event as The person presented subjectively should always if on the scene.

be seen on a level eye-to-eye basis, as if the viewer were sitting or standing on the same eye-level are more dramatic than angle shots. Shots of a The importance of shooting close-ups at the car, train, or other vehicle rushing head-on toward subject's eye-level cannot be over-emphasized, because the camera give the viewer a subjective impression cause so many non-theatrical cameramen fail to position similar to a player looking into the lens. The lower the camera, particularly when a person is speed, increase in image size and subjective treatment seated. Students may note how carefully close-up treatment can be highly dramatic.

close-ups in theatrical feature pictures are positioned. It may be necessary or preferable in technical Slight variations from subject's eye-level are made in films to present a flat, level, undistorted view of a

only when necessary to correct facial faults; such tool, machine or instrument panel.

as a turned-up nose, which may look better from

a slightly higher angle; or a weak chin, which

may be improved by a slightly lower angle. Men

may appear more virile when filmed from slightly

lower angles, with the camera looking up. Flabby

jowls or wide nostrils may be visually corrected by

a slightly higher angle, so that the camera looks

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A technical shot ~ such as this scene of an

astronaut being tested in Gemini ejection

seat on inertia table - requires level cam

era filming set-up square-on for engineer

ing study.

e", l••0 P,,, b>t HIGH ANGLE

Level camera and simplest photographic

A high angle shot is any shot in which the

treatment are required for shooting tech

camera is tilted downward to view the subject.

nical films - such as this Electron Density

Profile Probe, which will be launched into High angle does not necessarily infer that the

space for study of ionosphere. camera be placed at a great height. Actually, the

37

CAMERA ANGLES

THE FIVE C's

camera may be placed below the cameraman's Action occurring in depth, such as a football

eye-level, to look down at a small object. Yet, it is game, a military formation, a production line or

filming from a high angle! an -tnimal migration, may be viewed in its en

All angles are relative and should be considered tirety from a high angle. A level or low angle

in relation to the height of the subject being shot will only record foreground action. The

filmed. The camera may be positioned to shoot a camera may shoot across the entire area of the

normal eye-level scene of a person looking out of action, from front to back, only from a high angle.

a window of a tall building. Any downward angl Raising the camera and shooting downward is

ing of the camera should be considered a high also useful whenever reducing the lens depth of angle shot, regardless of whether the camera is field aids in keeping sharp focus across the entire angled slightly to photograph the top of a pack picture area. A level shot may require filming near age, or almost vertically downward to depict a and far objects over a greater area than it is possible to carry sharp focus. A high angle may cover

A high angle shot may be chosen for esthetic, technical or psychological reasons. Placing the camera higher than the subject and looking down may result in a more artistic picture; make it easier to keep action occurring in depth in sharp focus; or influence audience reaction.

Subject matter laid out in a pattern upon the ground may look better from a high angle. Included are: a vast garden with patterned flower beds, winding paths and sculptured hedges; a walled enclosure; a race track; an airport; a military base; an industrial complex; a terraced courtyard; a golf course; a construction site. High angle shots help acquaint the audience with the geography of the setting. Looking down provides a map like layout, allowing viewer to orient himself.

Laying railroad rail bed is best viewed from above. High side three-quarter angles - which causes construction area to diminish into the far distance - results in composition with greatest depth effect.

A film on industrial complex may open with high angle extreme long shot to establish story.

38

CAMERA ANGLES

THE FIVE C's

the same front-to-back area with less difference in his situation. Such high-angle is excellent when between near-and-far focus. Never a player should be belittled, either by his surroundings or by his actions. An important player

or object. A tall player would look down at a who loses prestige or honor may thus be depicted. shorter person or a child in a point-of-view shot. as beaten down by circumstances, or natural ele The subjective camera may also place the audi ments, or terrain, simply by positioning the cam encehigher, so that it may look down on a player era high, employing a Wide-angle lens to look to feel superior to him; and to achieve a certain down upon him, and reducing his image to lowly heavenly transcendence over both the player and insignificance in relation to the setting.

Subject matter which fonns a ground pat Low camera angle should be used when

tern - such as this freeway under con presenting symbol of law or authority.

struction - may he viewed with map-like Such scenes are best filmed by positioning detail from high angle. opposing playerin lowly position.

Ship entering harbor - {llmed from high Suspect's beaten appearance is intensified

angle - may introduce travel film. Such by high-angle treatment. High and low

extreme long shots acquaint viewer with camera angles are most useful for present geography of area. ing players as dominating or degraded.

39

CAMERA ANGLES

THE FIVE C's

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Above scene of aerial tanker refueling jet Aircraft configuration is best depicted from fighters in flight is filmed from objective high angle.

side lines - viewpoint. This shot may be compared with scene on page 23 depicting tanker boom from operator's viewpoint,

Subjective or p.o.v. shot involves audience more intimately in the screen event than would objective shot filmed {rom imper sonal viewpoint. Documentary cameramen should employ subjective camera angles, rather than stand-offisll, objective camera angles, whenever possible.

A high angle shot may be filmed to take advantage of particular framing - such as this over-the-shoulder shot of statue of President Lincoln.

The subjective camera, acting as the collective eye of the audience, may look down from an airplane in flight. a tall building. a bridge or a mountain peak to view the terrain below, city traffic, High angle shot of electronic microscope the top deck of an ocean liner, or a vast crevasse. would be poor choice for opening scene of A high, downward angle should be used with picture, because it is not immediately identifiable. It may be used later, when viewer or auto race or chase, because movement will be more familiar with instrument. Weirdly angled shots in technical films may be slowed down. The slow effect is greatest toward wilder or confuse viewer. or away from the camera and less apparent cross-

40

CAMERA ANGLES

THE FIVEC's

LOW ANGLE

A low-angle shot is any shot in which the camera is tilted upward to view the subject. A low angle does not necessarily mean a "worm's-eye" view of the setting or action. Neither does it imply that the camera be positioned below the camera man's eye-level. A low angle shot may be made of a bug, a building or a baby. In some instances it may be necessary to place a player or object on a -- pedestal, in order to enable subject to appear higher in relation to the camera. Or, the camera may be placed in a hole, or below a false floor, to achieve the required lens height in relation to the subject. Low angles should be used when desirable to inspire awe, or excitement; increase sub

U. S. Army camera crew - filming in Greenland - makes use of unique snow ject height or speed; separate players or objects; tractor camera car for high angle shooting. eliminate unwanted foreground; drop the horizon and eliminate the background; distort composi

tional lines and create a more forceful perspective; position players or objects against the sky; and intensify dramatic impact.

Low angle shots of religious objects or architecture, such as a crucifix or church interior, may inspire awe in the audience, because the viewer is placed in a lowly position from which he must look up to the symbol of the Almighty. The same effect is useful in filming important personages, such as a President, judge or company executive.

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High downward camera angles slow down subject movement. Slow effect is greatest toward or away from camera; less apparent cross-screen.

screen. Such scenes may not match similar shots filmed at eye-level unless under-cranked."

High angle shots are a welcome departure from eye-level shots and provide contrast, variety and dramatic impact even to commonplace scenes.

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High angles should be considered to establish the

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story. supply pictorial beauty, or influence audience reaction to the screen players. Low angle shot of soldiers on firing range produces diminishing perspective, converg

"Filmed at less than 24 f.p.s., so that they will appear in lines and dropped horizon - all of faster when projected. which contribute toward unusual shot.

41

CAMERA ANGLES

THE FIVE C's

Low camera angles are also useful when one close-ups without requiring matching a studio set, player should look up to another player who dominates or returning to a particular outdoor location site. nates the story at that point. This works particularly Low angles cause people, objects and structures

larly well with point-of-view shots, because they tend to loom up in the picture because they are seen from the audience's perspective. The audience will identify with the lowly player and corded with a broad base and a diminishing perspective. Employment of wide-angle lenses for a player who is knocked down in a fight, must stand there emphasize the optical effect. When filming beneath a judge for sentencing. If degraded in players, however, from a low angle with a "wide" lens, in some manner - he would look up at his opponent, angle lens, care must be taken - or a caricature or symbol of authority. may result.

The star, or dominant character in a scene, may stand out from a group if he is positioned slightly forward of the others and filmed from a low angle. This will cause him to tower over the players behind him. This simple trick will give a player prominence, and allow him to dominate the event. Sometimes the effect is more dramatic if the player steps forward during the scene to coincide with an increase in dramatic action. or significant dialogue.

A low angle is excellent for cheating a cut-away reaction close-up against the sky, or other nondescript background. Dropping the horizon out of the frame removes all background identity and permits filming such close-ups almost anywhere at any time. jump-cuts or other editing problems Low angle shot of advancing soldier increases his stature. and causes him to rise higher in frame as he approaches camera. discovered when the film is later assembled. may be easily solved by insertion of low-angle reaction Wide-angle lens It will increase this effect.

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Low-angle shot of this wounded airman Three-quarter low angle shot of Marine allows camera to look up into his face, and formation provides distinct separation he also provides added stature by causing [gap] between rows of men - with front TOW ap ures to loom upward in the frame. appearing higher than rear row.

CAMERA ANGLES

THE FIVE C's

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Low angle shot of location interior allows filming unique ceiling. Note how priestly official in left foreground is positioned much nearer than centered player

- and how rear player provides subtle accent to complete triangular composition.

Both natural and man-made structures may be structured minus ceilings, to allow overhead light given increased height and dominance by shooting. However, location interiors of actual buildings up at them. Skyscrapers, church steeples, etc. may utilize ceilings if they provide additional mountains. may all benefit from such treatment. dramatic effect to setting or story. Low-angle The distortion inherent in such filming is accept shots of players against a sculptured church ceiling, because viewers have been conditioned to seeing, a wooden-beamed colonial inn ceiling, or a seeing tilted photographic perspectives, and realize glass-domed library ceiling, would present them that the converging lines are parallel. In reality, a against unusually picturesque backgrounds, tying person looking up from close to the base of a tall them in with the setting.

structure gets an impression similar to that produced by the camera. A low-angle static shot of an advancing group of players may provide a dramatic introduction,

Low-angle studio interiors are rarely filmed for if they enter from the bottom of the frame as they theatrical pictures, because sets are generally constructed to approach the camera. An advancing army may

CAMERA ANGLES

THE FIVE C's

thus appear to rise up against a clouded sky as they press forward, and grow in stature and numbers as they file past. An individual player may be treated in this manner either as an introduction, or during a sequence when he must approach another player in a dominating manner. Autos, trucks and other vehicles may be similarly handled. Such low-angle treatment is most effective if filmed as described in the next paragraph.

Low angle positions subject against sky and produces tilting verticals. Combined

with train movement, this adds hazard to shot.

Shooting upward from a low angle at these men quarrying rock, positions workers • against sky with greater separation than if filmed with level camera against cliff back ground.

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Engineering progress report employs low angle shot of dummy crew prepared for test launching of experimental: spacecraft ejection seat - to depict clearly construction and positioning of components.

ANGLE-PLUS-ANGLE

An angle-plus-angle shot is filmed with a camera angled in relation to the subject, and tilted either upward or downward. Such double angling

Low angle shot of (a) tractor at work will record the greatest number of subject facets; causes it to loom larger and higher in the result in the finest modeling; deliver the most frame as it advances toward camera. forceful linear perspective; and produce a third

44

CAMERA ANGLES

THE FIVE C's

dimensional effect. Angle-plus-angle shooting trick is to prevent flatness at all costs, by angling eliminate the two-dimensional flatness of straight even slightly to introduce diagonals in lines of on angling, and the dullness of filming with a setting and background, and plastic modeling in level camera. Not only are the front and side of players. Players and objects will stand out more the subject depicted, but the camera also looks up prominently in the setting, and the separation or down to record the underside or top of the subject between players and background will be greater. The resulting three-dimensional modeling if the camera records the scene at an angle depict and diminishing compositional lines presenting both front and side, and a tilt that reveals the subject - whether person, building, or machine top or bottom of objects.

in a realistically solid manner. Very high and very low angles will present the

The camera angling need not be very high or most drastic effects, and should be utilized only very low, or from a full three-quarter angle. The when highly dramatic results are required. More

subtle angling should be employed as a matter of course on every possible type of shot. Wide-angle lenses will increase the angular effect by recording a more forceful perspective. Players should be positioned so that they present a three-quarter view to the camera, and travel in diagonal lines, whenever feasible. Furniture and other props

should be cheated, if necessary, so that they are turned at an angle to the lens. The background should be filmed at an angle, rather than flat-on, to produce diminishing compositional lines.

Linear perspective is greatest, and presents the most interesting series of converging lines when the camera is placed very high, and shoots downward on streets, roads, industrial complexes, preferably with a wide angle lens. A three-quarter low front view of building is flat, because it records only height and width.

Aerial view of building also records top.

By presenting front and side of building, Three-dimensional effect is greatest when three-quarter angle records height, width camera is angled so that front, side and - and depth. top - or bottom - of subject are seen.

45

CAMERA ANGLES

THE FIVEC's

angle shot is excellent for filming a moving column of soldiers, a long line of vehicles or a train. angle lens, adds illusion of tremendous speed and Such movement should approach the camera, so power to moving vehicles. Starting from a mere that it becomes larger as it advances. Side three speck in the distance, an automobile develops long quarter angling, plus the low viewpoint will produce converging lines as it rapidly approaches, and becomes produce converging lines, which are made more in larger and higher in the frame. Such angling is interesting by player or vehicle movement. requires careful placement, so that most of the horizon is close to the bottom frame line and forms a solid base for the movement. This treatment may

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Background should be angled to produce diminishing compositional lines. Players

Angle-plus-angle camera set-up with low should travel in diagonal line. not straight three-quarter angle. Infantryman looms up across screen. Flat-on angles, presenting ill frame and background falls away with subject travel and background square to greater separation.

lens, should be avoided.

Camera #1 records background with grad.

ually diminishing lines; and running player Low three-quarter angle on fast-movement

with: gradually increasing image. Camera subject adds to illusion of speed and

#2 records flat square-on background and power. Train image becomes larger and player with: same size image. higher in frame as it approaches camera.

46

CAMERA ANGLES

THE FIVE C's

vertical axis of the subject. This results in tilting of the screen image, so that it slopes diagonally, off-balance. Such slanted images must be used with discretion, or they may detract from the story-telling. They should be reserved for sequences when weird, violent, unstable, impressionistic or other novel effects are required. A player who has lost his equilibrium, or is drunk or delirious, or in a high emotional state, may be shown to advantage in a tilted shot, or a series of tilted shots, perhaps in pairs of opposing tilts, so Angle-plus-angle shooting presents more interesting compositional lines. Downward angling on this magnetic tape set-up records

equipment at side and rear of room; and
console deck as well.

also be applied to a long line of moving vehicles.

Those in the foreground will fill the frame from
top to bottom, while the remainder will gradually
diminish and converge in the distance.

Rooms with ornate ceilings, or patterned floors,
may be filmed with a slightly lower or higher

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camera; that requires tilting upward or downward

Dutch tilt angle may be employed to shoot

- in addition to three-quarter angling, which re scene of distraught player in highly emo
cords two walls. Double-angling in this manner tional state. Series of such scenes may
will present the greatest number of facets to the utili::eopposing tilts for greatereffect.

camera, and the greatest convergence of lines

particularly if a Wide-angle lens is employed. that the audience realizes he is behaving irration

Trucking shots, filmed with a camera tilted ally. These shots may be combined. with subjec
slightly upward, will cause the background to slop tive point-of-view shots, in which the upset player
away from the players. This is excellent for fren sees other players or events in a tilted off-balance
zied chase scenes where players are presented in series of shots.

turmoil. Buildings or trees will not simply slide Aman-made or natural catastrophe, such as an
past the players - as in a level shot - but fall accident, fire, riot, fight, shipwreck or earthquake
away backward. may employ tilted camera angles for conveying

Angle-plus-angle shooting should be considered violence, or topsy-turvy, out-of-this-world effects
whenever the greatest three-dimensional effect to the audience. If preceded by calm, static,
and greatest convergence of lines are desired. peacefulshots that lull the audience into believing
everything is all right, such scenes will be much

TILT "DUTCH" ANGLES more effective. A quiet, statically-filmed, slowly

In Hollywood studio parlance a "Dutch" angle paced sequence in an art museum, for instance,
is a crazily-tilted camera angle, in which the ver could suddenly be thrown into uncontrolled pan
tical axis of the camera is at an angle to the demonium by sudden insertion of a tilt shot of a

47

CAMERA ANGLES

THE FIVE C's

man racing through a doorway and crying; "Fire!" Cameras should never be tilted just a little off

The remainder of the sequence could employ a level, so that the slightly slanted image seems series of tilted shots, to portray the panic of the accidental. A tilt should be deliberate, with a definite trapped museum visitors. Editorial effects may be a slight slant of sufficient angle to throw the image enhanced by using opposing left and right tilts, off balance, but not so steep as to appear on its in pairs, and player movement in opposite directions. The actual angle will vary with subject matters. The camera need not be tilted

Dutch angle shots may also be employed in throughout the shot. It may start level, and then montage sequences, for creating an over-all impression abruptly tilt to depict a weird change in events, or impression of passage of time or space. Short shots introduce sudden unbalance in player involved. of clocks, calendars, feet walking, wheels turning, Or, a tilted shot may return to level when events ship's whistle blowing steam, etc., may be angled return to normal. The camera may, on rare occasions in a tilting manner. A series of tilted angle shots may rock back and forth during the shot, tilting may be used in research, industrial, advertising, from one side to the other.

Dutch tilt angle of building produces impression of building. The angle of tilt is most important. An impressionistic view; unusual treatment suitable that slants to the right is active, forceful, while suitable for montage sequence. Scene should one that slants to the left is weak, static. A be filmed with opposing tilt. For example, a slanted horizon, running from lower left to upper choice. This is important when series of right, suggests ascent; while one that slants from tilt shots oppose one another.

Upper left to lower right suggests descent. The angle of the horizon is important in shots of engineering and similar documentary films that traveling players, moving objects, or vehicles; require dynamic depiction of a great deal of especially if they advance from a distant point action in small snatches, which show mere toward the camera. or retreat from the lens to the glimpses of the events. Thus, the assembly of an distance. They should climb up coming toward automobile, the manufacturing and packaging of the lens, and climb down going away.

a new product, or the numerous experiments in 'Dutch angles are most effective if filmed from involved in developing a synthetic yarn, may be a low camera set-up, which throws the images shown with unusual treatment. Several, or all, of backwards in a crazy slant. A wide-angle lens, these shots at tilt angle. will forcefully portray low-angle tilt, combined with a three-quarter the situation. Pairs of opposing tilt shots should camera angle is strongest, because such angle employ the same degree of tilt in opposite pattern. plus-angle shooting with a short focal-length lens

CAMERA ANGLES

THE FIVE C's

records the most violent angling, the greatest separation of subject and background, and the most forceful perspective. The effect is further increased on moving action, because the wide angle lens enlarges or diminishes the moving player, object or vehicle as it moves toward or away from the camera.

EMPLOYING CAMERA ANGLES

The area photographed, or type of shot, and the viewpoint, or angle of the camera in relation to the subject, may be employed in various combinations to produce a motion picture story with visual variety, dramatic interest, cinematic continuity.

Contrasting shots utilize pairs of different size images in opposition; such as long shot and cut-away close-up.

Progressive series of images may depict full shot of group; medium shot of two players, and close-up of dominant player.

49

CAMERA ANGLES

THE FIVE C's

AREA

Contrasting shots utilize pairs of different size

The area photographed determines the subject's images in opposition. A long shot may be contrasted with a close-up, or the other way around. Each pair of shots should have sufficient difference in image size to provide suitable contrast. Image sizes may be employed in a series of increasing or decreasing image size to provide suitable contrast. For greater over-all effect, series of contrasting shots to present the event in a progressive (or regressive). contrasting or repetitious manner. pairs may be used.

Progressive (or regressive) shots utilize a series of images increasing (or decreasing) in size. A series of close-ups may depict reactions. Repetitious shots utilize a series of same size images. A series of long shots may proceed from long shot to medium of a crowd to a speaker. A series of long shots

shot to close-up; or procedure may be reversed. may show several industrial sites. Any series of The sequence may begin and end with any type similarly-sized narratively-connected images may of shot. Most important is the progressive change be used.

in image size, from shot to shot. Similar series or pairs of shots need not be used throughout a sequence. A sequence may begin progressively, so that it moves in from establishing long shot to close-up. Then, it may move into a repetitious series of close-ups - such as individual reaction shots; and climax with a series of back-and-forth contrasting shots. Movie makers lacking imagination sometimes resort to a monotonous pattern of progressive long shots, medium shots, close-ups. A more vigorous representation will result by integrating progressive, contrasting and repetitious series of shots within sequences, throughout a picture.

VIEWPOINT

The viewpoint determines the subject's image

Repetitious shots employ same size images, angle, or the camera angle from which the audience such as these close-ups. Long shots - or once views the subject matter. The viewpoint may any size image - may be used provided be progressive (or regressive), contrasting, or they are similar in size. repetitious.

In a progressive (or regressive) series, each angle is either greater (or smaller) than the preceding angle. Angles may also progress in height, going from low to eye-level to high angle (or may regress in opposite manner). Or they may progress in relation to the subject, such as going from front to side to rear angle. Any series of angles progressing (or 'regressing') in orderly fashion - in or out, up or down, or around, the subject - is governed by this principle.

Contrasting angles are pairs of shots employing camera angles in direct opposition to each other.

A high angle may be followed by a low angle; a low angle by a high angle; a front angle by a reverse angle; a reverse by a front angle. To be most effective, angles selected should be dramatically opposed in viewpoint, in the same manner as sizes of images. Treatment of repetitive angles and series of similar angles and images should be integrated, and applied to the same or different subject matter, used in combinations to provide visual variety: so a series of shots may be filmed from the same angle at intervals, to show various stages of a manufacturing process. Or, similar angles may be employed to film different people, objects or actions. The viewpoint remains the same, the subject matter changes, as events progress; or different subjects are depicted from similar angles. Recording the required series of images from the proper camera angles cannot be successfully accomplished in a haphazard manner. Thoughtful planning, with definite editorial patterns in mind, is required.

THE FIVE C's CAMERA ANGLES

It is not necessary to employ similar series of angles through a sequence. Angles may be varied in the same manner as sizes of images. Treatment of repetitive angles and series of similar angles and images should be integrated, and applied to the same or different subject matter, used in combinations to provide visual variety: so a series of shots may be filmed from the same angle at intervals, to show various stages of a manufacturing process. Or, similar angles may be employed to film different people, objects or actions. The viewpoint remains the same, the subject matter changes, as events progress; or different subjects are depicted from similar angles. Recording the required series of images from the proper camera angles cannot be successfully accomplished in a haphazard manner. Thoughtful planning, with definite editorial patterns in mind, is required.

HOW TO SELECT AREA AND VIEWPOINT

It is often difficult to draw the line where a certain type of shot ends and another begins. However, it is necessary that a distinct change in both image size and camera angle take place whenever they are employed progressively or regressively. A slight angle change with the same image size will look like the figures shifted abruptly. A slight image change from the same angle will appear as a sudden expansion or contraction of the image.

The same procedure applies to contrasting opposing angles. Camera distance and images and camera angles. Contrasts from one camera angles should be similar, in order extreme to the other should be marked. Half-way to produce uniform appearance. changes in image size, in between camera angles,

present only slight changes; not a radical contrast
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to each other.

A series of repetitious images or camera angles means exactly that. Don't vary the images. Keep them approximately the same size. Don't shift the camera angle slightly, so that it views each subject from a different angle. Keep the camera the same distance from each subject. Shoot each subject from the same angle. Use similar camera angles, or opposing matched angles, such as in a series of repetitious back-and-forth over-the-shoulder shots. or a series of objective or point-of-view close-ups.

Image size and camera angle should be integrated so that they match. Progression in image

51

CAMERA ANGLES

THE FIVE C's

Same camera angle with slight change in This close-up depicts a definite change in image size - suits as between close-up image size from first close-up.
above and below - will appear as slight expansion of image, rather than definite change at that particular moment in the narrative. Simple progression from long shot to close up may not always provide the most suitable type of sequence. For instance, subject matter or dramatic content of the story may require that the camera first record a close-up, in order to isolate, emphasize. or introduce a small object. An extreme long shot may be required to portray scope. grandeur, complexity; so that the audience fully appreciates the vastness, beauty. or conflict involved in the story. The over-all action of each sequence should be broken down before shooting. and the type of shot required for each portion of

the action determined in advance.

Establish the setting with a long shot, or an

extreme long shot - if vast in nature. Move into a

medium shot to introduce the players as a group.

size should also employ camera angles that move and use close-ups for individual screen filling

around and shoot the subject from a side angle as shots of each. Employ long shots to show the

it moves closer. Contrasting pairs of shots may players in relation to the background, and to allow

utilize contrast in both image size and camera them space to move from one place to another.

angle to be more effective. Series of repetitious as the action progresses. Use medium shots, par

shots should repeat both similarly-sized images ticularly two-shots. to show important inter-action

and similarly-angled camera set-ups, or repeat between players. Utilize close-ups to emphasize a

similarly-sized images with opposing matched particular action. or to isolate a player or action

camera angles. by removing all else from view. Use extreme

close-ups for full-screen shots of very small ob

DEPICTING THE ACTION

jects or actions. Progress inward as the action

The camera angle chosen for each shot is deter develops. Move back to re-establish the over-all

mined by how the players and the action should scene, to depict new developments, to introduce a

52

THE FIVE C's CAMERA ANGLES

The cameraman should ask himself: "How

much should be included in this shot? Where

should the camera be positioned to view this par

ticular part of the action?"

The area and viewpoint should be considered

from both esthetic and dramatic requirements.

Difficulties encountered by pioneers in crossing a

trackless wasteland may be most expressively

conveyed to the audience by an extreme long shot,

which dwarfs the people against the rugged ter

rain. On the other hand, technical problems In

involved in soldering may best be shown by moving

in close and filling the screen with a single drop

of solder!

On occasion it may be more dramatically

effective to open sequence with a close-up
- and then pull back to reveal content of
over-all scene.

A single drop of solder being applied to an
electronic circuit may be as dramatic as
long shot of group of pioneers crossing
rugged terrain.

new player or allow the players to move about. As
example, contrast an extreme long shot of a mis-
sile launching with an extreme close-up of the
firing button. Think in terms of dramatic impact
on audience as well as visual variety. Employ a
repetitious series of reaction close-ups of various
persons to the launching; or a repetitious series of
medium shots of personnel at tracking stations.

Don't attempt to tell the entire story in a single
shot! Remember that a sequence is a series of
shots, and each shot should depict its particular
portion of the story in the best possible way.

Think first of the area required for the particular
shot, and then of the best viewpoint.

53

CAMERA ANGLES

THE FIVE C's

Think, first of the impression the shot should make upon the audience. Should the screen event habit, or lack of imagination, or laziness. Employ influence their emotions, or should they be de repetitious treatment whenever a matching pair tached from the proceedings so that they may or series of similar shots - such as a series of evaluate events without prejudice? A comparison close-ups - must present the same size image of prototype aircraft may be best presented ob from similar or opposing viewpoints.

jectively without trying to make up the viewers'

minds. Events must be individually evaluated, CHANGE CAMERA ANGLE, LENS, OR BOTH
and filmed accordingly. Change the camera angle, the lens, or prefer

Inclusion or removal of people, objects or ably both every time the camera stops shooting
actions should be justified by whether or not they during a series of continuous shots. Adapt this

are essential to the story-telling. Only significant technique as a standard operating procedure portions of setting, performers and events should whenever filming continuous action that must be depicted in each shot. It should be remembered without a break, without cutting to be remembered, however, that on occasions a blank frame something else, or without opticals. Using the is significant! What is depicted at any moment same camera angle and same lens on consecutive should contribute to the over-all story-telling. Shots will result in a jarring jump-cut, due to While the point in the action where a shot changes in players' positions. This is tantamount should be terminated, and another type shot to stopping the camera in the middle of a shot, begun, is usually an editorial decision; it must be since nothing photographic is changed; but player made by the cameraman or director, if not indicated movement which occurred during the shut-off indicated in the script - or if filming is off-the-cuff. Interval is missing. There should be a definite A shot should be held no longer than required to change in image size and viewing angle from shot make its point. When setting and players arc to shot. This may be accomplished if camera is established and camera is moved in, the bulk of moved, if lens is changed, or if camera and lens the sequence should be continued in a variety of are both changed to meet requirements of the medium, medium close and close shots. The over new set-up. Moving the camera with the same all scene should be re-established, however, when lens is better than changing lenses from the same ever a wider expanse is required to move players camera position. Most rewarding results will be about, introduce a new player or allow the players obtained when the camera is repositioned for the to exit.

Emphasize and isolate significant players, actions or dialogue with close-ups. Shift the camera on movement that may be overlapped from shot to shot. Move the players out of and into shots. Shoot cut-in and cut-away close-ups whenever possible. If in doubt about unusual camera angles, pan or dolly shots, or any shots that may cause editorial problems, shoot protection shots for additional coverage. Don't be hide-bound by a by-the-numbers 1-2-3 shooting pattern. Approach each sequence with a fresh attitude; and strive to treat the action in an individual manner. Employ progression as a standard operating technique, but always look out for dramatic contrast or unusual oppositional treatment which can lift the Camera may move straight-in to shoot a

sequence out of the run-of-the-mill cinematic rut. close-up of individual in crowd.

54

THE FIVE e's CAMERA ANGLES

best possible angle for each shot; and a focal length lens that meets the technical and dramatic aspects of the scene is chosen.

Some inexperienced, unimaginative, or lazy cameramen change the lens, and continue filming from the same position. This requires only revolving the lens turret, so that a different focal length lens is shifted into shooting position. If a longer lens is brought into play, the screen effect is that of an optical pop-in, because a portion of the previous shot is suddenly magnified to fill the screen.

There are instances when pop-in treatment either switching to a longer focal length lens or moving the camera straight in, preferably the latter - should be employed. It may be used when filming a single person in a long shot, such as a master of ceremonies on stage. A long shot from the back of the theater may be followed by a close-up which moves straight into the subject. A subject seen from a distance, such as a person in a crowd, may be followed by a closer shot from a similar viewpoint. A person centered in a group

A magnified or pop-in effect is similar to intermittent zoom ~ minus actual zooming - because camera is moved straight in for closer shots. This treatment may be used when a player is centered, and relates with other players on each side. Camera #1 films long shot, #2 medium shot and #3 close-up.

55

CAMERA ANGLES

THE FIVE C'S

so that he must relate with others on either side, angle and lens height chosen that would best portray may be filmed in a closer shot with a straight-In tray the player. The camera is moved in, around camera move. to the side, and raised or lowered for closer shots.

The point-of-view close-up which follows an over-the-shoulder shot, is another instance where the camera is moved straight in. The reason for a few exceptions to this rule, it should be applied filming over-the-shoulder of a foreground player whenever filming conditions permit. is to prepare the audience for the close-up that follows - as seen from that player's viewpoint. A director of photography on a theatrical feature picture would rarely shoot a close-up with a telephoto lens from the long shot camera position. The camera would be moved in closer, an intermediate focal length lens employed, and a camera actor is centered and relates with others on each side of him. It will not provide the best close-up when the camera should be moved around to the side - whenever players relate across the screen. Camera should move in and around to the side whenever two or more people relate with others across screen. Camera #1 films long shot. Camera #2 is moved in and to the side to film close-up of lead player. Camera #3 films opposing player from opposite angle. This treatment is recommended whenever players relate across screen.

56

THE FIVE C's CAMERA ANGLES

The camera is generally higher for long shots than it is for close-ups ~ so it is usually necessary to lower the camera when it is moved in. There are instances, however, when the camera is positioned at eye-level for the long or medium shot. so that it only requires being moved in and around, or straight in - in certain cases, to film close-ups. Or, the lens focal length need not be changed, the move in is sufficient to alter the image size. There are also occasions during filming of documentary

or newsreel films when the camera must shoot from a fixed platform, or other static position, so Moving camera in and around to side angle for closer shot will help cover inadvertent minor mis-matches in players' positions. A major mis-match, as shown here, would require insertion of cut-away shot of another individual in the scene.

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Retaining same image size in consecutive shots with slight change in camera angle results in jump-cut, because players will appear to jerk or shift across splice.

57

CAMERA ANGLES

THE FIVE C's

that switching lenses from the same camera SCENE REQUIREMENTS

set-up is the only way to record different size im

Each scene should be considered as part of a ages. The most impressive screen effects, how sequence. or series of shots; but must be given ever, occur when the camera is moved to a fresh individual attention based on story requirements. viewpoint, the camera height: is adjusted to suit In addition to esthetic, technical and psychological factors that determine camera angles, there fit the individual shot.

are dramatic, editorial, natural and physical

While is it not absolutely necessary to change phases to be considered. These factors need not the lens for each shot, it is wise to switch to a be individually considered for each shot or select lens focal length best suited for the particular quence. Many are handled intuitively by experi

scene being filmed. Generally, this necessitates a
 ended movie makers. But all these elements
 change, since a wide-angle lens may be required
 should be included in over-all planning of a sc
 for a distant shot, a normal lens for a medium
 quence. so that each series of shots will depict its
 shot and a semi-telephoto or telephoto for a close
 portion in the best possible cinematic manner.
 up or extreme close-up. A normal focal length
 lens may be used to film an entire picture, if the ESTHETIC FACTORS
 camera has sufficient room to be moved about for Many esthetic factors should be considered in
 every type of shot. Such situations are unlikely in selecting the right camera angle. All compositional
 professional production filming, where a variety elements: players, props, furniture, setting, back
 of different focal length lenses are available to ground, vehicles, etc., should be studied with
 record the area and perspective required. player movements and general action of the scene
 Moving the camera in and around to a new in mind. Objects should be arranged to facilitate
 angle helps cover inadvertent mis-matches in suitable staging and pleasing photography. To
 players' positions. A mis-match is much more no achieve the desired effect, some items may have
 ticeable if the camera moves straight in, since the to be added or eliminated. Filming fictional fea
 only change is that of magnification. Thus, a tures present few esthetic problems, because sets
 slightly different head position or changes in hand arc designed and built around the scene's require
 or arm movement may be apparent to even the ments. Documentary films, shot on actual loca
 casual viewer. Moving in and around, however, lions, often require much improvising to stage the
 permit considerable cheating, because the audi
 ence views the players from a completely new

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angle. All effort should be made to match player
 positions, but small discrepancies due to slight J
 mis-matching between shots will be less apparent
 with a change to a new viewpoint. than with a
 straight-in move.

The camera angle should not be shifted slightly
 in consecutive shots of the same subject filmed
 with the same image size. A two-shot of players
 facing each other will appear as a jump-cut if
 filmed from a matched pair of camera set-ups,

which are varied slightly to favor each player in turn. Since the pair of images are the same size, and the angle is only slightly changed, the players - rather than the camera angle - will appear to shift. Some documentary films require compromise. A definite change in camera angle will mislead camera angles because of uncontrolled factors. assure a smoother flow of images. controllable factors.

58

CAMERA ANGLES

THE FIVE C's

action, particularly in interiors of real structures. lighting and accessory equipment. Need for portability. Compromises in choosing camera angles may be ability, lack of trained personnel, inadequate electrical power, insufficient time, cost and difficulties.

When filming exteriors, advantages of foregoing transporting heavy studio equipment - particularly ground frames, such as tree branches and arches, usually by air - all contribute to the technical problems that should be considered. Whenever possible, camera angles encountered by non-theatrical camera operators plus-angle viewpoints should be chosen to record men filming on actual locations. Lack of camera equipment, the best modeling, greatest number of planes, and dollies restricts filming to fixed tripods. The area to be filmed should be adequately illuminated and is determined by electrical power and lighting facilities available. Forms should suit subject matter and aid in creating proper atmosphere and mood. The amount of equipment that may be carried is important. Relationship between players and background tied to location generally precludes many camera angles also warrants forethought. If the background is and lighting accessories, ordinarily available in the area important to the story - such as an oil field, an oil rig, a studio. All these technical factors combine to restrict the cameraman in his handling of the camera. So, camera and player movement, ground action. Compositional lines, forms and camera placement, area to be filmed, and over-all movements should all be exploited to facilitate the camera treatment must be compromised to make story-telling. (See: COMPOSITION) do with available equipment and conditions.

TECHNICAL FACTORS PSYCHOLOGICAL FACTORS

Few technical restrictions are imposed on the cameraman explained in the discussion of camera height, camera angles, either in the studio or the audience may be emotionally affected by the camera on location. On the other hand, because of budget, camera viewpoint. Up, down, Dutch tilt, and sub Dutch tilt. personnel, transportation and other limitations; jective angling of the camera may place the most documentary cameramen have less camera, viewer in other than normal eye-level objective

viewing position, and strongly influence his emotional reaction to events depicted on the screen. Such abnormal viewpoints may bring the viewer closer to identification with the picture and the screen players. If disinterest is the effect desired, or the scene is too violent to view close-up, long and medium shots will position the audience at a distance from the event. Closer shots actually help to involve the viewer in the action. Subjective angles tend to depict the scene as the screen player sees it, and bring the viewer even more intimately into the story.

Through distorted subjective camera treatment, the viewer may actually experience the intoxicated, frenzied or insane attitude of the player through whose eyes he is looking. Thus, psycho

Many technical restrictions are placed on logical reaction of viewer is based, to a great extent, on camera angles and editorial treatment.

location. Camera angles and staging may

The principal psychological purpose of a motion picture have to be compromised to meet limita

tions set by lighting facilities and equipment. The picture is to sway the audience to react in a determined availability. Sordid mood. Whether a picture's purpose is to sell,

59

CAMERA ANGLES

THE FIVE C's

ical camera angling is one of the most powerful story-telling weapons available to the cameraman.

DRAMATIC FACTORS

If the story requires an exciting treatment of the action, dramatic factors should be analyzed.

Ordinarily, the camera should not intrude on the story-telling. Since it is able to interest the viewer by content alone, inherently dramatic subject

matter requires little or no special camera treatment. For instance, a dramatic speech should not be filmed with complicated lighting, tricky angles or distracting background action, if full audience

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attention belongs to the speaker.

Static, prosaic or commonplace subjects may be enlivened, however, by imaginative camera handling.

Murderer in mystery picture may startle

audience by suddenly revealing himself. When the cameraman is faced with dull material, the audience should be aroused. On

educate or entertain, its success depends on how other occasions, dramatic material may be further thoroughly it interests the viewer in the picture's enhanced by inspired camera treatment. Would story or message. an extreme long shot impress the audience with

Choice of camera angle may be decided by the majestic grandeur of the setting? Would examining the purpose of the shot, and the effect of extreme close-ups of key players, objects or actions wanted on the viewer. Should the audience be brought greater audience attention? Would low shocked at slum conditions depicted ... sold on a angle filming increase tension, distort composition new product ... angered by a corrupt political line or exaggerate action? Would high situation ... awed by a display of atomic weapons angle filming add significance to players, setting ... look with disdain upon a despicable character or action? Would subjective camera angles aid ... be inspired by a religious message ... be audience identity with lead player?

shown the world as seen by a mental patient? All Should the cameraman employ Dutch tilt and these suggest specific camera placements, and gles? Dolly shots? Dramatic lighting? Extreme

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photographic techniques designed to make the viewers care about the subject matter. The audience is not only impressed by what appears on the screen, but by players, objects or actions partially or completely hidden, revealed in a sudden or startling manner, or not shown at all! ~

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The camera need not do all the work! The

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viewer should be urged to use his own imagination in understanding what is happening. The camera

may create suspense by angling downward on the murderer, showing a knife in his hand - but his I ~

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identity is not revealed. A reverse angle may

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show the backs of villains as they conspire. The ,

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camera may pan, tilt, zoom or move to reveal

suddenly a player, object or action. Because it is

Straightforward camera treatment is gen

a direct link to the viewer's emotions, psycholog- ically best for highly dramatic scenes.

60

CAMERA ANGLES

THE FIVE C's

wide-angle lenses? Agitated movement? Or, The cameraman must plan the event as a whole, should the story be told in a straightforward doc and decide on its breakdown into individual shots.

umentary style, devoid of camera tricks and light He must decide how much setting should be in ing effects; or fancy camera angling which may cluded in the establishing long shot; what portions

detract from the narrative? Unorthodox camera of the action require medium shots; and where treatment should not be employed when it may the emphasis should be placed with close-ups.

distract the audience from the picture to aware Normal progressions from long shot to close

ness of camera. On the other hand, audience emo ups are generally safe, but not always the best tion may be raised to a high pitch by presenting technique. If the sequence develops into a series

subject matter in a distinctive, dramatic manner. of back-and-forth close-ups of various players,

The cameraman should study the event to be progressive camera angles should switch to rcpu

filmed, along with the script; and decide whether tlous camera angles. If a great deal of player

forceful camera participation would be an asset to movement is involved, or new elements are intro

the story-telling; or whether the camera should duced, it may be necessary to return to the long

function merely as a detached observer. shot to re-orient the audience. The cameraman

should continually try to analyze the event through

EDITORIAL FACTORS

viewers' eyes. The audience should be shown the

Editorial requirements often dictate the pre player, object or action which they are most inter

ferred camera angles for a series of shots. De ested in seeing at that point. This becomes of

tailed shooting scripts usually specify type of shot vital importance when narrative interest is di

or camera treatment. Many scripts, however, are filmed. The camera must concentrate on the more written in master scenes, in which the filming interesting of the two story elements. The film treatment is left to the director and cameraman. editor should be supplied with every possible type. A cameraman filming a documentary off-the-cuff of shot consistent with time and budget limits should shoot according to editorial requirements. Conditions imposed on the production.

While a few key scenes in a picture may be treated individually, all scenes must be considered NATURAL FACTORS in relation to other scenes in the sequence. Sun position, weather, terrain, influence choice of camera angles on exterior filming. Outdoor filming - particularly in color - depends upon the sun angle. Except for special effects, such as back lighted scenes; the sun angle is best when the scene is side or three-quarter front lighted. Even with careful planning to take full advantage of the sun at various times of the day or season, this restricts choice of camera angles. Fronts of structures facing north, for instance are rarely directly illuminated by sun in the northern hemisphere. Weather can be a factor, although overcast light permits filming with equal ease from almost any angle. It may be necessary to shoot in a direction that avoids bald skies. Terrain, particularly backgrounds, may force the cameraman to choose. Documentary subjects filmed off-the-cuff camera angles that either include or eliminate must be photographed with definite editorial pattern in mind. Over-all event must be broken down into types of shots re merits. Allowances for sun angles, weather and required for each portion of action. topography are made in construction of outdoor

61

CAMERA ANGLES THE FIVE C's

sets; but uncontrollable elements in natural set more often on where the camera and lights can be things often handicap the cameraman, so that he is squeezed into position, rather than the best angle must compromise camera angles to fit prevailing conditions for telling the story.

conditions. Weather maps in corresponding sea

CAMERA ANGLES ON SIGNS

sons of past years should be studied, if extensive

& PRINTED MATTER

outdoor production filming must be accomplished

in unfamiliar locations. Signs, plaques, labels and similar identifications should be filmed either straight-on - in the

PHYSICAL FACTORS

manner of titles - or given a three-quarter angle,

Physical factors seldom interfere with the so that the lettering diminishes in size as it recedes from left to right. This is particularly important in the studio cinematographer's choice of camera angles.

The documentary cameraman, to the contrary, must be particularly portant if the sign is of considerable length, such as lettering covering the front of a wide building.

tated by size and shape of rooms;fixed dimensions It is of less importance if it occupies little area of settings (without aid of "wild walls"which may such as a sign on a door - and may be read at a

be moved at will); ceilinged rooms (particularly glance. The name on the front of a courthouse,

lowceilings);practicalprops,machines,structures post office, school or other structure is more

and objects that do not "break-away" for film quickly legible if angled in this left-to-right direction,

ing,poorly painted walls (especially light-tinted minishing manner.

walls in color filming); and many other physical A lengthy sign, filmed with a panning or dolly

factors beyond his control. A very small room, for instance, may be difficult to light and impossible so that lettering enters from screen right and

to shoot without an extremely wide-angle lens slides across the picture from right to left. Care

which distorts the players. Actual interiors of air must be taken to angle the camera in the manner

plane cockpits. automobiles, control rooms, engines described above for static shots.Square-on camera

neeringinstrumentation trailers,blockhouses, and angles may cause a skipping effect - in which the

similar "live" sets may provide little space for letters break as they chatter across the screen.

camera and light placement. The choice of camera angle in many documentary interiors depends piece of printed matter, such as a letter or report,

era angle in many documentary interiors depends piece of printed matter, such as a letter or report,

era angle in many documentary interiors depends piece of printed matter, such as a letter or report,

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On occasion, major studio theatrical cine Lengthy signs on buildings are best filmed

matographers have to shoot in crowded so that lettering diminishes in size as it

quarters - such as this "submarine" set. recedes from left to right.

CAMERA ANGLES

THE FIVEC's

should be given an upbeat effect by postnontng If a Wide-angle lens must beemployed to film a it in the frame so that it slopes up-hill - that is. tight area, the camera should not be drastically from lower left to upper right. This treatment is angled so that perspective distortion is increased. essential when two or more lines must be read. The wider the lens angle, the greater the linear because the eye has a tendency to drop down to convergence. In this case, the camera angle read the next line. If the printed material is slop should be as square-on as possible to prevent ed downward (from upper left to lower right) weird foreshortening. Persons in the scene should the eyeis forced to move up to read the next line. not reach toward the camera to pick up objects Such unnatural eye movement will distress the such as a mechanic reaching for a toolin the fore viewer. Applications of these reading angles may ground - or a hand may appear like a ham!Tryto seem like splitting hairs, but they are based on keep the players equi-distant from the camera established reading habits. It is unwise to cause under such conditions, or the closest player may the viewer to strain or react unpleasantly in order appear unduly large in comparison with a player to read poorly angled material. (Sec: COMPOSI standing a short distance away.

TION, EyeScan) Extreme wide-anglelenses record the area from front to back of the setting so that it appears

PROBLEM CAMERA ANGLES lengthier than in reality. Player or vehicle move

Angling the camera for a particular effect ment toward or away from the camera will cause may introduce unforeseen photographic problems the subject to grow progressively larger or regres which may require compromising the set-up. For sively smaller at an accelerated rate- resulting in example, an establishing long shot filmed with a the subject appearing to cover a greater distance wide-angle lens, may include the desired width, than exists. Such movement should be avoided, but record too much foreground. Lowering the unless desired for a specialeffect.

eamera will eliminate some of the foreground, Problems often arise in positioning the camera without disturbing the basic composition. Raising because of physical limitations. Small, low rooms, the camera, so that the setting is viewed from a confined areas - such as the interior of a space high angle, should also be considered as a solution. capsule may prevent the camera from being

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Cameras should not be drastically angled on Tight interior shots - such as this scene in Hght interiors, filmed with wide-angle lens. missile capsule - provide little room for Distortion and linear convergence may be camera and light placement. Choice of

held to minimum with slight angling or camera angle on many documentary shooting square-on. scenes is often severely limited.

63

CAMERA ANGLES

THE FIVE C's

positioned as far back as desired. Rather than Tilted verticals can often be straightened, or use of an extreme wide-angle lens - which general lines may be tilted as desired, by angling the camera. For example, a three-quarter low angle sequence may be broken into additional shots, so shot of a columned courthouse may look better if that several normal angle shots are filmed, rather than shot with a slightly off-level camera so that the side of the building nearest the camera is squared to pan the camera with a normal lens to cover the whole to appear approximately parallel with the side area, rather than record the entire width in a part of the screen. This may look better than having a single static shot with an extreme wide-angle lens. Both sides of the building converge skyward. This is particularly important in industrial, scientific important point is not how the camera should be tilted and research films - where distortion of tools angled - it is the screen appearance of the subject and equipment cannot be tolerated. Studying the image in the viewfinder with Camera angles are related to subject angles. A various tilts will aid in deciding the best solution. A tilted object - filmed with an equally-tilted camera There are no pat solutions to every camera angle problem. If the subject should appear as in ...S.....

Low three-quarter angle shot presents U. S. Air Force MACE - surface-to-air missile - with lower-left to upper-right ascending flight line.

64

THE FIVE C's CAMERA ANGLES

real life, it must be presented in a manner that is be viewed from the side or even the top, not acceptable to the viewer. If a special effect is ways from the front. Visual variety should be the desired - anything goes! Distorted, violent, trick, keynote, so that the audience is kept interested in gimmicky effects are easily achieved because it is what is happening and what will happen next. It is easier to break the rules than to film the subject films are composed and filmed in a long shot, in a natural way! The most natural results are medium shot, close-up, 1-2-3 manner, the audience achieved when the subject is filmed in an undistorted manner will subconsciously expect a certain type of distorted manner with normal perspective effects. shot, a certain angle, a certain scene length. As a This requires avoidance of extreme wide angle result, viewing the film becomes tedious. Viewers lenses, weird camera angles and abnormal move should be shown something new or different at

ment of players or vehicles. This does not imply every opportunity.

that everything should be filmed from eye level Non-theatrical cameramen should consider with a normal focal length lens Visual variety filming mark over-the-shoulder and point-of-view not weird variety - will keep the viewer interested camera angles, in order to involve the audience in the narrative. the subject. The story should not be filmed with a stand-offish objective camera. The viewer should

CONCLUSION be brought into the picture intermittently and

Proper camera angles can make the difference stand alongside the players and view the other between audience appreciation and indifference. players, the setting and the action from an inside Image size and image angle determine how much angle. The viewer may thus more readily identify of the subject matter the viewer will see, and with the people in the picture and become more from what viewpoint. Each time the camera is engrossed with the message.

moved, the audience is transported to a new vantage point. The documentary cameraman has the advantage. Since the audience should never be moved stage over the theatrical fiction feature director of about needlessly, every change in camera angle photography, in that he can employ the subjective should count. camera now and then, and allow the subject to

Whether working with a shooting script or off look directly into the lens. The engineer, salesman the-cuff, the cameraman should film the event or company executive may be presented with a with definite editing pattern in mind. The series performer-viewer eye-to-eye relationship to relay of shots comprising a sequence should be recorded the picture's message more forcefully.

with progressive, regressive, repetitious or contrasting treatment - singularly or in combination worthy of experimentation - is the subjective -not with an oddly assorted hodge-podge of shots. treatment in which the camera replaces a player

To be truly successful, a motion picture should who must relate with the other players in the visually surprise the audience by presenting fresh picture - in the manner of Lady In The Lake. viewpoints, different types of shots, varied image sizes, in an unpredictable pattern. This technique should be considered whenever an A series of unusual subject may be treated in a novel manner close-ups may be followed by an extreme long shot that requires shocking or startling the viewer. shot: or a sequence may open with a close-up Or, whenever the mental condition of the player. instead of a long shot. The camera should view or an event told in flashback, would be enhanced events now from this angle, now from that. with a little different treatment.

Images should be scaled up in one shot, down in the next. Thoughtful use of camera angles can add variety and impact to story-telling. Camera angles should be changed, switched, reversed not simply designed to capture, sustain and point the way to play repeated in a similar pattern. Settings should continued audience interest, should be selected.

CONTINUITY

INTRODUCTION success. A continuity, or shooting script, is a pre

A professional sound motion picture should liminary motion picture on paper - a continuous present a continuous, smooth. logical flow of vts plan for photographing and editing the produc ualimages, supplemented by sound,depicting the tion. Other than a simple news shot, a motion pic filmed event in a coherent manner. It is the con ture cannot depict an event in a single scene. A tinuous aspect of a motion picture;it isContinuity series of scenes - a sequence - are required to that decides success or failure of the production. portray any action properly. Asequence without a A picture with perfect continuity is preferred time lapse should present the event in a continu because it depicts events realistically. A picture ous,realistic fashion.

with faulty continuity is unacceptable, because it Motion picture sequences may be compared to distracts rather than attracts. This does not imply chapters in a book. A director, working from a that action should flow smoothly across every cut detailed script, is forced to think of the picture as in a motion picture. There arc times when an a series of shots comprising each sequence; and a impression or a disturbed mental condition must series of sequences making up the complete pic be so portrayed; so that the audience can be ture. Acameraman shootingoff-the-cuffmust also emotionally aroused by incoherent images. These think in sequences, and not.in individual shots. are exceptions. Action will flow smoothly from shot to shot only

A motion picture is a record of an event, in when the over-all action of the entire sequence is fact, fiction or fantasy. The images should repro broken down into particular actions required in ducereal life,or amake-believe world. Sound may each shot. Without good continuity, a motion pic be dialogue and/or narration, accompanied by ture would be a jumble of unrelated animated appropriate music and sound effects. Visual and snapshots. While these pictures may have move audio elements of a motion picture should be ment in each individual shot. they are not a series integrated, so that they complement each other of fluid, flowing. merging images. Because of its in affecting the audience. jerky, jarring, mis-matched images, poor continu

Every motion picture should be based on a itydistracts audience attention from the subject shooting plan. The plan may be a few mental matter. Good continuity encourages the viewer to notes, scribbled suggestions, an outline, a story become absorbed in the story-telling, without board,or a detailed shooting script. The better the bothersome distractions. The prime purpose of a plan - or continuity - the stronger the chances of motion picture, whether theatrical fiction feature

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

or documentary fact film, is to capture and hold A motion picture can go anywhere in time and audience attention - from opening shot to final space at any moment. Thus, a story may suddenly fade-out. To accomplish this, the film must be pre go back into history, or shift across the world; or a scene may be speeded up; or a setting made to involved in the screen story. If viewers have to fig appear fore-shortened. Time and space may be ure out where the camera has suddenly shifted, or real or imagined, enlarged or reduced, torn why an unexplained change has occurred in play apart or tied together. An event may be presented ers' action, the spell is broken. in its entirety as it actually happened; or frag

Motion pictures create and sustain illusions. mented into bits in which only highlights or im The illusion is shattered whenever viewers' atten pressions are actually shown. Several locations tion or interest is distracted. Smooth, fluid, real separated in space may be presented singly, or istic continuity can contribute more to a motion combined on film to appear as a single setting. picture's success than any other cinematic device. Proper handling of both time and space will enhance the visual and audio values of the motion picture story. Abusing time and space require

CINEMATIC TIME & SPACE

ments may shatter the audience's receptiveness

TIME & SPACE CONTINUITY to the screen happenings.

A motion picture can create its own time and

TIME CONTINUITY

space, to fit any particular story-telling situation.

Time may be compressed or expanded; speeded or Actual time moves forward only, chronologi slowed; remain in the present or go forward or cally. Motion picture chronology, however, may backward; or it may even be held constant for as present the story in reel - rather than real - time, long as desired. Space may be shortened or Motion picture time may be divided into four cate stretched; moved nearer or farther; presented in gories: present, past, future, and conditional. A true or false perspective; or be completely remade motion picture story may employ one or more of into a setting that may exist only on film. Both these time elements, singly or in any combination. or either - time and space may be eliminated, The film may depict events as happening in the recreated and presented in any manner that will present, and then switch backward or forward; or help the audience comprehend. it may compress, expand or freeze time in any A motion picture may go anywhere - by An event - such as this Indian making a showing actual travel - or editorially, by sand painting - may be presented in en cutting from one locale to another. tirety, or by showing only highlights.

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

manner. However time is portrayed, its handling must be easily comprehended by the audience.

Uses of realtime, and employment of dream time, are limited only by the imagination and technical abilities of those producing the film.

However the time factor is employed, the film story based on time continuity is told with the passage of either actual or fanciful time.

Present-time continuity depicts the action as if occurring now. This is the most popular and least confusing method of presenting the material.

Events transpire in a logical, straightforward see it-now way; so that, regardless of story developments, transitions, continuity lapses, the audience is always watching the event in the present. The viewer observing events this way has a stronger feeling of participation in the screen happenings. Documentary films benefit from presentation in a see-it-now manner.

Neither he nor the screen characters know what will come next. This keeps the viewer interested occurring now, before spectators' eyes. Thus, the in following the screen story to its conclusion. event is re-lived as if happening in the present, While most modern theatrical features employ rather than in the past.

present-time continuity, use is also made of other An event progressing in one locale: such as a time and transitional techniques, as required. By construction project, an athletic contest, a scientific demonstration - any happening without documentaries could benefit from present-time moving from place. to place - may be filmed with continuity, which would enliven the material and present-time continuity.

give it greater dramatic impact and audience Past-time continuity may be divided into two participation. Rather than depict a laboratory experiment as a past event; a flashback, from present to past.

construction of a missile base as a historical document; it may be more dramatically shown as

Construction project may be filmed with

Stories based on present-time continuity time continuity, because events are de

69

THE FIVEC's

then brought into present tense. While once-upon-a-time There is no limit to the ways flashbacks may be used in a dramatic film - providing the story such fantasies make the audience work harder to always return to the present, and the audience become involved in the screened event; and the pattern is carefully worked out so that the audience come identified with the players. For this reason, the audience is not confused. This is particularly important for historical screen subjects often fail to gain favor tant if several characters each tells his or her own version of the story out of chronological sequence.

when players, story and setting "come alive" on Flashbacks may be effectively employed in industry the screen in a way designed to capture both in-trial films, when comparing the old with the new.

70

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

Or, a completed project may be presented at the start of the story. How it was researched, designed, and constructed can be told in flashback.

Flashbacks have these advantages. They permit several characters to tell their portions of the story.

They allow narrators to regress in time, and present historical or background material. Different factual or fictitious aspects may be presented from various viewpoints by flashbacks. The story may depict an earlier period. Story-telling is not restricted to the present, but may move back and forth in time to describe or explain events significant to the narrative.

Flashbacks have certain disadvantages. They tend to break up chronological continuity and

Today's jet fighter aircraft may -

confuse the viewer. They often demand greater audience attention, particularly if several flashbacks are employed. Viewers may become "lost" in a lengthy flashback, and become disoriented; the story may move backward instead of forward, so that the normal progression of building toward a climax is impeded. Sometimes, the audience knows the outcome of the story in advance, because they have seen the end. The latter problem may be solved by beginning narrative just before the ending; then going into the flashback to tell the story up to the point where the picture began.

Then, the story returns to the present for its denouement.

Employment of flashbacks, or telling a story

flashback to World War II prop airplane- entirely in flashbacks, should be carefully considered. Flashbacks should not be used unless their advantages in story-telling greatly outnumber their disadvantages. Use of an occasional flashback, however, can be a tremendous aid in both theatrical and documentary films; when ever regressing in time supplies the picture with a missing ingredient, provides background material, or allows a novel portrayal of events.

Future-time continuity may fall into two categories: occurring in the future; a flashforward from present to future.

Events occurring in the future may be predicted, projected or imagined. A story transpiring in the future may thus involve a science-fiction prediction, an industrial projection, or epilogue of the or flashforward to future Space Liner. present story, or events imagined by a character

71

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

in the present story. The viewer is transported moves ahead into the future to describe events into the future. so that he is seeing the event "as that will, may, or could happen - and then re it will or could happen." The event is presented turns to the present. A scientist will project how with present-time continuity, as if happening now. present pollution of streams and rivers will affect The audience should be kept aware of the time our future water supply. An air force officer clement. so that they are not confused. A future describes what may happen in a future nuclear time continuity may involve space ships on route war. A space scientist explains how a manned to the moon; the projected growth of a company; satellite could reach the moon. The difference or tomorrow's happenings, imagined by a player. between a flashforward and a story occurring in A flashforward is the opposite of a flashback. It the future, is that the former is a fragmentary leap ahead which returns to the present, and the latter is a futuristic story in itself.

The flashforward possesses few of the disadvantages of the flashback. If not properly pre

sented, however, flashforwards may confuse the viewer. By jumping ahead of the present story, the flashforward may add a future dimension to a documentary fact film. This technique shows what could happen if a different course is followed in research, development or design of a new missile, an electronic brain, or a color television set.

A flashforward may be filmed and edited in a follow-through continuity, similar to present-time continuity. Or it may be depicted in impressionistic fragments, as if in a dream or imagination.

Future events - such as flashforward depicting (first moon landing - may be pre-dicted. Audience is transported into future, and sees event as it could happen. Conditional time continuity does not deal with real time. It is the depiction of time as conditioned by other elements, such as the mental attitude of

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Flashforward - such as this depiction of Conditional time depicts events as assumed interplanetary refueling - adds future dimension to present-day documentary film eyes audience views happenings, on space travel.

72

THE FIVE C's CONTINUITY

viewer viewing the event; or the memory, imagination also possible - as with lime continuity - to move nation or thoughts of a person who may "see" an back and forth in space, 10 speed or slow travel, event in a distorted manner in his mind's eye. or to be instantly transported to another location; Since conditional time is unreal, it is unlimited providing that the abrupt change in continuity by boundaries or manner of presentation. is understood by the audience. Viewers should This does not imply that conditional time need always be aware of location of action. and the not make sense. The audience must comprehend direction of the movement. That is the only way what is happening. A switch to conditional time the audience will know "from where the moving

must be properly established or explained with players or vehicles are coming, and to where they appropriate pictorial transitions and/or audio are going."

effects. Straight cuts may be employed, viewers Space is rarely portrayed in a motion picture as must be made to understand why the setting is it actually exists, except in a single setting: and suddenly switched to a scene existing only in the then it may be condensed or expanded by physical player's distorted mind. cal. optical and editorial techniques. Illusions of Time may be eliminated, fragmented., com space maybe created in various ways. Space may pressed. expanded, distorted, or combined in any manner, so that one or more event may be presented in a continuous manner - impossible in real life. Conditional time continuity may be employed to express a nightmare, delirium; drunken or other distorted thinking by a player. Or, it may be used to portray a player's musing, memories, or an imagined event.

Conditional time may be used for a single scene, a sequence or an entire picture. This technique may be compared to a stream of consciousness. in which unrelated real and fanciful events. clear and distorted thoughts - present. past or future - are all intermingled in jumbled continuity. Events may be depicted in slow nightmarish motion. or in a series of flash shots, in which Spacecontinuity is used to tell storywhich images are changed at high speed. Or, an image moves from one place to another. may be frozen for a long interval.

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Conditional time may also be employed to introduce a flashback in which a drowning person views his entire life, depicted in a straightforward continuity requiring several reels - in a few moments! If conditional time is properly presented, the audience will interpret and accept the situation under conditions depicted.

SPACE CONTINUITY

Telling the story as the action moves from one

place to another involves space continuity. An expedition documentary, an auto trip or a travel picture are typical examples. To be acceptable, a logical pattern of movement must be shown. It is

73

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

be stretched or shortened through employment of TIME & SPACE CONTINUITY

optical transitions. This result can be attained by

A film taking place in a single setting may be

simply skipping unimportant areas; by altering

told with time continuity only. A constantly-mov

spatial relationships; by ingenious editing and by

ing film depicting a race, a journey or a chase

imaginative story-telling. A simple dissolve may

may be told with space continuity only. Most

cover hundreds of miles. Filming only areas of

stories employ both time and space continuities

special interest, or different types of terrain. may

alternately. A picture may start out with space

give the audience the impression they are seeing

continuity by transporting the audience to a for

the entire trip ~ although only highlights arc

eign land. Then it settles down to tell the story

actually shown. Choice of lens focal length may

in time continuity. Even an expedition picture

drastically change perspective, the distance be

must pause at the various locales and switch to

tween objects or the relationship of the players

and the background. Clever editing may convince time continuity as the explorers make camp,

the audience that they arc viewing all the travel. study native habits, and carry out their assigned

Inventive story construction may provide means duties. Time and/or space stories featuring sim

of moving about in space, so that a great deal of ple, straightforward, chronological continuities

territory is covered; while the viewer is unaware present few filming problems. A complex picture,

that much of the travel is really missing. in which the story moves back and forth in time

Audiences have been conditioned to accept the and here and there in space, must be handled removal of needless travel, so that a player may carefully - so as not to confuse the audience. be shown leaving his office on the tenth floor and Most important - the viewer must never be left immediately dissolve to the street entrance. There in doubt where the event is taking place, and what is no need to show him walking down the hall, is happening. Only suspense stories are designed taking the elevator, emerging and walking through to confuse the audience, until explanation of the the lobby, etc. Or, space may be lengthened in a mystery in the last reel.

subtle manner, so that the audience is not aware

that part of the travel is repeated; for instance, FILMING THE ACTION

by overlapping several shots of a walk down a

short flight of stairs to make the flight appear TYPES OF ACTION

longer on the screen. CONTROLLED

,

UNCONTROLLED

CONTROLLED ACTION

Filming of any event which the cameraman

can direct or regulate is known as controlled

action. In this category, the best examples are

theatrical motion pictures. Sequences are plan

ned, rehearsed and staged for the camera. Each

scene is filmed from as many angles, as many

times as required; until a satisfactory take is

recorded. All esthetic and technical elements in

involved in filming the picture are under complete

control of director and cameraman.

u.....u, UNCONTROLLED ACTION

Subject travel need not be shown in its

entirety. Space may be shortened by depict Events which cannot be staged for the camera

showing only highlights of a journey.

constitute uncontrolled action. A newsreel of a

74

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

shows. The cameraman knows what will happen,

but has little or no control over action or staging.

Many shots and sequences in non-theatrical films cannot be controlled by the cameraman, and are best treated in newsreel technique. Engineering trials, field problems, flight tests, missile firings, military maneuvers, historical pageants, and similar events must be filmed just as they happen. When filming uncontrollable action, the cameraman must adapt his efforts to prevailing conditions, to record best coverage available. Standard filming procedures should be followed as much as possible to obtain technically excellent results. In completely uncontrollable filming situations, the cameraman may be able to choose little more than the camera-angle and lens focal length. Choice may be further limited by lighting fully planned in advance. All shots should be filmed from same side of action. Time, space restrictions, and physical dangers. so that line of march moves in constant direction. **FILMING TECHNIQUES**

MASTER SCENE

TRIPLE-TAKE

MASTER SCENE TECHNIQUE

A master scene is a continuous take of an entire event occurring in a single setting. It is a complete chronological motion picture - silent or sync

.. sound - of over-all action, from beginning to end.

~

Some scenes in engineering films - such as this static test of rocket engine - cannot be controlled. Multiple cameras should be used for complete coverage. natural or man-made disaster, such as a hurricane or a fire, is recorded just as it happens. Without

control over the subject, the cameraman is merely an observer with a motion picture camera. At Dramatic theatrical features are generally filmed with one camera; which records worst, uncontrolled filming is a one-take affair. master scene of overall sequence and later At best, it is filming of previously-announced closer cut-in medium shots and close-ups events, such as parades, beauty contests, air of individual players.

75

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

If filmed with a single camera: portions of the action are later repeated to obtain inter-cutting closer shots.

If filmed with multiple cameras: inter-cutting closer shots are filmed simultaneously.

HOW TO USE MASTER SCENE TECHNIQUE

Theatrical films: Generally filmed with a single camera because the action is staged. and may be repeated any number of times; in order to shoot medium shots, two-shots, over-the-shoulder shots and individual close-ups required for inter-cutting. Closer shots are set up and lighted to portray the players best from that particular angle. Both action and dialogue are overlapped for each shot.

Non-theatrical films, which the camera

Television films: Dramatic television films are

man controlled - such as missile

generally filmed in the same manner as theatrical launching or flight of prototype airplane pictures. Situation comedies and similar "stage should be filmed with multiple cameras, to front" material - in which actors perform for obtain various shots required (or sequence.

audience as if on-stage - are filmed with multiple

cameras, to record all angles simultaneously. Single cameras vs. multiple cameras: The choice lies not only with nature of material, but

Non-theatrical films: Controllable action, such

with people being filmed. Closer shots require as staged scenes, may be filmed in a theatrical precise duplication of action performed. and dta manner with a single camera and action repeated logue spoken in the master scene. Professional for closer shots. Uncontrollable action, such as actors are able to repeat their performance any field tests, may be filmed with multiple cameras, number of times for various shots required. Ama to record all angles simultaneously.

teur actors. company personnel. people performing in a documentary film, may not be able to duplicate their action or speech. Therefore, it is better to employ multiple cameras whenever subsequent matching of tnter-cuttling scenes may be a problem. There is no question about using multiple cameras to film one-time events that cannot be repeated - a missile launching. a static rocket engine test, an ad lib speech - so that all angles are covered. Sequences in a documentary film utilizing amateur actors, may often be advantageously filmed with multiple cameras, to insure editorial matching.

Single camera should be used on any staged action which can be precisely duplicated for closer shots. Multiple cameras should be used for news Non-theatrical films - such as this report events, quiz shows, panel programs, round-table of Titan IIIC checkout activities being discussions, question-and-answer sessions, engi photographed by RCA cameramen - may

be filmed willi single camera, when action neering tests; or whenever people being filmed is undercontrol ofcamera crew. may not be capable of exact repetition of their

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~ ~ ~... -.-~~~~~: "/:..X__

Round-table discussions, quiz shows, panel Theatrical cinematographers employ multi cameras to film tricky stunts - such as type sound sequences ~ should be [dmcd this simultaneous fall of six horses and with multiple cameras to record simultaneous riders - so that the feat need not be re-ously overall scene, and close-ups of individuals as they speak.

performance. Directors of theatrical features often use more than one camera to film complicated action sequences, highly emotional scenes, or tricky stunts which may be difficult to duplicate.

ADVANTAGES OF FILMING MASTER SCENES

The master scene and inter-cutting closer shots supply the film editor with all action and dialogue in a sequence in duplicate - both in long-shot and various kinds of close shots from different angles.

Thus, the editor has wide choices in cutting the sequences, since he may "open" up the picture and return to the long shot whenever he wishes to

re-establish setting or actors, or move actors to if a particular portion of a player's performance is new positions. Or, he may cut to a closer shot or weak. Or, dramatic emphasis may be shifted to a another angle when he desires to emphasize a player other than the one indicated in the script.

particular player's action or speech, or a fellow The editor will encounter few problems in match player's reaction. He may cut-an-action to move ing action and dialogue when performed by professional actors. Or, when multiple cameras are is covered in duplicate from several angles, edit used to film uncontrollable action.

ing decisions are facilitated. If unsatisfactory for Theatrical production personnel prefer the sin any reason, the sequence may be re-edited in an gle camera master scene technique because it in entirely different manner. sures complete coverage without costly holdups

The editor may even "improve" an actor's performance on the set, necessitated while editorial decisions formance - if required - by inserting a reaction are being made. Closer shots of portions of the shot of an opposing player; or go to another shot, action are easily repeated. Single camera coverage

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

permits filming the entire action in long shot; and stop-and-go in small bits. Even though the scene each cut-in shot with individual attention. Dupli is repeated later in short pieces for closer shots, cating action from two or more angles permits the actors arc allowed one complete run-through. re-lighting for each camera set up, so that best It is much easier to record a performance in this photographic results are obtained. way, since actors can repeat portions of the mas

The single camera master scene technique is ter scene,once a satisfactory longshot is obtained. preferred by professional actors,because it allows Precise repetition of action and/or dialogue in them to carryout a complete performance without closer shots is not always necessary, if camera interruption. It is often difficult - particularly men or director make a change after the master with highly dramatic material - to obtain a satis scene is filmed. If the player is moved into or out factorily sustained performance, when filming of position, and both ends of the closer shot are matched where they cut into the master scene, the heart of the individual shot may be cheated.

This is possible because either the master or the cut-in shotis used - notboth. Action and dialogue must overlap only where scenes are inter-cut. It is important that player movement out of and back into the master match-cut. This allows for second guessing when filming closer shots. Editors should be notified of any script changes.

Multiple camera master scene coverage assures perfect matching of action and dialogue, without regard to performers' ability to repeat scenes exactly. Uncontrollable action may be covered from all angles simultaneously. Lighting must be a compromise and camera set-ups are best when -.,,""P".

shooting more or less from the same angle with

Professional player,~ prefer master scene

tratment because it permits complete per different focal length lenses. Amateur actors, or formance without interruption. Later, cut company personnel, need not be concerned with in close-ups (below) are filmed by repeat repeating their performance, because every angle ing necessary portions.Actionanddialogue is filmed in a single run-through. Salesmen, lec must he precisely matched wherever they

turers, company executives, engineers, may all be
flow across cut from master to closer shots.

Hmooop,,",

78

CONTINUITY

THE FIVEC's

Multiple cameras should be used to shoot Players' positions, movements and looks
long shot and medium shot, or close-up, on must: be carefully blocked out in master
noncommercial action - such as flight test of scene, so that they may be matched in
prototype airplane. All cameras should be closer cut-in shots filmed later. Players
positioned on same side of action axis. should move into and out of closer shots.
filmed in least time and effort. Yet, sufficient coverage The single camera master scene technique does
coverage is obtained for editorial purposes. not readily lend itself to improvising as shooting
progresses, because closer scenes may not inter

DISADVANTAGES OF FILMING

cut with the over-all long shot. Radical changes in

MASTER SCENES

positions, looks, moves, will result in jarring

The several disadvantages in filming single jump-cuts. Since flawless master scenes call for
camera master scenes are far outweighed by editorial more rehearsals, they require more re-takes than
editorial benefits. shorter, less complicated scenes. However, a mis

Single-camera theatrical filming requires play take may be disregarded if the editor uses a closer
shots to memorize entire sequences; and to be capable shot for that portion of the action.

able of delivering their lines, making their moves, In master scenes, the ratio of film exposed to
hitting their marks precisely- and repeating their film used in finished pictures is greater than in
performance a number of times for matching recording a series of individual consecutive shots.
closer shots. Long or complex sequences should For instance, in a scene lasting several minutes,
be attempted only by professional actors, capable the film editor may use only the opening, re-establish
of sustained exact performances. Player and/or close-up shot once during the sequence, and return to the
camera movements must be precisely blocked out master for the closing.

and followed. Closer shots must be carefully planned If editorial requirements can be pre-determined
needed. Once player positions are captured in the when filming, there is no need to shoot a master
master scene, they must be duplicated in medium scene all the way through on every sequence. Re
shots and close-ups. Looks must be correct; and required portions should be filmed; and remainder
props, such as cigarettes, hats, papers, must be of the sequence walked through for positions, and

held or placed in the same manner, in closer shots. movements into and out of closer shots. If heart As previously explained, a limited amount of of closer action will definitely not be used, there is cheating is permissible; but generally it is best to no need for these portions to be filmed in long adhere to the master scene as closely as possible. shot. Thus, much shooting time, raw stock and 79

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

the same angle, with different focal-length lenses, There are few disadvantages in filming multiple camera master scenes outdoors on uncontrollable action - such as field tests or new equipment demonstrations - except additional film and processing costs. Ordinarily, this is the only way such events may be properly covered, so that the editor can be supplied with all shots required to put together a satisfactory sequence.

TRIPLE-TAKE TECHNIQUE

The simplest method for obtaining shot-to-shot continuity, particularly when filming without a script, is by overlapping the action at beginning and end of each shot. In this filming technique Master scene need not be filmed in its entirety - if most of scene will definitely be covered in finished film, with closer shots. regardless of the number of scenes being filmed, Doorway sequence may require entrance Action at the end of the first shot is repeated and exit only. at the beginning of the second shot; and action at processing can be saved. While all these costs may end of second shot is again overlapped at beginning be insignificant in theatrical pictures, they are of the third shot, Triple-take technique is worth considering in limited budgets of non very simple in operation, The cameraman need theatrical producers. refer only to ending of the previous shot; and Multiple camera filming of staged action - such repeat a small part of that action, to match be as television shows - requires much planning and ginning of the shot being filmed, Then, the end

rehearsal, so that both players and camera crews of the present shot is noted; so that its final hit their marks on every position. Camera set-ups, action may be carried over to beginning of the lighting and player movements must be blocked next shot.

out; to enable various cameras to record all necessary shots in one run-through. Cut-in cameras must use long focal-length lenses in order to remain out of line-of-sight of the wide-angle long shot camera. Some cameras must be dollied, or moved to other positions, during filming. Lenses must be changed, cables kept clear, lighting varied, cameras moved - noisettes!

Because of many camera angles and various player positions, lighting must be a compromise. Fully-illuminated action may be most successfully filmed in this manner. Low-key dramatic lighting can rarely be used, since it must be precisely tailored to each shot. Multiple camera filming is ideal for comedy, panel, quiz or similar shows.

Triple-take technique requires that action Disadvantages of employing multiple cameras on occurring at end of first shot - such as artificially-lighted interiors are minimized when picking up cliffing fool - be repeated at evercameras may be operated from approximately beginning of second shot.

80

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

Therefore, it is not the heart of the action during the shot that must be most closely observed; but movements at beginning and at end of each shot which must be matched to bracketing scenes.

Motion pictures are presented in sequences, not shots. While individual shots have their own value, each must be considered a portion of the sequence, serving only to advance the story. A

series of shots must be woven into a coherent sequence, without distracting jumps or breaks in the continuity. The audience should be barely aware of changes in camera angle or image size. As in life, the sequences must appear as a continuous flow of movement, from start to finish.

LLOILS

While cheating of both time and space during Action continues into medium shot as tool filming and editing is permissible. it should not be brought into frame. Scene progresses be apparent to the audience.

until machinist begins positioning cutting edge of tool. Action at end of medium shot

is repeated at beginning of close-up. HOW TO USE TRIPLE-TAKE TECHNIQUE

The triple-take technique may be used only on controllable action, which the cameraman may start and stop at will. While it generally requires a single camera, multiple cameras may be used on occasion to film additional angles, time-consuming or difficult action; or scenes impossible to repeat. Both theatrical and non-theatrical pictures may be filmed in this manner with the assurance that all shots will match-cut.

The triple-take technique calls for thinking in threes. As filming progresses, the cameraman thinks back to the last shot before filming the present shot; and also ahead to the next shot.

First the cameraman should acquaint himself with the sequence by having players walk through

This link-chain procedure produces a series of the entire action from start to finish, without interlocking images, planned to convey the impression of uninterrupted action when edited. If a mechanic is going to assemble a jet engine, he should Overlapping action assures perfect continuity. explain the work step by step - to acquaint the audience because scenes may be match-cut. The triple-take cameraman with the operation. Careful analysis automatically preserves cine continuity, since it of work and mechanic's movements will suggest

forces the cameraman to be constantly aware of the types of shots required for the various steps; the action at the beginning and end of each shot; camera angles that will best portray each part of and eliminates possibilities of jump-cuts caused the action; and where to cut the camera, and by missing or mis-matched action between shots. overlap the action.

While the middle portion of the scene is very It is usually best to begin and end the sequence important for story-telling purposes;start and fin with a long shot. Itis also advisable tore-establish ish of each shot cause most editorial problems. the long shot whenever the audience should be 81

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

Long shot should be used to establish geo Movement at end of previous shot should graphyof setting. It isadvisableto re-estab be repeated at beginning offollowing shot. lis!1 long shot whenever audience should Action should be carefully matched so that be re-oriented, because of major changes film editormay cut on action. in players' positions.

with a longshot. Itis also advisable to re-establish explored street by street,and building by building. the long shot whenever the audience should be Objects arc first viewed in relation to their sur re-oriented.because of a change in the mechanic's roundings,or as parts of a larger group, and then, position in relation to the engine; or the introduc perhaps individually.

tion of new tools; or for other narrative reasons. Obviously,it is best to cut aftercompletion of a If the camera stays in close, the audience soon movement - such as opening a door, sitting in a becomes "lost", and forgets location of the work chair, picking up a tool, moving into a new posi being performed. The camera should begin far tion, etc. The entire movement is then repeated back for a full shot, from a higher angle. Then at the beginning of the next shot, from a new the camera should move in, lower and around to camera angle. The film editor is thus given a the side, for medium shots and dose-ups. choice in matching the shots, since he may cut

By establishing and re-establishing with long before or after the movement, or cut on action shots, depicting the heart of the action in medium during the move. Certain movements should not shots, emphasizing the important portions with beinterrupted by cutting,because the natural flow close-ups; good continuity will be achieved. Closer of action may be disturbed. Usually, however, a shots will automaticallysuggest themselves when cut between shots can becarried by the movement ever the action becomes concentrated in a smaller for a smoother visualeffect. The movementmakes area. Moving in closer satisfies the audience's the splice less evident, since the viewer is watch curiosity for a more intimate look. ing the action, and will be less aware of a change It is natural to view the scene first from afar, in image size and/or camera angle.

and then approach the subject as interest in The cameraman should overlap all movements creases. This is equally true whether viewing people and not attempt to decide on editing during film ple, places or objects. Players are first shown in long. Such decisions are best made later on the long shot, in relation to the setting; then in closer cutting bench, where various possibilities may be shots; and finally in close-ups, as they relate with studied for best screen effects. The cameraman each other, exchange dialogue or perform some should overlap complete movements at end and action. Cities are first seen from a distance, then beginning of consecutive shots.

82

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

when edited. This can be handled most expediently if cameraman and players walk through the entire action, so that camera starts and stops may be pre-determined; and camera angles blocked out for the various portions of the sequence. Camera stops should not be made impulsively, and camera moves should not be decided after the scene begins; otherwise confusion will result. Players may have to hold frozen positions for an unduly long time, while awaiting decisions for the next move.

The triple-take technique requires the utmost concentration by the cameraman if he is filming alone; or by the director assigned to the task. The cameraman, or director, should attempt to de

Overlapping action - from one shot to develop a "stream-of-consciousness" thinking process, which projects the finished sequence in individual shots in the mind's cine eye before filming.

For instance, an individual may sit down at the end of a medium shot. He should again sit down visualized, and player and camera positions blocked at the beginning of the following static close-up. Out properly.

A worker may pick up a tool in a long shot. He should again pick up the tool for the following single camera method of filming, there are occasions

medium shot. sions when a second camera may be successfully

The cameraman should be sure that the action employed to film an additional angle, or a cut-in is performed in exactly the same manner each close-up. Two ~ or more - cameras may be used time: sitting the same way, reaching with the for a particular portion of a sequence, to record all same hand, turning in the same manner, looking shots required simultaneously. A tricky, time-con in the same direction. If overlapping portions of suming operation may be required in assembling the action are not performed in precise duplicate, an intricate machine part; a lengthy demonstra they ere useless. The editor cannot make a match tion may have to proceed without interruption; a cut on mis-matched action! Professional actors rocket engine may be ltrcd only once. Under such understand this problem thoroughly, and can be conditions, additional coverage is obtained only by relied upon to repeat their exact actions every using another camera or two, to film extra shots.

time. Amateurs or factory personnel, lab tech

ADVANTAGES OF TRIPLE-TAKE TECHNIQUE

nicians, engineers - and others recruited to per

form in a documentary Him - must be instructed The triple-take technique permits greatest free to repeat their actions in exactly the same way. dom while filming, because action may be broken and observed closely to be certain that they do so. down into small parts, and improvised if neces If there is no perceptible movement between sary as shooting progresses. Only beginnings and people involved in the shot, or if an individual is ends of shots require matching, so duplication of performing a solitary task, it is best to "freeze" the entire sequence is avoided. Film waste is held him in position at proper intervals; and to move to a minimum, and a higher proportion of film the camera to a pre-determined angle before con exposed to film utilized in the edited picture is tinuing filming. Such freezing and unfreezing attained. Off-the-cuff filming of difficult or long must be deftly accomplished, since it interrupts drawn subject matter is more easily handled. be the natural flow of action; and may appear jerky cause the cameraman need only concern himself

83

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

with three shots at any time. If all shots are prop the subject, and shooting required scenes with erly overlapped and action matched, editing prob least inconvenience to those being photographed. lems will be minimized. Filming in continuity preserves natural flow and If the subject makes a mistake, the cameraman rhythm of an event, and is almost always easier stops shooting, switches angles, and overlaps the for performing personnel unfamiliar with pro action transpiring just before the mistake occur fessional motion picture production procedures. red. The entire shot need not be retaken, because

DISADVANTAGES OF

footage up to the mistake may be saved, and only

the faulty action discarded. Only mis-played or TRIPLE-TAKE TECHNIQUE

tions of action need re-take coverage. While the triple-take technique permits filming

The triple-take technique allows filming the perfectly matched shots, it may get out of hand

sequence in consecutive continuity, as action in complex off-the-cuff shooting. This can result

progresses. Many industrial operations, military in a hodge-podge of odd camera angles, shots of

tests, assembly "nuts-and-bolts" training films, varied lengths, mis-matched cuts, poorly-chosen

progress reports - and similar documentary sub medium shots and close-ups, and other unsatis

jects - will present few problems if filmed in this factory procedures based on spur-of-the-moment

way. A complex machine need not be assembled, decisions. Cutting in the camera, and mentally

and dis-assembled and reassembled for close-ups. carrying both action and camera treatment, de

Achemical, electronic or mechanical test,demon mand concentration and adequate planning.

stration or experiment, need not be repeated in its Impulsive filming can create pitfalls. If the se

entirety for both long shots and closer matching quence is not properly planned, and the camera is

shots. If can be filmed under the cameraman's frequently moved merely to get away from the

control in chronological order as it is conducted; previous angle, the shot ends whenever there is a

providing the work can be stopped at any time, mistake; and the length of individual shots de

and the personnel will perform as instructed, and pends on how far performing personnel can go

overlap their actions for various shots and angles. before they make a mistake!

Through the triple-take technique, the camera If the cameraman concentrates on overlapping

man gains opportunities of moving in and around movement from scene to scene, the principal

action of the scene may be deprived of proper

attention. The result may be perfectly-matched

footage with lifeless character.

Constant shifts in camera angles and changes

in image size may be more easily handled out

doors, where daylight problems are minimal. In

terior lighting continuity, however, may be very

difficult to preserve, especially on location-filmed

documentary subjects, since lights may have to

be changed for each shot. Matching lighting be

comes involved whenever camera is moved back

and forth for long shots and closer shots of the

same general area.

If sufficient lighting units are available, the

long-shot lighting should not be disturbed. Closer shots should be illuminated with other units, so that a re-establishing shot with the original light

Assembly of a complex unit - such as

Explorer XII space satellite-may be filmed in set-up may be made whenever required. If with triple-take overlapping technique. the lights must be moved, their previous positions

84

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

should be chalked or taped on the floor; so that the film editor with the greatest possible variety they can be returned to the long shot lighting in assembling the sequences. The master scene arrangement. method is truly professional and should be used

The cameraman, or director, filming improvised whenever filming from detailed shooting scripts. action without a script to guide him, must be well The master scene method with multiple camera used in both filming and editing techniques. He should be used whenever the action is not must thoroughly understand the art of cheating under the cameraman's control; whenever an from both shooting and editing standpoints, so event cannot be interrupted; whenever it is desired that he instinctively knows how far he can go in able to stage a sequence in its entirety only once; changing action, angles, players' positions, props whenever amateur actors or working personnel, and other cinematic elements. Yet he must shoot who cannot duplicate their actions, are filmed; scenes that will match-cut when edited. whenever long shot and closer shots must be recorded simultaneously.

MASTER SCENE VS.

The triple-take technique with single camera

TRIPLE-TAKE TECHNIQUE

should be used whenever it is advantageous to

The master scene method with single camera film an event in a stop-and-go pattern; whenever should be used whenever a sequence is filmed inexperienced personnel perform a series of from a shooting script; whenever professional actions which are best filmed individually, when actors are employed, whenever all production elements ever film costs are a factor; whenever shooting elements are completely under control; whenever off-the-cuff on an improvised basis; whenever the sufficient time and unlimited film are available; cameraman can control the event, start, stop and whenever the director wants greatest range of repeat any portion at will; whenever it is difficult choices in editing the sequence; and whenever all to light, stage, or otherwise shoot the entire event of the action should be covered in long shot. in longshot; and whenever the cameraman and/or

On the surface, disadvantages of filming may director have sufficient editorial ability to cut the
ter scenes may appear to outweigh advantages; picture in the camera.

but a properly-executed master scene, with com The triple-take technique may also utilize multi
plete coverage in matching closer shots, provides ple cameras for any portion of the action that
Properly filmed master scene, with match Triple-take technique should be used when
ing medium shots and close-ups, provides ever filming industrial operation; which
iilm: editor with greatest variety in assem may be started, stopped and repeated- for
bling sequence. overlapping action from shot to shot.

85

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

the action may be staged in its entirety in long DIRECTIONAL CONTINUITY

shot - such as the beginning and end of a se

quence - and the in-between action is best filmed IMPORTANCE OF ESTABLISHING DIRECTION

in an overlapping manner. This means shooting The direction in which a person or a vehicle

partial master scenes, or certain portions of the moves, or the direction in which a person looks,

long shot action with a single camera set-up. The can cause the most vexing problems in motion

remainder should be picked up with triple-takes. picture continuity.If a complete production could

This will save considerable film. be photographed in a single shot there would be

Or, a master scene may run until the actors no directional problems!

fluff their lines, or miss a cue.Then a switch made A motion picture is made up of many shots,

to triple-takeoverlapping filming-returning tothe filmed from different camera angles and put to

master, perhaps, for re-establishing the over-all gether in a sequence - a series of shots - which

setting, or for an exit at the end of the sequence. becomes a chapter in the story. In turn, a series

Many possible combinations to meet prevailing of sequences is combined to make up the com

conditions can be worked. When in doubt, a

plete narrative. If an established move or look in

master scene may be attempted, with the assur

a particular direction is unaccountably changed in

ance that a switch may be made to the triple-take

consecutive shots, the picture's continuity will be

technique, if required. The cameraman need not

disrupted, and the audience will be distracted or

feel committed to one method or the other for the

even confused.

entire filming. The event should be analysed in its

An unexplained change in screen direction can

entirety. All factors involved - people, types of

result in a serious mis-match, in which players

action, length and complexity of event, lighting,

arc suddenly looking away [rom rather than to

editorial requirements, time available, budget, etc.

ward, each other; and vehicles suddenly reverse

- should be considered. Size of camera crew and

their screen movement, and appear to be going in

availability of camera equipment may also be in

the opposite direction!

portant, if multiple cameras are required.

Since the cameraman using the triple-take Even veteran directors working from a detailed

technique has already cut the sequence in the shooting script will often rely on the director of

camera, little or no choice is left the film editor. photography for screen direction, so that actors

The editor may either use a shot or discard it; or and vehicles are sure to look and move in the

he may dissolve to cover a jump-cut created by correct direction. A cameraman shooting off-the

eliminating footage which is undesirable. Other cuff can get into serious directional trouble if he

choices are the use of protection or reaction shots fails to pay particular attention to this highly

which the cameraman may have seen fit to film. important filming problem. Once it is thoroughly

understood and given proper attention, directional

The master scene technique offers the editor

continuity can be easily mastered. There is no bet

unlimited selection to cut the sequence in any

ter way for a cameraman to win the respect of a

number of ways, because each portion of the action

film editor than by delivering footage which will

is covered in long shot as well as medium shots,

close-ups and additional angle shots. In either "cut together" without the need of optical {lop

case, the cameraman should furnish the film edit overs, or other reversing editing tricks - necessary

tor with sufficient cut-in and cut-away close-ups, for salvaging carelessly-filmed footage.

to help shorten the sequence, or to cover contt A motion picture lives in a world of its own.

natty lapses. There is only a single viewpoint: the lens of the

In the final analysis, the triple-take technique camera. How the camera sees the subject is im

allows more leeway during filming; but the master portant - not how it appears in actuality. In cer

scene technique provides greater editing freedom, tain instances, it is necessary to film the subject

86

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

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I tain instances, it is necessary to film the subject traveling in the wrong direction, so that it will

I appear correctly on the screen¹Action is judged only by its screen appearance; by the way it should look - and not the way it actually appears while being filmed.

SCREEN DIRECTION

There are two types of screen directions:

DYNAMIC (Bodies in motion)

STATIC (Bodies at rest)

DYNAMIC SCREEN DIRECTION

Constant; either left-to-right or right-to-left

Contrasting; both left-to-right and right-to-left

Neutral; toward or away from the camera

Constant screen travel depicts subject motion

in one direction only. A series of shots of a person walking, a car driving, a plane flying - should move in the same direction to show progression.

If a shot suddenly depicts the person or vehicle moving in the opposite direction to that previously established, the audience will receive the impression that the moving subject has turned around, and is returning to the starting point!

Once screen direction is established for a particular travel pattern it should be maintained.

This holds true for two shots, a series of consecutive shots, or a single shot inserted at intervals in the narrative. The narrative may be concerned

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Subject should move in a constant direction. Established screen direction should be maintained - either left-to-right or right-to-left maintained throughout a travel sequence, to show progression. regardless of camera angles.

87

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

Contrasting screen travel may be used to show subject going and returning.

Left scene depicts group traveling from Group at right is returning home - in home to town. opposite direction.

solely with activity inside a train, but whenever - perhaps from his home to town and back again.

the moving train is shown - it must move in a Both travel directions should be decided before constant direction. The train may enter from the scenes are filmed, so that whenever the sub screen left, move across the screen in a left-to right appears walking or riding, he comes and goes right direction, and exit screen right. Camera angles may be varied, long shots of the train may be established as left to right. Town to home would intermingled with close-ups of its drive wheels be filmed right to left.

but direction of movement must not be changed. This would apply regardless of camera angles,

When cutting from an exterior of the moving whether long shot or close-up - or if only player's train to an interior shot, the camera should shoot horse's feet are shown! The audience will be oriented from the same side of the train for a smoother transition that town is toward the right and home is transition. Later, the camera angles may be varied toward the left.

as the interior sequences continues. If, however, Later, a group of men may be shown leaving the camera were to cut abruptly from an exterior town and going right to left. The audience will shot of the train moving in one direction to an automatically assume that they are headed for interior shot showing the people (and the view the subject's home because they are riding in that through the window) moving in the opposite direction. Travel direction for both coming and rection ~ it would create the impression that the going must be consistently the same, however train were suddenly going backwards! many times the action returns to the same locale.

Contrasting screen travel depicts subject moving This is just as important in documentary films tion in opposite directions when necessary to show showing airplanes leaving their base and return a person or vehicle .Going and returning; or when ing. Or, in depicting raw materials arriving at a ever two subjects must be shown moving toward plant and finished products being shipped out to each other. In order to establish and maintain market. Camera angles and types of shots may be both directions of travel, think of screen travel in varied, but the subject must come and go in

terms of "comings and goings" (a descriptive and established directional pattern, maintained phrase used by early film makers) which must be throughout the picture. An oriented audience will strictly followed. The subject may go and return be confused if travel movement is switched.

88

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

also because the audience is properly oriented through earlier establishment of directions - town toward right and ranch toward left. By judicious use of opposing screen travel, the audience will always assume that the two opposite moving images will meet - unless otherwise informed through dialogue or other means.

Contrasting screen direction may employ moving opposition to build suspense, predict a clash, or contribute dramatic impact to the narrative.

Suspense can be built by showing hero and villain approaching each other for a show-down. A clash can be predicted by showing Indians and cavalry galloping toward each other. Dramatic impact can

be increased by introducing two football teams

Audience will assume that group of men trotting on to the field from opposite directions.

shown leaving town, traveling right to left,

While individual shots may not be suspenseful, are headed for subject's home - because

they are riding in that direction. clashing or dramatic in themselves, they will help build toward climactic meetings. This can be achieved

Contrasting screen travel is also employed to be accomplished with visual simplicity, without need depict opposing subjects moving toward each other for forceful dialogue or narration. A cameraman other. Opposing screen movements are generally filming on his own, or a director shooting from a edited in an alternating pattern, to portray movie detailed script, should use contrasting directional moving subjects that will meet or clash. The hero continuity. Thus, the film editor is supplied with a leaves his ranch, riding left to right. Next, the dramatically-fashioned series of scenes, filmed to heroine is shown leaving town, right to left. The film fits a definite editing pattern.

audience will correctly assume that they are riding. Series of opposing action shots, such as Indians riding toward each other, and will meet. This effect and cavalry, should be filmed with progressively closer shots as the action reaches its climax. Such contrasting screen travel may be used to show opposing subjects moving toward each other. Moving opposition-edited in alternate pattern-may predict a clash.

89

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

closer-and-closer shots may be cut shorter and neutral condition between two shots moving in shorter, so that the sequence builds from lengthy opposite directions.

long shots to shorter medium shots. to clipped Head-on and tail-away shots, in which a person close-ups and a frenzied finish. The viewers' emotion walks or runs directly toward the camera and tions are excited by the acceleration editing pattern covers the lens, so that the screen is blacked out; and involved even more deeply as the camera or, walks directly away from the camera so that camera moves into the clashing climax. the lens is uncovered and the setting is revealed

Neutral screen direction depicts moving subjects have limited use for chase sequences, or for projects traveling toward or away from the camera. avoiding fade-in or fade-out effects.

Since neutral movements are non-directional, Tracking shots, in which the camera moves they may be inter-cut with scenes showing movement directly ahead, or directly behind the player or movements in either direction. The following are neutral vehicles, are neutral if the subject does not enter screen movements:

Head-on and tail-away shots, in which the subject moves directly toward or away from the camera. Such shots are neutral only as long as the moving image remains centered in the frame. An entrance or exit will denote direction. The front or rear of the moving subject should be depicted for an absolutely neutral effect. If one side is seen, such as the side of a horse or a car, the direction of travel will be indicated. A head-on shot may begin neutral and then exit one side of the picture to match-cut with a following directional shot. Or, a tail-away shot may enter one side of the picture and then become neutral as it moves away from the lens. Such shots may be used deliberately to

If head-on subject exits frame - proper
switch screen direction, by presenting a temporary
exit side is important to preserve established
screen direction. Rider, above, must
exit right side of frame in order to travel
left-to-right in next shot, below.

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Head-on shots - depicting subject moving
toward camera - are neutral in screen direction.

90

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

Subject movement is neutral when camera travel movement is neutral when filmed
tracks directly ahead of walking players. from high downward angle so, that subject
exits bottom of frame.

or exit the frame. Either a front or rear view is
depicted. If a side or three-quarter angle is filmed,
High or low angle shots in which the moving
one side of the subject is favored, so that the shot
subject travels directly toward and under or over
will indicate direction of travel.

the camera, so that it exits either bottom or top of
the frame. A car filmed from a high angle may
travel directly under the camera. A train or a
jumping horse may travel directly over the top of
a low-angled camera.

Tracking shots: Camera

#1 films front three-quarter
angle depicting walking
player moving left to right.

Camera #2 films neutral head-on shot; Camera #3 films neutral tail-away shot. If player walks into or out of neutral shots; he must enter from left of Camera #3, and exit right of Camera #2 to preserve left-to-right directional travel.

Directional travel is neutral when two or more players walk abreast toward camera, and then split up to exit both sides of frame.

91

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

effect a greater depth than cross-screen shots. Head-on and tail-away tracking shots offer welcome changes from the usual three-quarter side angle. High or low angles, in which the moving subject goes under or over the camera, furnish contrast to eye-level shots.

To provide greater audience impact. Head-on shots place the viewer dead center, with the action advancing toward him. An on-rushing train or a jumping horse, which exits at top of frame, will jar the audience into increased involvement with the screen action.

To distract the audience. A sequence depicting subject travel in a constant direction, is often filmed with one or more shots moving in the opposite direction. This may be due to carelessness, light conditions, backgrounds, poor planning - or it may be intended by the director or camera

man. A neutral shot inserted between shots moving

Directional travel is neutral when several subjects moving in opposite directions will distract the audience. When players enter frame from both sides momentarily. Head-on, tail-away, or front or rear camera and join up going directly away. Tracking shots will allow the editor to reverse completely the original screen movement; without the

Shots of groups of people, or two or more

abruptness of a direct cut from a shot moving in vehicles, traveling abreast - which advance to one direction, to another shot traveling in the opposite direction. The camera and split up to exit both sides of

the frame. Or, enter from both sides of the frame and join up going directly away from the camera.

An army may march toward a centered camera; and half the men may exit left, and the other half may exit right. A crowd may enter from both sides of the picture, and rush away from the camera.

USE NEUTRAL SHOTS

To provide visual variety. A constant left-to-right or right-to-left series of shots may be broken up with neutral subject movement. A head-on shot may be used to open a sequence by bringing the moving subject from a distant point toward the audience. A tail-away shot may be used to close a sequence, or a picture, by having the subject recede from the camera by walking, riding or driving.

Neutral/lead-on shots provide greater audience impact than angled travel shots, being images which increase or decrease in size as the subject increases in size as it advances. They advance or retreat from the viewer, and thus vary.

92

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

ACTION AXIS

A simple method for establishing and maintaining screen direction is by use of the action axis. Subject travel may be considered as a line on a map, or an imaginary line made by an individual walking down a hall; or a vehicle driving on a road, or a plane flying through the air. This travel line is the action axis.

If all camera set-ups are positioned on one side of this line, screen direction will remain the same throughout a series of shots, regardless of camera angle. The subject may travel cross-screen, or toward, or away from the camera. Directional movement will be constant when the subject moves in a constant direction: and contrasting when the subject moves in opposite directions. The relation All camera set-ups should be positioned on same side of travel axis to depict progression between camera and subject movement remains the same, providing the camera never crosses the action axis.

A picture shot from script should have all its travel mapped out before production begins. A cameraman shooting off-the-cuff should take particular care to establish and maintain screen direction, so that all travel will match-cut. If travel shots are not filmed according to pre-conceived plan, the resulting series of scenes may be a hodge-podge of opposing movements, which will prove difficult to edit. Matching movement is just as important in two shots of a person walking down the street, as in a long series of scenes. Once the left-to-right or right-to-left directional movement is established, it can be maintained throughout a series of shots, by remaining on the same side of the action axis. A new location will step. ~ ~ hows her entering frame from screen

left - to preserve established left-to-right
requiredrawing a new axis, and remaining on the
travel direction.

same side as the original axis to preserve estab
lished travel direction. Many cameramen and di

An exception to crossing the action axis occurs
rectors think of the axis as a directional left-to
when twoor more players walk abreast or ride side
right or right-to-left movement, rather than an

by side. The camera may track directly ahead or

imaginary line. While this is the same, it compli behind the moving players, to film neutral shots.

cates the work: because the travel movement Or, it may track alongside to shoot a three-quarter
must be considered every time the camera is front angle - which will depict travel direction.

moved to a new set-up. If the camera is always Whenever the players look at each other, an axis
positioned on the same side of the axis, the proper may be drawn through them (based on two-shot
travel direction will be filmed automatically. axis explained in Static Screen Direction).

93

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

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Exception to crossing action axis occurs
when two players look at each other as
they walk or ride. Two-shot static action
axis should be drawn through moving
players. Camera may be positioned on
either side of travel axis to shoot opposing
shots of moving players - in the same
manner that they would be filmed. standing
still.

The camera may then be switched to the opposite
side of the travel axis, to film the players from an
opposing angle. Although consecutive shots of the
players may show them moving in opposing screen
directions, the audience will not be confused. The
camera may be safely switched to opposing angles

when filming walking players, or players seated in a vehicle. It is best to establish the moving players or vehicle in a long or medium shot; and then move in for a two-shot from the same side of the axis. An opposing two-shot from the other side may then be filmed, based on the axis drawn through the players. Individual opposing close-ups may also be filmed, if desired. The camera should return to a two-shot from the original side of the axis, before filming a final long shot or medium shot. Thus, shots moving in the opposite direction - filmed from the other side of the travel axis _

Camera #1 films head-on shot of walking player. Player exits screen right to establish left-to-right directional travel.

94

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

HOW CAMERA SET-UPS CAN BE USED

TO ESTABLISH & MAINTAIN

PROPER SCREEN DIRECTION

ON MOVING PLAYER OR VEHICLE

Camera #2 shows player in front three-quarter angle as he enters from screen left, crosses screen and exits screen right. This angle is excellent for tracking a moving player or vehicle.

Camera #5 depicts player entering frame screen left and walking away from lens in tail-away shot, as he enters building. Player may be filmed with any or all of these

Camera #3 records player moving left to right across screen. Shot may be static, or travel left-to-right - regardless of whether camera may be static for entrance, pan static or moving shot; long shot, medium

player for SHOT distance, and hold static shot or close-up; or whether player is moving toward or away from camera.

95

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

Camera should remain on same side of Constant care is required when filming travel axis to show player leaving building curving movement. If camera viewpoint is not return to starting point. Player moves allowed to cross travel axis, camera photo in contrasting right-to-left screen direction. graphs moving subject from opposite side Head-on or tail-away shots may be filmed - moving in the wrong direction. View in same manner. point should cross axis only when subject movement curves back and rights itself.

subject entering and exiting the same side of the

ACTION AXIS ON CURVES

frame - should be avoided. It will not Inter-cut

Preserving the directional movement on curves with other shots moving in a constant direction. requires careful camera placement. Curves can be A curve may be utilized, however, for a deliberate switch in screen direction when required, curve, and place the lens viewpoint on the opposite side of the axis. The switch may serve as an editorial transition site side of the axis. If this occurs, it is the same between two series of travel shots moving in opposite directions; yet intended to depict continuous action. A subject moving left to right would be filmed against screen direction, In this case, the entrance across the curve moving right to left. This would be correct, but the subject would curve back and exit the same side of the frame; and entire curving movement is included, so that the inter-cut with the following shot going in the opposite direction. The audience will accept this and then resuming the proper left-to-right direction. A closer shot of the Curves may be an asset or a liability, Curves moving subject filmed across the curve would offer the cameraman an opportunity for filming beautiful curving movements offering variety from straight-line travel. Film a correct entrance, a correct exit an opposite movement during the shot; but it to maintain established directional continuity, A subject should right itself and curve back, so that the closer shot records a portion of the movement in original direction is again filmed when the subject crosses the curve, It will depict the subject moving

exits the frame. A moving subject may be filmed in the opposite direction, Do shoot across a curve. moving in opposite directions as it follows the however, to film the subject moving correctly, and curve. providing it enters and exits the frame cor then curving around and exiting the wrong side reedy, A camera set-up on a curve - filming the if a change in screen direction is required,

96

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

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LEFTTO RIGHT

RIGHTTO LEFT

Curve may be used to switch travel dircc non deliberately. Camera #1 is set up on wrong side of travel axis - so that its view Camera #1is positioned on proper side of point crosses axis optically,and filmsmov travel axis - to film subject moving left to ing subject witht correct left-to-right move rictu: Camera # 1'.~ viewpoint crosses axis ment at beginning of shot. Subject then

optically, and films subject from wrong curves in front of Camera # 1, and travels side - moving in opposite direction. Camera in opposite direction - right to left. Subject enters frame, and will match-cut with: subject that subject is shown turning and moving traveling right-to-left, correctly when crossing camera and exits.

A curve may be utilized, however, for a deliberate ACTION AXIS ON CORNERS create switch in screen direction when required. A person or vehicle turning a corner may be The switch may serve as an editorial transition filmed head-on, so that the moving subject turns between two series of travel shots moving in in front of the camera. If filmed tail-away, how opposite directions; yet intended to depict continuous. The turn will require two shots - to depict constant screen direction. In this case, the entrance the subject going away from the camera, turning would be correct, but the subject would curve the corner and being picked up in a head-on shot around and exit the same side of the frame; and around the corner. The axis should be drawn inter-cut with the following shot going in the around the corner, and the camera positioned on opposite direction. The audience will accept this the same side for both shots. In a tail-away shot natural change in screen direction, the lens may view the turn across the axis, as on

97

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

a curve. This can be handled editorially by cutting on the turn. The moving subject may begin the turn in the tail-away shot, and be picked up around the corner in a head-on shot. The reverse travel at beginning of turn is of no consequence. A corner may be used in the same manner as a curve, to switch directional movement deliberately. If a change in direction is desirable for editorial or other reasons, the moving subject should be allowed to exit the frame asviewed from across the exit, so that subject moves in the opposite direction to that established. This will

work best on wide turns, where the moving subject will travel enough distance to establish the new direction before it exits.

Camera #1 pans to follow player around corner. Camera #2 films tail-away shot: player entering (from screen right, to establish right-to-left travel). Camera #3 films rear three-quarter angle - with player moving right to left. Camera #3's viewpoint crosses axis, and films player moving in opposite direction after rounding corner. This may be used on wide turn to switch direction deliberately. Optical axis cross may be avoided by cutting film on turn to Camera #4, which shoots (from three-quarter angle). Camera #5 films head-on shot. Player must exit screen left, to preserve original right-to-left travel movement. These camera set-ups may be used in various combinations.

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98

## CONTINUITY

### THE FIVE C's

#### ACTION AXIS THROUGH DOORWAYS

Established directional movement need not be maintained when subjects go through doorways.

Many cameramen and directors feel that this creates a "new deal" because the moving subject enters a new setting. If the movement is filmed cross-screen, it will appear smoother if the camera remains on the same side of the axis on consecutive shots - filmed on opposite sides of a door. If the moving subject exits one room in a tail-away shot, and enters another room in a head-on shot; the directional movement may be switched with

out difficulty. Rooms and doors in actual buildings and studio sets should be checked, to be certain that sufficient room is available for positioning the camera properly on cross-screen exits and entrances. Whenever difficulty arises, it is fairly simple to bring the subject into the new setting in a head-on shot, and switch direction if desired. For precaution, players' exits should be filmed before breaking down interior long-shot lighting and moving in for close-ups. This is also important in exterior shots where lighting changes constantly as filming progresses. Don't discover after a series of medium shots and close-ups are filmed that an exit is required, and the long shot must be filmed again. When in doubt, it is best to shoot an exit immediately after filming the entrance. It is better to discard the shot—if not needed - than to set it up again.

#### CHEATING THE ACTION AXIS

At times, it is expedient to have the subject move in the direction opposite to that established; because of light, background or other production factors. This may be done if both the camera

Since doorways create a new deal, directional viewpoint and subject movement are transposed, so that they remain the same in relation to each other. Neutral tail-away (Camera #1)

other. If the subject movement is reversed, or if and head-on (Camera #4) shots may be the camera is switched to the opposite side of the used - with proper entrance and exit, to axis, the screen movement will be in the wrong maintain screen direction - or wrong exit direction. Both elements must be changed, so (Camera #4), to create a new directional movement. Three-quarter side angles may that when the movement is reversed, the camera be used (Cameras #2 and #3) - if play.

is photographing it from the opposite side: result is filmed cross-screen, and directional

ing in preservation of the original travel direction. continuity is maintained.

99

## CONTINUITY

### THE FIVE C's

#### ENTRANCES & EXITS

----- A moving subject should enter and/or exit the frame under the following conditions;

Whenever a series of moving shots are filmed against different backgrounds. An entrance-and exit provides the editor with progression from one shot to another. Players walking from one room to another - or cars in a chase sequence - should exit one locale and enter the other. It is impossible to depict progression if the moving subject is already in the center of the frame when the scene starts, and does not exit the frame during the shot. A series of different shots cannot be edited

Action axis may be cheated - to take advantage of sun angle, background or terrain - constantly center-screen - panned or tracked for rain - providing both subject movement and camera position are reversed. Subject a while - and left there when the shot ends. The may move in opposite direction, if camera moving subject would be suddenly somewhere else is moved to opposite side of axis. Thus, in the next shot, against a different background!

subject movement and camera set-up relationship

This is particularly undesirable when the subject relationship remains the same.

ject - such as a moving car - is filmed in the same manner; with same image size and same image angle, in both shots. In the resulting jump cut, the subject seems to remain the same; but the background abruptly changes. Non-theatrical cameramen occasionally try to save film by shooting

a moving subject in a pan shot, minus entrance or

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exit. The camera should be started before the subject enters the frame, and cut after the subject exits. Entrances and exits should be shot "clean" not just as the subject enters - and cut just before a complete exit. Cutting the film is the editor's function - not the cameraman's.

Cheating the action axis on outdoor shots must be handled carefully, so that sun angle and shadow should be followed by a shot showing the subject does not disclose the cheat. Considerable cheat entering the frame in a similar way. If the subject may be done outdoors around noon, or on enters the far side of the frame in the next shot, close-ups when reflectors or booster lights are used the audience will be distracted; because the distance to illuminate shadow areas on faces. Long shots, distance is too great to cover between straight cuts. made early or late in the day, may show long shadows in a direction opposite to that already carefully matched when straight cut. Two or more established. A late afternoon shot, for instance, players should follow in the same progression, if may depict the players walking westerly into the filmed going through doorway outside to inside sun with long shadows toward the camera. A building; or from one room to another. This may reverse cheat filmed elsewhere would have to be seem obvious, but during a long interval between shot in the morning in an easterly direction, to such camera set-ups, a mis-match may occur, match established sun angle and shadow pattern. unless notes are carefully taken and observed.

100

## CONTINUITY

### THE FIVE C's

A moving subject should not enter or exit the frame under the following conditions:

A series of consecutive shots against the same background may be inter-cut if the moving subject remains center-screen. Since the background remains the same, there is no progression - other than that shown within the shot. Thus, a medium shot or close-up may inter-cut with a long shot, while the subject remains centered. In this case, it is best editorially to have the subject enter the

Exit made close to side of camera- frame in the first shot of the series; and exit the frame in the last shot - to provide progression with bracketing sequences.

Individual shots of moving action - such as a man on horseback or a car in motion - may be filmed center-screen without an entrance or exit, if edited in alternate pattern with other scenes.

Progression will be shown by the changing background in different shots. It is advisable to make occasional entrances or exits for visual variety, should depict subject entering frame in same manner. Exit to screen left would be cause moving shots arc cross-cut with other scenes. followed by entrance from screen right.

When in doubt, an entrance and/or an exit should be shot to provide editor with cine choice.

#### REACTION CLOSE-UP

#### FOR SWITCHING SCREEN DIRECTION

There are differences of opinion regarding direction in which a player should turn his head, following moving action in reaction close-ups.

This often results in shooting it both ways.

The player should follow the moving object with his head, as though it were behind the camera. The player may be considered a member of the audience, viewing action on the screen. An airplane, flying left-to-right on the screen, would be followed by the viewer turning his head in the same direction. Since the camera is shooting a reverse shot, this results in a right-to-left screen movement in the reaction close-up. While this may seem illogical, it is correct!

Moving player should not exit close to side. Before close-up is shot, directional movement of the camera, and enter next scene at far of the matching scene must be confirmed. Player side - and walk cross-screen. Off-screen should follow the action as if it were occurring

distance is too far to travel between con  
behind the camera. Often, better reaction results  
secutive shots.

if somebody walks, or runs - behind the camera,  
so player has moving target and speed to follow.

101

## CONTINUITY

### THE FIVE C's

if necessary to polish the sequence. They may be  
filmed against sky or trees, without a background  
matching problem.

### REVERSING SCREEN DIRECTION

Established screen direction should be pre  
served, if at all possible; or explained, if necessa  
rily reversed. Contrasting screen directions cannot  
be changed without confusing the audience. Once  
a directional pattern is set, it should be rigidly  
maintained. Constant screen direction, is often  
altered inadvertently; or by production factors  
which do not permit strict directional continuity.  
Whenever possible, a switch in constant direc  
tion should be shown on the screen - to inform  
the audience of the change. Cutting from a person  
or vehicle moving in one direction, to a shot de  
picting the movement in the opposite direction,  
will confuse the audience. The switch in screen  
direction may be explained in the following ways:

Show the person or vehicle turning around.

Shoot across the action axis on a curve or  
corner, to allow the moving action to exit the  
wrong side of the picture.

Insert a reaction close-up of an observer view  
ing the movement in the new direction.

Use a head-on shot which exits the wrong side

Player observing moving action should

turn his head as if following movement occurring behind camera.

Reaction shots may also be used to distract the audience, so that screen movement may be switched to the opposite direction. In this case, the player would follow the movement occurring in the second series of shots. A sequence may begin left-to-right and later move right-to-left. If a turn around is not shown, the change may be covered by cutting to a head-on or tail-away shot; followed by a reaction close-up of a player supposedly watching the moving action going in the new direction. The neutral shot will aid in breaking up the directional pattern established, and the Established screen direction of moving reaction shot will distract the audience by "ex subject may be reversed by inserting a cut plaining" the directional switch. Such reaction away close-up of someone supposedly observing shots may be filmed after the picture is completed, serving the directional change.

102

#### THE FIVE C's CONTINUITY

An airliner flying from Paris to New York should be shown heading screen left, or West. A ship sailing from Hawaii to continental United States should be depicted moving left to right, heading East. The initial shot of the airliner pilot, ship captain, or passengers, should show them facing in the established travel direction. This preserves continuity of the action axis. Later, the camera may move around and show crew members or passengers from either side.

This may seem unimportant to inexperienced directors or cameramen, who question the validity of this proven theory. "Why can't the moving car, plane or ship be seen from the other side, going in the opposite direction, and still be traveling correct? Screen direction may be reversed by filming



rectly?" It can! But, why not take advantage of a

"head-on neutral shot, which shows subject

exiting wrong side of frame. This will serve pre-established concept, already planted in the  
to introduce new series of travel. Shot of moving audience's mind? This will make it as easy as  
moving in opposite direction. possible for viewers to understand happenings.

of the picture, to match-cut with the moving person. Moving an airplane, ship, train or car in an  
person or vehicle going in the new direction. A tail opposite map direction sets up - in the viewer's  
away shot would only distract the audience's mind - a subconscious disturbance, which warns  
momentarily, and is not nearly as effective because it tells him that the movement is wrong. The viewer will  
it does not exit the scene. be momentarily distracted, It is wise to keep the  
audience properly oriented, by establishing and

Effectiveness can be gained by cutting to the  
maintaining map direction on all travel shots.

interior of a car, train, boat or airplane; and then  
cutting to the exterior moving shot going in the  
opposite direction. If only one shot is used, it is

#### LOCATION INTERIORS

best to cut to a head-on view of the players. If a  
series of shots are used, the camera angle may be Shooting through the open side of three-walled  
worked around so that the final shot has the play studio sets helps maintain directional continuity  
players facing in the new direction - which will of players moving about the set, or going from  
match-cut with the exterior scene. room to room. Filming in multi-floored, complex,  
natural location interiors with a maze of rooms,

#### MAP DIRECTION

hallways and stairways often complicates direc

Travel over great distances should employ directional continuity. If much room-to-room, floor-to-  
ground map direction with East always on the right, floor or stair travel is involved; it is smart to keep  
and West always on the left. That is how a map all camera set-ups on the same side of the build  
is established in the human mind. Since North is up - so that the lens viewpoint is always in the  
and South are usually depicted as up and down, same general direction, and the camera never  
such directions are difficult to handle on a horizontal screen crosses the action axis.

horizontal screen. If possible, northbound travel Travel in any direction, even up and down  
should be staged on a line ascending from lower stairs, should always match, and players will  
left to upper right; southbound travel, on a line always move in a similar direction, in any part  
descending from upper left to lower right. This is of the building. If physical or other limitations  
in keeping with the accepted compositional conventions prevent positioning the camera on the same side,

cept of up or down movements. head-on or tail-away shots of the players should

103

## CONTINUITY

### THE FIVE C's

This ocean liner is traveling from Hawaii Jet airliner is {lying toward screen right to continental United State.~ - west to east. west to east - New York to Paris. plan - so that both constant progression and contrasting movements will be photographed in established directions. Established direction should be maintained throughout the filming.

While preservation of directional travel continuity may seem like a Simple task, it has pitfalls.

Long shots may be photographed one day, with inter-cutting close-ups made several days later.

Or, an entire series of traveling shots may be

The following sequence from Martin Rackin's production of STAGE COACH (released by 20th Century-Fox) illustrates how Dynamic Directional Continuity is established and maintained.

Train going from Chicago to Los Angeles should move right to left - east to west.

be shot; but they should enter or exit the frame on the side which preserves the established travel direction. Thus, travel toward the front of the building may always be from left to right - for instance - and toward the rear, from right to left.

### PLANNED SCREEN TRAVEL

All screen travel must be thoroughly analyzed before a foot of film is exposed. If shooting from a script, marginal notes should be used. Outlines, or diagrams, are most important if filming off Stage coach is established moving left to the cuff. It is essential to work from a definite right in a front three-quarter angle,

104

## CONTINUITY

### THE FIVE C's

Stagecoach continues traveling left to right. Reverse shot of opposite players is filmed in cross screen shot. (from same side of action axis).

Players are filmed from exterior camera. Coach continues on its way. Vehicle enters angle, from same side of travel axis. screen left, and exits screen right.

Interior shot shows players from similar angle. Pursuing Indians move left to right.

105

## CONTINUITY

### THE FIVE C's

Driver is filmed in three-quarter angle. Three-quarter angle shot shows attackers. medium shot from same side of axis.

Stagecoach must exit screen right to preserve. Cut-away shot reveals U. S. Cavalry cutting across established travel direction. entering on scene.

Coach is filmed in three-quarter angle. Shot of troopers maintains direction.

106

## CONTINUITY

### THE FIVE C's

filmed at one time in both directions. The camera man, or the director, who becomes overly concerned with background, sun angle or camera angle, may forget established screen direction.

The action axis is sometimes overlooked, in order to film a pictorially beautiful individual shot.

This oversight can be avoided if all shots in a sequence are thoroughly mapped, and the action axis established to favor the best camera angles, sun angles and backgrounds.

There is no need to sacrifice a particularly good shot in order to preserve directional continuity.

Sequences involving a great number of shots may be best planned by working backwards, and study

Indians are driven off, and cavalry escorts along the terrain where the climax will be staged. A stagecoach to destination. particular location site or building may require filming from a certain angle, which will decide the screen direction for the entire sequence. If this is overlooked, a switch in screen direction may be

made when the location is reached. The moving subject may be picked up in a head-on shot and simply panned around in the new direction. Or, it may be shown exiting the wrong side of the frame a shot or two earlier, and switched to the new direction before it arrives, so that subject is moving in the proper direction for entering the setting.

The entire terrain covered by travel shots should be studied for sun angles, camera set-ups and backgrounds, at the time of day that the various shots will be filmed. Only then can the camera

Stagecoach enters town - still traveling - make sure that he can keep obstacles at left to right. a minimum, while filming the entire sequence.

Travel sequences which include interior scenes of cars, buses, trains or airplanes, must be carefully planned with both interior and exterior camera set-ups in mind. A studio film may involve a mock-up of a vehicle which has an open side requiring that all action be staged against one side only. Or filming in an actual airplane may permit little room for camera angling.

A transition from exterior to interior - or interior to exterior - particularly the former, should be filmed from approximately the same camera angle - as if the camera moved through a window or side of the vehicle to look inside. The original travel axis is maintained for a smooth match-cut.

Interior shots may be filmed from various angles.

Coach pulls up to depot - left to right.

107

## CONTINUITY

### THE FIVE C's

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This sequence - depicting landing of Allied troops on D-Day  
- demonstrates right-to-left progression (in this instance dramatically stronger  
than left to right) throughout a series of shots - from landing craft being  
beached, to officers and men moving up into battle positions.

108

## CONTINUITY

### THE FIVE C's

**STATIC SCREEN DIRECTION** Modern motion picture production techniques,

Static screen direction is concerned with the way in which players face and look on the screen. shifted between shots, so that each portion of the  
The screen treatment of motionless bodies may action is presented from a different camera angle.  
seem incongruous, but even action pictures present In spite of the moving players and repositioned  
sent the players at rest, or at least in a static camera, it is necessary that matching shots be  
position while they talk or perform. filmed with a one-sided viewpoint. The axis is a  
The principle of the action axis is just as it means of remaining on one side of the players, so  
important in filming static set-ups of players as in that the players' positions and looks appear con  
sistent from shot to shot as the sequence progresses.  
Established directional continuity must be maintained, regardless of the player or camera move  
ment, not only when players move about, but also when they are at rest, so that direction in which a

The action axis is established by drawing an  
player moves, and direction in which he looks, imaginary line through the two players nearest  
match throughout a series of consecutive shots. the camera on opposite sides of the picture. The  
The position in which a player faces may not camera viewpoint and the players' looks must re  
necessarily be the same direction in which he main on the same side of this imaginary line in  
looks. A player may face the right side of the screen in matching shots. A sequence of shots  
screen, but his eyes may look over his shoulder may be filmed by placing the camera anywhere  
toward the left. It is important, therefore, to refer within the 180 degree arc which may be described  
to matching the look: when discussing static on one side of the players.

screen direction, rather than simply matching The camera may be placed near or far, film  
facing positions. A single player - or two or any number of players or a single individual, but  
more players - must look in the same direction it must not cross the line. The camera may not  
on each side of a match-cut, so that the edited sequence be moved 180 degrees from one set-up to another.  
shots will present a consistent appearance. A player may be moved within 180 degrees, a complete  
player may not look left in one shot, and then semi-circle, on one side of the axis only, every time  
suddenly look right in the next shot - unless he the camera is positioned for a matching shot. If

is shown shifting his look. the camera crosses the line and views the players

The action axis could be disregarded on static from the opposite side, they will be transposed on set-ups if motion pictures were filmed stage the screen so that a player seen on the right will front - with the camera viewpoint always from suddenly appear on the left. A close-up of an individual from the audience angle, and the players and setting visual player filmed from across the line will be visible only from one side. A camera placed anywhere recorded with a "fake reverse" or a look in the opposite where in the audience, shooting from any angle opposite direction to that previously established. and distance, would record perfectly matching A close-up filmed in this manner will appear on shots; since the lens would remain on one side of the screen as if the player is looking away from, the axis, and the players would be seen from the rear rather than toward, the other player. audience viewpoint only, never from the opposite Note that the camera angle, or point of view, side. Most live television shows and many filmed must never cross the axis. The camera itself may television plays, particularly situation comedies, cross over, however, to film a player in the rear of are presented in this manner, so that they may be the set, providing that the camera angle is in keep filmed continuously with multiple cameras. Working with the established action axis. This amounts to "This applies only to dramatic or other story type television to drawing a new action axis parallel to the original plays where the players relate only with each other across the original axis; and positioning the camera on the same

a stage. It does not apply to a live or filmed television

show. A simple method for shooting across the axis

show, where the master of ceremonies faces front and

relates with the audience. is to remember that the camera may move across

109

## CONTINUITY

### THE FIVE C's

Camera #1 films two-shot - girl on left,

boy on right. Camera #2 51100tSclose-up of

boy over girl's shoulder. Camera #3 shoots

close-up of girl over boy's shoulder. Cam

era #4 crosses axis and films over wrong

shoulder of boy- thus transposing players:

boy is now on left and girl on right.

### MATCHING THE LOOK

The reason for the camera remaining on one

side of the axis when filming two or more players

is readily understood, since it is apparent that

crossing the line will result in transposition of the scene. The player on left will suddenly appear on right - the player on right will appear on left.

Such an obvious mistake should be avoided.

Mistakes do occur, however, in filming individual opposing close-ups of two players because the look may cross the axis. This may happen in a close-up in which the player is facing the camera.

Such oversights can be prevented by positioning the off-screen player on the proper side of the camera, to preserve the established two-shot relationship.

Camera #1: Two-shot - girl on left, boy on right. The on-screen player will always look on right. The proper side of the axis if this is done. If the on-screen player simply reads his lines to another to film any shot that it could shoot from the original imaginary off-screen player he may look on the original axis with a telephoto or zoom lens. Thus the wrong side of the camera and be filmed with a camera actually crosses the axis optically, rather than physically, and the viewpoint remains the same. The shorter focal length lens simply allows a three-quarter angle, since the position of the player the camera to move in closer and film the same is facing will generally govern the look. A flat-on shot that could have been photographed with a p.o.v. angle may result in a wrong look, because longer focal length lens. The eyes may inadvertently shift to the wrong side.

liD

#### THE FIVE C's CONTINUITY

The eyes govern the look. A perfectly centered person facing the camera may look either right or left, up or down, or straight into the lens - without moving his head! Or, the head may be turned in one direction and the person look over his shoulder in the opposite direction. It is most important that the look be correct, so that opposing players relate with each other smoothly in a series of consecutive shots. Any change in look must be shown. It must not occur between shots, so that it is suddenly opposite to the look shown in the previous

shot. Matching players' positions and looks is an absolute requisite if a series of consecutive shots must be match-cut, so that an entire sequence is to Camera #2: Over-shoulder close-up of boy. appear as continuous action.

Particular attention must be directed to high and low camera angles, which may be required to film back-and-forth point-of-view shots of grown ups and children; or, if one player is seated and the other standing. The look must always be to the side of the camera, but it should be directed slightly above the lens by the player looking up, and slightly below the lens by the player looking down. Considerable cheating can be employed in positioning the camera for height; but care must be taken not to cross the action axis by looking on the wrong side of the camera.

Player movement into or out of a close-up must also be properly handled, or the axis may be

Camera #3: Over-shoulder close-up of girl.

Un;vo,H,0'so.C""'.C"O"" """"

Camera #4: Over-shoulder close-up Player may be given reference point for of girl. Players are transposed. look by holding fist at side of camera.

111

## CONTINUITY

### THE FIVE C's

Camera #2 films girl from boy's point-of-view. Camera #1 films boy from girl's point-of-view.

Girl's look has crossed axis, and created

Camera set-ups for opposing p.c.v. close

new look in opposite direction. ups should be very close to side of players, so that look is to side of lens.

crossed. This is particularly important when the camera is very close to the line - such as in the

filming of a point-of-view close-up where a player LOOK ON

is looking close to the side of the lens. Cross BOTH SIDES OF LENS

screen movements will give little trouble, because



they point obviously toward right or left. Head-on A player may turn his head from one side to movement sometimes appears neutral to the the other, and look past the camera lens - to player, cameraman or director; and it is very easy relate with players on either side of him; or to to make a mistake. and look in one direction and look from an on-screen player to an off-screen then exit in the opposite direction! To preserve player. The trick in sweeping a look past the lens screen direction in close-ups, where the player is to avoid looking directly into the lens. The look enters or exits the scene close to the side of the must pass just above or below the lens, depending camera, movement should always occur between on whether the camera is below or above the the lens and the action axis. player's eye-level. A professional actor will have

112

#### THE FIVE C's CONTINUITY

Camera #2 films girl. Camera #1 films boy.

Camera set-ups for opposing three-quarter angle close-ups are made from inipersonul objective angles.

no difficulty in sweeping his gaze past the camera without actually looking into the lens. Without careful instruction, an amateur may "sneak" a look into the lens, out of the corner of his eye!

Inexperienced cameramen and directors often hesitate to allow a player a sweeping look; because they fear the look may be into the lens, or the shot will not match bracketing scenes. The player

may turn and look on both sides of the lens any Player in close-up relating with off-screen

player must exit scene between camera and

time he is positioned between two or more players;

action axis. This is particularly important

or, any time he switches his gaze from an on

in p.o.v. close-ups because player is work

screen player to a player or action off-screen. For

ing close to the axis and filmed almost full

instance, he may turn to watch a player enter a face to the camera.

113

#### CONTINUITY

##### THE FIVE C's

Examples of QJ.is cross: Camera set-up :H1

depicts player with knife on screen left

girl on screen right. Camera set-up #2 has

crossed axis, and transposed players on screen.

room. or a car arrive. A new axis is created when Neutral look - above or below lens - may

ever a player switches his look at the end of a PUZZLE audience, unless player is looking

up or down at another player, object or

shot. The next shot must be based on the line

action. Neutral look breaks up normal

drawn between the player and the subject with

right or left directional look toward oppos

whom he relates. This is important whenever a player. Up or down look should be to

player looks at an off-screen player, who is then side of camera, to preserve direction.

shown in a cut-away reaction close-up.

thrusts a puzzling non-directional look at the audi

NEUTRAL LOOK

ence. The neutral look is so close to a look directly

Whenever a person looks above or below the into the lens that it may be misinterpreted. Cam

lens, the resulting look is neutral. A neutral look eramen and directors sometimes resort to a neu

must be used with discretion, because it suddenly tral look, to cover an inadvertent mis-match due

breaks up the normal right-and-left looks and to wrong player or camera movement. The neutral

114

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

CAMERA VIEWPOINT

MAY CROSS ACTION AXIS

Camera viewpoint may cross action axis to

film players in rear of set. Camera #1

films (III shot, Camera ::2 may be posi

tioned across axis to film medium shot of

rear player. ~. This is same as drawing par

allel axis or shooting across original axis

with longer focal length lens.

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look is rarely successful if both players are the down look should be to the side of the camera, to same height; since they must look at each other in preserve the action axis. The neutral look should opposing close-ups, and cannot look up or down. be used only in emergencies when retakes cannot It can be used if one player is seated, or if a be filmed, or when a cameraman or director must player is knocked down during a fight, or if a film a player looking up or down to match stock player is at another level - such as the top or bot footage which has not been chosen, or whose direction of a staircase or a mountain. A player looking tional look is unknown. If only a shot or two are up. in such instances, would look just above the involved, it is best to shoot the scenes twice, with lens. One looking down, would look just below the both a left and right look - rather than a neutral lens. Even in these cases, however, the up or look - so that the film editor may have his choice.

115

## CONTINUITY

### THE FIVE C's

**MATCHING LOOK ON MOVING PLAYERS** This is necessary because the players may change their positions. or camera may pan or

Matching the look on statically-positioned play dolly so as to originate a new look in a direction ers presents few problems, because the action axis different than that with which the shot began. remains fixed. When players move during a scene, The players, the camera, or both, may cross the the action axis moves with them, and must be re axis while filming is in progress because the audi drawn at the end of each shot. Thus, the action once observes the moving change in their posi axis may be further defined as a line drawn tions. However, the player, or the camera, may not through the nearest players on opposite side of the cross the axis between camera set-ups, because frame each time the camera is cut. player positions would be changed unaccountably, and the following shot would not match.

Anything may happen during a scene - nothing must be altered between scenes. Drawing a fresh axis at the end of each shot will automatically maintain matched looks, because the camera will always be positioned on the proper side of the line. To avoid a jump-cut, care must be taken to duplicate players' positions.

### MATCHING LOOKS ON

### MASTER SCENE CUT-IN SHOTS

When consecutive shots are filmed in chronological order, it is fairly simple to match the look on moving players. Difficulties sometimes arise when several cut-in shots must be matched to a master. Opposing close-ups of players with lamp scene. Matching the look on closer shots may be more difficult - between them, should not be tricky if a great deal of player and/or camera include portion of object, because it will move as occurred in the master. Since the action appears on right in one close-up and on left axis moves with the players, and can be altered in opposing close-up. Object should be by camera movement crossing the original axis, it is cheated out of close-ups or moved closer to one player so that it appears in one close-up is necessary that the axis be drawn through the up only. players at the particular point in the master scene

116

## CONTINUITY

### THE FIVE C's

where the closer shot will be cut in. If all player and camera movement is blocked out and filmed with the aid of chalk or tape marks on the floor, returning to any position and duplicating the axis at that point, is fairly simple. The Polaroid camera is a valuable aid in matching precise positions and looks. Stills may be shot during the master scene to aid the players and the cameraman. Particular care should be taken in shooting close-ups which may call for the player looking in one direction at one point in the master, and in an opposite direction later for a separate cut-in shot. Although such close-ups are filmed at one time, changes in direction should not be disregarded.

Multiple cameras should remain on same side of axis throughout scene. Opposing angles, above. will alter-cut. If players move about - such as in fight scene - so

that cameras shoot from both sides of new axis, below, players will appear transposed in film: film is inter-cut.

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Opposing close-ups of players should not be filmed with microphone. crystal ball, bowl of fruit, or other object. on table between them, which will appear on right in one close-up, and on left in other (above). Object should be excluded or positioned closer (below) to one player, so that it appears in his close-up only.

117

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## CONTINUITY

### THE FIVE C's

#### ACTION AXIS MATCHING LOOK WITH SINGLE PLAYER

FOR CUT-AWAY CLOSE-UP An individual - sitting at a desk, working at a machine, or operating an instrument panel \_ should be filmed with a consistent look in a series of consecutive shots. The fact that he is alone and not relating with anyone else in the scene makes no difference. The principle of the action axis holds true when filming an individual because the look must be consistent on each side of a cut unless the player or the camera crosses the axis during a shot and begins a new look. A worker operating a machine should not be shown first from his left side and then from his right, unless he necessarily turns during the shot.

Action axis for cut-away shot is drawn from on-screen to off-screen player. Camera # 1 films on-screen player. Camera #2 films off-screen player. Looks will oppose each other when on-, -crossing and off-screen

players are filmed from the same side of axis.

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Hmo.

Player looking screen right turns his head to observe other player entering room.

Action axis is drawn between on-screen and off-screen players. Camera should be positioned on same side of axis for cut-to close-up so that both players look toward each other.

118

## CONTINUITY

### THE FIVE C's

The featured person should first be considered over the left shoulder. If the camera were to shoot in relation to his work, so that the axis is drawn over his right shoulder, it would cross the line and in the direction he is facing. If sitting at a desk suddenly present the player transposed - facing signing papers, for instance. he may be filmed in the opposite direction - on the screen. The a front three-quarter angle facing screen left. The camera may be moved to the front for a head-on axis would be drawn through him in the direction shot. but the look should still be toward screen he is looking. The camera may be positioned any left. If the camera were moved too far. it would where within a 180 degree arc on the right side of cross the line and transpose the player - because the line. An over-the-shoulder shot - such as sign he would be facing screen right. ing papers or reading a report - would be filmed The person may turn his head in any direction during the scene. The camera may dolly across the axis during the scene. But, any shot that ends with a new look requires a corresponding axis for filming the following shot. Such a situation may arise if another person were to enter the scene, and stand or sit in a position that would create a new axis. It is wise, however, to remain with the original axis when filming one person in a static position, particularly for a short sequence involving only a few shots.

Before the longshot is filmed. it is best to check whether the individual is right- or left-handed.

Otherwise, the close-up may require shooting over the wrong shoulder to avoid hiding the action.

A right-handed person. for example, should be

Matching players' looks on master scene filmed over his left shoulder; so that the audience and cut-in shots is easier when players re may see what he is signing, or view what he is main in static positions. Looks must be doing with his right hand. Shooting over his right carefully noted if master scene contains considerable player and/or camera move shoulder would obscure the action if it covers the ment. act of signing his name.

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Camera set-ups are positioned on same side of axis, and players' looks are precisely matched in these objectively-filmed opposing cut-in closer shots.

119

## CONTINUITY

### THE FIVE C's

Person looking through window should have action axis drawn in direction of look. Bolli interior and exterior camera set-ups should film from same side of axis.

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Man at desk may be filmed with neutral head-on camera (or subjective into-the-lens shot, or for objective shot, in which he sweeps look left and right.

Multiple camera filming of machine operation should be based on action axis drawn in direction of worker's look. Cameras #1 and #2 film worker with same directional look. Camera #3 crosses axis and films opposing look.

120

## CONTINUITY

### THE FIVE C's

yo"...",...So.Col,•.c...",.0...

Camera #2 filmsover left shauider,Man is  
still facing screen left.

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----- 'Will- .....

Uno"••,,,O••.c.",.Coo,,,,.0'0'

Camera #1 films three-quarter angle of Camera #3 is positioned across axis

man {acing screent left. [i.lms over right shoulder. Man is trans  
posed - now faces screen tight.

Employing multiple cameras to film an indi side for all types of single shots - but should not  
vidual at work requires careful placement of all be placed on the opposite side of the axis. Then,  
cameras on the same side of the axis. so that the the entire operation would be reversed. Careful  
person is not transposed in some of the shots. A camera positioning is required if the event in  
machine operation, engineering lest or field trial, volves a large area - such as a rifle range. Al  
should be filmed so that the featured individual though far apart, the rifleman and target form the  
looks and works in a single direction. axis.The target may befilmed head-on - from the  
Even when shotwith a neutral camera shooting rifleman's point-of-view - but allcamera positions  
straight on, the look should be on the proper side on the range should be from the same side of the  
of the lens, to preserve the action axis. Cameras axis, so that the gun always points in the same  
may be positioned behind. in front of and at the direction on screen.

121

## CONTINUITY

### THE FIVE C's

#### MATCHING LOOKS ON

#### SPEAKER & AUDIENCE

Handling the action axis when filming a  
speaker - such as a master of ceremonies, an  
instructor, a lecturer - talking to an audience,  
differs from shooting a play or television show  
performed for an audience.

The actors relate with each other across a stage  
in a play. Aspeaker relates directly with the audi  
ence, when addressing them. An instructor speaks



to his class, as if engaged in a two-shot with each individual. Therefore, the speaker and each member

— — —

ber of the audience should have opposing looks, the same as in a two-shot. Difficulty in matching

opposing looks may arise because the audience is Neutral head-on. Position of instructor and spread out in a row. so that the speaker must look class. Instructor may look either left or both right and left to relate with members. The right, Individual shots of students should

be in an opposing manner- when

audience forms the base of a triangle with the

instructor looks left. student looks right,

speaker at the apex.

when instructor looks right, student looks

There are two ways to film a speaker and an audience. This is similar to a three-shot which

audience. Either method may be employed and breaks up into two two-shots - usually individual opposing close-lips.

Individually or in combination.

The action axis may be drawn down the center teacher or lecturer - and audience or class - with aisle. If there is no aisle, a center line may be opposing looks, as in a two-shot. Profile close-ups

drawn. The camera may be positioned on one side, of speaker and members of the class may thus shooting toward the centerline. This is the same as in a two-shot. Three-quarter angle and point-of-view

simplest method for presenting master of ceremonies, close-ups - similar to those in a two-shot - may Speaker and audience are depicted with opposing looks. Camera positions were

set up on same side of centerline axis. Speaker may also be filmed with neutral

head-on camera and look either left or right. Film should be edited in an opposing

manner, so speaker and members of audience appear to look at each other.

122

## CONTINUITY

### THE FIVE C's

stage toward the audience- with the camera close

to the axis, or from the corners of the room - for

angle shots, with the same opposing looks. This

method is recommended for classroom or short

theatrical sequences. Such treatment may become

monotonous when drawn out, because it lacks

visual variety.

The alternate method is to draw the action axis across the audience, parallel to any of seats,

TOW

or base of the triangle. The camera may be positioned anywhere within the triangle formed by the speaker at the apex and a row of people along the base. This is similar to a three-shot. This permits freedom to shoot speaker or audience looking

In theater scene (filmed from right: side of in either direction. The speaker may be filmed centerline axis, band conductor faces straight-on and sweep his look past the camera, screen left. Reverse shot of audience so that he looks both right and left at the entire should be filmed from same side of axis

audience. Members of the audience on one side for OPPOSITE. In an exchange sequence, will look left; on the other side they will look right.

the camera may be positioned (or neutral

shots or opposite shots looking in either direction. Editorially, it is wise to inter-cut the shots, so that directionally. Speaker on stage should be followed by a look by a cut with opposite shots of members of audience in the opposite direction. audience for smoother continuity.

Or, if several close-ups of the audience follow one

also be filmed with the assurance that the speaker another with opposite looks, the final audience will always look in one direction and members of shot should oppose the next shot of the speaker.

the class in the opposite direction. Long and me This should make for smoother continuity. as the dium shots of the auditorium or class may be opposing-look treatment is employed for matching filmed from the rear toward the stage, or from the consecutive shots of speaker and audience.

Master of ceremonies may relate with performers on stage and also relate directly

with audience. He may look left and right; Members of audience may look

in either direction. Consecutive shots of M.C. and audience should oppose each

other for smooth effect.

123

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

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Since stage speaker relates directly with audience. theater sequence should be filmed with centerline axis for opposing speaker-audience treatment - similar to filming two players in opposing dose-ups. Camera #1 shoots toward stage for long shot of audience and speaker on stage. Camera #2 films opposing long shot of audience from same side of theater. Camera #3 films speaker facing screen left. Camera #4 films audience facing screen Tight. Camera #4'5 viewpoint may cross axis optically - to film close-ups of individuals. Camera #5 films individuals on opposite side of theater with screen right look. All camera set-ups shoot toward centerline. to present: speaker with look toward screen left; and members of audience with opposing look toward screen right.

124

THE FIVE C's CONTINUITY

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Theater sequence may be filmed with parallel axis (line running parallel with

TOWS). Camera #1 films speaker. who may sweep his look left and right - to relate with members of audience on both sides of theater. Camera #2 shoots members of audience on left side of theater. with look toward screen right. Camera #3 shoots those on right side. with look toward screen left. Shots of audience and speaker should be trer-cue with opposing looks for best pictorial effect. Camera #4 films neutral shots from rear of theater. Centerline axis and parallel axis may be combined in lengthy sequence - for visual variety.

125

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

Medium shots of several people or individual In a long sequence. the camera may go any close-ups should look in accordance with their where. if mis-matched shots are spaced a scene locations. Those seated on the left side of the or two apart when edited. This can be handled auditorium should look right; those on the right because an auditorium is a fixed situation with a should look left. Thus, each member of the audience definite front and back, and the people are seated and the speaker are engaged in a two-shot, and facing in one direction only. The viewer will with opposing looks. Or, the speaker and any two not be confused, no matter what type of shots are members of the audience at opposite sides of the screened. or how they are edited. Results are pictorial room, may be considered engaged in a three-shot is more effective, and easier to view when which becomes two two-shots. The speaker turns opposing looks are presented so that speaker and from one to the other, so that his look creates a audience relate in consecutive shots. new axis for the following two-shot.

Neutral shots may be inserted between shots ACTION AXIS FOR THREE PLAYERS of speaker and audience - which do not present

Three-shots require special consideration in opposing looks. Neutral shots also break up the accordance with their staging. There are two types back-and-forth opposing treatment of directional of three-shots: with one dominant player who shots. The speaker may switch his look in a neutral shot from one side of the auditorium to the other; and the scene may cut with medium shot turns in dominating the scene.

dose-up of audience members with opposing look.

The first type occurs when a minister relates

Individual long shots of either the stage or the

with a bride and groom; a teacher speaks to two

audience should be filmed head-on for a neutral

pupils; a bartender serves a couple. Under these

treatment; or, from the same side of the center

conditions the dominant player should be posi

line for an opposing effect. Long shots toward the

tioned on one side of the screen, and the other two

stage and toward the audience filmed from oppo

players on the opposite side. The supporting play

site sides of the centerline should be avoided. be

ers are treated as a unit, and the set-up is handled

cause speaker and audience will face in the same

direction - not toward each other!

The centerline treatment is best for simple

sequences, as in a classroom. The parallel treat

ment, or a combination of both treatments, may

be employed whenever greater freedom in posi

tioning camera or more visual variety is desired.

Either, or both, these treatments may also be

employed to film any type of play, demonstration,

or staged action: where people on stage do not

relate with the audience. Such filming is less com

plicated, because the people on stage relate only

with each other, and the audience merely observes.

Opposing looks are not required.

The important point to remember is that the

— 0:- — —

camera must remain on one side of the centerline

axis whenever opposing looks are required. Or, it Camera shoots three-shot with players

spread apart, and equally dominant ill

may remain neutral for head-on shots. The cam

turn. Camera may cross axis optically to

era may not cross the centerline axis in consecu

film rear player - who may relate with

tive shots - because looks will be in the same either foreground player - hy .~witcliin.9

direction, rather than opposing. his look {rom one to other,

126

THE FIVE C's CONTINUITY

in an opposing manner - for example, with the at the player in right background, the look creates dominant player facing screen right, and the oth a new axis between them. The camera may now ers facing screen left. Over-the-shoulder, objective be positioned helween the two players on the right, orpoint-of-viewclose-ups may all be filmed - with to film a front-face dose-up of the dominant the same treatment as a two-shot - with the earn player. It is important that the look be directed era positioned on the same side of the action axis screen right - toward the far player - so that a drawn through the two players nearest the cam smooth cut results from the side angle to the in era, un opposite sides of the screen. The support between rear angle. Many directors and film edi ing playersmay befilmed together or in individual tors prefer a strong speech or action, which de close-ups - both with the same screen left look. picts a definite connection between the dominant When the dominant player - on the left - looks player and the far player. An action - such as serving a drink - is preferred, so that the two shots may be cut on the move, with an action toward the right to preserve the dominant player's right look. Inweaker situations, the camera should not be brought completely around between the supporting players - it should remain on the same side of the original axis.

The second method - with players spread apart and each dominant in {urn ~ should be filmed with a single axis. Thus two players will be in the foreground and one in the background. If the camera should cross the axis, one of the fore ground players will suddenly appear on the oppo site side of the screen and the rear player on the other side!The camera may cross optically tofilm

Minister dominates marrurqe scene - so the rear player in close-up, and he in turn may that it may he fUmed (rom both centerline relate with each of the players in separate shots. axis (above), and a parallel axis (below). Each two-shot may be handled individually with Minister 100l1s toward right, at DT0om, at

over-the-shoulder, point-of-view or objective close
up of shot (low), to preserve
ups, as desired.

screen right. look for smoother transition.

Then, let him switch his look to bride. when two players arc close together, they
should be treated as a single unit. Either or both
should be filmed from the same side of the axis,
so that they present the same look toward the
opposing player. A three-shot with a dominant
player and two supporting players may thus be
treated as a two-shot. since the dominant player
and the supporting players arc at opposite ends
of the axis.

When three players arc spread apart and each
dominates in turn as he speaks or reacts, each
must be treated individually and present an op
posing look to the player he is relating with at the
time. The three-shot thus becomes a series of two
shots - with each two-shot creating its own axis
as players switch their looks.

127

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

ACTION AXIS

FOR THREE-SHOT

Action axis for the scene. Camera #1 shoots
across the action axis (similar to the actor, with
M.e. facing camera and members of audi
ence on either side of center). Camera #2
may make optical cross to film close-up
of the actor - who may look in either direc
tion to relate with the actor on left in oppos
ite close-up (filmed by Camera #4),
or with the actor on right (Camera #3).
Three-shot may be broken: up into

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128

THE FIVE C's CONTINUITY

MATCHINr. LOOKS ON CROUP

SEATED AROUND A TABLE

Difficulties may be involved when filming a group of players scaled at a table, particularly a

round table. !!. closed circle of players, looking in
..... ward toward each other, requires filming scenes
... that arc staged with the editorial pattern in mind.

Such scenes should be well established, so that the viewer is not confused when two or more players - shown in two-shots or individual close-ups - speak to off-screen players.

The axis should be drawn through the two players nearest the camera on opposite sides of the screen. The camera runs across the axis to film a far player - or several players - by drawing a parallel axis. An individual player may look at an on-screen or off-screen player by drawing the axis from one to the other, so that they are filmed from the same side with opposing looks. If a number of close-ups follow one another, it is best to pull back.

Three-shot in which one person dominates. At intervals and re-establish the scene.

Camera moves from side to side; with dominant player facing right; (and supporting player facing left). The camera may move around to film individual players. Camera ~1 (film ~ entire table from each group. Camera ~2 and ~3 may film one or other; because the look of an on-screen player posing close-up, bartender looks or serves drink - to player in right background

around, new action axis is created. Cam

era :#2 films bartender 100hillg riolu to

nrescrnc oriainat lootc.

Player.~ scatedaround table .~II011ld be prop~

crly estchlished, so tlwt audience is not

coniueed cohen camera moves in (or mc

dium shots ami cloec-upe. Axi.~ should be

drawn bctioecti players retauun nJith each

Rurtender may later lum to player on left other, so tliat tilell are presented "lt1th

as scene Pffj~lff.~.~e.~. opposing looks in individual d ose-ups.

129

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

c/

If thre-shot is broken into two-shots - centered player will appear on right in olle twoO-.~JIOt and left in other,

toward an off-screen player creates a new axis. tioned on the proper side of the camera to ex

A player rna)' look in one direction. and relate change dialogue. The background may require re

with a player whois shown with an opposing look. dressing - with a picture - to suggest another

Then the original player may swi tch his look and wall.if it appears in other shots.

relate with another player on the other side of the

MATCHING [LOOK ON STOCK SHOTS

table. No confusion will arise in the viewer's mind

& PRODUCTION SCENES

if the scene is established and each set of players

arc shown with opposing looks. It is often neeessar}' to match stock shots with

Shooting a three-shot - followed by a pair of production scenes. A stock library shot of a large

two-shots which places the middle player on one audience may be used with production scenes of a

side of the screen in one shot. and then on the speaker on stage. Or, a picture may be made up

opposite side in the following shot - is not advis almost entirely of stock shots with freshly filmed

able. It is better to break IIP such shots into two cut-away reaction shots, or other scenes needed

shot and close-up;or into individual close-ups. to provide continuity or trunsntons. In either case,

it is wise to study the stock shots before filming

RE-POSITIONING ACTION AXIS the production scenes, so that properly oriented

FOil BACKGROUND CHEAT opposing or matching looks may be recorded. It is

Often, it is impossible lo shoot a reverse close advisable to project the stock shots; or to study

up of a player because of space limitations on a set on a film viewer. and make a detailed listing location interior, or the absence of a background with small diagrams depicting the angle and look on a two or three wall set. In such instances, the If possible, short lengths of film should be studied player may be positioned against another wall, on the set when shooting the inter-cutting scenes. providing camera angle and player's position and The best way to assure matching is to make a look match the original set-up. First, the camera mental pan from the look in the stock shot to the set-up should be plotted in the original position. shot about to be filmed. This will automatically Then. hath camera and player should be turned suggest the correct look. If an audience is looking around - as if both were on a turntable - so that screen right, the mental camera is panned to show the relationship is unchanged. In this way, the - in the mind's eye - the opposing look of the camera and the player's look remain on the same speaker, as well as the proper opposing camera side of the new line as they were in the original angle. If a missile or an airplane soars into the acts. The opposing off-screen player should be post-air, the reaction shot is filmed by having the player

130

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

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Three-shot should be followed by two-shot and close-up of single player; or individual close-ups of each player.

Camera #1 films girl. Camera #2 cannot film boy because of absence of set.

Both camera and boy are turned clockwise so that boy may be positioned against available wall and film'd from original opposing angle. Player's position may be changed, providing original player-camera relationship is maintained.

131

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

imagine he is seeing the action happening on the side of the axis. Or. a neutral shot may be inserted behind the camera. If a take-off or landing of an airplane between scenes filmed with opposite looks, due to the airplane must match a stock flying shot, the plane crossing the axis.

must take off or land in the same direction. If a Reversing the camera may be safely accomplished close-up of the pilot is filmed for insertion in a stock flying shot - the pilot should be faced in the direction with a distinctive feature - such as a staircase. a direction of travel. large doorway, a fireplace, bookshelves, etc. A

nondescript room. with similar walls, undistin

REVERSE SHOTS

guished furniture. drapes, or other accoutre

Because of matching problems they may cause, reverse shots may confuse the viewer. While a reverse reverse shots seem confusing on occasion. Positioning a camera on the opposite side of a set or new angle. it will present a similar background.

room - or otherwise turning a camera around so that it points in the opposite direction - deserves serious consideration, because it may transpose the players. Reversing the camera also introduces a new - and sometimes completely different background. This may confuse the viewer because players' positions must be re-oriented in relation to the setting.

Matching and editorial problems can be eliminated if the principle of the action axis is followed. Opposing over-the-shoulder and point-of-view close-ups, and head-on and tail-away travel shots, are filmed from diametrically opposite re-

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verse angles. Yet, through use of the axis, the players' looks and the subject's travel direction

Camera action must be recorded in any scene remain consistent. Accordingly, the simple experience with fixed shots - such as airplane or

direction of the action axis will automatically insure success on reverse shots. If camera is positioned, on

the camera angle may be freely reversed in one side of the centerline - it should remain on the same side for reverse shots, to

theaters, churches, courtrooms, or in vehicles preserve directional look.

autos, buses, trains, airplanes - because the people are positioned in fixed seats. Such settings have in common distinctly different fronts and backs - stage, altar or judge's bench; or front and rear ends of vehicles.

Seated persons may be photographed from the front, rear or side. The viewer becomes immediately aware that the camera - not the people - has changed positions. Even under these conditions, however, it is wise to stay on the same side of a centerline axis whenever possible - so that a uniform directional look is presented in all shots. The camera should shoot either neutral straight-on front or rear views; or shoot toward the front or back of the sculng or vehicle - from the same

132

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

It is usually safest to establish the overall scuing. In that way, the audience will know the geography of the room, and will readily comprehend the change to a reverse angle.

A reverse where a player, or group of players, walks toward the camera and exit - and are then picked up in a reverse shot entering and walking away from the camera, to cross the room - should be based on a mental plan. This would show that if the subject exits right, he should enter left.

Travel in a constant direction will show progression only when it is filmed from the same side of the action axis. This is the same as filming head on and tail-on shots for a travel sequence.

If a group of players remains fixed, and the camera films them first from one side of a room and then the opposite side, a different situation is presented. The players may look off-screen to observe a new player entering the room. Then, the camera may be placed behind them on the opposite side of the room - to show the player coming through the door toward them.

The players looking off-screen create a new axis between them and the player entering. If the camera remains on the same side of the axis for the reverse shot, players' directional look will be the same in both scenes. The camera may be positioned to shoot the entering player between two other players - from a reverse angle - providing the new player walks toward the group's look. A reverse may be accomplished with a player's off-screen look - which allows the camera to be turned around to show what he sees. A player may look past the camera toward the opposite side of a room - and the camera reversed to show the scene from his point-of-view. This should be filmed from the same side of the axis if the player relates with another player, so that they present opposing looks. This is equivalent to a pair of objective or point-of-view close-ups filmed as part of a two-shot - except that it covers a wider area.

Reverse camera set-up for U'r. ~ on crossing

1st important. in reversing the camera, the room should be based on mental plan. viewer should not be confronted with transposed Camera #1 films player, who rises from desk and exits screen right. Camera #2 players against new backgrounds. The scene films reverse angle - as if panned around should be established so that the audience is immediately aware of the type of setting - church, players opposite side of room.

133

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

Camera may be reversed: will encounter JfQ!JCJrIS - whenever it can be re-positioned on same side of Clc/irJl axis. Camera #1 film, ~ group of people _ u/no turn to observe player entering mom. It is drawn from player in group nearest camera to new player. Camera #2 films reverse shot, as player enters

and joins group.

bus, auto. Or, the camera should be positioned so various set-ups must be filmed with entrances and that a distinctive cutting feature is seen in an exit which match the established directional continuity overall view. Thus, later reverse will not cause confusion. All players - whether on or off screen must be presented in both cut-in and cut-away shots with properly matching looks, which leave

CONCLUSION

no doubt in the audience's mind where players

Directional continuity must be maintained and they are positioned, and to whom they are relating. The throughout a sequence depicting continuous action axis must be redrawn at the end of any action, without a time lapse. Player movements, shot where player and/or camera movement has positions and looks must match on each side of a cut caused it to change from the original axis. straight cut. Movement of players into or out of the action axis encourages rather than stifles

134

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

C

A

Camera - film group to observe
positioned in room. Camera #2 is positioned
toward players A and B (or reverse
angle. Entrance player should walk toward
players B, C and D, to prevent walk and
look toward screen right - to opposite
players' look toward screen left, filmed by
Camera # 1.

the use of camera angles. By use of this principle, the players
camera and subjects are free to roam the set, or may reverse direction or change looks or positions;
look in any direction - without fear of the wrong the players may cross the axis; the camera may
directional look. There are no restrictions on either pan or dolly in any direction: the camera may
camera or player movement. The most important cross the axis; both camera and players may
(act to remember is that player movement or move in any manner in any direction, in any
player looks must be the same on each side of a combination. Nothing should be cut between
match-cut. Therefore, the movement or look at shots. the players may not change direction of
beginning and end of each shot must be noted, and movement or change looks or positions; the cam

new axis drawn through players at the end of shot, era muu /lut cross the axis established by the
if it differs from axis which shot began. players at the end of the last shot. All this applies
135

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

which are edited alternately with other shots,
since, for practical purposes, these scenes can
continue. In the final analysis, directional conti
nuity consists of remaining on the same side of
either moving or static players or vehicles. so that
the established movement or look is maintained
in consecutive shots.

BRIDGING TIME & SPACE

Ordinarily, motion picture continuity should
flow in an uninterrupted sequence of images. It
may not always be practical or desirable to depict
an entire motion picture story in a continuous
manner. Films may entail meaningless passages,
which would detract from the story-telling, and
slow down - rather than accelerate - the narra
tive from Introductory opening scenes through
developing sequences and on to the climax.
Real, by-the-clock, time may be used in a con
tinuous sequence. However, cut-in or cut-away
shots permit removal or inclusion of action; with
out the audience realizing that time has been
compressed or expanded. Since motion pictures
are an illusion, no fixed rules can be laid down for
depicting time or space.

Regardless of how these elements are handled,
the audience should receive the distinct impres
sion of viewing events in their entirety. Even com
pilation films should present a continuous picture
whenever a series of consecutive scenes are to be

presented. Such an illusion must be properly con

era. Camera # 1 films place, it turns to reveal, or the story-telling spell may be broken. Look across room, it follows as it draws him. Whenever a lillie lapstrot or a ditty of locale must be explained, either within a sequence or between sequences. Cum camera #2 fills reverse shot from scene sick of it - it follows malliner 10 sequences. various transitional devices may be employed. It angle dose-lip, c. (it) for under employed to bridge time or space. anomic.

TRANSITIONAL DEVICES

only to match-cuts, in which the action is continuous from shot to shot. It does not apply to scenes PICTORIAL connected by dissolves or other optical effects; or SOUND

to scenes edited into other scenes occurring elsewhere. These methods may be used individually or in combination. to bridge time and space.

parallel axes are used. Whenever the action is interrupted editorially or optically, it is possible to

PICTORIAL TRANSITIONS

assume that changes may have occurred in the scene. Established screen direction should be preserved in a series of shot... - such as a chase - pictorial transitions is by use of introductory titles: 136

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

stating place and/or time to set the stage. Place first scene is balanced by a gain in image density name and calendar time. such as Omaha Beach, in the second scene. Dissolves are used to convey a jump in time. 6. 1944. would introduce a sequence show time lapse or a change in locale, or to soften the invasion of Europe by Allied Forces in scene change that would otherwise be abrupt or World War II. Dateless elapsed time may also be jarring. Consecutive titles are generally dissolved conveyed with the title: Five Years Later. A map so that one blends into the other. Scenes that may show progress at intervals during a journey, would appear as jump-cuts because of sudden or location of the event that follows. The scene shifting of the center of interest, may be dissolved.

may open on a place name at port of entry, air Length of dissolves may be varied to match dra pore or train or bus depot. Or. it may open on a matic tempo.

newspaper. clearly focusing on date. Matched dissolves, in which the two connected

Pictorial transitions may employ any of the scenes arc similar in form,motion or content,may

following optical devices: be utilized to effect a smoother transition; or to

preserve the narrative flow, by making the image

FAnES

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DISSOLVES

WIPE

FAnES

A [ade-m, in which a black screen gradually

brightens into an image.is used to begin a story or

sequence. A fade-out, in which the image gradu

ally darkens to black, is used to end a story or

seqU(. 'ncc. Fades may be of any length required to

fitdramatic tempo of the action.

While fades are generally employed in pairs

fade-out followed by fade-in - this is not a strict

rule. An individual sequence, several sequences,

or a complete picture, may be bracketed by fades.

This will se~reg:ate the various narrative units. Dissoine lllal! be llw,a to cover lime lapse

- ~llclJ as df'pictt'd in ,~l'qlll'1/(' of Navajo

Sequences separated by fades arc similar to chap

women cordino awl spinuillll w(Jol to be

ters in a hook; or acts in a play. Fades between

woveII into blanuets.

sequences occurring in the same locale, indicate a

passage of time, such as from one day to the next,

or weeks or months later. Or. fades may be used

to indicate a switch to another setting. Fades

should be used sparingly. or they may produce a

choppy or episodic effect, which disrupts the nar

rauve flow. Fades should be used only at begin

ning and end of a picture, unless the subject mat

tcr is divided into distinct time intervals, or nar

rauvcly separated in space.

DISSOLVES

A dissolve blends one scene into another. Technically, a dissolve is a fade-out superimposed upon a fade-in, so that a loss of image density in the

137

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

change less abrupt. Similar forms, such as flowers. If the story involves a news event, such as a and jewels; like motions, such as wheels and propeller; the image may be frozen by a still photograph: similar content, such as a match flame, a grapher's flash bulb. The frozen frame is then and a forest fire: arc effective combinations. dissolved to the still picture. revealed as part of a Matched dissolves should not be too tricky. Nor newspaper story - when the camera pulls back. should they draw attention away from the narrative. Unless their images stem from story, matched

WIPE

shots should not be used for transition dissolves.

In their simplest forms, wipes are moving optical

Distorted dissolves, in which the blending image effects in which one scene seems to push another away. shimmy, ripple, shiver, shake, twist, turn, go, other scene off the screen. The wiping motion may in and out of focus, or are otherwise blurred; may be vertical, horizontal or angular. Demarcation be employed to denote a sudden switch to a play between the two scenes. May be a distinct line, or a subconscious, retrospective, mentally-unbalanced soft blend. Wipes are also available with circumscribed, drunken, doped, or other abnormal state of mind, expanding, contracting, swinging, spinning, mind. Such dissolves, often accompanied by eerie rolling or twisting motions. Or, they may be sound. may be used to introduce a flashback, shaped like stars, flames, lightning, keyholes, A pair of dissolves should generally be used for hearts, spades, diamonds, clubs, etc.

bracket a flashback, flashforward or other abnormal condition. Wiping patterns may be continuous, or broken. A return dissolve may not be set up into several shapes within the frame - such as a circle in situations where the audience comprehends a series of expanding circles which merge to heralds the change; or it is desirable to startle or reveal the new scene. Wipes are mechanical transitions shock the viewer. If the same person, or group, tells several stories and always returns to the same setting, the audience may only need a dissolve employed in dramatic films. Wipes were frequently used in early sound pictures, particularly

when the flashback ends and is straight-cut to in musicals. They are now used mainly in trailers, present narrative. Or, a player describing a weird advertising films and television commercials. experience. may be straight-cut to the present with Since wipes require the production of a duplicate a sudden shock; as if waking from a nightmare! cate negative. or dupe reversal fi hn, their use is ordinarily limited to 35mm motion pictures. A few

Frozen dissolves, in which both the last frame of the first scene and the first frame of the second print simple traveling wipes from "A & B" rolls. scene arc frozen during the dissolve, may denote If elaborate wipes are required, the picture should time standing still between scenes. A highly picture be shot in 35mm, and a 16mm occlusion interstitial variation of the frozen dissolve may employ negative made.

matched paintings or drawings. The moving photographic image is frozen, and dissolves to a

MONTAGE TRANSITIONS

painting or drawing. This in turn, dissolves to another painting or drawing; which then dissolves to a Frozen photographic image; which - connected by straight cuts, dissolves or wipes then moves and continues with the story. The used to condense time or space. This rapid editing match between picture and painting or drawing technique may depict portions of the story - when is accomplished by photographically enlarging the events need not be shown in detail - but must be film frame, and either painting or tracing the included for continuity, editorial or narrative purpose. image. Such optical effects must be handled by poses. Since the audience receives the impression an optical camera/enlarger set-up, equipped for that a journey. industrial operation, or any holding precise registration through various steps. lengthy, complex event, is being shown in en-

138

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

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Montage dCllicts series of short SCCI1C~' (:()lllpr('~silly lime. These rcprescntutiuc

shots show desisni. cumputing,teMi1l,q, shi{lpill[J ofspace capsules.

tirety - rather than in pieces - the visual effect is months of time, or miles of space into a few mo
often psychological. ment on the screen. Some of the scenes may be

The research. design and development of a stock shots or scenes filmed for some other pur
complicated electronic system; a new missile; or pose! An engineer could be workingon almost any
a giant dam may be depicted in a series of short project; a conference could suffice for any narra
scenes of drawings being sketched; blueprints tive purpose; scenes depicting office work, trans
being processed; computers working; models be portation, computing, etc.. could serve for many
ing tested; electronic brains flashing data; engi different subjects.

neers in conference;components being assembled, A short montage may show an expedition trav
transported to the site and placed in position; and eling to a remote land by modern modes of trans
finally. views of the completed unit in operation. portation. Upon reaching its destination, the ex
While some of these individual shots may have pedition may resort to dugout canoes. Then the
little connection with the event, combined they narrative proceeds to tell the story in a straight
create a cumulative effect of extensive effort. A forward manner. In this case, the montage sets
montage assembled in this manner may compress the stage for the main event.

139

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CONTINUITY THE FIVE C's

Superimposed images may be used in a mon etc, - should also be considered in planning a
tage to connect two or more ideas. Circus or con montage sequence.

cert posters may be changed continuously over

HOW TO USE PICTORIAL TRANSITIONS

shots of speeding trains. Newspaper headlines

may spin into focus over a trial sequence, to Pictorial transitions may be used in many novel
show day-to-day developments before reaching the ", 'ays. While simple titles announcing time and
final verdict. Ticker tape may move across the place may suffice when introducing a new se
screen. over scenes of frenzied stock market activ quence. creative thinking will usually develop
ity. Arising graph line may be laid over scenes of more interesting visual methods. By studying
a new product moving off the assembly line, being story, selling, people, props; and looking about
shipped. displayed for sale. Progress reports on for a moving transition stemming from the narra
tests of new equipment may be moved across the tive, various sequences may be tied together.
screen against scenes of field trials. The oscillo The two key shots depicting beginning and end
scope pattern made by a heartbeat may be super

imposed over a patient undergoing a heart test. Several separate shots may be individually positioned within the frame, in any number of pattern!>. The frame may be divided into four or more parts, or a center image may be surrounded by several others. The shots may change simultaneously, or in a round-the-clock manner, to depict various sporting activities, industrial operations; or summing up of a test, report or sales campaign. A many-imaged montage may be used for a title background to introduce the subject. Several images may also be combined within a single frame, when important to show what is happening in several places simultaneously. The effect of rapid decompression upon a pilot in a test chamber may be shown with instrument readings. Pictorial transitions may cover time lapse.

(from Marl /O (illisl of prouwt - ."/lc! a,~

Stock shots are often used in a montage, be this model of freelay dis~olving to COIII cause of budget limitations; or need of depicting pie/E' ruad complex [I' operation.

historical, foreign, or other scenes which are im

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passible or impractical to film. If montage shots are filmed, it is wise to work closely with the film editor, to establish an over-all tempo for all action scenes. A metronome may be employed while shooting, if a precise beat is essential for matching action in all scenes. A hand may punch a time clock, punch out a pattern, punch a button to operate a punch press - all these actions will convey greater impact if punched to a definite beat. Subject movement, or camera movement - whether pan, tilt or dolly - should be similar or contrasting throughout a series of montage shots, for most effective results. Many other factors - camera angles, lighting, camera speed, editing pattern,

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

of a particular interval are most important. A

dinner party may be dissolved from soup to nuts.

A baby's toddling steps may dissolve to a man's sturdy stride. A miniature airplane model dis-

solves to the actual full-size aircraft. A roaring

fire dissolves to dying embers. A tiny flame be-

comes a raging forest fire. A few raindrops falling into a puddle may dissolve to a roaring flood.

Raw material can become the finished product.

Whatever may be consumed or changed by time, maybe filmed to cover elapsed time.

Repetitious action may be removed from a

lengthy industrial process by dissolving highlights of one repeated operation to those of the next step.

Dissolves are particularly useful when the entire processing takes place on a machine - such as a

turret lathe - which requires few changes in

camera angle or image size. Progress of tool cutting metal may be shown at intervals without

jump-cuts, by utilizing dissolves or wipes. Any

repetitious mechanical operation; such as tightening a series of similar bolts, throwing a number of switches, or performing other routine tasks.

may all be covered by dissolving from the begin-

ning to the end of the action. Years of watching motion pictures, have conditioned audiences into accepting such time bridges as continuous action.

A person may walk out of his office, and then be dissolved to the street entrance as he leaves the J

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building. Or, he may enter an elevator and be

wiped to the desired floor. Any insignificant time

interval may be effectively covered in this manner.

Flashback transitions may employ historical events to pinpoint the time. Newspaper headlines such as: U NDBF; HGII FLIES ATLANTIC!, LIN COLN ASSASSINATED!, or PROHIBITION REPEALED!- all convey easy-to-recognize periods.

Space may be bridged by cutting or dissolving to signs, names on doors, plaques on buildings, city names on rail, bus or airport terminals, etc.

The identifying name will immediately inform the audience of the new locale. A journey may be dissolved from beginning to end with two simple shots, showing departure and arrival.

Wipes should be considered whenever screen movement would be enhanced by pushing one Series of left-to-right vertical wipes may scene ahead of the next in the direction of travel. depict IO"~J ioumeu by train, plane, ship.

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CONTINUITY THE FIVE C's

This is excellent handling for train shots, because being punched; arriving and departing buses, the length of the train keeps it moving across the trains, airplanes and ships. These actions may be screen for a considerable period. A series of shots individual, or superimposed over the traveler's showing different modes of travel may be continuous face, or over other scenes.

ously wiped. A player may also be wiped as he Well-known symbols may be used to depict walks, rides or drives from one setting to another. countries or cities. Big Ben is England, or London Lengthy travel may be depicted by a montage in particular; the Eiffel Tower is France, or Paris; of scenes showing spinning car wheels, changing the Statue of Liberty is the United States, or New odometer figures, thick line moving on a map, York; the Coliseum is Italy, or Rome; the Sphinx passports being stamped, hotel labels being slap or the Pyramids is Egypt; the Acropolis is Greece, ped on luggage. travel folders cascading down, or Athens; cable cars denote San Francisco; the road signs flickering by. changes of terrain, tickets Liberty Bell says Philadelphia; the Capitol or the White House is Washington.

Camera movement may also be utilized to switch from one setting to another. The camera may tilt up to the sky, dissolve to another sky, and then tilt down to reveal a new scene. Or, the

tilt may be downward to water or ocean waves,
and upward to the new location.

Through repetition, many pictorial transitional
devices have become hackneyed. A fresh photo
graphic treatment, a novel production technique,
or a new twist by a creative cameraman, director
or writer will enhance the production and stimu
late continued audience interest.

SOUND TRANSITIONS

Well-known symbols may be used to intro
duce scenes of cities - such as pyramid
and sphinx for Egypt -

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Acropolis for Greece, or Alamo for San Francisco.

142

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

jumping about from place to place. The entire production may be
sound track of a compilation film may be transitioned to show actually delivering his speech, by dissolv
tional. to cover the lack of pictorial continuity. A man in a courtroom. Or, he may continue talking
documentary film may use simple narration to link as he walks in his office - out of the picture; and
sequences; moving about in time and/or space. into the picture - in the courtroom. Such transi
A monologue may move the story forward or transitions are best made with close-ups. so that the
backward, to a different time or place. A tape featured individual fills the frame during the
recorded confession, being played back by the switch from one setting; to another. The camera
police, may continue narrating events as the picture should either cut to. or move into, a close-up at
ture dissolves to a flashback of the crime being the end of the first scene. Then it should pick up
committed. A shot of an archeologist, reading an ancient manuscript, may dissolve both sound and picture to a close-up, and either cut-back
ancient manuscript, may dissolve both sound and picture to a close-up, and either cut-back
picture to original dictation and reading of the
document. A company executive may read an engineering field report aloud to his colleagues. As

picture to original dictation and reading of the

document. A company executive may read an en
gineering field report aloud to his colleagues. As

he continues reading, the picture dissolves to the activities being described. A scientist may imagine life on earth a thousand years from now. The picture may dissolve forward in time as he talks. Picture and/or dialogue may dissolve. The person speaking may dissolve to another person who continues the speech. A player's voice may be heard as he writes a letter. Both picture and sound may dissolve to the recipient reading the letter aloud. Or, the voice of the original person may continue as the picture dissolves to the recipient silently reading the letter. A business report may be used to bridge several persons in different places; by depicting the announcement being dictated, then cutting from control room to track, and then dissolving to report being read at all stations, with engineer in each speaking aloud by other people in turn.

Counting down one number until "Fire" is reached and dissolves are not always necessary. Dialogue as a missile is launched.

may activate a straight cut to another shot, such as a player exclaiming: "We'd better fly!" and then cutting to a plane in flight. The foreman of a jury may declare: "Guilty!" Shots follow of barber, butcher and baker shouting: "Innocent!" Since such shots may be located anywhere, dialogue reactions of various individuals may provide a dramatic method for moving the story across straight cuts. A missile countdown could include ten individual shots of engineers in various locations on range, or even throughout the world, each counting down until "one" is reached - and the chief engineer orders: "Fire!"

Monologues may bridge an individual player's movement from one setting to another. A lawyer,

CONTINUITY THE FIVE C's

picture cuts. which transport the moving player national airs may be used to introduce a country. from one setting to another, would have been con Americancities maybeidentified bypopular songs sidered poor editorial technique a few years ago. spcctf'ytng locales: SlllfficOff to Buffalo,Clucaqo, With today's faster-paced story-telling,locales can San Francisco and Meet lve ill St. LOLLis. States be switched abruptly unthout. opncals, provided and regions may be ldcnuflcd with Catdcmia, the audience comprehends what is happening. Here I Comet, The Eyes of Texas, Dixit', Okla Non-essential action may be skipped, and sig homu! and similar Favorites. Available songs can nificant highlights shown, by bridging scenes with cover most situations; wars. military groups, dialogue.narration and/or sound effects.Abuilder occupations. courtship, marriage, flying, Sailing, discussing blue-prints or model of a new house, motoring. cowboys.etc. Aswitch to a new setting could dissolve into actual construction - as he maybe quicklyestablished by including a few bars continues the description. The scream of an on of an appropriate tune. Music bridges simplify looker at a traffic accident could be blended into identification when a different location is shown, the wail of an ambulance siren. A highway engi without need of introductory titles, or other ex neer proclaiming: "We'll blast!" could pound his planatory inserts.

fist on a conference table as the picture abruptly Music is also useful for time lapses. Songs such shows tons of earth exploding! as It's Three O'Clock In The Morning, may be Telephone conversations provide excellent used to climax a longf'venjng of dancing or night means for switching the story to another locale, d ubbing; and, the New Year is almost always in Radio and television may also be used as sound troduced with Auld Lang SYI/t'. Music of a partic transitions. The program may be shown originat ular period may aid in establishing a flashback. ing- in the studio; then cut to reactions 01" people .011111 Brown's Body will idcntifythe Civil War, and listening or watching in their homes, on the 0 1'('1" There! - World War I. Use of rnusic must streets, in their cars. Hcactlons to a presidential always be cleared with copyright owners. address. stock market reports, or a news flash, Sound effects, unaccompanied or blended with may switch from one person to another - regard music and/or dialogue, offer a variety of possi less of their locations. bilities for imaginative sound transitions. Success

Familiar songs provide excellent opportuniucs of a venture. growth of a project. transfer from for establishing location. Well-known Irish, one time or place to another, mayall be expressed French, Italian or Russian folk music, or other by sound effects. A gushing oil well rumbles into a squirting champagne bottle. A splashing \vatcr faucet blends into a waterfall. Typewriter. tele type or stock ticker clattering dissolves into a

machine gun firing. Baby birds chirping softly
 merge into a baby crying. The clackety-clack of a
 train becomes a repetitious phrase or slogan. A
 human cry becomes a wailing whistle. Train and
 boat whistles suggest travel over land and sea.
 Sounds may be faded in or out; dissolve
 (blended, segued or merged); or distorted (echo
 chamber); made faster or slower. Multiplied, com-
 bined. etc. Both picture and sound may thus be
 similarly treated for special effects or transitional
 bridges. A distorted dissolve - which introduces a
 flashback - may be accompanied by distorted
 sound. An engineer may pound desk, and exclaim
 music and sound effects. Narration may be dram-
 atized by use of echo chamber.

144

CONTINUITY

THE FIVE C's

It is often better to prepare the audience by
 introducing the sound before the picture appears.
 Since the ear takes longer than the eye to note
 what is transpiring - hearing should be given a
 head start. A sound can be heard before its
 source is sighted. An ambulance siren can wail
 long before the vehicle approaches the camera. A
 ship's fog horn can be heard before the vague
 outline of the vessel can be discerned in the mist.
 Factory din is heard before machines are shown.
 Music or sound effects may introduce a flash-
 back. The sound may be "heard" by the mind's
 ear before the image is recognized. A tinkling
 piano may be heard in the distance and gradually
 brought up to full volume. Then, setting and peo-
 Directional continuity should be established

ple are revealed. French taxi horns may be heard as the flashback is maintained, even on uncontrolled before the flashback dissolves to a Paris street scene - such as a taxi horn. This is a test of continuity (IS

scene. A setting may bring back memories in the choice of camera set-ups. The correct side of the action axis.

which the sound precedes the images evoked. A

veteran pilot wandering around an airplane grave

yard may seem to "hear" the roar of airplane engines while filming, and avoidance of pitfalls

engines. This introduces a flashback of a bombing mission - whether shooting from a mission. Or, an actual sound - such as a train whistle or off-the-cuff. Good continuity is a whistle - may trigger remembrance of a vacation expected by the audience. By drawing attention to the incident itself, poor continuity detracts from the narrative.

Nothing should interfere with the illusion through

APPROPRIATE TRANSITIONS

which the audience becomes involved in the story.

Pictorial or sound transitions should be handled. These steps are advisable for better continuity:

1. Pictorial transitions should be handled in keeping with the event being depicted. Learn how to analyze and handle cinematic

Materials on hand will often suggest a transitional time and space. Establish and maintain dynamic device. Props foreign to the setting should not be used and static directional continuity by proper employ

introduced. A grandfather clock would be out of place in a scientific laboratory. Recognize differences between place in a scientific laboratory. Players, story, set between controlled and uncontrolled action. Decide

ting. action. available props, should be imagined when to shoot single or multiple cameras for best

tively blended into an appropriate transition results. Choose between master scene and triple seeming to grow out of the event. Elaborate props, take techniques; or utilize a combination of both,

or false action - staged only to introduce a transition to fit the filming situation. Overlap and match

sition - should be avoided. Any transition that action from shot to shot. so that it can be edited

attracts undue attention to itself. distracts from in a continuous manner. Allow the editor sufficient

the story. Transitions should supply logical means of overlapping footage to facilitate cutting on

to an end: devices for interlocking sequences, coverage action. Film pictorial and sound transitions to

ering time lapses, changes of locale. bridge time and space.

A motion picture is a constantly-changing series

CONCLUSION of images. By keeping the images as close as possible

Continuity is merely common sense in coordination with real-life action. good continuity should be

nated action. It requires thinking in sequences. It is a continuous thought instead of individual shots. Careful planning, continuous continuity.

CUTTING

INTRODUCTION

What is left must be woven into a continuous

Film editing may be compared with cutting, narrative, to present the screen story in a manner polishing and mounting a diamond. A diamond in that captures audience interest and holds it until the rough state is barely recognizable. The raw material from opening scene to final fade-out.

A diamond must be cut, polished and mounted so the film editor strives to impart visual variety that its inherent beauty can be fully appreciated. In the picture by skillful shot selection, arrange in the same way, a film story is a jumble of odd lengths, and timing. He recreates, rather than rephotographs, until, like the diamond, it is cut, polished and mounted. Both diamond and film are enhanced by what is removed. What remains tells the individual scenes put together. It is the film the story. The many facets of the diamond, or the editor's responsibility to create the best possible movie, are not apparent until the final cut. A motion picture from available footage. Often, a

This chapter is not intended for film editors. A good film editor can turn in a picture superior to the original. It is aimed at the non-theatrical cameraman, the director's or the cameraman's original conception of filming without the benefits of a shooting script, a script girl or a director to guide him. It is aimed at those who may edit his own films. It is aimed at production personnel who want to appreciate the editor's problems. Everyone involved in filming a motion picture should understand the editorial requirements in mind. Serious consideration is given to the editorial requirements, and should consider screen direction, players' positions and looks, and consider each shot from that standpoint. Every edit matching action and dialogue from shot to shot. Every editing decision possible should be left to the editor. A theatrical film editor will generally encounter only good editing can bring life to a motion picture. A few editorial problems that he cannot solve. He picture! The various shots are just so many odd pieces of film until they are skillfully assembled than correcting shooting errors due to mis-match to tell a coherent story. Cutting takes up the slack in other wrong filming techniques.

In the film, by removing all superfluous footage: Much of the film editor's work on non-theatrical false starts, overlaps, unnecessary entrances and exits, extra scenes, duplicated action, bad takes. consists of covering or otherwise correcting

CUTTING

THE FIVE C's

be able to break down an event into a series of shots that can be cut into a presentable sequence.

The non-theatrical cameraman should be familiar with cutting problems. He is either his own editor, or must make editing decisions during shooting stages. Many cameramen, working for small producers, do their own cutting. Some become adept at editing, but a good cameraman is .._..!!',....,

A theatrical picture is shot with editorial requirements in mind. Players' positions, looks, dialogue and action are matched from shot to shot,

avoiding mistakes. Mis-matched footage, missing scenes, cutting on camera movement, covering jump-cuts, and solving other shooting problems may be traced to use of poorly applied filming

techniques. Second guessing by the narration Non-theatrical films - particularly Hollywood shot like Old a script - should be finished

by writer, director or producer. may also require

very careful, otherwise, unsatisfactory

editorial corrections to comply with the revised

sequence of events may cause editing

concept of the manner in which the story should problems.

be presented. By transposing shots, using opti

cal", and employing some scenes in a way not rarely an expert film editor. While theatrical mo

intended when filmed, an editor with a broad picture production demands utmost speciali

knowledge of documentary production problems. the non-theatrical field often requires

various editing tricks to aid in salvaging the show. doubling or tripling specialties, so that a camera

An experienced film editor can often cheat-cut man/director/editor combination is not unusual.

a picture with such imagination that the cameraman working this way, can develop

completed film depicts a screen story that was with a greater appreciation of motion picture editing

conceived and created on the cutting bench. rather problems than one who merely shoots what is

than in the camera. However, the cameraman requested by a director. He has a greater oppor

should not let the editor's skill become a crutch. Therefore, to become proficient in shooting when shooting, he should not depend upon the scenes that will cut together, since he is closer to the editor to "doctor" avoidable filmmaking mistakes. In the over-all production of the picture than is the normal course of his work a film editor must cameraman fill in a theatrical feature, lie soon cheat a great deal. But he should not be expected to learn that certain actions must be carefully to save every picture in the cutting room. As one observed to make them match in consecutive scenes, the cameraman should thoroughly understand shots. Certain camera and player movements will film editing from a visual, rather than a technical cut together and others may not. Cut-in and cut standpoint. He need not know how to assemble away close-ups and reaction shots can save the A & B rolls, or even make a splice, but he should picture when jump-shots show up in a sequence.

148

CUTTING

THE FIVE C's

Changing the camera angle and/or the lens every time a new shot is filmed provides best coverage.

TYPES OF FILM EDITING

CONTINUITY CUTTING, in which the story telling is dependent upon the consecutive scenes; and COMPOSITION CUTTING, in which the story-telling is dependent upon the narration, and the scenes merely illustrate what is being described.

CONTINUITY CUTTING

Continuity cutting consists of matched cuts, in which continuous action flows from one shot to another; and CROSS-CUTTING, in which the action of two different scenes is shown. The non-synchronous cameraman/director shown is a portion of the previous shot. A editor must make editing decisions during continuous sequence, or series of matched cuts, filming. By necessity, he is close to over-all may consist of various types of shots filmed from picture production team is the theatrical director of photography. The on-the-cut different angles. The event depicted, however, can vary in manner, but is particularly adaptable should appear as a continuous series of moving to [film]. The controlled action. images. whenever action continues, the players' ,.....c.,.....c.

movements. positions and looks should match through shots spliced together. A mis-match. caused by change in body position or a switch in directional look. will result in a jump-cut. This occurs because the player will appear to jerk or jump across the splice between shots.

Whenever the camera is moved from a long or medium shot to a closer set-up. a mis match becomes most discernible. A minor mis match, such as a slight difference in head position. may go unnoticed if the camera is shifted to a slightly different angle. as it is moved in for closer shots. It is always wiser, therefore, to move the camera closer and to one side of the subject.

rather than straight in. Whenever a shot includes from a closer shot to a longer view, it is necessary a portion of the previous scene - such as when only to match the action shown in the previous cutting from a long shot to a medium shot close-up. because everything else was outside the players' positions. body movements and looks frame. Cutting from a long shot to a close-up and should be duplicated as closely as possible. And then cutting back to the long shot again permits arm should not be shown raised in the long shot, considerable cheating. The audience, being momentarily and then appear lowered in the following medium mentally distracted, will accept any change in shot. A head should not be depicted turned in the last long shot as having occurred while the different direction, so that the player's look during close-up was on screen.

not match the previous shot. Such discernible cut-aways need not match previous scenes.

differences in screen images will jar the audience. because they are not a part of the main action.

When the camera is moved back, or cut back, Cut-aways are shots of secondary action - directly

149

CUTTING

THE FIVE C's

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Theatrical motion pictures generally employ corllnuity ('tilting. An event is depicted in a sequence - a series of ccnsecunue shots - in which plnyers' move menU, positions, Woks and dialogue match across shots spliced together.

150

CUTTING

THE FIVE C's

or indirectly related to the main action - used as his established off-screen position in relation to a reaction, a comment or a distraction. However, the prtncipal players. The wrung look will give cut-aways should be established when they appear the impression the player is now on the side as part of the original long shot and later moved opposile that shown in the establishing long shot. off-screen. when the camera is moved in to film Cut-aways need not be matched or established the principal players. A long shot may depict if they arc scenes of players not shown in a previ several players. Later, the action may be covered ous shot. A series of man in the street cut-away with a two-shot. The off-screen players' reactions close-ups may be used to comment on a verdict are directly tied in with cut-away close-ups. In handed down in the previous courtroom scene. this instance, it is important that each player be Unless alternating right and left opposing looks shown with the proper ri~hl or left look. to match arc desired for greater pictorial effect, a look in either direction would suffice for these shots.

Acut-away close-up may be used to distract the audience to cover a directional change in travel continuity, a time lapse or a jump-cut. These need not match. Nor need they be presented with a particular look, since they are shots of (mt eidcr«, not included in the general scene.

A close-up of a person turning his head may be Inserted between two shots of a vehicle moving in opposite directions. A lengthy operation, such as the workings 01' a pmver shovel. may be shortened,

and the missing portion covered by inserting a close-up of a sidewalk superintendent looking on. An inadvertent jump-cut or a [urnp-cut caused by Wilen the camera is hronqlit in fora close" up, it should be moved around to the side - not moved straight in, if the pluyers rc late to each other across tile screen. Body movements and loohs should be duplicated as closely as possible; hut a minor mis match will not he discernible if camera is shifted to a slightly different ang..le.

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Since cut-oioau close-ups are never a part of the main event, they need not match previous scenes. However, if previously established, and later moved off screen, they should be shown with the proper right or left wok to match their off-screen posi tion in relation to principal players.

151

CUTTING

THE FIVE C's

of the animated snapshot nature of the visuals. These arc connected by continuous narration. The rf sound track holds the narrative together and pro pels the scenes, which may make little sense if I' shown without audio explanation. Compilation cutting presents few matching problems since the individual shots simply illustrate what is being heard and need have nu visual connection with one another. Compilation type films have no set form other than guing from the general to the

particular. Long: shot may follow long shot, and close-ups which have no connection with the bracketing shots may be inserted. Every rule in the editing book may be broken if the narration makes sense and presents a coherent story. The

A "man in the street" cut-away close-up shots themselves may move about in time and may be used to comment on a verdict.

Unless alternating right-and-left opposing space if they are satisfactorily narrated.

looks are desired [or a series of such close-ups, a look in either direction will suffice.

CONTINUITY CUTTING

Storyfilms which utilize continuity cutting may also employ compilation cutting occasionally, such as a series of introductory long shots, a montage sequence which condenses time or space,

or a series of disconnected shots to present an impression, rather than a reproduction of an

Photographs below and on facing page by NASA,

By inserting a cut-away close-up of an onlooker, lengthy sequence of powerful action,

as above, may be effectively shortened. Removal of repetitious footage may then be accomplished without jump cuts.

Removing unwanted footage may be covered by distracting the viewer with a cut-away close-up of a spectator or bystander.

Progress reports and other documentary

COMPILATION CUTTING films employ compilation cutting, The various

shots are connected by narration."The

Newsreels and documentary-type films of such

Gemini Titan II Launch Vehicle arrives at

views, reports, analyses, records, history or travel Cape Kennedy where it is unloaded from logs, generally use compilation cutting because the specially modified 'Guppy' aircraft."

THE FIVE C's CUTIING

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"It is transported from the C/"!ckout Build-

ing to tile Launch Pad."

"Gemini Titan II Vehicle Fuel sections "The Gemini Spacecraft is mated to adap

slunon: just priorto er('c:lion and.assembly." ter section ofTitan 11 Launch Vehicle."

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"Work on erection and assembly of Booster "Gemini Astronauts walk toward elevator

sectiQn continlles through tile night." widell will take them to Gemini Spacecraft,"

153

CUnING

THE FIVE C's

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"The Titan II, willi Astronaut.~ on board "Fin'! Tlle Fin' Inmon i.~ pushed - and »-"

the Gemini Spacecraft.is rcadu for launch

illg. Va /kal service stmcture in fore

ground is hcino 100vercd to its horizontal ~

position. Umbilical lower, u/hich: provides f

power and various other remote (UIICti01IS

to booster and spacecraft. prior to launcu, I

is shown immediately to left of uehicle."

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"- the Titan If liits majestically off launch

pad ami heads tov Data space. Month,~ of

coordinated efforts reslilt in success."

should be employed in a compilation film when

ever two or more consecutive shot necessitates

"Engineers in control room Us/en intently matching action.

to comudoion, 10,9, 8,7,6,5,4,3,2, 1- "

event. Such compiled sequences, particularly if CROSS-CUTTING used for introduction or transition purposes, may Cross-cutting consists of parallel editing of two employ explanatory narration, or more events in an alternating pattern, In studio Compilation films may utilize continuity cut parlance, this is known as the "meanwhile back at ting whenever a sequence of shot is required (0 the ranch" treatment. Cross-cutting may be employed to depict a portion of the story'. A series of un played for any of the following purposes; matched shots may introduce a sequence which To heighten interest by depicting two or more tells a story in itself which requires match separate segments of the story in an alternate ing of consecutive scenes. Continuity cutting manner. Audience interest may be revived by

## CUTTING

### THE FIVE C's

cross-cutting to a related event whenever interest To heighten interest by keeping the audience in the subject being depicted lags, in a state of anxiety as events move toward a

To provide conflict by editing of two actions climax. Scenes of the police searching a building which will come together in a smashing climax, for a time bomb may be cut back and forth with Opposing armies may advance toward each other close-ups of the bomb ticking in a closet.

in a gradually faster-paced, closer-and-closer series

To make comparisons among people, objects. Of alternating shots until they clash.

events. Cross-cutting may alternately depict each.

phase of an engineering test between two competitors manufacturing similar items.

To depict contrast among people, countries.

cultures, products, methods or events. Contrasts may be shown between old and new methods of farming, manual and automated manufacturing procedures, life in the tropics and the Arctic.

Cross-cutting may be used to provide con

flict by alternate editing of two actions

such as Confederate soldiers advancing on

Yankee position - with gradually faster

paced, closer and closer series of shots.

.....

., "" ,

~

Contrast between the lives of  
Pueblo Indians and metropolitan area of

... ..

American downtown Manhattan in the 1920s. ~

To increase tension by alternate editing of two  
events which have a direct bearing on each other.

Editors of two rival newspapers may be shown  
planning and carrying out campaigns backing  
political opponents.

155

## CUTTING

### THE FIVE C's

#### HOW TO USE CROSS CUTTING

more facets of a dramatic story may be shown

The uses of cross-cutting have one common alternately to inform the audience of significant  
characteristic: Any event happening anywhere interdependent events as they occur. Documentary  
may be connected with any other event. Cross films may be cross-cut to depict, for example: the  
cutting may present: Why people live in various countries all over the

world: several methods of producing steel, or how

Events occurring simultaneously, but separate

an electronic center controls an automated assembly  
rated in space, may be depicted by alternately  
showing the progress of each. Typical examples

would include the classic last-minute rescue in which the hero faces to save the heroine in dire present a back-and-forth comparison of present

distress, and the chase sequence which alternately events with similar events that have happened in

shows progress of pursued and pursuers. Two or the past, or may occur in the future. Methods of  
Events occurring simultaneously, but separate

Events separated in time may also be

separated in space, may be cross-cut back and  
cross-cut (or for purposes of contrast or comparison)

forth. The progress of a jet fighter may be

comparison. Civil War infantry may be compared

tracked by a ground control station as air  
pared Wit/I World War II soldiers,  
nafr approaches its target. ....

~.".""."."~ ole.'

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CUTTING

THE FIVE C's

modern warfare could be compared with those significant movement. All moving action should  
used in the War Between The States, and then be filmed to completion. The end of the action  
compared with futuristic space warfare. Current should be repeated so that it overlaps at the begin  
news events may be cross-cut with historical ning of the next shot. The film editor may then  
happenings of a similar nature. decide where to make the cut. Marry non-theatrical  
cameramen pride themselves on their ability to

The first shot in a series of cross-cuts should  
cut on action in the camera. Such close overlap  
be treated as an establishing shot and allowed  
ping may save film, but it severely handicaps the  
slightly greater sen-en length than the Following  
editor.

cross-cuts. This will give the audience a frame of  
The film editor should always be provided with  
reference with which to compare the cross-cut  
event. Introductory cross-cut shots should not be -\  
thrust on the screen without identification. unless  
audience confusion is an important story factor.

In most cases. the audience should be immedi  
ately aware 11'1/(11 is happening. and u-iro is in  
wueve

vclvcd. and the cross-cut is occurring:

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- if that is a pertinent story point.

Cross-cutting should no! be regarded as a  
strictly theatrical fiction-film editing device. It  
may be used advantageously in documentary fact



films. particularly when it is employed to cut on action, compare two or more actions or events. Parallel editing of two or more events provides a

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welcome departure from straightforward story telling. because it heightens audience interest and Most editors prefer to cut on action when it moves the story about in time and/or space.

ever a play! it moves into a close-up or sits

CUTTING ON ACTION into a chair. However, it may be preferable for a player to finish a drink in a single close-up

Many film editors prefer to make their cuts on action. The cameraman should film all movements

movements, so that the actual switch from one action to completion, and repeat the end of a shot to another is masked by the action, and not action at the beginning of the next shot. as apparent as the cut between two static shots. The film editor decides whether or not to cut on action,

Such actions as: opening a door, taking a drink, sitting in a chair, climbing or descending stairs, picking up a telephone, or simply walking from one position to another; may all be cut on movement at the discretion of the film editor. The decision for cutting on action should be left to the editor, and not made by the cameraman.

While many moving actions appear at their best when carried to completion in a single shot,

others may be split and carried across two shots more effectively. An editor may, for instance, cut from a medium shot to a close-up as a player sits in a chair, but he may prefer to allow a player to finish his drink in a single close-up.

The cameraman should never cut during any

157

CUTTING

THE FIVEC's

as much overlapped movement as possible in con shot to shot. Unexplained gaps in continuity or secutive shots,so that he can study the action and technical variations will distract the audience and make the most effective cut. destroy the illusion necessary for effective presen

Cut-in close-ups should he made of all lengthy tation. While editorial and technical cheating can movements,such asclimbingordescendingstairs, repair some mis-matching. the cameraman should orwalkinggreat distance. Thatway,theeditor may deliver visually-perfect scenes, regardless of the shorten the long or medium shot by cutting to the number of shuts required.

closer shot, and eliminating as much of the move The experienced film editor,whenever possible, ment as desired. Closer shots may also be used La inserts distracting cut-away close-ups or uses lcnothcn the longer shots, if necessary, by repeal other editing devices to salvage scenes which do illg a portion of the movement without the audi not match in dynamic or static directional con ence being aware of the repetition. Always move tinuity. In extreme cases, an editor may have a players into and Ollt Df close-ups to allow cutting shot optically "flopped" to reverse screen direction on action. The camera should be started beiore or a player's look. He may optically "blow up" a a player enters the frame and stopped utter he shot to produce a missing close-up from a two leaves, to provide "clean" entrances and exits. shot. These desperate measures arc resorted to Statically positioning a player in a close-up only when all else fails. Generally, they are appli forces the film editor to usc the entire length of cable only to 35mm films, since 16mm optical the movement in the lung shut in order to arrive work introduces additional grain patterns, which at the point where the player is shown in close-up. can expose the trick. Afilm editor may do little or However, if the player moves into the close-up. nothing, however, to correct technical errors the editor may cut the previous scene shorter by which result in mis-matched visual or audio con moving the player into the closer shot - without tinuity. Editorial effort needlessly expended in the audience being aware that pan of the end attempting to salvage poorly-filmed footage could movement in the long shot is missing. be better used in a more finished editing job - if the scenes were properly filmed! There is rarely

CUTIING & CONTINUITY excuse for pictorial or technical mis-matching,

Cutting is closely related to continuity. A mo which make problems that the film editor cannot tion picture is a custom-made jig-saw puzzle in solve satisfactorily. Filmino all scenes witll due which film makers fashion the individual pieces, consideration qiten (lll editorial factors inootied Each piece requires special attention, so that it is tnc best solution to cutttno problems.

will merge harmoniously with pieces surround The director, with the help of the script girl, is ing it. In order to fit properly, pieces may have responsible for matching action from shot to shot. to be made to fill out incomplete sections. All the However, if the cameraman is working alone as a pieces must be provided. made to fit properly and cameraman/director, matching can be a vexing form a continuous, matched picture. The puzzle problem, especially when shooting without a

will be much easier to fit together if the various script. The easiest solution is carefully planning: pieces fall into place without difficulty. If the the places in the sequence where the camera will individual shots were filmed with the editing pat be shifted to new angles, and thoughtfully analyz tern in mind, a film editor can assemble a per ing what the action "ill be at that time.Ifmatch fectly matched sequence. A well-constructed ing involves movement. make sure that the move screen story cannot be assembled from shots is duplicated at the beginning of the next shot, so filmed haphazardly, that the film editor maycuton action if he wishes.

The cameraman must film series of shots Players' looks and positions should be carefully that match visually and technically. Action must duplicated in subsequent shots to prevent jarring match across straight cuts; exposure, lighting, jump-cuts. Professional actors can usually be color and other technicalitics must match from relied upon to repeat a move or action, or match

158

## CUTTING

### THEFIVE C's

a look countless limes. or hit a mark. in precisely is followed; but the „clalio".~ltiJJ of players. furni thesame manner. Amateurs without acting exper rure. props and background clements must be ience should not be given a floor mark. because carefully noted when changing; angles for con they may madvcrctntlv glance at it when moving secutive shots. On occasion it may be necessary into postuon. Rather than a floor mark; an engi to remove or cheat an object's position 10 make it neer. technician or company executive should be nppcor correct in a series of shots. This is most given a corner of' a desk to lean against.or to feci likely to happen in close-ups. where an intruding; forwith a hand 01'foot,as he reaches his position. portion of a lamp shade or a corner of a picture It is askill~ too much to expect a professional per frame appears in the picture. A lamp may seem formance from all amateur actor. no matter how too close to a player because of a change in lens brilliant he may be in his particular Held. Move focal length between long shot and dose-up. Or. a mcm and stagin~ ..hould be restricted when deal ing with non-actors. so that they may concentrate on their action and dcllvcrv. If motion or speech would be difficult to duplicate for the various type shots required for a matched sequence. usc of multiple cameras should be considered.

The cameraman should "protect" a series of continuous shots hy filming every possible cut-in and cut-away close-up that could be used to cover any jump-cuts which might crop up in editing.

An extremely close cut-in close-up, in which little more than a face is shown, can be very useful for covering mis-matched action between a pair of uncontrollable or complex action shots, such as a fight or any other movement that is difficult to duplicate. Such tight close-ups eliminate the need when the camera switches to a new angle for exactly matching positions or body move to film a close-up. It may become necessary to match movements, and match cuts show only the correct directional to clear or completely remove an object, such as the corner of a lamp. Such clear look. They may be filmed in pairs, so that both a left and a right look are provided the cutter for joining will not be apparent if deftly performed. The object should be replaced if it is inserted anywhere in a sequence where the object appears in a subsequent wider angle shot. Players' looks vary as action progresses.

#### CUTTING & COMPOSITION

Compositional elements - players, furniture, props, background objects - should remain in the same relative area of the frame in a series of matching scenes. Shifting of compositional elements within the frame between shots may confuse the viewer. For instance, a table lamp appearing in the background on the left of a player in the long shot, should not suddenly appear on his right because of a vast change in camera angle. Players and objects will be positioned correctly if the principle of the action axis

159

#### CUTTING

##### THE FIVE C's

picture which seemed far away from a player. Movement may also be introduced in a static shot suddenly appears behind him when the camera establishing shot and is then filmed with a continuous movement around for a close-up. If the object is obviously moving camera. Two actors may walk down a street in a static long shot. The medium shot should not be removed because it will be obviously a street in a static long shot. The medium shot should be missed, it should be cheated so that it looks right, that follows may be filmed with a continuously

If the sequence requires a static long shot, the moving camera. Individual close-ups of each actor however, the object must be moved back (it may also be shot with a moving camera. The original position. sequence may end with a static long shot as the

Changing both the camera and the image actors enter a building. In this case, static shots size will aid in obtaining smooth cuts between would be cut directly and effectively with moving shots, because the camera viewpoint is shifted as shots, because the movement was begun in a the image size increases or decreases. Shifting the static scene and picked up the camera, with a viewpoint, rather than moving straight in or out, moving camera.

will cover minor mis-matches and changes in furniture, props or background objects. The scene is opening with a walking medium shot of the play thus viewed from a completely new angle. scene filmed with a continuously moving camera, and then cutting to a static long shot to show

MOVING SHOTS & STATIC SHOTS their progress down the street. More moving shots

Moving and static shots may be inter-cut only may be made if desired. and the sequence ended under certain conditions. A series of moving shots with a static shot as they enter the building. Can will generally inter-cut without difficulty" if the continuous player or vehicle movement may be carried tempo of the camera movement is properly maintained across both static and moving shots. A series of the same subject filmed of continuously moving shots. of the same or different from various camera distances and angles. or of different subjects. may also be inter-cut successfully. different subjects filmed in a repetitious manner. A continuously moving subject may be filmed

A moving camera may be introduced in a static camera shot may

limy shot, and then filmed in a continuous film from various angles and continuously moving camera. Any movement may be made. The camera may track along be picked up the move with a pan or side, in front of or behind the player; it may

or be cut in a series of moving shots. the camera may be

continuous movement of the player movement should be pre

pared for (low across static and moving shots. closely duplicated in various type shots.

160

## CUTTING

### THE FIVE C'S

from various distances and angles. Or, the camera may employ repetitive movement. such as a pan or dolly. on static subjects. The moving camera may film a moving car from the front. rear

and side in long shot, medium shot and close-ups.

Or, the camera may dolly toward a building, down a hall, through a room: Or toward several similar objects, such as various types of roofs, for comparison. The shots may thus be directly or indirectly connected with each other. Similar camera movement is used to tie subjects together.

However, intercutting static and moving shots of static subject matter is generally difficult.

because the switch from a static shot to a moving shot (or vice versa) is abrupt and jarring due to intercutting of static and moving shots of

lack of subject movement. As example, a static

shot of a dial on an instrument panel can be

successfully edited into a continuous pan shot and then film a static close-up of a single

of the entire panel. In order to cut it into the dial. The pan shot should pause at the

moving pan, the close-up would have to be filmed point where the close-up would be inserted;

with the same camera movement. Since it would or the pan shot would be eliminated, and

have long shot: and close-up filmed with

sweep past the dial and provide only a fleeting (

static camera.

glance at the reading; such a panning close-up

would defeat the purpose. It would be best in this

movement across a cut will jar the viewer. How

case to shoot both shots with a static camera; or

ever, a combination of a static shot of static

to pan to the point where the close-up will be

subject matter, and a moving shot of a moving

cut in. Then, static footage should be filmed, and

subject will intercut properly motivated. These

panning continued.

combinations occur in cut-away shots, such as a

A pan, tilt or dolly shot of a static subject, pre cut from a static shot of the heroine tied down to

ceded or followed by a static camera shot, should

the railroad tracks to a continuously moving shot

always be filmed with a static camera at the beginning of the shot. Thus, the cut will be further reinforced by the editing rule that it is possible to cut away from anything happening at any time. It is very jarring to cut from a static shot of a static subject to a moving shot that begins moving immediately; or to go from a continuously moving shot of a static subject to a static shot. The screen length of a pan, tilt, dolly or other static shot.

moving shot should be considered in relation to its editorial value. A moving shot should always be considered in its editorial value. The screen length of a moving shot is based upon the time the camera is in motion, while the screen length of a static shot is based upon the time the subject is in motion. Shots of moving subject matter will generally offer little or no editing difficulties, because based on subject action. A moving shot must be used in its entirety (or any continuous portion) either static or moving shots. Moving camera because it is difficult, if not impossible, to cut between static camera shots of static subject during camera movement. A static shot, on the other hand, may generally be trimmed shorter or the abrupt introduction or cessation of image cut into several shots. This applies particularly to"

161

## CUTTING THE FIVE C's

Many cameramen and directors mistakenly believe that a moving shot contributes flow to the story-telling and speeds the screen action. In many instances, movement slows the screen story because it takes longer to come to the point! Unless the camera move is dramatically motivated, it is much better to shoot several static shots that may be straight cut, rather than a long moving shot which drags from one significant bit of action to another. Even when a moving shot is satisfactory from an editorial standpoint, it may

be difficult to insert between static shots.

Moving shots, timed to a sync-sound or narra-

tion track, will generally present no problem

because the movement is justified by length of

A continuous moving, or silo! of a moving sound track involved. Silent shots, however, are

un-

usable, such as F-104 jet fighter, may often poorly timed because the cameraman may

be trimmed to any desired length, since it

pan, tilt, or dolly too fast or too slowly. A long,

depicts repetition. ~ movement.

lingering pan of a machine may look fine in the

rushes, but when the editor tries to fit the shot

static subject matter or action performed by

into the picture he may find that it is worth ten

seconds in story value, and runs thirty seconds. A

apply to moving shots of travel action, such as a

long, slow dolly may be worthless because it can

vehicle or player in motion, which may be cut to

not justify its screen length in relation to the

any desired shot length.

over-all sequence. Such shots may also alter the

For example: a static long shot of a worker

assembling a power tool may be edited in several

ways. It may be used in its entirety. It may be cut

into several shots, or it may be used as establish-

ing or re-establishing shots to open and close the

sequence. Medium shots and close-ups may be

inter-cut at any point. A moving shot, such as a

dolly in or out, or both, would be very difficult to

inter-cut with other shots except where the cam-

era is at rest. The editor may be forced to leave

in a lot of superfluous footage, simply to arrive

at a medium shot or close-up where the camera

paused in its travel. Thus, useless action, which

would be trimmed out in a static shot, may have



...

to remain in a moving shot - to preserve the movement, or to avoid a cut during movement.

Paradoxically, sometimes close-ups are always (as if the camera dwells in from this long than moving shots, because they come to the subject too close-up of the man at the center point immediately. A moving shot, such as a control panel, the film editor may be forced long pan or dolly shot often contains much useless to leave close-up areas deal of excess footage in the picture. Because the subject cannot be cut footage included simply to allow the camera to during the move. A moving shot should "go somewhere." The camera should record significant action en route, not just at the end of the action en route - not at its destination. its destination.

162

## CUTTING

### THE FIVE C's

Silent dolly. Sometimes, particularly of static player who moves into a static close-up subjects, are O.K. too often because their should be. Filmed with a locked camera. Sometimes the editor Camera movement at the beginning of ally. Silent dolly shots should always be such a down-up motion picture. The editor limited to narration, or - if silent with (Tom cutting on action, however, he will out a script - several shots should: be made have to cut to the player in position after at different, or, the dolly shot the camera settles down.

should: be protected with a static shot.

jerky if it occurs across two static shots, such as

tempo of a sequence. and may not work with a medium shot and a close-up - if the end of the static shots. or with other moving shots made first shot or the beginning of the second shot, with different timing. particularly the latter. is filmed with a slightly

Use of moving shots, particularly silent shots moving camera that tends to correct the framing. of documentary subject matter filmed without a It is much better to be slightly off center in script, requires considerable forethought This is framing than to move the camera. Sneak framing especially important on static subject matter is particularly disturbing in a close-up where the where the cameraman desires to inject move player enters the frame and positions himself. In ment by panning, tilting or dollying. The value of some instances slight panning; motion is tolerable. camera movement. in relation to the story-telling but if the camera moves about with a panning and editorial problems involved, should be serious and tilting motion to frame the player correctly

ously considered. Camera movement should be as he enters, the editor may have to discard the employed only where justified - providing its entrance and cut to the player in position after screen length does not restrict the film editor. player and camera have settled down. This eliminates cutting on the move, and necessitates using

LOOSE CAMERA SHOTS the complete movement in the preceding shot to

As the shot of a player moving into the frame, the point where it settles down. Then, the final shot, such as sitting into a close-up, should be filmed with the player in position. The player will match-cut in both shots with a locked camera, not one that moves about. Proper rehearsal, enabling the actor to hit this mark, nervously at the beginning of the shot until he can eliminate sneak framing and allow the cameraman to be satisfied with the framing. The cameraman locks the camera. This is a particular editor may experience difficulty in match-cutting fault of documentary cameramen who shoot with such shots to a preceding scene filmed with an unlocked pan and tilt head to allow for any locked camera. Culling on action may appear contingencies. This newsreel technique cannot be

163

## CUTTING

### THE FIVE C's

tolerated in production filming. Such loose cam Certain production situations automatically call for operation may complicate cutting on action for protection shots because it is difficult, if not and result in a less fluid film. impossible, at time of filming to pinpoint the film editor's future needs. A pan, tilt, or dolly shot may

### PROTECTION SHOTS

be filmed several times at various speeds, for

"Protection" or "cover" shots are extra scenes inserted, to give the cutter choices. Pans and tilts filmed to cover any unforeseen editing problems. of static scenes may be made in both directions or to replace any doubtful scenes that may present and the choice left up to the editor. Lengthy pans editorial difficulties because of wrong timing. or dolly shots may also be protected with a pair excessive length. possible mis-matching, lengthy of static shots of each end of the scene, in case pan or dolly shots, etc. They may be additional the editor must cut the footage short and cannot shots not indicated in the script or duplicate cut in the midst of camera movement. Dutch scenes filmed in a novel manner. A particular angle shots may be tilted both left and right, scene may be editorially doubtful when filmed if particularly if several are filmed, so that there is a question concerning its cutting. Since editor may use them in an opposing pattern or in editorial decisions are often difficult to make any contrasting combination. Reaction close-ups during shooting. and since the choice should be filmed for insertion in lengthy scenes, left to the editor, it is wise to shoot protection particularly if filmed entirely from one angle, such

shots if the director or cameraman feels that a scene as an industrial operation. In this way, unnecessary scene runs too short or too long; the camera is shaky; footage may be removed without a jump-cut. panned or dollyed too slowly or too fast; a possible mismatch may exist in looks or screen travel, shoot "all-purpose" reaction close-ups in which the player, prop or camera angle is cheated too much; player looks in all possible directions. These may be the background does not match that previously been cut in anywhere they are needed, and are parallel established; player's clothing, movement, position particularly useful if they are filmed either to eliminate or look may be wrong; or the scene may be unrelated to the background, or to place the player against an acceptable background for technical reasons, a neutral background.

Pan shot across the scene. These environmental reaction close-up is recommended search satellites should be protected against for filming a worker performing a lengthy static shot, in case the moving camera mechanical operation. This technique prevents a shot runs too short or too long, or is otherwisevides the editor with means of removing unsuitable editorially, unnecessary footage without a jump-cut.

164

## CUTTING

### THE FIVE C's

Matching problems concerning players' looks, and be aware of their possible editorial use. A or travel or clothing, often arise when matching simple protection shot, filmed on impulse, may scenes are filmed after long intervals, or insufficient proof of value in solving an editorial problem. Important notes are taken during the shooting session.

Although time-consuming and expensive, it is DISSOLVES

wise, if the cameraman or director has the least Dissolves were originally employed by theatrical doubt of matching scenes, to shoot the scene both film producers to indicate time or space transition; ways. While shooting scenes both ways should be change in a player's mental condition; or means discouraged when no doubts exist, film and the or blending shots in a montage. Recent abuses of few moments involved in re-shooting a scene from dissolves have been caused by indiscriminate use the same set-up, cost much less than later re in live and taped television, and in documentary takes. Differences among production personnel compilation films. The abrupt cuts between badly concerning cheating of players' positions, camera staged or poorly-edited material, sometimes "soft angles, furniture or props can best be settled by tending" by dissolves, could have been prevented by filming the scene both ways: in a straightforward thoughtful camera work and direction. Expert manner, and with the desired cheat. Matching the excellent theatrical film editors have actually speeded original background for added cut-in close-ups or story-telling by eliminating dissolves wherever cut-away reaction shots filmed later, when the possible, particularly in television films. Some

film i., being edited, may produce problems, documentary editors, on the other hand, have especially when original footage was shot on a increased use of dissolves to a point where they distant location. have become a cinematic "crutch" to cover jump

If, at time of filming, there are reasonable cuts. insufficient coverage. directional changes, doubts about later need of additional shots, the missing scenes, sloppy editing and other cine original sequence may be protected by shooting: shortcomings.

against easily-duplicated backgrounds, such as Dissolves should be used to blend credit titles, sky. trees, neutral walls or drapes. Low-keyed to provide time or space transitions. or to denote backgrounds are easier to match because little or a flashback. They may be further employed in a nothing is seen behind the actor in a close-up. A montage or a television commercial to blend a difficult background match may be attained by series of short scenes of varied subject matter into filming the added close-up as tight as possible, even a choker close-up, to eliminate most or all of the background.

Protection shots generally involve shooting a cover scene "just in case" the original scene may not work for any reason. Protection shots, may, however, consist of added scenes not called for in the script. These may aid the editor in unforeseen ways. Examples of added protection shots are: long shots of buildings; extreme long shots of Factories, industrial complexes or other vast areas; close-ups of signs, plaques, markers; scenes of general activity, which may serve many editorial purposes; inserts of wheels turning, gears grinding, liquids flowing: in fact, anything of particular or neutral nature that could serve to introduce, TOWs, to ""

Dissolves should not be used in continuity.

establish or bridge sequences. The cameraman sequence where continuity is action (1.ows should always be on the lookout for such shots, across scene shots.

165

CUTTING

THE FIVE C's

smoother visual continuity. They should not depict the original action. It need not faithfully

used because they are so readily available with reproduce the original event as it actually occur  
 A & B roll printing! There is no good reason for red 'n time and/or space. In other words, as long  
 using a dissolve in a continuity type picture as the screened picture looks right the audience  
 simply because the sequence was badly staged, will accept and believe it. This allows the film  
 and cannot be edited satisfactorily with straight editor much latitude in cutting silent pictures.  
 cuts. Because of the nature of the material, there Narrated sound pictures offer considerable leeway  
 may be greater [unusually for dissolves in documentary way in their editing, since they are basically silent  
 elementary compilation-type picture. If the producer pictures supplemented by descriptive narration,  
 would make the editor justify each dissolve he music and effects. However. lip-sync-sound picture  
 utilized, fewer would be used. Dissolves should be pictures, in which dialogue tells the story, must be  
 used only where properly motivated. Most often. cut to the sound track. Since the audio record is  
 poorly-filmed scenes cause the editor to say: "I'm anchored to the picture. the editor is limited in  
 you can't solve it, discontinue it!" juggling the visual images. In so doing, he may  
 alter or completely ruin the meaning of the dialogue.

**SOUND EDITING PROBLEMS** dialogue. Cutting to sync-sound compels the editor to  
 match-cutting sync-sound scenes is inherently accept whatever is available for the particular  
 more difficult than cutting silent scenes. Action section of sound track in question. His only choice  
 only need be matched in silent scenes. If the is either to use the shot or discard it. It is possible,  
 action depicted in the edited picture conveys the of course, to juggle the sound track itself by  
 transposition of the original event, the result will generate transposing words and using other editorial tricks,  
 usually be satisfactory. Shots may be switched, but this need not concern the cameraman.  
 sequences condensed or expanded, action "Match-cutting dialogue scenes require that  
 action and reactions inserted. Silent picture edit player action or movement across straight cuts  
 editing is limited only by the experience and ingenuity  
 of the film editor. The edited version of the  
 filmed event will be acceptable if it appears... to  
 Sync-sound sequences must be cut to the  
 sound track. Action and dialogue  
 must match across straight cuts. The editor  
 cannot search for the frames where  
 Action only need be matched in a series of play positions and looks are duplicated.  
 silent sequences, such as this sequence of a Cutthroat on action - which as player sitting  
 Gemini astronaut being fitted into a space into close-up- requires precise duplication  
 of craft for emergency crossing of dialogue and movement, as performed  
 in the wider shot.

## CUTTING

### THE FIVE C's

match precisely. The editor can choose any point his speech start and stop simultaneously. The in a silent shot where the turn of a head or the camera should rarely remain on the speaker for wave of a hand matches the end of the previous the duration of his speech, unless what he says is shot. Match-cutting dialogue shots offers no such more important than reaction of listening players. choice. The editor must cut to the sound track and The editor should have players' speeches as accept whatever action is portrayed. Strict visual well as reaction shots of all concerned, so that and audio continuity must be maintained during he may edit the sequence as he sees fit. Such filming, so that both dialogue and action and silent reaction shots also allow considerable editing matched across straight cuts. Unless players' positional cheating if dialogue must be removed, or tions and looks are duplicated when camera is additional "wild" (unsynchronized) lines inserted moved, a jump cut will result. later. This alteration in dialogue will not result

Dialogue scenes are almost always filmed from in a jump-cut, because the audience is watching a prepared script, so that continuity of dialogue reactions of listening players, rather than the is easily maintained. Since, however, the emphasis

is generally on what a player says, rather than on what he does, the cameraman and/or director must take great care to match player movements, positions and looks. Dialogue scenes should be carefully rehearsed with emphasis on what a player does, and where he stands or moves as he speaks his lines. This is particularly important if the master scene technique is used, and players must repeat their actions and dialogue in closer shots. If both action and dialogue do not match precisely, the film editor will have difficulties in match-cutting the sequence. Such action mis-matches may force the editor to cut to reaction shots of the listening actor, or resort to

cut-away reaction close-ups of other players, be solo and reaction of each player

cause they offer the only solution to covering a should be filmed in continuity when shooting jump-cut. If the triple-take technique is used, and pair of over-the-shoulder close-ups. Each should speak, listen and react to fellow

the sequence is filmed shot-far-shot, both action player.

and dialogue should be overlapped to insure

H "...,"p",,,

match-cutting.

## SOUND FLOW

Sound and picture should not be edited in a parallel manner, in which the audio and visual elements begin and end together in each individual shot. Sound should flow across scenes to be most effective. Film editors generally prefer to continue the sound track of the player speaking over reaction shots of one or more of the listening players. This results in a back-and-forth treatment in which the speaking players take turns talking and listening to each other. It avoids the abrupt editing that would result if the player's image and

167

## CUTTING

### THE FIVE C's

actor who is speaking. Thus, a player's speech may be shortened or stretched. The camera should never be stopped in the middle of important dialogue. Although the cutter change in dialogue is required. The editor uses may have no interest in the picture at that point, the last few words of dialogue over the listening he may want to continue the sound track over player's reaction shot. Then the editor subtracts reaction, or other shots. If a particularly long original dialogue or inserts unsynchronized wild speech is involved, and the script definitely states lines, as required. After the dialogue change is that the picture is not required: the camera should be cut, but the entire speech should be recorded. The editor may return to the original sync picture and sound track. All camera cuts should be predetermined by the Over-the-shoulder close-ups, in which two play sound track content, and marked in the script. crs talk back and forth to each other, should be Jump-cuts may be avoided whenever portions filmed in their entirety on each player. This pro of a long speech arc presented, such as a newsreel, includes reaction shots of both players as they of an important person addressing a large group, actually listen to each other's speeches. Each actor by cutting to reaction shots of the listening audio on-camera speaks his lines, listens and reacts to each. The screened picture may present only high

his fellow player; who has his back to the camera lights of the speech, without the viewer being in over-the-shoulder close-ups, or is off-camera in aware that large segments are missing. The only p.o.v. close-ups. While this technique may apjX!ar way the camera may remain on the speaker, and wasteful of film, it provides matched reaction avoid jump-euts caused by removal of portions of shots to thoughts expressed and results in better the speech,would be bydissolving each time a cut interplay between actors, because the actual dia is made to smooth the change in the speaker's logue is heard over the actor's reaction. Film appearance or position.

saved by shooting a few all-purpose silent reaction

shots for insertion anywhere needed may harm EDITORIAL REQUIREMENTS

the actor's performance. Also, the film editor will All footage submitted to a film editor must be severely restricted in matching suitable reac meet three requirements:

tions to the particular dialogue.

TECHNICAL

ESTHETIC

NARRATIVE

TECHNICAL REQUIREMENTS

The technical clements of a film - such as photographic treatment, lighting, color, exposure, sound, etc. - should he uniform in production quality. No noticeable visual or audio differences should be apparent when the picture is assembled, and a properly timed and balanced release print made. A mis-match or distracting change, unless deliberately inserted for a special effect, may disturb the audience. A poorly recorded stretch of sound, a perceptible change in lighting, unbalanced color; or any other tcchntcal discrepancies

Reaction shots of listening audience may are unacceptable. Excellent craftsmanship is be inserted in a sync-sound sequence of an taken for granted in professionally-produced the executive addressing a group.This penults

the editor to usc higillights of the talk, atrical films. Ifserious non-theatrical film makers wit/Wilt audience bcinq aware that por expect their films toreceive proper audience attention have been removed. tion, theyshould strive for professional quality.



## CUTTING

### THE FIVE C's

#### ESTHETIC ELEMENTS

The assembled picture should unreel in a series of moving images. pleasing to watch and easy to understand, unless the film maker desires - for story purposes - to shock or distract the audience; or otherwise create a violent or unpleasant audience reaction. Scenic compositions. player and camera movements. light effects. choice of colors, camera treatment and other pictorial aspects of settings. costumes. backgrounds and props should all be integrated on the basis of their cumulative result when the scenes are finally edited. The good cameraman strives to produce the most beautiful - \_\_ - moving images possible. However, it is often better, under documentary conditions, to present a realistic rather than a pictorially beautiful picture. Non-theatrical films should be as pictorial as possible. This does not imply that beauty and realism can ally beautiful is possible within realistic confines. This documentary shot of radar not be combined; or that non-theatrical films must operators enhanced hydramatic lighting. be photographed in a dull, unimaginative, mechanical style. It simply means that documentary elements involved should be handled in an esthetic subjects should be representational rather than ically suitable fashion, without stealing the show dressed up for picture purposes. Engineering. from the subject. The primary aim of a documentary military, educational, business. industrial, in-plant, tary is to "sell" the subject. not the photography. and other non-theatrical films should be as beautiful as possible, within realistic confines. Pictorial NARRATIVE FACTORS

Technically perfect, excellently-composed shots have little or no meaning if the picture is presented in an illogical, uninteresting or incoherent manner. The audience should neither be confused nor have to strain to follow subject themes, unless plot deviations will help for narrative purposes.

Story problems are not the main concern of cameramen shooting from prepared scripts. But the non-theatrical cameraman/director, shooting on his own camera outline, or a few notes, must be sure that his footage can be assembled into a story-telling motion picture. This calls for thorough understanding of story values, audience reaction and editorial requirements. Even the simplest documentary film must capture the audience's interest and hold its attention as the film unrolls. After the theme or plot is introduced and should: It appears like a professional film. developed, the narrative must build in interest as Lighting, color, exposure, sound, etc., it progresses. Each shot should make a point. All should be uniform in production quality in scenes should be linked together so that their a properly timed and balanced release print, Technical discrepancies are distracting combined effect. rather than their individual coming, and break the story-telling spell. tends, produces the desired audience reactions.

169

## CUTTING

### THE FIVE C's

#### CAMERAMAN CAN LEARN FROM FILM EDITOR

A cameraman can learn much in the cutting room, either by observation or preferably from comments of an experienced film editor, who can provide constructive criticism of coverage. This procedure can be most helpful in filming off-the-cuff material. Such filming requires shooting individual shots planned to match-cut and heighten interest as the event progresses. The cameraman should learn how to break down an event into individual shots, first by deciding what type of shot is required for each particular portion

of the event. Then he should consider whether par

Tilt: audience should become involved in particular camera angle and player and/or camera people and events depicted on screen. movement, if any, should be used to portray best the particular portion of action being filmed.

Film editors have a motto: "Make them laugh or

Next, he must decide where to insert significant make them cry, but make them care!"

cut-in and cut-away close-ups. These may be used

The all-important goal is to make the audience

to involve the audience more closely with the

care about the people and events depicted. This

events depicted; to distract the viewer, if required

means identifying with the performers in a fiction

to cover a jump-cut or directional change; or to

film, and being concerned in what happens to

shorten or lengthen scenes. Next, he should anticipate

them. It also implies caring about the subject in a

path where it will be necessary or expedient to

documentary film, and being interested in the

provide reaction shots for story-telling or editorial

message. theme. problem. propaganda, engineering

purposes. The cameraman should understand why

is lost. sales pitch. project report, or whatever

subject matter is being depicted.

A film editor always strives to be on the player,

object or action in which the audience is most

interested at that particular moment in the story.

The cameraman should always keep this editorial

requirement uppermost in his mind during pro

duction, so that he will automatically move in and

make close-ups of important action, film the most

meaningful portion of the over-all event, and fol

low the most significant of several actions occur

ring simultaneously. What the audience would be

most interested in viewing should be considered.

A cameraman thinking in this vein will shoot a

picture more likely to capture and hold audience attention. To succeed in filming a narratively interesting picture, the cameraman must create a make-believe screen world in an acceptably real, scripted, carefully-planned, motion picture style. This is accomplished by using the - with a definite editing pattern - will motion picture camera as a story-telling tool, not generally cut together with minor, easy-to-merely as a recording instrument. solve editorial problems.

170

#### THE FIVE C's CUTTING

It is important to supply protection shots, and why they may be filmed, and the additional protection coverage he should film additional cover shots which may be provided. There is no excuse, be helpful to the editor. He should also learn how, however, for shooting scenes that do not cut to film scenes so as to provide the editor with the cause of poor filming techniques. Editorial consideration of the greatest number of editorial choices. This consideration, before and during production, will be pre-accomplished by overlapping actions from shot to shot to prevent many problems. The editor can assemble shot, filming clean entrances and exits, placing the picture only from the footage provided. If pauses in moving camera shots whenever possible he needs unfilmed scenes, or finds it impossible to permit cutting-in static scenes, and other shoot splice scenes that cannot be logically matched, editing tricks acquired as he becomes more proficient the director or the cameraman failed to film the in thin editorially before and as he films. required scenes, or filmed them inadequately. The cameraman should realize the importance. Experienced film editors may perform wonderful of integrating esthetic, technical and narrative feats in salvaging poorly filmed footage but they elements in a unified style, employing the camera cannot work cinematic miracles. in a way that will heighten audience interest. The film editor cannot: change screen direction. While film editors' criticisms will not correct past actions or players' looks; change tonal values or mistakes, they will provide a reservoir of cinematic colors of costumes or sets; change composition; knowledge for future use. Understanding difficult change lighting; change camera angles; speed up ties involved in matching, timing and arranging or slow down actors' and/or camera movement; scenes, will give the cameraman editorial insight insert non-existent close-ups; provide action in on his next shooting assignment, and enable him static scenes; cover jump-cuts without reaction or to appreciate the editor's problems, and provide protection shots; successfully remove footage from

properly-filmed footage. the middle of a shot, unless cut-in or cut-away  
close-ups are provided; match consecutive shots  
if players arc out of position, looking the wrong

## CONCLUSION

way or otherwise changed; correct visual or audio

A motion picture is conceived in the camera technical imperfections, beyond salvaging in film and assembled in the cutting room. The better the processing or sound dubbing; assemble a motion conception, the better the assembled picture. A picture from shots filmed in a haphazard manner. well-scripted motion picture, minutely planned Only the cameraman - if he is working alone, and carefully broken down with a definite editing or with the aid of the director and script girl, when pattern in mind, will generally cut together with filming from script - can see that all these re minor, easy-to-solve editorial problems. A film requirements are met during filming. Thus, the shot off-the-cuff, on the other hand, requires editor is furnished action-matched footage, sufficient expert handling and should be photographed: sufficient coverage and properly-staged shots, which with a rigidly-followed definite shooting plan; or permit every possible cine choice. A qualified cameraman with techniques that allow the film editor a cameraman does not attempt to "cut the picture in wide range of selections in assembling the footage. the camera" to the point where the editor has Even when filming from a script or shooting plan, little or no choice in assembling the film. While it is wise to give the editor cine choices. the cameraman can greatly influence how the Experienced directors and cameramen provide picture is presented, prerogative to make all edit their editors with more than sufficient coverage to editing decisions should be reserved for the editor. allow every possible editing choice. Budget and

" Except optically by flopping the picture, editing time limitations on theatrical feature films usually governing portions of the shot to full frame, usually govern the number of camera set-ups that skipping or repeating frames, or making dissolves to connect scenes that would be abrupt may be made, the number and kind of shots that or action-matched if straight-cut.

171

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TRW Systems

CLOSE - UPS

INTROOOUCTION scene: eliminate <III nan-essentials, for the mo

The close-up is a device unique to motion picture; and i,wJ/ale whatever ,',iynificant incident tures. Only motion pictures allow large-scale por should receive narrative emphasis. A properly trayal of a portion of the action. A face, a small chosen, expertly-filmed, effectively-edited close-up object, a small-scale action, may be selected from can add dramatic impact and visual clarity to the the over-all scene, and shown full-screen in a event. When improperly used, the close-up can dose-up. Ordinarily, a play, an opera or a ballet confuse the audience and detract attention ~ thus must all be viewed from a fixed distance. Monon neutralizing its cinematic effectiveness. picture close-ups make possible depiction of de Close-ups are among the most powerful story tailed portions of such performances. telling devices available to the film maker. They The close-up may transport the viewer into the should be reserved for vital spots in the story, so that their intended visual impact upon the audi ence is assured.

Close-ups should beconsidered from both visual and eduoruii standpoints. A theatrical director of photography is primarily concerned with the vis ual aspects of close-ups. Ordinarily, the choice of a close-up in a feature film is made by the writer or director for valid story reasons.

The scripctlcss non-theatrical cameraman/direc tor, who is required to make editorial decisions during filming, should thoroughly understand the use of close-ups. Close-up choice when filming off he-cuff may be influenced by editorial, rather han visual reasons. For example, cut-away reac ion close-ups may be filmed in anticipation of cutting problems that may arise later. The em ployment of a close-up to distract the audience in The motion picture camera may depict a small scale action full-sculc. Fingers pro order to cover a jump-cut is as important editor vide viewer with clue to size of objects. ially as its use for visual dramatic emphasis.

173

CLOSE-UPS

THE FIVE C's

CLOSE-UP SIZE

Close-Ups may be designated in the script according to image size. Or, they may be listed as close-up or CU. and size left to the discretion of director or cameraman. Interpretation of actual area filmed for a close-up varies greatly, but is almost always considered in relation to the subject matter. Thus, close-ups of people, animals or objects would require different treatments.

The following are acceptable designations for close-ups of people:

Medium Close-Up: from approximately midway between waist and shoulders to above head.

Head and Shoulder Close-Up: from below the shoulders to above head. Head Close-up

Head Close-up: head only.

Choker Close-up

Medium Close-Up

Choker Close-Up: below lips to above eyes.

A close-up of a person, unless specified, may be regarded as a head and shoulder close-up.

#### EXTREME CLOSE-UPS

Tiny objects or areas, or small portions of large objects or areas, may be filmed in extreme close up so that they appear greatly magnified on the screen. Insects, small machine parts, calibrations on an instrument dial; or a small action - such as applying a drop of solder to an electronic part are very effective when photographed full-screen in extreme close-ups. Portions of a person's head, such as ear, nose, lips or eyes, may be featured whenever the connected scene warrants ultra Head and Shoulder Close-up dramatic significance.

174

#### THE FIVE C's CLOSE-UPS

Action occupying tiny areas - such as a The over-the-shoulder close-up has no

plication of drop of solder to an electronic counterpart in still photography. It is part - is very effective when filmed (ull purely a motion picturc dcuis:e used to pro screen in extreme close-ups. 'vide effective transition (rom objectively filmed shots to point-of-view close-ups.

#### OVER-THE-SHOULDER CLOSE-UPS

A typical motion picture shot, with no counter part in still photography, is the close-up of a person as seen oocr-tnc-enouldcr of another person in the foreground. Such over-the-shoulder close-ups provide an effective transition from objectively filmed shots to point-or-view close-ups. The camera is thus moved around from an objective angle to an intermediate angle which introduces the p.u.v. dose-up that follows. The over-the shoulder close-up may be eliminated if the players arc shown in objective close-ups only. The cut to a p.o.v. close-up, however, becomes much smoother if preceded by an over-the-shoulder close-up.

Over-the-shoulder close-ups should be filmcd in a similar manner on a pair of players, so that they Ovcr-thc-shoulder cloec-upe should bc present a uniform appearance. While it is not filmcd in opposing pairs. Both d ose-ups absolutely imperative that camera distance, cam should appear uniform in size and angling. era angle and image size be precisely matched It is not absolutely impcrative that camera they should approximate each other. An exact distance, camera angle and image size he precisely matched - but they should ap match is sometimes difficult, especially between a proximatc each other.

man and a woman; because of the differences in body contour, head size and height of players. A over whose shoulder the opposing player is being high hair-do on a woman player may also influ filmed ~ should be so angled and framed that his ence image size and framing. Most important - a back and side are seen from a rear three-quarter back-and-forth series of over-the-shoulder close view. His cheek line, but not his nose, should be ups must appear about the same to the viewer. seen, so that his facial features are not identifi The foreground player nearest the camera - able. No part of the nose should extend past the



## CLOSE-UPS

## THE FIVE C's

check line. If the nearer player's features are cut off slightly so that a portion of his head only is visible, the scene is a two-shot, rather than an over-the-shoulder. The first method is preferred because it permits better framing. When players are closely grouped, or a larger close-up or a more compact

If the two players are facing each other, the shot - such as in television filming - is desirable, farther player will be shown in a three-quarter view. The second method may be employed.

angled close-up. The foreground player may be treated in either of two ways: his entire head and Over-the-shoulder close-ups are designated in a portion of his shoulder may be included, or the script - or referred to while filming - by specifying his head farthest from the camera may be filming the camera set-up in relation to the characters. The shot may, for example, be Over-the-shoulder of Harry's shoulder. Over-the-shoulder of Helen. The opposing matched close-up would be Over-the-shoulder of Helen's shoulder. Over-the-shoulder of Harry.

The foreground player, in an over-the-shoulder shot, should be angled so that his head and side (if seen from rear three-quarter angle).

When players are closely grouped; Over-the-shoulder, more compact over-the-shoulder close-up is desired - such as in television filming - the side of the near player's head.

When players are closely grouped; Over-the-shoulder, more compact over-the-shoulder

close-up is desired - such as in television filming - the side of the near player's head.

When the camera is insufficiently angled on this over-the-shoulder close-up. Note the tip of the nose extending beyond the cheek line.

If the nearer player's features are visible, the scene becomes a two-shot.

## THE FIVE C's CLOSE-UPS

TYPES OF CLOSE-UPS Cut-in close-ups may be filmed from four cam

CUT-IN eye angles:

CUT-AWAY 01) j'l' C'tircl.'l.in which the camera films the close

up from an unseen observer's viewpoint; not that

CUT-IN CLOSE-UPS

of a player personally involved in the scene. An

A cut-in close-up is a magnified portion of the objective close-up brings the viewer closer to the preceding larger scene. It is always a part of the player's action, without becoming person

main action. The cut-in close-up continues the action. Involves the main action with a screen-filling closer view of a significant player, object or small-scale action. looks directly into the camera lens. This is employed on rare occasions in dramatic theatrical

film; objectively-filmed cut-in close-up is a

magnified portion of the preceding wider shot in which the player

scene, the close-up must maintain, play looks directly into the camera lens - are

players' position, the close-up, because they can rarely be in a dramatic film.

to follow the action across a straight cut.

Camera is moved in and around to film the

action, because players are relating

across the scene - it is straight in.

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Over-the-shoulder close-up - in which the

camera films over the shoulder of another

player - are often photographed in

opposite matching pairs.

177

## CLOSE-UPS

THE FIVE C's

films - so that a player or commentator may look over camera height or angling. When player's explain, describe or comment on the story as it highlights vary - such as one seated and the other unfolds. It is often used in feature comedies 10 standing - the look must be cheated to the side allow a player to make an aside to the audience. just (1) Over the lens for the player looking up: and It is most often encountered in television films to the side just in front of the lens for the player look featuring newscasters, commercials and narrators going down.

who appear on camera to explain the event to the The players involved in over-the-shoulder and viewer. Subjective close-ups are also employed in point-of-view close-ups should first be identified non-theatrical films so that the head of a film may with a two-shot so that the audience is not confused. speak directly to the audience, or an engineer may be confused when the camera moves in for a series of explain the workings of a machine. close-ups. Both types of close-ups may be edited Cncl-thc-ehoutdclv, in which the camera films in any desirable pattern, although it is best to the close-up over the shoulder of an opposing have opposing pairs of similar close-ups follow player. Over-the-shoulder close-ups are generally one another.

filmed in matched pairs when two players confront each other for dialogue exchanges.

Point-of-view, or simply p.o.v., close-ups are filmed from the viewpoint of a player in the scene. The camera is positioned at the side of the player (as close to the action axis as possible) so that the audience views an opposing player, or an object or small-scale action, from his viewpoint.

When two players are filmed in opposing p.o.v. close-ups it is wise to position the off-screen player at the side of the camera, or hold up a dosed fist at the point where the player should look. so that the on-screen player's look will be correct. The look must (dw(!J'~ be to the side of Oil' lens regard-

The off-screen player - in a pair of opposite point-of-view close-ups - should stand at the side of the camera to provide the player being filmed with the proper look.

A point-of-view close-up - in which the player is filmed from the point-of-view of an opposing player - is photographed from a camera position at the side of the opposite player.

178

## CLOSE-UPS

### THE FIVE C's

is actually seeing the on-screen player from the

opposing: off-screen player's viewpoint. Thus, the p.o.v. close-up involves the audience most directly in the screen action.

#### HOW TO USE CUT-IN CWSF,-UPS

To play up narrative highlights, such as important dialogue, player action or reaction. When ever dramatic emphasis or increased audience attention is required, the subject should be brought closer to the viewer.

When filming point-of-view close-ups of two opposing players, highlights vary such as one standing and the other sitting - the look must be to the side of the camera, just above the lens, for the player looking in; to the side just below the lens, for the player looking down,

Cut-in close-ups should be employed to depict narrative highlights of the story such as this player's reaction. Dramatic emphasis demanding increased audience attention should be brought closer to viewer.

To isolate significant subject matter and eliminate all non-essential material from view. Audience attention thus may be concentrated on an important action, a particular object or a meaning.

Intense, meaningful facial expression. Close-up treatment pre-

A two-shot should precede a pair, or series, showing only what should be seen at the moment, by of over-the-shoulder and point-of-view removing all else.

close-ups; so that audience may first identify

To magnify small-scale action. A close-up may identify all players involved.

visually clarify what is happening, if the action

The p.o.v. close-up is the closest the objective is too small for the audience to view - without camera can approach a subjective angle without strain - in a medium or long shot. The audience's having the player look directly into the lens. The curiosity should be satisfied by bringing them

look of the on-screen player is just slightly to the closer, otherwise the viewer may lose interest. side of the lens. The side selected will be determined to provide a time lapse. The time interval determined by the action axis at the end of the previous required by lengthy actions may be shortened by shot. The viewer is given the impression that he is inserting a cut-in close-up. The close-up allows

## CLOSE-UPS

### THE FIVE C's

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Cut-in close-ups ('Ol/cell/rate audience al A /('71l/ll,!! nianujacturinn process - such len/ioll on the important activill 1J.1/ i.~olat as illsl'rlill~J larUe numbersof rivet.~~ may inq signiiicant subiect matter, and elimi be shortened Gild COIJered witli clll-in d OH' nating all non-essentials, liP of umrker, Vic'it'a s will get impression flwf they seeflu' ('lltirecvell!.

need not be depicted in detail. nor shown in entirety - may all be considerably shortened and covered with a cut-in close-up or two. The audience will accept the sequence as complete because they receive the impression that they are seeing the entire event and will not miss the removed sections.

To distract the audience. Acut-in close-up may cover a jump-cut caused by mis-matched or missing action. A long shot and a medium shot may not cut together because of differences in players positions, looks or movement. A close-up inserted between the two shots will allow the jump-cut to

Ma,qnifyiny small scale action - sue" as go unnoticed, since any change could have occur .~olderi/lg a hll1J terminal ~ will visually red uihlc the close-up was on screen.

clarify w1at is happcniny. Viewers' inter

To substitute for hidden action which cannot est is hciqtuend by brinyin,qthem doser.

be filmed for physical reasons - such as opera

tions concealed or inaccessible inside a machine, removal of tedious or repetitious action. As in a blast furnace, or an electronic computer. As raw stance, a person may begin typing. A close-up pellets are dumped into a plastic moulding machine reaction shot of the player, and/or a close-up of chine hopper, close-ups of control panel and his fingers striking the keys, may be followed with machine operator handling switches and observe a shot of the finished letter being pulled out of the machine dials and gauges, may be filmed to indicate typewriter. Or, a lengthy manufacturing process; the plastic being moulded within the die. Then, a repair requiring repeated operations. such as the finished part maybe shown emerging. Thus, a inserting many holds. or a familiar action that few seconds of exterior close-ups may be utilized

180

## CLOSE-UPS

### THE FIVE C's

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Hidden action - such as operation of an electrical close-ups should always be established before the action begins - may be covered by filmed in the preceding wider shot, so that the audience is aware of the location of the action: control panel, or by depicting the player in relation to the over-all scene. Filming of close-ups of dials, Tilt is particularly important when several counters, gauges, or other instrumentation. player, are shown in a long shot. to cover several minutes of invisible machine operation. The same close-up technique may be used on any subject that cannot be filmed because there is no image for the camera to record. These may be the action of electronic circuits; or events too dangerous to allow a camera in range.

### ESTABLISH CUT-IN CLOSE-UPS

A cut-in close-up should always be established in a preceding long shot, so that the audience is aware of its location in relation to the over-all scene. A cut-in close-up of a player, object or action, not clearly seen in the preceding long or medium long shot, will confuse the audience. One reason for presenting a long shot is to establish relative positions of players and objects

in the setting. Since a cut-in close-up is a portion of the set, whenever a viewer has to pause to locate the main event, it is important that the subject, a player in the set, maintain narrative continuity. The action shown must be immediately recognizable. The close-up may occur before the audience can properly orient itself before comprehending its significance. When the camera moves into a close-up, and later returns to a wider shot, it is important to properly orient and re-establish the audience with a re-establishing shot; if a great deal of action is particularly important, if the action involves close-ups of complicated devices. For example, a medium or long shot of a mechanic at work on a jet engine will leave no doubt in the audience's mind of the location of the parts shown. Camera movement in a tight close-up may cause the viewer to lose track of the present whereabouts of the depicted player in relation to others in a subsequent close-up.

181

## CLOSE-UPS

### THE FIVE C's

The viewer may become confused if the camera stays in close, and follows the mechanic as he moves about various areas. A maze of wiring, tubing, or engine parts may look like an impenetrable jungle, conveying no specific area of action. In such a filming situation, it is wise to pull back occasionally and re-establish the closer action in relation to the over-all object.

Following a player about a room in a tight close-up may produce the same dis-orientation problem. If too little of the set is seen, or if the player is not shown crossing other players, the audience will not know where he is located in relation to other players, or setting. Later, a re-establishing long shot can suddenly show the player on the other side of the room. This may completely mystify the audience!

such as a player reacting to other players

There are rare occasions when a cut-in close-up across the room- or by a doorway- of action

is not established in a preceding shot. A close-up Cut-away close-ups. not part of previous scene, is sometimes used as a sequence opener. Since it is the first scene, it cannot be established. However, it should match cut with the following shot. they should always be - directly or indirectly or be revealed as a portion of the over-all action connected to the narrative. when the camera pulls back to continue depicting Cut-away close-ups may be filmed from three angles: the event. While the cut-in close-up is not truly camera angles: cut in to the main event in this instance. it should Objectively, in which the audience views the be treated as part of the wider shot. close-up from an impersonal viewpoint. The When stories require suspense or confusion, it viewer is simply brought closer to the subject is permissible to avoid establishing cut-in close without being involved. ups. The villain may be shown in a darkened room in pursuit of the hero. A cut-in close-up Subjectively, in which the person being filmed showing him moving about is intended to be looking directly into the camera lens. Cut-away subwilder the audience. and provide additional subjective close-ups are rarely used in theatrical suspense - because his proximity to the hero is films, but their employment in newsreel, documentary not disclosed. A player may hide behind a pile of military reports and similar explanatory films. crates in a warehouse, but his exact location is may capture greater audience attention. The narrative not shown in the close-up. Because audience confusion may cut-away from a field test to an engineering fusion is intended. the camera may follow the engineer who may explain with charts. the operation player in close-up. of a new drilling rig. Thus, the viewer is directly involved. and feels that the engineer is reporting CUT-AWAY CLOSE-UPS to him personally. This is stronger treatment than having the engineer talk to an interviewer, or to A cut-away close-up is related to. but not a part of an off-screen narrator. An unseen speaker may of. the previous scene. It depicts the action supply the questions which the engineer may be an happening simultaneously elsewhere. Whether answer directly into the lens. cut-away close-ups are separated from the principal Point-of-view cut-away close-ups are filmed pal action by a few feet or by thousands of miles; from the viewpoint of a player in the scene. An-



## THE FIVE C's

other player, a clock or a small-scale action such as cocking a gun, may receive increased audience interest when shown from the viewpoint of a player in the scene, rather than objectively. Such treatment creates stronger audience identity with the player and greater involvement in the event.

## HOW TO USE CUT-AWAY CLOSE-UPS

Cut-away close-ups may be used in any of the following ways:

To present reactions of off-screen players. The reaction of an off-screen player may be more significant than the action of the principal player on-screen. How an off-screen player reacts to the dialogue may be more important, for instance, Cut-away close-up of player portraying part than showing the principal player speaking. Most ticular emotion may be used to simulate similar feeling in viewers.

often, the audience is more interested in various players' reactions than in the event itself.

To cue the audience on how they should react. inserted to play up the main event. Symbolic cut

A cut-away reaction close-up of a player portray away close-ups of birds and animals may be giving fear, tension, awe, pity or any other action, shown to comment upon human behavior. Examples will stimulate a similar feeling in the viewer. are : cut-away from a woman applying

This is a simple technique for inspiring a receptive mood. away from a man eating; a meal sloppily, to a pig

To comment on the principal character by showing wallowing in a trough. A series of man-in-the corresponding action. Related or unrelated visual street cut-away close-ups may be used to comment

comment may be made by a cut-away close-up upon action, dialogue or narration of the principal

Reaction of an off-screen player- depicted Close-ups of birds or animals may be in

in a cut-away close-up - may be more inserted in a film to comment upon human

interest to the audience than dialogue or behavior. This "smiling" porpoise imitates

action of a principal player on-screen. human characteristics.

183

## CLOSE-UPS

## THE FIVE C's

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Cut-away close-ups 111lly /Jl' employed to Tliis clll-llway cIOS('IIP shcnus Indian, all  
di.~fruL'l tlll:' (/ldicllU! wllik ('Overillg a di distant vantayc' point. o/)sermng mOl'(  
rectional change ill .K rC('1l travel. mrnt« of('(/t'cllr/f troop.

event. Public reaction to a jury verdict, an elec The actual crash may be covered by a horrified  
tion, or a comment made by the narrator, may be bystander's facial reaction, accompanied by a  
covered with a few fast-paced cut-away close-ups crashing sound effect, which may be obtained  
of several people expressing approval or disap from a stock sound library.

proval of the event depicted: or dialogue or narra To distract the audience. Because off-screen  
tion;or speaking;a single word.such as "Guilt)!" players, objects or actions are featured. cut-away  
To mottoatc a sequc1lce. The principal action close-ups offer greater possibilities for distracting  
may be motivated with a cut-away close-up. A the audience than cut-in close-ups. Since the  
screaming siren may motivate a scene showing camera is not limited to on-screen action, it may  
jet pilots scrambling toward their planes. A boat go anuiohere. A shot of an on-looker may be used  
whistle could hurry passengers to board. A chec to cover a jump-cut in an excavating operation.  
kered flag being waved could start an auto race. A deliberate or inadvertent switch in screen di  
Pushing a button could begin operation of an rection may be covered by a reaction cut-away  
assembly line. The unique impact of such cut close-up of a person looking at the moving player  
away close-ups may open sequences effectively. or vehicle, as if watching the change occur.

To replace scenes too gruesome or expensive to  
depict. War, accident or disaster scenes need not

#### 00 NOT ESTABLISH CUT-AWAY CLOSE-UPS

be shown in their entirety if they are too revolting  
for the average viewer. Ashot of the reaction of a Cut-flway close-ups need 110t be established,  
bystander to the event will put across what is hap since they are not a part of the main event and  
pening. This can also be a practical solution to may occur anywhere. This rule does not apply,  
budget problems in filming auto accidents, air however, to players previously shown in a long or  
plane crashes or similar disasters, too costly to medium shot, or in a cut-ill dose-up, who are  
stage. For instance, filming of an auto crash may moved off-screen and later appear in cut-away  
start by showing the cars approaching each other. dose-ups. Three players may be shown in a long  
Then, a series of short shots of the drivers, point shot. The camera may move in on the two prin  
of-view shots of the advancing cars, glass break cipal players as they converse. 111c off-screen  
ing, hand-held shots simulating the cars twisting player may then be depicted in a cut-away close  
and turning as if rolling over, etc., may follow. up. It is important to present such a cut-away

## CLOSE-UPS

### THE FIVE C's

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"... ~"

Cut-away close-up of onlooker, above, conveys to audience that Ill' is positioned

on left side of street, watching stagecoach. Player in cut-away close-up must

have "look" match line that previously established in wider shot.

close-up with the same look as previously established away close-up intended to distract the audience,

which. If an opposite look is filmed, the audience in order to cover a jump-cut or some other edit

may be led to believe that the supporting player is not necessary.

has crossed to the opposite side of the principal. In choosing between a close-up from an object

players. Because the look is wrong, the audience, like a point-of-view camera angle, the player's

would be confused. If the camera is positioned p.o.v. is usually best. This provides the audience

on the proper side of the action axis, the looks of with a more intimate view, since the subject is

both on-screen and off-screen players will always be seen from the viewpoint of a player in the scene.

be correct.

A cut-away close-up may also be established by CLOSE-UP LOOK

"planting" it earlier in the sequence as part of the

Cut-in close-ups should always match the looks

over-all scene, so that its location will be recalled

of the players in bracketing scenes. Because cut-in

when shown, for example, a player may be in the

close-ups move into and continue the main action,

in a long shot, standing in the corner of a room,

rules governing the action axis should be used to

The audience will recall his presence later, when

preserve the players' looks throughout a series of

he is depicted in a cut-away close-up.

consecutive scenes. It is expedient to film all

close-ups of each player at one time, when they

CLOSE-UP CHOICE occur in the same area. If the look varies during

Where possible, it is preferable to use a cut-in, the long or medium shots, the corresponding look

rather than a cut-away close-up. This will heighten interest in the cut-in close-up used for that

interest, because it is more intimately involved with particular point in the sequence.

with the principal action, rather than with related action elsewhere. The look may vary during an individual close

action elsewhere. While the cut-in close-up goes up, if another player is being observed as he

directly into the heart of the established scene, the move about off-screen. The look may sweep from cut-away close-up to match the audience outside the one side to the other when a match, or find a player in an area depicted. Unless the cut-away close-up makes a player positioned between two foreground players at an important story point, it should not be in opposite sides of the frame. The rear player may be employed. Otherwise, it may disrupt the narrative. Shown in the three-shot, or in close-up looking over the shoulder.

An exception would be the insertion of a cut-in first at one, and then the other. The look may be matched.

## CLOSE-UPS

### THE FIVE C's

also sweep across the screen when a player in a fight should be positioned at the proper place to two-shot is shown in a close-up, and switches his position to provide the on-screen player with a reference look from the opposing player with whom he is in contact. If the off-screen player stands too far from the on-screen player, to an off-screen player not previously on the side of the camera, the opposing on-screen player is shown. When crossing the camera, the player will have to turn his head - spoiling the point-of-view relationship of both players.

To insure a matched pair of looks in opposing A cut-in close-up filmed with the over-the-shoulder look - point-of-view close-ups, each off-screen player right instead of left, or left instead of right - is should be positioned as closely as possible to the editorially useless because the player will look side of the camera. If physical limitations - such as away from, rather than toward, opposing player. as lights or mike boom prevent this, a closed Cut-away close-ups removed from the main event, or intended to confuse the viewer deliberately.

Alternatively, may look in either direction. A series of unrelated cut-away close-ups, such as various persons in different settings, may be more pictorially effective if filmed with alternate right and left looks.

Cut-away close-ups need match the look only when their location is narratively significant.

When an off-screen player is positioned on the right of the principal players, he should be filmed with a look toward screen left.

Close-ups of players talking to each other by telephone should face in opposite direction, so

that they present opposing looks. This presents the conversation as if the players were standing together, and talking to each other. The audience looks may vary during a series of shots. is conditioned into believing that opposing move Wilen filming a series of cut-in close-ups, care must be taken to see which look is correct, and that opposing looks infer (VI) partially of event being filmed. that the players are relating with each other. Player in center looks at player on right. Player on right returns her look,

186

## CLOSE-UPS

### THE FIVE C's

The look on cut-away close-ups may be negatively affected from a three-quarter angle, because it is not considered as important angle, so that the face is roundly modeled. While a matching problem that encountered with profile close-ups offer pictorial variety. they are ;"IS

cut-in close-ups. Cut-away close-ups should be given careful treatment to avoid a flat cardboard given as much editorial attention as cut-in close cut-out effect. The profile's single eye lacks the ups, particularly when the location of the player intimate eye-to-eye contact between player and shown is narratively significant. audience characteristic of three-quarter angle, and particularly p.c.v. close-ups.

Much of the theatrical cinematographer's reputation

### CLOSE-UP CAMERA ANGLE

tation is based on how he shoots close-ups. partic

### & IMAGE SIZE

ularly those of actresses. A great deal of time and

A three-quarter front face camera angle is attention are devoted to camera angle, image almost invariably best for close-ups. A three size and lighting of theatrical close-ups.

quarter angle will show more facial facets, be The non-theatrical cameraman, however, may cause it depicts the front and side of the head. be guilty of "stealing" close-ups with long tele At the same time. a flat front p.n.v. close-up can photo lenses from long-shot camera positions!

Player Oil If/t [nob at player 011 rig/II. Player all lig/lt IUO/IS10 fi1(IIW 011 left.

Player 011 left look~ to centered player. Cl: "ltered playl: 'rloons at pf(l.tft'r (HI left

## CLOSE-UPS

### THE FIVE C's

Players talking to each other by telephone should be photographed with opposite looks. Opposing looks infer that players are relating with each other.

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While this may save additional camera set-ups, and may be necessary when filming newsreels, it usually results in poorly-angled, flat, inadequately lighted close-ups. Although such close-up filming may be tolerated on uncontrollable action, it is inexcusable on staged sequences. For instance, a pair of profile close-ups should not be filmed from the same camera set-up as was a preceding shot. Front-face to three-quarter angling is in of two players facing each other. The camera variably best for close-ups. Point-of-view close-ups are best if roundly modeled with should be moved in and around to shoot either cross-lighting. Objective close-ups present objective or p.o.v. close-ups of each player. more facial facets. In most objective close-ups, the camera should

188

## CLOSE-UPS

### THE FIVE C's

be positioned at the eye-level of the person photographed (or slightly higher or lower to solve particular facial problems). Since the objective angle is that of an impersonal observer, however, the camera may be positioned practically anywhere. For example, if the long shot is filmed from a low angle, cut-in close-ups should follow from similar low angles. If the camera looks down at a crowd, a close-up could be filmed in like r: 'In ncr. The objective close-up should generally be

filmed from eye-level; but it may be shot from a higher or lower height to match the camera treatment given a particular sequence.

Subjective close-ups are best filmed from the eye-level of the subject being photographed. In this way, the subject is at an eye-to-eye level with the camera lens, and therefore with every member of the audience. This relationship applies whether the subject is standing or seated. If the camera is higher or lower, the subject must look up or down to look into the lens. The resulting expression on the subject is distorted, and may discourage the viewer from relating with him. Since the subjective camera acts as the eye of the unseen viewer; a higher or lower than eye-level camera height places the audience above or below the subject. This creates an awkward relationship.

Point-of-view close-ups should be filmed with the camera positioned at the eye-level of the subject, whose viewpoint is being depicted. Thus, when one player looks at another; or when a player looks off-screen at a player, an object or an event; the view is presented as seen by the player involved.

Considerable cheating is permissible in point-of-view shots. The camera should be higher to simulate an adult looking down at a child or a standing player looking down at a seated player; and lower to simulate a child looking up at an adult or a seated player looking up at someone standing. The camera position need not be at the exact height of the person involved. The up or down viewpoint may be cheated in order to suggest a difference in height. Or, it may be exaggerated.

ceding tum-shot, This treatment generally  
generated for psychological effect- so that the adult results in close-ups which: lack intimacy,  
appears taller than actually, to a small child. because players' features are flattened.  
189

## CLOSE-UPS

### THE FIVE C's

1. "R\_c", "e", cl

Objective close-ups are usually filmed from Point-of-view close-ups should be timed  
eye-level of player photographed. Here, the camera positioned at eye-level or per  
camera is raised to eye-level of an impersonator whose viewpoint is being depicted.  
observer positioned alongside subject, Director should work on this space missile con  
trol panel - Used for trailing astronauts

IL - allows the audience to trade places with  
trainee", and view diols from vantage point.  
difference in height of players is involved, camera  
height will have to be adjusted to accomplish the  
best foreground framing, together with proper  
modeling and positioning of the featured player.  
Differences in height may sometimes be cheated  
by having a shorter player stand on a block, or a  
tall woman remove her high heel shoes.

The CLIMAX ANGLE Chapter thoroughly dis  
cusses uses of progressive contrasting and reverse  
camera angles and image angles. A sequence  
may progress into a close-up or a series of close  
ups- or a close-up may be contrasted with a long  
shot; or a series of repetitive similarly sized close  
Subjective close-ups are best timed from  
ups of various players or objects may be presented.

eye-level of person photographed. Subject

A series of close-ups should be filmed with cor  
should look directly into lens - as if look  
responding image sizes. preferably from similar  
ing at another person seated or standing

nearby. This results in proper camera angles, so that their screen appearances



eye-to-eye relationship on same level. If remain uniform. Back-and-forth close-ups of objects has to look up or down - at higher posing players in a two-shot should be matched or lower camera - effect should be strained; in image size and image angle. whether filmed because relationship is awkward.

objectively or from each player's point-of-view.

Over-the-shoulder close-ups are filmed as closely as possible to the back of the player depicted, glasses may be used: but it is best to present as and as determined by the height of the player in matched pair before switching size or angle. If the (or) filmed. When two people of equal height different types of close-ups, or different angles, are filmed. little trouble will be encountered. If are mixed, a hodge-podge of shots will result.

190

## CLOSE-UPS

### THE FIVE C's

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Player's. ~ III:ad s/I should not hold around in a Point-of-view close-ups. well as this tight close-up, so that cameraman must close-up of soldiering operation - are particularly important in training films. Camera should move camera to keep it particularly important in training films. Camera should be positioned over-the-shoulder he instructed to hold his position as lie of world. ~ perform the task, ~o that speaks or resets. Unreliable subject following close-ups depict action as trainee should be photographed with shorter focal would set it if lie were doing the 0.1 cb., .....\_ length lens, so that wider area is covered.

This allows filming with a static camera.

Unless for narrative reasons, close-ups should not be presented in a monotonous series; merely to maintain uniformity of size and angle. Each player should be filmed with the same change in image size. and from the same angle. so that the film editor may utilize matched pairs of close-ups.

A series of repetitious cut-away close-ups of unrelated players or objects. such as several in-the-street close-ups, or close-ups of various objects - such as tools or dials - should maintain the same image size, and similar or opposing

camera angles. They may all face in the same direction, or face each other in pairs of opposing shots with alternate right and left looks. Dutch, needed later. With these precautions, uniformly angled close-ups, filmed for special effects, may of close-up image size and image angle can be given opposing angled tilts so that they present maintained throughout <1 production. counterpoint pairs. Head movement is permissible in a moving

It is advisable to make notes of lens focal close-up. If preferred, the camera may follow a length, camera angle, particularly whether left or player with a panning or dolly movement. But, a right Dutch-tilt angles, and distances between head should not be allowed to bob around in what camera and players or objects. It is best not to should be a static close-up so that the cameraman trust to memory, especially if a long interval must pan and/or tilt to keep the head properly occurs between the filming of matched close-ups. framed. This may be observed in newsreels and Such data will also be important if retakes are documentary films, where an over-long focal

191

## CLOSE-UPS

### THE FIVE C's

and end, with each shot, often results in a "stop and-go" appearance. Movement will flow through out a sequence, or a series of shots, if cuts are made during movement. A player may begin to move in one shot, and complete the movement in the following close-up. For example, a player should sit into a static close-up. As he moves toward the chair and begins to sit down, the movement flows across the cut, from medium shot into static close-up, as he settles into the chair. Movement into and out of close-ups should, therefore, duplicate action of preceding or following wider shots - so that overlapping movement results.

It may be difficult for a player to move into precise position, for a static head close-up. A simple

Player movement - begun in this shot

one solution to filming a tight head shot is to keep

may be completed in following close-ups,

when players sit. at tanto, Players should the standing player's feet static, bend the upper

du.pliccue their movements IJ!! sitting into body to the side, and then swing the body back close-ups. This permits editor to cut on into vertical position. In that way, the head may action withmovement fluwinq acrosssplice.

be moved into perfect framing when the player is

length lens - or a zoom lens set at the telephoto standing.

position - is employed to film an uncontrollable, While filming a move into a tight close-up may restless subject. In such instances, it is best to use be difficult to frame, a move Ollt of a close-up is fairly simple; and should always be filmed if the

a shorter focal length lens, and film a wider area

to allow static framing. player is picked up on the move in the next shot.

Should the player not be moved out of the close

#### PLAYER MOVEMENT

up, he must remain in his close-up position for

#### INTO & OUT OF CLOSE-UPS

next shot; and then be moved, during following

Aplayer may move from a long shot or medium medium or long shot,in order to continue action.

shot illto a close-up. Such movement should be The absence of moves into and out of close-ups

du.pucotcd in both shots, so that the Hlm editor is may severely handicap the editor, particularly if provided with a cine choice. The editor may cut he wishes to shorten the sequence gracefully. A

on the move, or after the move, when the player good rule is to move players into and out of close is in close-up position. If the player is positioned ups whenever such movement may be editorially in the frame for the close-up, rather than moved useful. (See: CUITI.\,1G, Cutting On Action)

into position, the editor has no choice, He must

move the player into position in the wider shot, CLOSE-UP TEMPO

and then cut to the already-positioned player in The timing of players' movements in close-ups

the close-up. should match that in bracketing scenes,especially

To assemble a more fluid film,editors prefer to if the movement flows across a cut. This is rarely cut on movement, rather than to a static close-up a problem in theatrical films, where professional

after movement is completed. While many move players follow the script and move about as di

ments should not be interrupted by a cut, a cam rected. It can cause complications in non-theatri

eraman should leave these decision tu the film cal films where industrial, research, training or

editor. Cutting on movement will often mask the scientific personnel operate control panels, lab

splice where the shots arc joined, so that the cut apparatus or test equipment. Since greatly magni

is barely apparent. Allowing movement to begin fied movements - such as throwing a switch,

## CLOSE-UPS

### THE FIVE C's

cutting a meter or swinging a tool into position - clear highly accelerated on the screen, the person performing a small action in a large close-up should move with deliberate slowness, so that hands, fingers or tools do not appear to flash in and out of the shot.

It is important to stage bracketing wider scenes with matching close-up tempo. This requires thinking ahead to the close-up, if the action is filmed in continuity. Cutting-on-movement in such cases will appear smooth only if precautions are taken to match the tempo of movement from wider shots to close-ups. For example, a medium shot of an airplane pilot in a cockpit moving his arm with a flashlight toward the instrument panel ("He will be cut-on-the-move with a close-up. Movement will extrude close-ups must be slowed down, or it will appear jerky, illogical of an airplane pilot as his fingers slowly enter the cockpit window screened. If this wider shot is frame to set the instrument. Only the portion of the close-up of technician's this close-up after his fingers have settled in position, as she positions machine part for motion on the calibration knob could be used. Calibration, it must be filmed with match. Differently-timed movements in wider shots and different tempo. If tempo varies greatly between close-ups in wider shots, it prevents close-ups from cutting on action, and forces the director to resort to statically-positioned close-ups, after movement into the frame is completed.

### BACKGROUNDS FOR CLOSE-UPS

Close-ups should not be filmed against "busy"

CLOSE-UP CAMERA SET-UPS backgrounds consisting of detailed designs, shiny surfaces, moving or similarly distracting objects,

Similar close-ups throughout a sequence are unless the subject matter justifies such treatment. almost always filmed at the same time in the same place. Possible exceptions would include amusement attraction pictures, to avoid duplicating camera set pieces, which would provide the gaiety of a ferris

ups. This may not be possible on a technical film wheel, merry-go-round, or other rides moving in where assembly of a complicated machine, for the background. Another exception is a television example, may necessitate shooting in straight commercial with multi-facet reflections, out-of-forward continuity as work progresses. When focus highlights, or other blurred visual effects in lengthy filming: requires moving the camera in the background. In a dramatic picture, however, for close-ups, and then back again to original players should not appear in close-ups against set-up, it is wise to mark camera position on the backgrounds which compete for attention. Even a floor and to record lens focal length, and other lamp with an ornate shade can be a provoking technical data useful in duplicating shots. Position influence!

Positions of light stands should be chalked or taped. Throwing the background slightly out of focus on the floor, if they are moved, so that they may be effective. but it should be avoided if lights, be returned to their first positions. Intricate light shiny objects, or highly reflective surfaces distracting set-ups may require diagramming, or they the viewer's attention from the players. This can may be photographed with a Polaroid camera to be particularly disturbing in color filming, if shiny insure precise duplication. Technical matching of colored objects - such as tinted light bulbs - show wider shots and close-ups can thus be assured, up in the background. Whenever possible, back regardless of time intervals between close-ups. grounds should be nondescript. softly-contrasting

193

## CLOSE-UPS

### THE FIVE C's

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Close-up camera angles for dramatic sequences should be staged against non-competing backgrounds.

surfaces. Primary or advancing colors, such as place names, insignias, posters, etc. In trying to "hot" reds or oranges, should be avoided. Recede solve 'what is missing, the viewer may pay less attention to the subject. Wild designs in drapes with a pale color tint, should be favored. or wallpaper may distract; particularly when en

All camera angles should be planned for a large background behind a close-up of a person. The most sequence: so that players in close-ups will not be suitable backgrounds for such close-ups are new positioned against troublesome backgrounds. Neutral grays, pastel tints or simple drapes, or other Lamps, picture frames, trees, poles, portions of plain material.

furniture, or other props; may crop up awkwardly

### CLOSE-UP FOR SEQUENCE OPENER

wardly behind heads. Such objects should be kept

"way from players: or so positioned that they do not If it is desirable to startle, confuse or withhold

not seem to protrude from a head. Camera and/or information from the audience, a close-up may help maneuver players into suitable close-up positions. An opener may show a gun firing in a close-up, followed by a long shot of the start of a frame or a lamp, appears where not wanted, foot race! A man lost in the desert, a little boy camera angle may be changed, player may be trapped in a crowd, or a needle moving toward moved, or the offending prop may be re-positioned on an instrument dial, may be mentioned. If only a small portion of the object shown first in close-up. Then the camera may be shown, it may be best to remove it completely. It moved back to reveal the over-all picture. should be returned to its original position, should A close-up may also eliminate a portion of the it appear in subsequent wider angle shots. setting, so that the player's identity, location or Newsreel interviews - or other documentary situation may be concealed until the camera pulls filming - may require shooting a close-up, or a back. A close-up may show a player sitting non unununu:

series of close-ups, introductory long or chivalantly on a container. In the following wider medium shots. Particular care should be taken in shot he may be depicted astride a keg of dynamite such situations to avoid backgrounds that may mislead! A close-up of a man behind bars may turn perplex or tease the audience. The viewer should not be surprised to see a teller in a bank. A close-up not be shown a section of unfamiliar background of a roaring lion pulls back to show him caged. in a close-up consisting of portions of signs. Thus a close-up sequence opener may be utilized

194

## CLOSE-UPS

### THE FIVE C's

1. To surprise or shock the audience when the full content of the scene is disclosed.

In order to motivate subsequent action, a sequence may open with a close-up of an object. A close-up of a ringing telephone can reveal, in an upward camera tilt, the person answering. A tape recorder playing back a confession may create suspense, until the camera pulls back to show the players involved. A close-up of a gun may hide the identity of the person holding it, until the camera tilts or pulls back to reveal him. If time is significant

can't to story, a sequence may open with a close-up of a wall clock. then pan to a long shot, to depict the action. A close-up may also establish the locale. Examples: a drink being poured - bar; a tray of food moving along - cafeteria; a slot Screen-filling extreme close-ups of small objects provide dramatic emphasis, Resting machine arm being pulled - gambling hall. electronic component on fingertip supplies clue to size.

#### CLOSE-UPS FOR TRANSITION

Pairs of close-ups, similar in size, motion or up, and then pull back. The camera may tilt from content, make excellent bridging devices. A pair a player to his shoes, as he walks across a room of close-ups may be optically blended or straight and through the doorway. Then it may dissolve to cut to furnish a pictorial transition between two the same shoes walking on the pavement; and tilt sequences, A sequence may end with a close-up: up to reveal the player going down the street. and the next sequence begin with one. A player (See: CONTINUITY, Transitional Devices) may be dissolved in a matched pair of close-ups to cover a time or space transition. Or, one player

CONCLUSION may dissolve to another player in a different set Properly-planned, effectively-filmed. thoughtful ting;. In that case. the players should be similarly ly-edited close-ups are of prime cinematic importance sized and positioned to achieve a subtle blend of importance. Close-ups add spice, the ingredient that images. Similar motions may be used; such as a enhances dramatic flavor of the finished film. lawyer pounding his desk, and a judge hammer Audience involvement is most successful when ing his gavel. Similar objects, such as wheels, viewers are brought into the picture: when they typewriter keys. as they may be filmed. see players. objects and small-scale actions in Sound will enhance a close-up transition the large screen-filling close-ups. A sequence may be cause of it.. combination audio-visual effect. A built to move toward climatic close-ups. A single line of dialogue. or a name may be spoken and quickly may open with a close-up that surprises. repeated in a pair of bridging close-ups, to tie startles or "hooks the audience into attention together different pictures or scenes. Or. a question Close-ups provide dramatic punch. point up station may be asked in a close-up and answered highlights depict related action; comment on in the next; by another picture in a different principal action. magnify the unseen; provide setting. transitions: emphasize narrative by isolation of

Camera movement may also be employed to subject. and elimination of unwanted matter: or move into and pull back from a pair of transitional close-ups. It may move into a close-up of a close-up should be made to count. The stronger the

player or object at the end (If a sequence and motive for us) In a close-up, the more the close-up  
better till the sequence with a similar type close-up can help make the story-telling truly effective!  
195

## HOW GREEN WAS MY VALLEY

### COMPOSITION

#### INTRODUCTION

able. The most dramatically striking scenes often

Good composition is arrangement of pictorial result from rule breaking. To break the rules  
elements to form a unified, harmonious whole. effectively. however, it is first necessary to com  
A cameraman composes whenever he positions or prehends the rules thoroughly. and to realize why  
a player, a piece of furniture, or a prop. Place they are being broken.  
ment and movement of players within the setting There are times when deliberately poor com  
should be planned to produce favorable audience positions will aid the story-telling. For instance, a  
reactions. Since viewing a motion picture is an film on slum clearance would actually be an  
emotional experience; the manner in which scenes hanced through employment of unbalanced, clutter  
are composed, staged, lighted, photographed and edited, poorly composed scenes. Such scenes  
edited should motivate audience reaction, accord \....ould irritate the audience, and express the need  
ing to the script's intent. The viewer's attention for decent housing. Pictorial and psychological  
should be concentrated on the player. object or impacts upon the viewer would he doubly effec  
action most significant to the story at that moment. nvc. He would not only want to see slum condi  
The camera mechanically records all properly tions corrected. he would also like to straighten  
exposed, sharply focused images with equal clarity the scenes that subconsciously disturb him!  
ity. Stimulation of audience response - the no., Composition reflects personal taste. A camera  
mechanical factor - can be best conveyed by the man with artistic background: inherently good  
cameraman through direction of dramatic composition; an inborn feeling for proper balance, form,  
phases where desirable. This is accomplished by rhythm, space, line and tone: an appreciation  
accentuating the motions and emotions, which of color values; a sense of the dramatic, may  
make the story live in the viewer's mind. create good compositions intuitively. Even a  
Composition should not be employed in a by mechanically-minded cameraman with limited  
the-numbers fashion to record pictorially beautiful artistic inclination, can learn to apply the basic:  
images devoid of character, meaning and move principles of good composition by developing belief  
ment. Of all rules by which motion pictures are made understanding of visual and emotional elements  
made, compositional principles are the most numerous involved in recording story-telling images.



## COMPOSITION

### THE FIVE C's

numerous other pictorial faults, holds the viewer's attention through sheer num. cmcn! alone! If abused, however. movement-which should be the motion picture's greatest asset - can very easily become its greatest liability. Good motion picture scenes are the result of intelligent use of camera and signification of players and/or camera. Unsatisfactory scenes are the results of thoughtless compositions and meaningless player or camera movements. which distract rather than aid in the story-telling.

Although the cameraman should be primarily concerned in telling the story with movement. he must guard against the inclusion of a subordinate player or unimportant object, which still photographs - well (/. " these jet air may detract from the principal player, action or craft in fluid motion. Be object. Such movement can be particularly dis cause of poor space relationships only,

. . . . . If well composed in a single tracing 10 quiet scenes that are more or less static in nature. Since the viewer's eyes are easily attracted or distracted by any moving object, the

STILL vs. MOTION PICTURE COMPOSITION cameraman should guard against undue imbalance. Still photographs freeze the decisive moment in movement anywhere in the scene.

one stationary image. A still photograph may suggest

motion, but it deals in space relationships GOOD CAMERA WORK BEGINS

only. It can, therefore, be well composed only WITH COMPOSITION

within its singular frame of reference. A motion picture scene is the cameraman's single picture, on the other hand, is composed in both time and space. He must arrange the various pictorial elements into a semblance of order before he can

The time dimension is just as important as

linear dimensions and placement of the pictorial

elements within the frame. A motion picture is a

progression of varied size images. Space and time relationships between various elements may remain the same, or change as the picture progresses. The size of the various images may remain the same, or change from scene to scene; or during a scene if the players advance toward or recede from the camera. or if the camera is dollyed, panned, tilted or zoomed. This constantly changing image pattern tends to complicate motion picture composition.

To produce a successful photograph, a still photographer must apply compositional rules correctly. A motion picture cameraman, however, cannot simply enter a moving image in his finder and follow it. He must choose a camera position (an angle, a distance) regardless of floor composition, improper placement of the camera may provide the best view of the scene, unsatisfactory background or foreground. - all the best composition,

198

## COMPOSITION

### THE FIVE C's

#### COMPOSITIONAL RULES

Because composition involves artistic taste, emotional awareness, personal likes, dislikes, experience and background, the individual cameraman, strict rules cannot be applied. While composing a scene is not a mechanical process, certain mathematical and geometrical factors may help insure success. The principal difficulty in composing for motion pictures is dealing not only with shape of people and objects, but the shape of motion. A beautifully-composed static scene may become a senseless shambles when players, objects, vehicles, or the camera move! The motion picture cameraman must remember

that rules of static composition cover still photo

If we should awe audience by beauty, graphs, drawings, paintings, designs. Because of

vasinccsorgrandeur of setting, a lot of still, the static content of many shots, still composi

or extreme still shot ~ conveying proper

unctional rules may be successfully applied to mo

maud mood atmosphere - should be used.

tion picture scenes with fully pictorial elements.

A scene may break all compositional rules and

light the players and the set; plot player and/or still attract the viewer's eye to the significant

camera movement, break down the sequence into player or object in the picture, merely by move

shots, and depend on the various camera angles meant or sound dominating the frame. A poorly

required to cover the action. Until the scene is positioned player, for instance, may attract atten

composed, the cameraman is not sure just what action by raising his voice. Even though obscure in

he is going to shoot. Even outdoors on uncontrolled position, a secondary action may attract more

valuable subject matter, which cannot be pre-empted by the principal action.

arranged, the cameraman can choose camera This does not imply that good

angles that provide him with the best viewpoint,

and consequently, the best composition

The cameraman should approach composition

with the question: "What can I do with this sub

ject matter that will aid in telling the story?"

Players' actions and setting often suggest a par

ticular compositional treatment. Script and sub

ject should be analyzed to determine the audience

impact intended. Should the viewer become

moved to pity, tears or laughter? Should the

audience be awed by the beauty, vastness or

grandeur of the subject? Or should they be sold

on a particular product, process or technique?

Whatever the script's intent, the scenes should be

composed to provide the proper pictorial aspects,

and inspire the desired psychological response in The curved grouping of these airmen, plan

ning a line in

the viewer. Pictorial thinking and appreciation of

space - extended by right arm of 111' of Ti

psychological compositional devices by the cam

cor at left - which tends to kccp vie,l'l's'  
eraman will produce intended mood. eyes focused un map.  
199

## COMPOSITION

### THE FIVE C's

should be disregarded. and action and dramatic  
dialogue substituted to capture viewer's attention.  
The rules of good composition should be utilized  
whenever possible, particularly when the scene  
consists of more or less sialic action - such as ill  
establishing long shots. players at rest in key  
positions during dialogue exchanges. and any  
time dramatic emphasis must be attracted to  
dominant subject matter. Esthetic values should  
I/O/ be neglected because of eye-and-car aurae  
lions of „11(;('.[ movement and mere sound. Players  
and objects should be harmoniously arranged  
within 111I~ scuing. and moved about with artistic  
effect.... striving to capture pleasing pictures at all  
times; regardless of player and/or camera move  
Lines .~I/}/(Id //ot part/lid tllllf side ot tile  
ment, and the need for continuous composing as  
[rnme lllll/'.~,(orllclll bl{ a lmilt/illrl - or  
the scene progresses. ("O/(llll//s. 11"1'/' or ollwr lines, as parl of (l  
repelitolts {lal/tTll. Ti,l' ."l'rif',~ of uerticat  
COMPOSITIONAL LANGUAGE lines nrc ill };ccpill,tj ioitu //1(' diqlly of tin  
LINES nmdcrn Mll,~ic CClIICI".  
FORAIS intelligent manner. they comprise a composi  
MASSES tional language which ITlay convey the desired  
MOVE:\fu..'TS mood. character and atmosphere.  
These compositional elements speak a univer  
LINES  
sal language 'v-htch tri~cr similar emotional  
Compositional lines may be actual contours of  
responses in almost every viewer. Properly inte

objects or imaginary lines in space. People, props, grouped and employed in an artistic, imaginative, buildings, trees, vehicles, furniture - may all be expressed in straight, curved, vertical, horizontal, diagonal or any combination of contour lines.

While moving about in the scenes, or following action, the eye also creates transitional lines in space. Such imaginary lines, suggested by eye

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movement or subject movement, may be more

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.. effective than actual compositional lines.

For instance, the viewer's eye may travel in a curved pattern, formed by the grouping of several players. It may move in a diagonal line as it follows an airplane taking off. Or in a vertical line described by an ascending missile. The linear composition of a scene is dependent, therefore, not only on actual contour lines but by transitional lines created by eye movement.

A rule of thumb is that for most effective composition, real lines should not divide the picture into equal parts.

Neither strong vertical nor horizontal lines should

be centered. A telegraph pole or the horizon,

should not be placed in the middle of the frame.

The frame should not be divided into two equal

parts with a diagonal line from one corner to another, as formed by the side of a mountain.

200

## COMPOSITION

### THE FIVE C's

should not be placed in the middle of the frame.

The frame should not be divided into two equal

parts with a diagonal line from one corner to

another, as formed by the side of a mountain.

Unless formed by buildings, columns, trees or other lines, as part of a repetitious pattern, straight lines should not parallel any side of the frame. A single strong line at the side, top, or bottom of the picture should be irregular, rather than absolutely vertical or horizontal. Silhouetted lines, paralleling one or more sides of the frame - such as a doorway - should be recognized, or they may suggest image "cut-off" caused by a misaligned filter holder or matte box.

Viewer interpretations of various compositional

lines follow: to illustrate a point of view

Straight lines suggest (1) masculinity, strength,

Tall, vertical lines suggest strength and dignity.

Softly curved lines suggest femininity, delicate

Parallel, diagonal lines indicate action, energy,

qualities.

violence.

Sharply curved lines suggest action and gaiety.

Opposing diagonals suggest conflict, forceful

Long vertical curves with tapering ends suggest

dignified beauty and melancholy.

Strong, heavy, sharp lines suggest brightness.

Long horizontal lines suggest quiet and restful laughter, excitement.

ness. Paradoxically, they may also suggest

Soft lines suggest solemnity, tranquility.

speed, because the shortest distance between

Irregular lines are more interesting than regular

two points is a straight line.

Long lines, because of their visual quality.

Various combinations of lines may influence

each other and convey different meanings. Un

opposed verticals, beginning at the bottom or end

ing at the top of the picture, appear to extend

beyond the frame. However, short secondary horizontals, such as a roof, may be used to contain a vertical composition within the frame. Short horizontal lines are useful as accents to help a series of strong verticals from becoming monotonous. Conversely, long horizontals may also be accented or broken up by short verticals, meeting at right angles or crossing. Curves require stronger straight lines for accents and contrast.

A series of curves may weaken a composition unless reinforced by vertical or horizontal accents.

A profusion of curves or diagonals may result in

Parallel diagonals converging in dis

talce t'onveyactioll and ellerY. ll- rl'inforced confusion, and should be used only to express by glare of sunlight on the rails, shocking excitement or uncontrolled action.

201

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## COMPOSITION

### THE FIVE C's

Lines that lie flat on the picture surface, or angular or jagged lines, such as lightning streaks, recede into the distance, convey different meanings, give impressions of speed, forcefulness, vitality, etc. Whenever a vertical or horizontal line be Softly curved lines slow eye speed and create a comes a diagonal, it appears to recede from, or leisurely or deliberate pace. Most beautiful curves advance toward the viewer. A tilting shot of a attract lingering attention. Since they do not building indicates that it is falling backwards, impede progress, unbroken lines make faster An angled shot of a straight road creates the impression of viewing than broken or erratic lines. pression that it is a diagonal, receding into the

### FOHM

distance. A geometric curve creates a pattern that lies flat on the surface of the picture. A receding All objects, whether natural or man-made, have or diminishing curve, however, suggests distant space. Physical Forms are easy to recognize, Forms space, since it carries the eye into the picture. A created by viewer's eye movement from one ob diagonal line parallel to the picture's surface suggest to another are not always easy to recognize. gests a moving, falling or other action line, such unless pointed out. Thus, many abstract forms as a falling tree. A diagonal receding into the distance exist solely in viewer's minds in the space created

tnncc. suggests a space line. Pairs of such diagonals by several physical objects.

Lines, such as railroad tracks, seem to converge. Eye movement From one person or object to another and meet at infinity. Another may describe a triangle, a circle or other

Meanings conveyed by lines are also influenced by form. Many experienced cameramen subconsciously by such forces of Nature as gravity. Diagonals are usually utilized in certain compositional forms without dynamic. Usually they suggest instability because actually analyzing them. They have learned

Lines are basically fallen verticals. A vertical tree through experience that certain groupings of becomes a diagonal when it falls. Lightning is a people, furniture, objects, vehicles and structures strong, sharp, jagged diagonal line. Rain drops or present harmonious pictures. Transitional lines SHOW flakes form a series of softly falling lines, created by the viewer's eye moving from one Rivers or meandering streams create curves as object to another may result in an aesthetically they follow the contour of the earth, pleasing effect.

Lines also express speed qualities, which can follow following compositional forms should be added dramatic emphasis to the picture. Straight, considered as both physical forms and abstract

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Transitional lines which describe forms in life - such as triangles formed by "like" derrick loading Polaris missile in the nuclear submarine - are compositionally strong. Other line forms will appear to lie on surface of screen,

202

## COMPOSITION

### THE FIVE C's

A reverse triangular composition - top, middle, bottom - may also be used to compose a group of people. While the main line of action is in form, it is an excellent choice in this instance, because still life elements dominate centered placement. Composition will not be cancelled if placed at right angles were necessary, forms existing in space. They should also be considered as groups of figures or objects arranged in a circular considered as extending in depth, from front to back of



pattern. causes viewer's gaze to wander without the picture. not solely as flat. two-dimensional ('scape from the frame. A circle of light, such as forms lyin?; on the surface of the picture, that produced by a spotlight. may be employed to

A triangular form suggests strength. stability. It encompasses a player. Yet. the rest of the framed solidity of the pyramid. It is a compact. closed area remains dark; discouraging viewer's attention form which causes the eye to continue from point to point without straying from center of interest. A circle to point without escape. A tall. thin triangle is or oval lacks the broad base and stability of the related 10 the vertical. and is found in Nature in pyramid or triangle. A base may be provided. how evergreen trees. A short. squat triangle is related ever. by a shadowed area, a foreground frame. or to the horizontal and. because of its broad base. some other lighting or compositional device. possesses greatest stability. Mountains are composed of a series of triangles. Triangle composition that may be centered. because its four arm radiations are very useful for grouping people because it is in all directions equally. The cross inspires a significant figure can dominate through added sense of unity and force. It is awesome and powerful height. It is much easier to compose in film because in many minds it symbolizes the other odd numbers; because a single composition is Almighty. The cross may be placed off center of the frame. The central element may become the center of interest in the picture; but it should not be placed too close by rising up and creating an abstract triangular to the side of the frame, or part of its radiance composition with the lower positioned figures on will be weakened.

either side. An inverted triangle. with its apex at the bottom. Radiating lines are a variation of the cross, bottom. may also be used although it lacks the stability of the pyramid, which rests on its base. located hub. There are many excellent examples In this fashion. two adults may be effectively composed in Nature - flower petals, tree branches, snow posed with a child between them. flakes, etc. Radiating lines seem to expand and A circular or oval form also tends to attract, especially if twirled. and their action hold the viewer's attention. A circular object. or a spread of joy and laughter. While radiating lines

203

## COMPOSITION

### THE FIVE C's

may be either straight or curved, to be most effective a line should be made up of any or all of these. Masses, the center of interest should be located near the center of the frame. Units, such as a large body of the hub, Unlike the cross, however, the hub need not be at the center. a mountain peak. a ship or an airplane; or not be near the center of the frame. a large head in close-up. or a combination of

Various L-shaped forms suggest Informality. several figures or objects closely grouped or inter and are very flexible because they provide a base so that they appear as a single composition and upright in combination. An L shaped compositional unit.

sition is... useful for landscapes, or establishing long lines and forms can dominate a composition shots; where a broad base created by a shadow by their esthetic or psychological value. They may area, a walk, a wall or a road, extends horizontally attract the viewer's eye, through sheer beauty or to one side of the frame with a tree rising in the viewer's senses through their emotional appeal strong vertical. A solitary figure at one side of the frame. Pictured masses, however, capture and hold the frame may also form an L with the ground or attention through the power of their heavy picture floor. The L can provide repose, through its base; tonal weight. They may also dominate by their and dignity. through use of figure or object rising isolation, unity, contrast, size, stability, cohesion, in the frame. The strongest L composition results lighting or color.

when the upright occupies the left or right vertical Strength is added to an isolated mass, if it is line created by dividing the frame in thirds. An area separated from its background by contrast, light accent at the opposite bottom corner lines will provide lighting or color. Such treatment will cause a mass to provide the opposing compositional weight required stand out from a confusing, conflicting or other for a balanced picture. avoid "busy" background.

A unified mass is strengthened when several figures or objects are tied together, so that they

## MASSSES

combine into a dominant group, Wildly scattered

The words "form and mass" are often used groupings should be avoided.

Interchangeably. "Form" has to do with the spatial A dark mass will stand out against a light background of an object, its physical shape as defined background, or a light mass against a dark area by its form. Form may be physical or abstract through contrast. This is the simplest way to proceed as explained in the preceding pages. Mass is the visual emphasis, and pull a figure or object away from the pictorial field of an object, an area, a figure or from the background.

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It may be a single pictorial element - a mountain peak - or it may consist of a group of figures that appear as a composition. A mass captures viewers' attention through the power of its form. In a pictorial weight

204

## COMPOSITION

### THE FIVE C's

A large mass will dominate the scene if contrasted with one or more small masses. Size of mass can be increased in relation to the frame through careful choice of camera angle, lens focal length and placement in the picture.

A finely-composed mass with a heavy base, presents an immovable appearance which will dominate through stability. The pyramid form, particularly with a dark foreground, is very effective when massed into a dominant full-frame pictorial element.

A compact mass - without projections, jagged edges or other protuberances - will dominate the scene because of its cohesiveness.

Massive lighting effects, especially if shot

against a darker background, will dominate by freedom from weight - as depicted in *Notre-Dame de Paris* creating unity and contrast. A burning forest, a streak of sunlight through church windows, a

fireworks display, or the backlit rays of sun from left to right has pre-trained the audience to light on the water arc all dominant masses here accept such movement; and to follow it with little effort. Right-to-left is stronger, because it is

A predominating color, such as a large blue "against the grain." Since left to right offers less shadow area or red-streaked clouds illuminated by resistance, it should be used for travelogue pan a setting sun, may create a massive color effect. Right to left movements should be employed where a more dramatic opposition must be depicted, such as the hero moving toward the villain.

## MOVEMENTS

Ascending vertical movements suggest aspiration

Compositional movements are a particularly important aspect of motion picture photography.

Complete movements may be only suggested in still photography. They may be both suggested and

depicted in motion pictures. Movements possess esthetic and psychological properties, which may convey varied pictorial and emotional connotations to the viewer. Movement may be created by the eye going from one point to another within the scene, or by following a moving object. Such eye movement results in transitional lines which are similar to compositional lines. Movements may change during a shot, or a sequence of shots, to match the changing character, mood or tempo of the action. Meanings of various compositional movements may be described as follows

Horizontal movements suggest travel, momentum, displacement. Left-to-right movement is harmonious, dangerous or crushing power - as easier to follow, more natural, smoother. Reading downwards this waterfall.

205

## COMPOSITION

### THE FIVE C's

This life-size model of proposed supersonic transport plane being readied for wind tunnel test, appears (as if) actual (if) it is angled in ascending line.

matter - such as smoke ascending from a candle, scenes. Diagonal movement may be suggested or a missile rising. Since an upward movement is even in many static scenes by a Dutch tilt angled uplifting, it may be employed for religious subject matter, which creates slanting dynamic lines. Objects. Feelings of lightness, free flight, happiness, Thus, a statue, a building a dominant player, may elevation may be conveyed by such movement. be given added dramatic impact by diagonal treatment. A descending vertical movement suggests heaviness. A top-to-bottom diagonal motion iness, danger, crushing power, such as portrayed should be used for an ascending movement, such by a pile driver, an avalanche or a waterfall. Such as climbing a mountain. An upper-left-to-lower downward movements may portray doom, imminent diagonal motion should be employed for imminent death or destruction. descending movement, such as lowering an object.

Adiagonal movement is most dramatic because Zig-zag diagonal movements - such as lightning it is the strongest. Diagonal movements suggest flashes - suggest swiftness and menace. Crossed opposing forces, stresses and strains, Inverse, over diagonal suggest opposing forces, such as crossed

coming obstacles by force - such as in battle scenes.

206

## COMPOSITION

### THE FIVE C's

Curved movements suggest fear; such as a BALANCE

curved snake, or fascination through fear. Circular

Balance is a state of equilibrium. If all forces

linear or revolving movements, however, suggest

are equal, or compensate each other, they are said

cheerfulness, as found in amusement park rides.

to be "in balance." An out-of-balance figure or

Revolving movements also suggest mechanical

object will usually topple over. Physical balance,

energy; such as wheels of industry or travel. therefore, is influenced by the law of gravity, by

Pendulum motion suggests monotony, relentless compensating forces and the power of attraction.

lessness, such as prison scenes or the back-and-forth Unbalance upsets the viewer because it disturbs

the pacing of nervous person or caged animal. his sensibilities, and creates unrest in the brain.

Cascading motion suggests sprightliness, light That is why some pictures may not "look right."

ness or elasticity such as a ball bouncing, water A properly-balanced composition is subconscious

rapids or a child skipping or playing hop-scotch. Usually agreeable, because the various elements are

Spreading or radiating motions suggest center combined in an acceptable picture. On special

focal movement, such as concentric ripples on the

occasions, the cameraman may wish to disturb

surface of a pool resulting from a stone thrown the viewer, and purposely presents an unbalanced

into the water. Radiating movement may also composition. Ordinarily, the scene should be pre-

suggest growth from the center outward. Spread centered so that the laws of balance are observed.

ing motion suggests panic, such as in a mob riot Pictorial balance in motion picture composition

ing. Hadtanning motion suggests radio broadcast can be either complicated or enhanced by player

ing, or any activity) emanating outward from the and/or camera movement. Moving players or ve

center of interest. hicles and the necessity for panning, tilting or

Interrupted movement, or movement that dolly the camera, require continuous compos

changes direction, attracts greater viewer interest ing as the scene progresses. Motion pictures com

than continuous movement or movement in a positional balance is a series of pictorial eon/

constant direction. promises based on the positions of players and

Movement toward the viewer is more interest pauses in the action when elements are at rest.

ing because it increases in size. Receding move Static scenes require better balance than moving  
ment decreases in size and loses viewer interest. scenes, where action will attract the viewer's eye,  
N""".~. ""•. ". "

Lower-left-to-upper-right diagonal motion should be used for ascending move  
ment. An,qlin.1J thismobile-launched jet {iqhter, so that it moves across the screen  
in tllis manner, results in a dynamically effective shot. If this shot were filmed  
from the opposite side,it would depict the aircraft with an opposing transitional  
line wflch should be used for descending motion

207

## COMPOSITION

### THE FIVE C's

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MOl'('mellt toward V;('ll'{'r is more intrrcstino, !lecausc it il1crt'usl'.~ in size as if  
(jdv{/nn.~. Movement of Marilles rushing forward in tllis amphibious landinu is  
[urthcr reinforced /!y jet fLY/llers fLYllllllo'ward tuo camera

regardless ofcompositionalinadequacies. psychological or pictorial weight.

Real /ik balance is concerned with l'ty...icul The location of a compositional dement within  
uciqlu, Pictorial balance is concerned withp.<ydlO the frame influences its weight. Afigure or object  
logical 1('t'(qlIt, which is influenced by relative l'ye placed. close to the cellter of the frame possesses  
attraction of various compositional dements in lesscompositional weight than one nearer the side  
the picture. Each clement attracts in accordance - because it exerts ltule influence on the seesaw  
with its size, shape, tonal value,color, movement, and cannot lip it cttbcr way. Therefore, a ltghrcr  
direction it faces. contrast with its surroundings weight element maybe moved further away from  
and placement in the frame. Balance may be con the center; while those of heavier weight should  
sidered as a pair of balances or a seesaw. A large he positioned closer toward the center - to keep  
static object on one side of the scene may thus be them in balance. Placing a heavy weight element  
counter-balanced by a small moiino object un the too far to either side of the frame will unbalance  
opposite side - such as a tiny car moving toward the composition and cause it 10 topple visually.  
a large mountain - because they hoth have equal The following compositional weight factors

208

## COMPOSITION

## THE FIVE C's

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This scene is pictorially interesting. The documentary subjects - Slid, as this high (uel truck ts ill lJtldlgroIIIUJ, framed l)/{ SIR'('<! .~JJa('('caneule ejection seat test willi airplane ld"". It would lack interest if instructional dummies - mmt be for s/wt squurr-on, with aircraft and fuel truck: mally composed umcn two object» are of ill Mfaiyilt tine-up across screen, equal interest,

should be considered on the basis of all other is compositionally weakest.

factors being equal: A large object in a static scene will carry more

A moving object possesses more weight than a weight, since it tends to dominate the picture re stationary object. This applies regardless of size. gardless of position or other factors.

A relatively small moving object - particularly if Regularly-shaped objects carry more weight light in tone, brightly colored or contrasted than irregularly-shaped objects.

against the background - will command greater Peculiar. complex or intricate objects may ap attention than a large stationary object. pear heavier because of the additional interest

An object moving toward the camera becomes they generate.

progressively larger, and thrcrtorc carries greater A compact object; with mass concentrated weight than a diminishing object moving away. around its center. will carry more weight than a

The upper part of a picture is heavier than the loosely-joined object.

lower part. because a higher object appears hcav A vertically-formed object will appear heavier ler than a lower one. than an oblique object.

Since most viewers' eyes automatically move A bright object will possess more weight than a toward the right. the right side of the frame can darker one. A high-key. light-toned object appears

obviously attract and hold more attention than the to adoance toward the viewer: while a darker ob left side. Thus. the left side of a picture can sup ject recedes into the background. A black area

port greater pictorial weight than the right side. must, therefore, be larger than a white area to

An isolated object possesses more lv'eight than counter-balance it. A bright surface appears rcla an object crowded, merged or stacked with others. lively larger than a dark one, because of irradi

This applies whether Isolauon is achieved by post ation effect.

tioning, lighting, contrast. color, or other factor. Warm colors, such as red, arc heavier than cold

An object will appear heavier if placed at the colors, such as blue. Bright colors convey more side of the frame, since the center of the picture weight than dark colors.

## COMPOSITION

### THE FIVE C's

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H",",",~""

Formal composition balance should be used to depict quiet, restful, static scenes

such as injured girl being comforted by /U" /Jlrl'ltii. Simplest camera and

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lighting! Treatment can best convey peaceful evf'Tlt....

### TYPES OF BALANCE

square-on, with little or no camera angling, so

FORMAL, or symmetrical balance that pictorial elements on each side are similar

INFORMAL, or asymmetrical balance in image size. Formally balanced compositions

should not be garish in handling - lighting, tonal

FOR, 1AL BALANCE~CF.

values, colors and contrast should be subtle.

When 180° sides of a composition are symmetrical formal balance is employed in the popular pro-

duction, or almost equal in attraction. formal balance two-shot, in which two players sit or stand on

opposite sides of the frame facing each other.

less, lacking in force, conflict and contrast. A dominance switches from one player to the other

formally-balanced picture suggests peace, quiet, as each speaks in turn. Since each player is equally

important pictorially. it is dialogue, facial expressions.

should be formally balanced because they are silent or other action which attracts audience at

generally presented to convey these qualities to attention. It is possible to "unbalance" such formally

balanced scenes should be filmed almost balanced two-shots by favoring one player with

210

## COMPOSITION

### THE FIVE C's

for the head's off-center position. The on-screen

player is thus balanced with an "invisible" off

screen player!

The simplest method for creating asymmetrical

compositions is to think of a fulcrum or fulcrum,

with one side heavier than the other. The heavy



side is the dominant figure or object, the center of interest in the scene. This dominant compositional element must have an opposing element on the opposite side of the frame, to balance composition of the scene.

A smaller opposing compositional element can compensate for its size by additional weight incurred through its location, shape, brightness, movement or color value. Since movement creates

Informal balance is used all dose-ups greatest interest in a motion picture scene, because the subject must be positioned smaller moving figures or vehicles carry greater weight. slightly off-center to provide more space compositional weight than much larger static objects in the direction of look.

jects, such as buildings, trees, or mountains.

brighter lighting, slightly better angling, brighter Thus, the center of interest may be a small boat color costume, better separation with the background moving toward a large harbor. Physical size ground or any of the other compositional tricks should not be the only consideration in choosing described elsewhere in this chapter. Thus, opposite a dominant compositional element. Movement is

tion, force and conflict may result from an other important. too. wise peaceful composition. The dominant subject should not be placed in the same horizontal line with the lesser-weight

#### INFORMAL BALANCE

opposing element; but should be slightly higher

When both sides of a composition are asymmetrical, or different in attraction, informal balance results. Informal balance is dynamic because it presents a forceful arrangement of opposing compositional elements. In an informally-balanced picture a dominant figure or object provides the center of interest. In contrast, or opposition, is a secondary figure or object of equal compositional weight on the other side. Compositional elements of different shapes, sizes, color or tonal values, or static and moving subject matter, may thus balance

ance each other because both sides of the picture are equal in compositional weight. Asymmetrical balance is employed subtly on close-ups - where a single player fills the frame - by placing the .....

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head slightly off-center, so that slightly more space

Formal balance is generally employed for

is provided in the direction in which the player

turn-shot: of boy and girl. Audience interest

looks. By association - with the off-screen player,

will shift from one player to other as each

objector action with whom the player is relating speaks in turn - or performs significant

the look carries sufficient weight to compensate action.

211

## COMPOSITION

### THE FIVEC's

bottom of frame - thus creating a triangular

composition. Dominance may be switched from

one player to another as the scene progresses, by

changing); positions, or by one player standing

if all are seated - or by stepping forward. A lower

than eye-level camera angle may be given the sig

nificant player by placing him toward the right

side of the frame, facing inward. The right side

has greater pictorial weight. The left side is more

obscure.

This does not imply that all arrangements

should consist of odd numbers of players with the

leading player at the apex of a triangular right

handed composition! Variations on this theme

should be used whenever practical. The dominant

The player who should dominate the scene need not remain compositionally strong

should not be placed in the same horizon

throughout the shot, or sequence. He may achieve

total line with lesser player. Positioning the

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dominance by movement, or by the movement of

nothing at the right of the frame, all the higher

than the seated figure, provides a composition other players, or the camera. He may thus capture

situationally stronger treatment. audience interest only when it is required - such

as when speaking an important line of dialogue

or performing a significant action.

or lower - preferably higher - so that it shows

heavier weight in order to attract attention. There

#### GRAVITY INFLUENCES BALANCE

fore, a dominating player should appear higher

Human senses rebel at compositions that defy

than the supporting players. Or, if placed lower,

the laws of gravity. Heavy compositional elements

or seated, dominate the scene by better lighting or

reaching skyward should possess a low center of

positioning; such as being placed on one of the

gravity, or they will seem about to topple. A tall

four strong compositional points of the frame; or

even capture attention by the "looks" of the other

players directed toward him. Being positioned

in 1, 1,

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higher or lower will do the trick, but placing the in

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dominant player at equal compositional height if joined

with less important player may weaken the scene. (

Positioning may also be accomplished in depth by

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positioning the selected player forward of the others:

ers to make him appear higher, or positioning him further

further back so that he appears lower. "

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l'

#### INFORMAL BALANCE, WITH ODD NUMBERS

A simple method for creating informal balance

is to compose with an odd number of players or objects. An odd number of pictorial elements, particularly three, may be so positioned that a single element will dominate the remainder. Also odd Gravity influences balance. Large structural numbers facilitate the arrangement of pictures should have heavy bases - such as pictorial elements; which permits placing the dominant element at one side of frame - or at top or breaking lip large [unclear] area,

212

## COMPOSITION

### THE FIVE C's

structure should be supported by a broad base, preferably dark-toned, to aid in supporting its top-heavy visual effect. A relatively large foreground area should be dark shadowed - or illuminated with light filtered through tree branches. To counter-balance buildings or other strong compositional elements. Large areas of sunlighted pavements should be avoided in such instances,

either by elimination. or by lowering the camera to foreshorten the area from front to back. Gravity also influences movement: a balloon ascends upward, all object falls downward, water flows downhill (preferably with upper-left-to lower-right movement), and a man climbs uphill (preferably with lower-left-to-upper-right movement). This fight scene forms all inverted triangles.

lar composition - with subdued player at Unbalanced composition may be created by bottom apex.

defying the laws of gravity through employment of baseless pictures. A tall building jutting diagonally integrated. The desired mood and atmosphere

nally through the frame; or tilted Dutch-angled should be conveyed by proper usage of line, form, shots of players. objects or structures depicted in mass and movement; lighting, player and/or slanting diagonals. which create out-of-balance camera movement; tonal values; color combinations; may be used when the script calls for them; over-all photographic treatment; and editing. The man)' technical. esthetic and psychological elements should be correlated in order to achieve

UNITY Yey a unified emotional feeling. Mixture of cinematic effects results in a discordant clash, which elements incorporated in the scene arc perfectly will weaken the story-telling.

A picture possesses unity when all cinematic effects results in a discordant clash, which elements incorporated in the scene arc perfectly will weaken the story-telling.

u-n..."" ,\_

At left of frame, and Writer; tile Low camera angle and selective focusing

11'0111(111 dominates tilt' alJov(' shot because make player in foreground stand out she is more favorable. IJ an~lled 'oward tile .~IUlpl\_'1 against supporting player.~ ill back camera, and better illuminated, YfOllUd, U:110(in! lower ill frame.

213

## COMPOSITION

### THE FIVE C's

CD""", "Col,'o,'"" Co

An odd number of players, preferably

Tile ascending motion of these jet fighters

three, may be informally balanced with a

is further T Sll.qW'.~t'd 1)11 fl!!lin{J a diagonal

single ('enter of interest - such as the

[ormution: Tlli~ creates a lmvcrl-left-to

actress in this three-shot, who is positioned

lppcr-riqJll truneiuonnt time in space,

tioned lower and better lighted than the

Ot1/t'T planers

Do compose a series of tall vertical columns

DO's & DON'Ts fronting a courthouse in a dignified manner with

Do combine long horizontal lines, static or slow a symmetrical, static composition. Don't destroy panning camera, soft lighting, slow moving or the effect by panning horizontally across the vertical static players, lengthy scenes, to inspire a quiet, tical columns.

peaceful, restful mood, Don't destroy the effect Do increase the action effect of mountain

by tilting the camera upward, or by allowing fast climbers, racing cars, marching soldiers, by stag

player movement, or by editing with short, choppying their movement so that the viewer's eye must travel in a diagonal pattern.

Do record the graceful effect of a skier twisting and turning downhill by following with a curving camera movement.

Do employ slanted Dutch camera angles, dynamic compositions, dramatic lighting, and rhythmic editing to create an unbalanced, tilted, unstable effect on anything weird or violent.

Don't employ unusual camera angles, distracting background movement or off-beat lighting on a simple scene with important dialogue, which requires greater audio than visual attention.

Do strive always to preserve unity of style throughout a sequence.

#### ONE CENTER OF INTEREST

A picture should feature one center of interest.

Girl dominates this scene because she is

lower, positioned on right and angled to Two or more equally dominant figures, objects or ward camera, compositionally stronger. actions in a single scene compete with each other

214

#### COMPOSITION

##### THE FIVE C's

for the viewer's attention, and weaken the picture's effectiveness. A two-shot may appear to be an exception to this rule - but it isn't! One player at a time dominates a two-shot as he speaks or performs a more significant action. A single player may also be favored in a two-shot in a number of ways previously discussed. The eye will thus be attracted to a single player either by his speech or actions or by more favorable compositional lighting or camera treatment.

The viewer's attention should always be attracted to the most significant portion of the

scene. This does not imply that foreground and background action may not occur simultaneously, or that several, or even hundreds of figures or objects may not appear in a single scene. Back formal principle the easiest to achieve is to have an odd number of players, or pictorial elements. Background action should complement foreground action. In the scene, the seamen are steering action, so that it provides the setting and atmosphere for the principal players without competing with them. Cause the triangular composition. A dominant compositional element need not exist, the effect is further enhanced by the officer dressed in light-colored clothing - this adds pictorial interest. Several figures, or any closely-knit combination of figures or objects, which may be merged into a general compositional treatment plays up significant unified grouping. Groups of players, trees, build up portions of the picture, There are occasions when a squadron of air when several scattered centers of interest are planes or several machines, may be formed into a justified: such as in scenes of battle, riot, panic, single compositional center of interest. Prefer- catastrophe and other actions involving violent, U-.....,C.....

where the dominant figure dominates this in fact because viewers' eyes will be attracted to dominant figure. In a two-shot because she is positioned in a two-shot position where he is given on right, favorably angled toward camera compositionally stronger position, better and better lighted. Audience is also directed toward her, more favorable lighting - or, directed toward girl by man's look, more dramatic speech or action,

## COMPOSITION

### THE FIVE C's

Scenes of riot, panic, catastrophe or other dramatic action of players in close-up. Violent happenings may employ several varied if balanced elements, in contrast to other objects. Scattered centers of interest such as these higher positioned candles all right allow people to see them in different directions, (man's play's light on the left, antenna, or any other object that radiates equally

in all directions, would be the rare exceptions. The center of interest should preferably be at the right dominant side of the frame. Making this a fixed rule, however, will result in visual monotony.

A simple and effective method for positioning the center of interest in a dominant portion of the picture, is to divide the frame into three equal parts: first vertically, then horizontally. All four

points where these lines cross are compositionally strong. As a rigid rule, this may produce a series of mechanically-positioned centers of interest always falling into similar places in the picture.

As a loose rule it will prevent bisecting the picture vertically, horizontally, or even diagonally.

The left side of the frame can support which results in visually dull compositions.

greater compositional weight, so this radar

The horizon, for instance, should not be centered

operator is properly positioned on right in

centered in the frame, because it will divide the picture in opposition to the larger mass on left.

picture into two equal parts. The sky may occupy

unbalanced, disturbing happenings. Members of a one-third or two-thirds of the picture, but never unified group of players, for instance, may scatter one-half of the frame. There are situations when

in all directions in a mob scene; or, individual the horizon should be completely out of the picture

airplanes in a squadron may peel off toward variety, such as in a low angle shot against the sky,

ground targets, or a high angle shot looking down. Or, the horizon

may be a thin line running along the very bottom

#### POSITIONING CENTER OF INTEREST

of the frame - if the sky is featured, as in a sun

The center of interest should seldom be centered in the picture.

A cross, a radio or television antenna, a telephone pole, a tree or similar object should

216

#### THE FIVE C's COMPOSITION

Scalco player is center of interest in this simply composed, effectively angled



and '1ue11liqlllcd scene. Position of pluy1'T, compo.sirion and lighting draw view en;' aucntion toward dominGnt sealed ((quTe. Supporting player on left is sub dw:d hy bcill.tl rmylcd away from camera Gnd less favorably illuminated.

not be vertically centered, or it will divide the pic attract the eye to a strong compositional point. ture into two equal parts in the same manner. A Odd-numbered divisions, preferably thirds, arc diagonal line, such as the slope of a mountain, best. Cross points should be moved about, how should not run precisely from one corner of the ever, so that the center of interest occurs at frame to the other, or it will create two equal irrcoular positions in the frame in various scenes. parts. Dominant subject matter should be posi Principal pictorial elements should not be com tioned so that it faces inward toward the center of posed with monotonous regularly. Many camera the picture. Framing with a slight lead in the men discover what they consider a satisfactory facing direction, will place it slightly to one side compositional arrangement, and they stick with of the picture.

it. This may result in a compositional similarity

The frame should be divided so that prominent from shot to shot, though subject matter changes. lines - horizon, buildings, trees, columns, win Through variety in horizon placement, chang dows, doors, large lamps - arc positioned to ing position of center of interest, and diversifying 217

## COMPOSITION

### THE FIVEC's

eO', ""e", ,,,

A player may remain subdued in the dark Centered ploucr is at a-pe-e o{ a trianoular recesses of a room - until moved into tile composition, staocd in depth. He domi l(qllt. L(qlttinrJin contmeuno planes allows nates the scene until playcr at left, al the player to move about from dark to tlwl1qh !wudeel and unseen, steps up. The light areas. center of{ interest in a scene may change

tnollg}, {orceful player movement. Thus,

player and camera movement; compositions of 1Jicwt"r inten-.~t can be switched from onc the various scenes will not appear repetitious. player to another, as dramatic interest chanDes, Such Il(:tions are also reinforced

ATTRACTING OR SWITCHING by looks uf other players.

### CENTER OF INTEREST

Audience interest may be attracted or switched during a scene by;

POSITION, MOVEMENT, ACTION & SOUND

## LIGHTING, TONAL VALUES & COLORS

### SELECTIVE FOCUSING

#### POSITION, MOVEMENT, ACTION & SOUND

The significant player, object or action may capture and hold the audience attention by being positioned in the most dominant portion of the composition: or by moving into the best position as the scene progresses. Or, he may attract attention by being isolated from the other players, or moving away from them during the scene. A striking another player. or drawing a knife or gun. player may also move for better contrast with the background. Or, a player may stand up or move trusts with the movement of other players. Or, a forward, thus increasing his height or relative size in the frame. A sudden move on the part of and obscuring other players. The principal player a previously inactive player may shock or surprise the audience, so that the player becomes the center of interest in the scene. Or, a player may silence others so that he alone is heard, or by act forcefully; such as pounding his fist on a table. speaking the most dramatic lines.

218

## COMPOSITION

### THE FIVE C's

A player may gain dominance of a Audience interest until he becomes the center of interest. Or, a player may move up, while others remain down, thus attracting most attention.

areas are formed throughout interior sets by similar

## LIGHTING, TONAL VALUE & COLORS

ulating low key lighting from individual lamps or

Viewer's eyes are normally attracted to the windows.

most brightly illuminated, the lightest toned. or

the most colorful area of a picture. This eye SELECTIVE FOCUSING

attraction may be exploited to make the leading player the center of interest by lighter or more colorful clothing. or better illumination. Large focusing. which presents significant subject matter screen image is seldom necessary. since even a center sharply, and the remainder of the picture

relatively small object. lighter toned or more slightly soft in focus. The human eye will always brightly colored than surrounding objects. will seek out the sharpest image, in preference to soft attract attention. This is due to the contrast or out-of-focus images. A player, or object, there formed with its surroundings. A brighter object foreground, will have the greatest eye attraction if it is advances from a darker background toward the the sharpest image in the scene, viewer. It is, therefore, important to see that a Modern filming techniques require that only subordinate player or object does not steal the pictorial matter of story-telling significance need scene unintentionally through these advantages. be sharp. Unlimited depth-of-field is rarely necessary. Player or camera movement may be utilized so rarely in theatrical motion pictures. Medium shots that a principal player may move into a more and close-ups are generally sharp against a brightly lighted area. to increase dramatic emphasis out-of-focus background in dramatic films. emphasis during a scene. Thus, the player may The background becomes progressively softer as remain subdued. even if costumed in light or the camera moves in for closer shots. Such grad colorful clothing. until he moves into the light. gradual fall-off in background sharpness will be barely Such movement should be timed. of course. to be perceptible if foreground action depicted is interesting enough to hold attention.

Lighting in contrast; planes allows the player

to move about from dark to light areas. Outdoors EYE SCAN

this may be shadowed arc created in the tree The scanning movement of viewers' eyes, as

branches, foliage, etc. Light and dark they search the picture for its meaning, should

## COMPOSITION

### THE FIVE C's

Matched pairs of close-ups of opposing players should be similarly sized from

opposing camera angles. Long shot: thus on a line toward each other,

be given serious consideration by motion picture frame, viewers may be jarred in scanning, and be cameramen. Studies have been made - many with momentarily distracted.

complex optical instruments that measure eye This also works with long shots, followed by

movement - by advertising and military agencies closer shots. viewers' eyes may be led to the center

to learn more about this interesting phenomenon. center of interest in a long shot. This area should

Advertisers seek a sure-fire method to direct the then be presented in approximately the same position reader's gaze to product being promoted. Attention of the frame in the following closer shot.

Force designers want to find the most practical Otherwise, viewers' eyes will make a decided jump

grouping for flight instruments in a jet fighter to try to find the center of interest once more.

cockpit, or a space capsule. This eye positioning can be easily checked on a

The cameraman is concerned not only with the Movtcla. or other editing device which permits eye scan witlzin the frame but - more important marking the film with a grease pencil. A mark - the movement from one frame to another when should be made on the portion of the frame where the picture chanqce. For instance, in a two-shot, the eye is attracted - either the center of interest, and subsequent close-ups, the viewers' eyes are or the place where a player in the scene is looking. directed first to one player and then the other in Then the film should be rolled a frame or two to a back-and-forth pattern. Positions of players in the next shot, and a similar mark made. In a the frame; their relative heights, whether their series of correctly-framed and composed scenes, looks at each other are level, or up or down; will the eye will scan approximately the same area; be result in definite eye-scanning motions by viewers. directed toward the proper portion of the frame That is the reason individual players must be in the following shot; or will scan back and forth, given correct framing and lead in close-ups. Pro as in a two-shot.

per framing places the player'Seyes in the proper While eye scan should be smooth and orderly portion of the picture, and the lead directs the for most sequences, there are occasions when the look off-screen to the opposite player, who in center of attraction should jump about. Asudden turn will appear on the opposite side of the frame, burst of activity, a new story development, a sur with opposite lead. Viewers' eyes are thus kept on prising move on the part of a player, may cause a level; or may look up or down if one player is the eye to shift abruptly to a new area of the higher, and be directed back and forth with each frame. This should be done whenever the script cut. If players arc improperly positioned in the calls for shocking the viewer into looking at a

220

## COMPOSITION

### THE FIVE C's

AltllOUyh qoucrruncru. uqcnu« and .qultman are depic/cd in separate shots, their guJJS are fired on similar tine across screen. Viewcrs' eye SCall u'll shift hach:and fortll alternately to follow tine of {ire, player, object, or action in another part of the screen. A murderer may be introduced, a vehicle may suddenly appear, or a twist in the story brought on with this jarring treatment. It is wise, therefore, to trap the viewer into scanning a cer tain area, lead him to believe that this is the place to watch - then, in a sudden cut, reveal action elsewhere!

Eye scanning is most effective on a large

screen. It is less important on television and small-screen IGmm projection because the eye Printed matter should be angled to slope up-hill- from lower left to upper right. Such angling permits viewers' eyes to drop down for next line. Downhill angling forces eye to move up to read next line in unaccustomed manner.

221

## COMPOSITION

### THE FIVEC's

### CORRECT INCORRECT

### EYE SCAN EYE SCAN

A murderer should lie suddenly introduced from screen left - to shock viewers who observe his intended victim on right side of picture, Abrupt eye scan from right to left contributes to startling effect. Audience will follow slowly action after preceding lull

progressive regressive, contrasting or repetitious in image-size However, the eye rebels when images are: changed slightly in size, or slightly in angle - an effect similar to a jump-cut. This occurs when close-ups are presented in a hodgepodge of image sizes. rather than in pairs of matched close-ups. filmed in series of opposing angled shots, or, series of same size reaction close-ups of several players. Close-up images, slightly smaller or larger than bracketing close ups, create expanding and contracting effects when scanned. This lack of uniformity in image size is most disconcerting to viewers.

Erratic eye scanning. caused by scattered, oddly-sized oddly-angled images, may be employed when unbalanced or weird effects are desired. Scenes of panic, catastrophe or violence may be enhanced by being oddly-sized or oddly

angled. or even Dutch-tilt angled. Viewers will thus be forced to scan the screen with abrupt back-and-forth. up-and-down or diagonal eye movements. involving the audience more closely with the screen action

The CAMERA chapter discussion on filming signs and printed matter should be re-read for its eye-scanning effects.

222

## THE FIVE C's COMPOSITION

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C'' '' '' '' ''

This scene is (compositionally) interesting because lines of tunnel diminish to a vanishing point, and a figure is placed in center of circular opening,

## IMAGE PLACEMENT

players are positioned too low in the frame, with

Image placement is the positioning of subject against a plain background, may be just right if an overhanging matter in the frame, or framing. Many scenes hanging tree branch stretches across top of picture involve player and/or camera movement, which helps. Excessive head room will make the picture require continuous cropping as the action progresses. Insufficient head room will regress. A moving player should be given slightly more space than a static one. A static player should be given more space in the direction in which he travels. Players should not come into contact with the top or bottom frame. Statically-positioned, he should be given slightly more space by standing or sitting precisely on the bottom line. A moving player should be given more space in the direction in which he goes. Top frame line: or leaning, or in precise line-up. Amount of head room - distance between tops of heads and top of the frame. The bottom frame line - distance between bottoms of feet and bottom of the frame. The bottom frame of players' heads and top frame line - varies with line should not cut across a player's joints; knees, elbows, shoulders, etc. Positioning of play-acting masses - such as framing devices - at top of picture particularly in closeups. should be arranged so that the frame line does not cut across body joints.

223

## COMPOSITION

### THE FIVE C's

Care should be exercised in moving shots so that a player, or players, come to a key position with framing similar to that used for static shots.

Careful framing of moving shots - where  
player's image size varies throughout the scene  
- is just as important as composing static shots.

The most important player object or action  
should generally be positioned on the right. If the  
dominant player needs to be positioned on the  
left, he may be given preferential compositional  
treatment by better lighting, more favorable body  
angling, stronger contrast or separation from  
background, or other methods. In a symmetrically  
composed two-shot, each player will dominate the  
shot in turn as he speaks. If it is desirable to sur-  
prise or shock the audience, a new player may be  
suddenly introduced from the left. This will cause  
the viewer to shift attention abruptly from right  
to left. The villain may pounce on the hero from  
screen left, an important prop or significant a familiar object - or by its relationship with a  
action may suddenly appear at the left of the background of known dimensions.

screen - by moving in, or through camera movement. In theatrical films, it is often necessary to cheat  
- to gain attention. This is much more the height of a leading player. so that he can look  
successful if it occurs during a lull in the action, down at other players. From a higher level. This is  
so that the audience is taken unaware. Leading lines should diminish toward the right, close shots - by having the player stand on a  
to attract the viewer's eye to the center of interest. block, or by positioning him forward of the other  
Large masses positioned on the right, however, players and lowering the camera so that he ap-  
pear may overtake the picture. As example, an imparts taller. Sometimes motion picture art direc-  
tor. ant player may stand on the right and look at tors design convincing sets, with built-in  
a large mountain peak on the left. If the picture is reversed, he may be "lost" on the left. and the in the foreground, and under-sized or even midget  
mountain would overpower the composition. The players are positioned in the distance! The eye is  
cameraman should be aware of merits of various easily deceived by the relative size of objects.  
frame positions, so that he can place dramatic Relative size. distance, perspective, may all be  
emphasis to best advantage. distorted or exaggerated.

In non-theatrical films, however, the opposite

## IMAGE SIZE

ordinarily applies. Falsification of any kind must

A viewer interprets the size of an unknown usually by avoiding, and the true size of the objects in a picture by contrasting it with an object to be shown. Tools, instruments, machines should be of known size or with the background; or by its being filmed with an operator in position to show appearance in relation to the frame. The viewer's perception of their proportionate size. If such items are filmed in close-ups against a plain background, the viewer's experience furnishes a mental scale by which he judges the relative size of known figures or objects should be combined with objects of known size, at varying distances from the lens. He has no way or a hand should be introduced. Where this is not of judging the size of unknown objects unless, for possible, they should be positioned against a background furnished with a clue - such as contrast with size of background of familiar dimensions.

224

## COMPOSITION

### THE FIVE C's

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SPCH.:t' , ~cientiM checks Ollt instrumentation and radio telemetru cirCllit beiorc mounting equipment in missile 110SI' cone, Through slunuing of hardware during progres<~ of operations, story is not interrupted: hy static display\_

Regardless of their actual physical size, images machine gears - will relay the impression that the that crowd the frame are considered larger than entire picture is too vast or complicated to capture images which are relatively small in relation (O in its entirety. If filmed from a high angle, so the frame. A tiny object may appear huge, if that personnel overflow the Framed area, a small crowded so that its edges almost touch the edge group of draftsmen at ,vork may suggest a large of the frame. A large object may appear small, if organization. The same effect may be accomplished with a great deal of space around it. A plished with small numbers of machines. com mountain may appear lofty, if it is positioned puters. file cabinets. etc.

high in the frame so that little sky appears above A figure or object maybe made 10 appear taller it. A relatively small number of people, objects or by angling the camera upward. particularly if the machines may appear greater if crowded so that image consists of vertical parallel lines tending to they overlap the frame, suggesting there are converge. A low angle, wide-angle lens shot of a more outside the picture. Seeing leu< than the tall building will make it appc<'ll' even taller. A or

whole - whether crowds, electronic circuits or low angle subjective shot a person from a

225

## COMPOSITION



## THE FIVE C's

child's viewpoint. filmed so that he crowds the posed and the player/background relationship frame. will result in a similar height effect. constantly revised to meet any compositional Psychological aspects of image size and any problems that may develop. Such planned moving, in relation to the frame, may produce movement will allow moving the players out of awkward greater emotional response in viewers than awkward pictorial situations, so that they are lined up appearances alone. An extreme long shot. looking up properly when the camera moves in for the downward from a high angle, on a tiny group of medium shots and close-ups. Side angles and over pioneers inching their way across a vast rugged the-shoulder close-ups may suddenly introduce landscape instantly portrays the hardships and table lamps, furniture or other objects. which depicts privations endured on a long, lonely trek. The tract from main action. or merge with player's theatrical films make extensive use of such contrast using shots; not only for visual variety, but to provoke the audience into greater involvement in the story by arousing emotions. Non-theatrical film makers may also employ extreme long shots or extreme close-ups for dramatic effects.

## INTEGRATE COMPOSITION

### & CAMERA ANGLES

Pictures must be composed with definite view points in mind. A perfect composition arranged for a particular camera angle may be very poor when viewed from an opposite angle. This is especially difficult in motion pictures where a sequence, or a series of shots, involve viewing the scene from several angles. Composition and

Switching camera angle [from above shot to

camera angles should, therefore, be integrated so scene below results in better composition.

that players and pictorial elements will be properly placed. Faces of Indian woman and child are seen.

composed as the camera is moved about to film. Heads are not hidden in work, and pattern of

run is clearly shown. Side angle also reveals

the various shots making up the sequence.

suits in (connecting lines and overlapped

Generally, a good long-shot composition will

(if the camera is placed in depth - rather than

work well on closer shots. if the camera set-ups across screen, arc not drastically altered. Moving in and around s,"

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the subject matter need not change the player/  
background relationship, if all shots in a sequence  
arc carefully lined up in advance during rehearsal.  
Player and/or camera movement are most im-  
portant in integrating composition and camera  
angles, because such movements may develop into  
assets or liabilities.

An excellent static composition may deteriorate  
into confusion as players or camera move during  
the action; or when player/background relation-  
ship is drastically changed from one set-up to  
another. On the other hand, players and/or  
camera may move in harmony as the action pro-  
gresses, so that the scene is continuously com-  
posed.

## COMPOSITION

### THE FIVE C's

features. Consideration should be given to cheat-  
ing such items, or removing them temporarily.  
Continuous composition, which keeps the play-  
ers properly framed as they move during the  
scene, is not difficult to maintain. It requires con-  
stant vigilance, however, to see that: players are  
given proper leads at all times; player/background  
relationship is pictorially pleasing; and pauses at  
key positions are particularly well composed. This  
can be best accomplished if players are first  
placed in each key position and carefully com-  
posed for the best pictorial effect; and then moves  
in between key positions are worked out.

### PERSPECTIVE

Perspective is appearance of objects as deter-  
mined by the angle of vision. It is well as railroad

mined by their relative distance and positions, or things - appear to converge 011 distance  
unseen.

as influenced by atmospheric conditions.

There are two types of perspective: viewer looks up or down. Illusion produced by

LINEAR geometrical linear perspective help the viewer

AERIAL judge distance of an object of known size. The

appearance of depth and solidity in a picture

LINEAR PERSPECTIVE

depends much on linear convergence, created by

Linear perspective produces convergence of diminishing sizes of figures and objects as dis

parallel lines in any plane at an angle to the plane increases.

viewer. Parallel horizontal lines, such as railroad

lines/PERSPECTIVE

tracks, appear to converge at a distant point on

the horizon. Parallel vertical lines, such as the Aerial perspective is a gradual fading and

sides of a tall building, appear to converge if a softening of distant outdoor objects, caused by

Players should first be composed in key All. f. J. W. shot of this javelin rocket presents

positions. The 11 moves between key positions in interesting composition due to depth effect

tions should be worked out. ...produced by converging lines.

227

COMPOSITION

THE FIVE C's

Aerial view supplies translucent quality to this wild scene. The more

distant foliage is lighter (and provides a soft background for the sharper, darker

figure of the deer and trees.

Intervening haze. While weather conditions influence top or bottom of an object are recorded for great

effect; aerial perspective even on a clear day, test solidity.

appearance of distant objects is governed by the Choose a combination of camera angle and lens

amount of atmosphere through which the viewer, focal length which produces the greatest linear

or the camera lens, must look. convergence will limit distortion, Select the short

est focal length lens (not necessarily a Wide-angle

lens) that will record a realistic linear perspective

HOW TO INCREASE PERSPECTIVE EFFECTS

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with converging lines to lead viewers' eyes into far

The following staging techniques and camera reaches of the scene. Extreme wide-angle lenses treatments may be employed. Singly or in combination should be used only for special effects where a variation to increase perspective effects: greater than normal convergence is desired. The Choose camera angles which portray the greatest finest modeling of the players and setting, and the greatest number of planes or facets of the subject. greatest audience involvement results when the Shoot angle-plus-angle so that the front, side and camera is brought as close as possible, to record

228

## COMPOSITION

### THE FIVE C's

Aerial - perspective - applies depth to this outdoor scene because the distant mountain is lightened and softer in contrast to the trees closer to the camera.

the scene without distorting the images. in front of, other players. Or, have players move

Position players, props, furniture and other between or behind furniture, lamp fixtures, desks objects so that they partially overlap. Overlapping or other objects; so that they are partially covered conveys spatial relationships simply and effectively at intervals in their travel from one position to

tively. Isolated figures and objects may be any another in the setting. Move the camera, so that distance from the camera. Clues to which arc it shoots through or past foreground objects. as it nearer are furnished by their known size. Since follows the players or moves about the set. Over sizes of unfamiliar figures are difficult to judge. lapping on movement in this fashion introduces positioning questionable objects behind other objects motion parallax, a variation in image travel of objects - so that the "overlap - leaves no doubt in objects at different distances from the lens. This viewer's mind of which is closer. conveys position and distance of various players

Move players and/or camera to cover and uncover objects in the scene to the viewer.

cover other players, objects or furniture in the scene. Move the players or vehicles toward or away selling. Have players move between, rather than from the camera, rather than straight across the

229

### COMPOSITION THE FIVE C's

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Greatest line convergence is obtained when camera is centered amidst lines of horizontal lines receding into distance. Depth without distortion is achieved in

this view of underground missile silo -

screen. An image that increases or decreases in size as it travels conveys a feeling of spatial depth and objects. Utilize side lighting or any and distance. An image that moves across the lighting which produces shadow areas that impart screen remains the same size throughout its three-dimensional modeling to figures and setting. travel. Even when a player or vehicle must move light an interior scene so that the picture pre across the screen. try to angle the camera slightly: sends a contrasting series of planes. with various or stage the movement so that it is not precisely degrees of light and shade, Such differential lighting at right angles to the lens. Always strive to impart lighting imparts a front-to-back quality to players and a change in image size - even if slight - so that scaling. When filming outdoors, try to include the the moving player or vehicle advances or recedes in distance background for additional natural when traveling across the frame. perspective, A similar effect may be achieved Avoid filming in flat light, indoors or outdoors. indoors by lighting the background just a trifle Over-all shadowless illumination produces a flat "hotter." in order to carry the viewer's eye into ness of field minus projections and modeling, far reaches of the setting, 230

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## COMPOSITION

### THE FIVE C's

- 0.1/11 this Set the effect of a magnetic tape in the further viewers' eyes as they travel into scene, the greater the effect. Camera should be centered for the type of shot, and lines converge at the center of picture.

### BACKGROUNDS

Items. Backgrounds may be wrongly treated on

Theatrical motion picture producers transport outdoor locations, because the director and/or the casts. camera crews and equipment thousands of cameramen do not understand the importance of miles so that stories may be staged against a backing up players and action.

Artificial backgrounds. Dramatic feature films even whenever possible. the background should be ploy interior and exterior backgrounds to advantage in so that it may contribute activity. authentic

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things as story-telling aids. (certainly) or realism to the story. Industrial subjects

For the most part. non-theatrical cameramen. may be set against machine...; farm subjects

filming on location. do not take sufficient advantage against growing crops; finally films staged with tangle of backgrounds. In many cases, they double airport background activity. Camera angles should catch eliminate or misuse them. For instance. be chosen and action staged so that the players

backgrounds are often ignored in Factories be move against backgrounds that spell out the par  
cause lighting or sound present technical prcb- ticular activity whether oil field. giant steel mill.

231

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Ann/e-plus-angle filming produces in/('re,~till!/ Linear pal/I'r'n in this scene, Effect  
is enhanced by semi-silhouette foreground o/ject, well-liyllferl players and light  
ing in contraetino plant's.

amusement park, assembly line or wheat harvest. outdoors, anti should be carefully scouted on  
Thus, foreground action... tied in with the back interiors where there is a choice of staging the  
ground, provide greater scope, additional pictorial action. For instance, it is not fitting to stage a  
interest and a !JfJII-{/re-tlll'Tf' feeling. factory production sync-sound sequence in a quiet  
Documentaryfilms shot on actual locations CHI area against a nondescript background.This treat  
be made more effective byproper regard for story mentdetracts from.rather than contributes to,the  
telling backgrounds. Finding suitable sites for story. In this approach, the true meaning of loca  
staging the action will add realism by backing tion filming is lost on the viewer. It is not enough  
players with whatever machinery. activity or to film establishing long shots of the actual set  
scenery is available. The background should con ting, and then retire to plain settings for the heart  
stantly. yet subtly. remind the viewer that the of the story - just because it is easier to handle  
story is taking place on the waterfront. in a steel that way. Such scenes may be filmed anuwhere!  
mill. in a nuclear power plant. There is no need for expensive travel to location:

Backgrounds are just as important indoors as then shoot against walls, or trees and sky.

232

## COMPOSITION

### THE FIVE C's

Farm IJlckyllml makes t1ti.~ scene imme Figure at sideof[ame may prot-ide simple  
diately iclenli/ia1Jlc' to audience. Stage I.-slmprd composition lceuse it supplies a  
action against background which may uerticul: in combination with a ground  
contribute .,lory ualue to f/Uivity being basic. Forcround soldier and tent provide  
depicted, e.n:elle,, ' frame for distant camp scene.

Tilt' camera s/Iotlid shoot IJlroUg11 fore Staye mouinu «c:lirm sn that it is an.qled in  
ground objl'('t,~ - such as this oil well relation to call/era. TII(''.~c rurning soldiers

with the vertical line. Such treatment adds interest in image size as they advance to the eye (feel, a suitable atmosphere - reward audience).

On occasion, it may be best to isolate the play more interesting than the player's action or dialogue against the sky or other nondescript background, or it will steal the show. The background ground, if action or dialogue demands concentration should balance with the foreground by remaining without distracting elements. This becomes in place below the action. It should not intrude increasingly important as the camera moves in on the foreground players or action, or distract closer: and a small group of players, or even the audience in any way by its make-up, move single player, must command the audience's comment or color.

plete attention. The background should never be. Players should be positioned so that there is  
233

## COMPOSITION

### THE FIVE C's

Action - the camera and camera angle's Spradina trial hrcnclr (Ufl/is/u's pictorial  
dlose" to (U/Ull".~l/(J)tillg {/{rO.~S or t/ITollgl, iorcoround (mille (or riders,  
foreground object's. Playas should more

It'llt'l'l/l. or Pl'(" behind other players. and

pause in position. s lll'icli present the/l

O!crlappiny Oll(' another. Compo.~in9 ill

c1l'pl// (llu/ .\'/(911119 actioll ill tllis manlier

ld ll pn.'scllf pla,t/IT\'. .we'lliny. o!Jjl'cts, ioitli

solid. three-dimensional appearance.

distinct separation between foreground action and

background. A figure or object. similarly toned or

colored. merging with the background. will flatten

the picture. Separation and isolation with lighting

effects. contrasting tones or distinct color is most

helpful. This is particularly important in close

ups. where the player's head should stand out

from the background. Often, moving the camera

a few inches, high or lower, or to one side, will

achieve a better background relationship by pre Interior [1"111111' - sllci/ as tuis window

venting an annoying line or shape from protruding may /J(' used to depict the interior scene.

a player's body or head. or by removing the (d1-e

of an object or a small portion of a light fixture, a posts, portholes. iron grilles. fences, porches. col

window or some other disturbing element. Any urns, bridges, or a portion of larger objects, such as moving or distracting object, or colorful activity as an airplane wing, a tree branch or a cannon which may attract unwarranted attention, should be excluded. A frame supplies a pictorial foreground element, contains the action, and prevents the viewer's eyes from wandering off screen.

**FRAMES** The frame should not be composed evenly on

A frame may consist of any foreground picture on all sides, unless it is round or absolutely symmetrical element which surrounds the picture partially. Frames are much more photogenic if shot diagonally or completely. Frames are available or contrived from a three-quarter angle, rather than square-on. For the purpose of lighting, arches, windows, awns. A slight angle will show the frame's depth, add meaning. doorways, street lamps, bell towers, sign solidity and prevent a cardboard cut-out appearance.

234

## COMPOSITION

### THE FIVE C's

Far from the camera, the frame should be well lit. Underside of the picture forms the excellent

;11.1/.mut also, why, light (stays warm and all'. [ramc for dodged boat,

ancc. Hack-cross or P/T!! complete back lighting

will add to the effect by sending a sun-splashed

pattern of light toward the camera, which repeats

the (r:1111("5 outline on the foreground. Long lead

in~ shadows, adding depth to the setting are also

supplied. Bad: lighting will also edge-light the

frame and separate it from the more distant view

by outlining it. This will impart a luminous, ethereal

quality to foliage and other translucent objects. The frame itself can often act as a gobo

to shield the lens from direct rays of the sun.

### FRAAMES HEQUIVALENTS

A frame must be appropriate, and yet not detract

from the main subject. Determining a proper

frame is not difficult. Usually improper frames Narrowing screen width, as in doorway

[frame produces ('onfinall,1j {'(fc,{-t to convey

are artificially contrived. Keeping a frame subtle

findings of younger wife U/IOUt ailing. nus

duced can often cause trouble. Elaborate, or other



band.

wise distracting frames, should be avoided. The

subject is the picture; the frame is only a compo

sitional aid. and merge with it. Frames should be filmed in

silhouette. semi-silhouette or partial shadow. If

#### DISTINCT FRAME SEPARATION NECESSARY

Front light is unavoidable. or desirable for color;

There should be distinct separation among employ a tree branch. a goho or a "cookie" to add

frame. main subject and background. Merging a shadow pattern. and thus break up and tone

caused by similar tonal values. similar colors or down the frame area. A foreground player, in pro

similar light effects will destroy the separation file or looking into the scene, will add the human

necessary for distinctive pictorial effect. A frame element; and direct viewers toward main action.

should not be shot in a flat front light, or it will Parually-tlurmntcd foreground frames arc

include the same tonal values as the main scene more effective in color than in black and white.

235

#### COMPOSITION

##### THE FIVE C's

kept equally sharp. A slightly soft-focus frame is

permissible. if sufficient depth-of-field is not avail

able. providing the frame is underexposed or in

silhouette. Since it possesses a much greater

depth-of-field than a normal objective. a wide

angle lens will prove useful. However. a telephoto

lens may sometimes be necessary. in order to film

a nearby foreground frame. and enlarge more

distant subjects. If the subject is too small. in

relation to the frame itself. it can be made to

appear larger by moving the camera back; em

ploying a longer focal length lens. and recording

the full-scene frame with relatively large images

of the main subject.

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Warellouse doorn'ay frames slip loading

#### FRAME MOVEMENT

operation

Wildly moving frames - such as tree branches

A frame in partial silhouette will contain soft sun in a high wind. flapping awnings or dancing derelict bluish hues. which offer subtle color leaves - should be avoided. because they may contrast to a correctly-exposed. warmly-illuminated subject and background. Exposure should be toward, away from, or a frame is permitted to be based on principal subject - not the frame. sible; providing the frame itself remains static. A slow pan or dolly shot ending in a well-composed frame as the camera slowly moves into position.

## PARTIAL FRAMES

Following moving action. can be most effective. A

When a full surrounding frame is missing, a dolly may pull back in a tracking shot, and go partial frame consisting of top and one side, through a doorway or arch to frame the scene. A should be used. A part of a tree branch, or other object, should not be included. A frame should show solid connection. It should not merely hang in space. Too little of a frame may tease the audience, if they cannot deduce what it is.

Partial frames are a great compositional aid in breaking up large expanses of empty foreground, or bald skies. A low wall or a shadow pattern cast by tree leaves. with a suggestion of a tree at the

-

side. will enhance a dull sun-lit pavement. Other props. such as wagon wheels. parts of awnings. lattice work and grilles will be useful on occasion.

## FRAME FOCUS

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Frames should be sharp. An out-of-focus foreground object. occupying a major portion of the long side of plane. Subjects with long, low silhouette can prove very disturbing. By splitting the silhouette - such as jet airplanes - are

focus. or employing the hyper-focal distance set more easily composed with aid of [ore  
ting. both the frame and the main object can be around frame, which covers excess sky.

236

## COMPOSITION

### THE FIVE C's

#### DYNAMIC COMPOSITION

Dynamic composition, in which forceful pictorial elements evoke a sudden change in a static set-up, should be employed when abrupt or surprising effects are desired. In this way, quiet scenes may spring into vigorous life, or motionless elements may abruptly become dramatically active. A restful distant scene may be interrupted by a nearby figure or object popping up. A falling down or running or swinging through the frame. This startling compositional effect is a familiar classic in western pictures where many Indians suddenly appear from behind rocks!

Vehicles may be dynamically utilized in many

Metallurgy and hose line - (or welding ways: an auto may swing into a country road  
steel rails - move appropriate frame for  
from the side of the frame; a truck may zoom up  
track laying operation.

into the picture from the bottom of the frame, an

airplane may drop jarringly down into the picture

moving camera, mounted on a car or train may from the top of the frame, and bounce on to a  
frame a distant tunnel opening, which gradually quiet runway as it roars away from the camera.  
becomes larger. revealing more and more of the distant peaceful vista framed through a bell  
view until the framed scene finally opens wide on tower may startle eyes and ears of the audience,  
the screen. An annoying shipping effect may result in a close-up as the bell swings into view and  
result from panning across a frame with strong clangs loudly. A long shot of oil derricks may have  
verticals close to the camera. suddenly interrupted by a close-up of a pump and  
swinging up into the frame. Dynamic composition

FRAMES CAN AID STORY-TELLING. These are most effective when the audience is encouraged to concentrate first on a quiet distant

The wing and landing gear of a giant airplane scene for a second or two. Then the suddenly - framing boarding passengers - instantly spells fast travel to far places. A bridge - framing a distant city - may provide the means of carrying the audience across an expanse of water, into the heart of the scene. A canopied boat deck may frame a welcoming harbor, as a ship makes port. Silhouetted factory chimneys belching smoke framing a distant swinging crane - may suggest industry. 1\long,low overhangingbranch,together with a winding white fence ~ framing a farm setting - may convey restful country atmosphere. An arch, framing an old Spanish mission, pictures old-world architecture in both close-up and long shot. A series of arches, receding into the distance, creates a pleasant rhythm through repetitious diminishing lines; which provide strong converging linear perspective and third-dimensional quality. A quiet street scene may be abruptly interrupted by a trolley moving into the frame.

237

## COMPOSITION

### THE FIVE C's

moving object or vehicle moves into the scene suddenly. so that the audience is kept in doubt as close to the camera. Treatment of this type as long as desired. A simple switch in camera angle requires the utmost discretion. so that it is limited player movement or unconventional staging is proper for unusual dramatic situations. A long generally all that is required.

It)

culmination have lulled the complacent

audience, who now need a forceful and surprising CATALOG PICTURES

cinematic device to recapture their attention. Catalog pictures; shots of tools, machines, packages, instruments - either singly or in groups

SUSPENSEFUL COMPOSITION seemingly defy laws of good composition. Non

Suspenseful composition - in which significant theatrical film makers, particularly producers of action is hidden, absent, or prolonged by the man industrial, military and training films. arc con

ner in which it is staged - can be a valuable learned with catalog-type layouts depicting the story-telling aid. While the villain may be moving paraphernalia involved in assembly, repair or behind a pile of boxes in order to pounce on the other work. Similar type shots consisting of groups hero. the audience is shown only a slow pan of buildings, engineering test equipment, in the boxes, with no indication of where the action is about to take place. Or, because the runway is chimes, instrument panels, and myriad other objects too short, a rescue airplane must take off and ejects, may lack a central center of interest. into a "alley to pick up flying speed. As suspenseful Catalog shots need not be static. They may be tail-away shot may be filmed from behind so that panned, dollyed, zoomed, or otherwise given move the aircraft takes off, and falls out of the frame. They should be inserted without interrupting For a few agonizing seconds, the audience sees the film's flow. A picture on operation of a turret blank sky. Then the plane climbs back into view! It should not suddenly stop to show a static Variations of blank screen suspense may occur catalog shot of accessories required for performance in a fight sequence between two armed men. They are doing a particular job. Equipment needed should be fall out of the frame as they fight, but the camera shown in course of the work.

does not follow them down - it remains on the There are occasions, however, when one or empty frame for a few seconds. Then a shot is more objects must be positioned and photo heard. The audience is kept in suspense until the graphed to resemble the still photographs found victor rises. Suspense is prolonged in the classic shot where the heroine is undecided whether or not to board a train and leave the hero. The camera is switched to the opposite side of the tracks, and the entire train goes by before the audience will know her decision, by her presence or absence on the platform.

An industrial film may keep the audience in suspense by showing raw material entering the feed end of a machine, and following its manufacturing procedure, so that the product is kept secret until it emerges. Camera angles may be employed to keep the identity of a selling a secret; such as a foreign-appearing locale in an American city until revealed as a surprise.

Diaconat and circular line may be used Whenever suspense of a "cliff-hanging" variety for composition objects for display. Pair of

is the keynote of the sequence, all possible methods of similar objects should be filmed in order of handling the subject naturally should be counterposing compositional patterns.

238

## COMPOSITION

### THE FIVE C's

For instance, in this SAC B-52 flying commutator, a simple circular composition - to reinforce their feelings of joy.

in a catalog. Rather than standard commercial in which the items may be positioned. A package catalog views, patterns of lines, shapes or forms should face inward toward the center of the conveying all esthetic or emotional impact on the frame, with slightly more lead in the facing direction; and so angled that the front, side panel and single center of interest may often be composed by top are seen. Three packages may be positioned to forming a pattern. For instance, a group of lathes form a triangle. Tools, boxes, cans, gears, small may be shot from a high angle, so that they form parts may be grouped in compositional forms. a rhythmical sequence of diagonal lines suggest such as triangles, circles, ovals or various lines coming in action, purposefulness, urgency. The lines in combinations. Items may be lined up in diagonals. this case should travel lower left to upper right, rather than straight across the frame. Two can impart an ascending spirit of accomplishment. successive shots may be composed, facing each other. Running upper left to lower right would result in other in opposing diagonals. Items may also be an opposite pattern, with a downward effect. stacked in pyramids, or grouped in ovals around Compositional rules should not be discarded a central object. Whenever possible, shoot angle without serious consideration of the various ways plus-angle slightly from the side, so that groups

239

## COMPOSITION

### THE FIVE C's

Series of similar objects should be lined up. A dominant player may be centered in a in diagonal pattern - rather than straight composition on rare occasions, such as tile across- (or for dynamic shot, above scene, where the girl's head faces as if looking and surrounding players' looks null of objects face one side, rather than flat front toward tier. Informally-balanced pictures or formally-balanced pattern pictures which convey a feeling of unity, rather than a scattered effect, are preferred. When filming a series of pattern pictures for a montage sequence, the cameraman's prime concern

sidcrations should be arrangement of the various shots in compositional opposition for greater forcefulness, conflict or contrast. A diagonal line up facing left may be opposed by a right; a high angle by a low angle, etc. It is wise, if both time and budget permit, to film such scenes both ways.

With this precaution, the film editor has a choice on a left or right, a high or low, or a camera movement in either direction. Often a pan, tilt or dolly shot may be opposed by a similar shot in H., "" :0'

the opposite direction. The order in which the A dominant dwracter consoling a dis shots maybe used should be left to the editor.

tressed player is best composed with a head resting on a shoulder to form a pyra

#### COMPOSITIONAL VARIETY

mid composition.

Variety is the spice of motion picture composi

tions. A film should maintain untry of style in movement should all be avoided.

integration of its technical, esthetic and psycho A cameraman may easily slip into a rut, par logical elements. At the same time, it should ticularly on short schedule, low-budget films. He present a variety of compositions, camera angles may be tempted to stay with a compositional rou and image sizes, so that players and settings are tine and stock photographic treatment - safe, not depicted in a monotonous pattern. Similar easily-handled and - since it has long been re compositional treatment of the various settings or peated - apparently effective. Slightly different similar staging, player movement or camera treatment, whenever possible, may add interest.

240

#### COMPOSITION

##### THE FIVE C's

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PO.-itiOll plaNers in deptti - rather than An,qling the camera on this jet engine ucrss the [rume - so tllat viewers feel repair operatioll - rather than sflvoting square-on - creates converging lines.

Illt'y art' if! the midst of the setting, not

oh~('n';uy till:' C'l-'('111 from ufal.

overlap. Move players and camera back and forth, toward or away from the viewer. Choose camera angles and lenses which produce converging lines and interesting perspective effects - light in contrasting planes, with less light on foreground objects - so that silhouette or semi-silhouette effects result. Shoot deep settings whenever possible, so that distant background may be seen.

Employ foreground frames or set pieces, so that the camera shoots through or across objects, to record the players and their action in the middle distance. Select interesting backgrounds that tie in and back up player's action. Position the camera so that it is in the midst of the setting, players and action; rather than back out of range, and simply looking on from a distance. Avoid

This is three-shot forms a triangle in depth, shooting across unobstructed empty space to This is basically a two-shot - with the record players or objects, standing as if posing judy in the far background forming the for an elementary school class picture. Arrange apex of a triangle. players, objects and set pieces so that both front and side views are seen, not simply the fronts: or

COMPOSE IN DEPTH the side. Always work for rounded, well-modeled

Create compositions in depth, rather than simple views of players. Integrate composition and positioning of players or objects across the screen camera angles so that players, and their relation are equi-distant from the camera. Utilize every practical space with their surroundings and the background, tactical depth device to build a three-dimensional scene well composed in all shots comprising the illusion on the motion picture's two-dimensional sequence. Use forethought and imagination! flat screen. Shoot angle-plus-angle. Position varied. Strive to overcome any tendency to restrict players throughout the setting. so that they have depth, because it is easier to light, carry focus and

241

COMPOSITION

THE FIVE C's

1. Contrast

2. Camera



Although these scenes - jet fighters, profile two-o'clocks arc (lat lwcl) use subjects and train u.lrecis, iJelow - arc dissimilar are {tlmed 8qUl/rC-on, alJovc, and display 111 sul)ject matter, tlu-'y h07.Jt' one common lillie modclino or roundness, Over-the quality. Both arc composed in depth, with shoulder dose-up, hclour, presents players repetitious circular paucrne rcccdinq into in depth, toiti foregrould player overlap the distance. pil/.£] rear player.

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stage action in a limited area. AhNllfS think in rules of good composition, will not be as effective depth. Avoid flat angles, flat lighting, cross-screen as a simple one. Simplicity does not imply stark movement and positioning players and staging ness. A simple composition is economical in use action in a lined-up straight-across fashion. Re of line, form, mass and movement; includes only member that depth on the screen hegins with one center of interest; has unified style which composition; and is enhanced by camera angles, harmoniously integrates camera angles, lighting, which produce three-dimensional solid effects, tonal and color values.

## SIMPLICITY

The test of good composition is whether anything

The secret of good composition can be ex can be removed from the picture without destroy plained in one word: simplicity. A complicated or ing its effectiveness. Any clement in the frame cluttered composition, even though it obeys all not required for story-telling purposes, attracts

242

## COMPOSITION

### THE FIVE G's

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Extreme long shot - depicting vast1les,~of setting - dn'arfs these riders ayahlst  
arid, ruyycc/ terrain and mountainous 1Jae/l,1]round.

unwarranted audience aucmlon. Such distracting turc. A table-top shot depicting half a dozen ob  
pictorial clements may steal the scene from prin jects may present a cluttered composition; while  
cipal subject matter. A simple composition is im an extreme long shot of an advancing army may  
mediately recognizable and readily assimilated by convey a unity of force and power immediately  
the audience. The viewer should not have to recognizable. because of its Simplicity. If a vast  
search the framed area to discover the shot's number of compositionalclements must be photo  
meaning. This is most important in motion pic graphed, they should be harmoniously grouped.  
tures, which arc series of individual scenes. A

person may study a still photograph until he is CONCLUSION

satisfied that he comprehends it. A movie scene Think of composition as the pleasant arrange  
appears for a limited time, and is then removed. ment of players and objects in the setting. or as a  
Confusing or puzzling compositions irritate the division of space. Don't be awed by composition.  
viewer. and may cause him to lose interest. Become familiar with the various characteristics  
Simplicity does not depend on the number of of lines, forms, masses and movements. Consider  
scenic clements; or the area included in the pic- compositional weights, so that the frame may be  
243

## COMPOSITION

### THE FIVE C's

.-.,

Man's conquest ofthe skies is simply depicted in this scene of soarino aircraft  
over a snow-capped mountain.

properly balanced. Understand differences be just the long shot. Utilize perspective effects.  
tween formal and informal balance, and when to Compose in depth for a three-dimensional screen  
usc each fur proper audience response. Remem appearance. Employ foreground frames to en  
ber that the viewer must be affected both pic hance the cornpostttou. and be certain they are  
torially and psychologically, to convey the script's appropriate, and do not detract from the main  
intent to arouse his emotions. Never allow more subject. Utilize backgrounds, by connecting them  
than one center of interest on the screen at one to the principal action. Consider the viewers' eye

time unless a disturbed, or scattered effect is de scan from shot to shot. \Work for visual variety, sired. Frame moving players or vehicles carefully, by changing compositional effects often. Elimi so that they always have the correct lead, Con nate frills, gimmicks and complex arrangements. sider all camera angles required to film the entire Make Keep It Simple the working slogan for sequence when composing the master scene, not interesting compositions.

244

INDEX

245

INDEX

THE FIVEC's

A Informal .....\_ 211 Tilt. Dutch Angles 47

With Odd Numbers 212 Types 13

ACTION Viewpoint . 50

Controlled \_\_. \_ 74 BALANCES

Cutting On . .... \_ . 157 Types of . \_\_\_\_...210 CAMERA HEIGHT 35

How to Depict. . 52-54 BRIDGING

CAMERAMAN CAN LEARN

Types of\_\_ 74 Time & Space \_\_\_\_\_ ... 136

FROM FILM EDITOR 170, 171

Uncontrolled 74

c CATALOG PICTURES . 238.239

ACTION AXIS .. 93-136

CAMERA CENTEROF INTEREST \_ ..214-219

Entrances and Exits... ... 100 Acts as Eye of Unseen How to Attract ..\_ 218

Exception \_..... 93 Audience \_\_\_\_\_. 19.20 How to Position \_\_\_\_\_.216,217

for Dynamic Screen Direction. .. 87 Acts as Eye of Viewer 13 Howto Switch 218

for Map Direction .... 103 Changes Places With Person Lighting.Tonal Values& Color 219

For Off-Screen Preyer.. ..118 in Picture 14. IS Position, Movement. Action

For Static Screen Direction 109 Movement ..\_. 160. 161 &. Sound 218

for Three Players 126 Multiple \_ . 76-78.80 Selective Focusing\_ 219

How to Cheat for

Set-Ups for Close-ups \_ \_... 193 CHANGECAMERA ANGLE\_\_\_. 54-56

Dynamic Screen Direction ..... 99 Shots. tcosa \_ . 163. 164

How to Cheat for CHANGELENS ..... 54-56

Single \_\_ 76. 79

Staticscreen Direction 130. 131  
 Single vs. Multiple .. 76 CINEMATIC TIME&.SPACE .. 68  
 How to Cross IIS  
 Space .. .....73, 74  
 How to Establish (Dynamic) \_\_94,95 CAMERA ANGLES,\_\_ . 10·65 ..... 68·73  
 Time  
 How to Establish {Static) 109. 110 Angle Plus Angle ..\_...44·47  
 How to Re-Position Player\_\_130, 131 Area .\_\_ 50 CLOSE·UPS ... 172·195  
 Location Interiors .....\_. \_ . 103 Camera Height 35 As Sequence Opener.. ..... 194·195  
 Look on Both Sides of Lens. .. 112 erose-ups 32 Background for . . 193, 194  
 Contrasting .. 50.51 Camera Angles ..... 187·192  
 Matching Looks Descriptive Shots .32.33 Camera Set·Ups ..... 193  
 Group Around Table.. 129 Dramatic Factors .\_. 60 Choice of.,....., .\_\_ 185  
 Master Scene ...\_. ll6 Dutch Tilt Angles 47.48 Choker \_\_\_\_\_ 174  
 Single Player lIO. 118 Editorial Factors 61 Cut-Away \_\_\_\_\_.. 182·185  
 Speaker &.Audience 122·126 Esthetic Factors 58 cct-m \_\_\_\_\_. 177·182  
 Moves With Moving Camera 116 Extreme Long Shot . . 25.26 Extreme ... ..... 174  
 Moves With Moving Players \_116  
 For Printed Matter.,\_, 62 For Player Following  
 Neutral Look 116 For Signs 62 Moving Action ..\_ 102  
 On Corners . 97.98 High Angle 37 For Transition . 195  
 On Curves 96.97  
 How to Change . 54 From Editorial Standpoint .. 173  
 Re-Positioning for Cheat How to Depict ..... 52 From Opposing Angles 190. 191  
 Dynamic 99. 100 How to Employ . 49 From Visual Standpoint . . 173  
 Static \_\_. \_\_ .\_. 130, 131 How to Integrate With Head 174  
 Reverse Shots ..... 132·135 Composition 226.227 Head Movement 191  
 Stock Shots .... 130 How to Select 51 Head & Shoulder.. 174  
 Through Doorways \_\_\_\_\_.. 99 Inserts \_ ,. 32 Howto Position Player in 192  
 Level Angle .. 35 Image Size .\_.187·192  
 ANGLE PLUS ANGLE... 44·47 Long Shot ,... . 26. 27 Look \_ . \_ . 185·187  
 ANGLES.CAMERA Low Angle \_ .. 41 Medium ...\_. \_\_. .... 174  
 SeeCamera Angles Medium Shot . . 27.28 Over-the-Shoulder 175, 176  
 Natural Factors . 61 Player Movement Into & Out of.. 192  
 AREA Objective .. 13 Reaction .. 179  
 Photographed ..... 50

Physical Factors . \_\_. 62 Repetitious . 190. 191

AXIS Point-of-View .. 22 Size 174

SeeAction Axis Problem 63 Tempo . \_ . 192. 193

Progressive 50 To Distract Audience . ... 180

B Psychological Factors 59 To Eliminate Non-Essentials 179

Repetitious 51 To Isolate Significant 179

BACKGROUNDS 231 Scene Requirements \_ 58 To Magnify,... . . 179

For Close-Ups .. 193. 194 Subject Angle .. 34.35 To Provide Time Lapse 179

BALANCE .....207 Subjective \_ 14·21 To Substitute for

Formal \_\_. 210 Subject Size..... 24 Hidden Action . 180. 181

Gravity Influence \_\_ \_ 212 Technical Factors . .... 59 Types of . 177

246

## INDEX

### THE FIVE C's

COMPILATIONCUnING.. \_\_\_\_152 CONTRASTING ANGLES 50.51 D

COMPOSITION \_\_\_\_196-244 CONTROLLED ACTION 74 DESCRIPTIVE SHOTS 32, 33

& Cutting\_ \_ 159

Backgrounds \_\_231-234 COVER SHOTS 164. 165 DIALOGUE, HOW TO MATCH \_\_166.167

Catalog Pictures . \_\_ 238.239 CROSS·CUTTING \_\_\_\_.. 154·157 DIRECTION

Centerof Interest \_\_\_\_214-219 Constant 87.88

EventsOccurring Simultaneously 156

Do's and Don'ts \_\_\_\_\_. \_ 214 Contrasting ...89. 90

Events Separated in Space \_ . 156

Dynamic . \_\_\_\_ 237. 238 Importance of Establishing ..\_... 86

Events Separated in Time \_\_156. 157

Eye Scan... \_\_\_\_219·222 Map . 103

Format Balance . \_\_\_\_\_. \_ 210 How to Use 156 Neutral \_ .....90·92

To Depict Contrast 155

Forms . .. \_ . 203.204

Frame,; . \_\_\_\_234-237 To Heighten Interest 154 DIRECTIONALCONTINUITY

How to Compose in Depth 241.242 To Heighten SUSpense 155 SeeContinuity

Howto Integrate With To Increase Tension ... 155 DISSOLVES

Camera Angles \_\_\_\_226,227 To Make Ccrrncanscns: . 155 How to Use \_\_\_\_\_ 165, 166

Image Size 224 To Provide Conflict ... \_ . 155 Types of.. \_\_\_\_\_ 137, 138

Informal Balance 211

CUT-AWAY CLOSE-UPS 182 DUTCH TILT ANGLES . 47,48

lines 200.201

DoNot Establish 184, 185

Masses 204.205 DYNAMIC COMPOSITION 237,238

For Reaction of

Movements 205.206

With Odd Numbers 212 Off-Screen Player 183 EDITING . .'- 146-171

Perspective .... 227.230 How to Use .\_\_183, 184 Cameraman Can Learn From

Rules \_ 198, 199 Objective \_ 182 Film Editor 170, 171

Simplicity 242, 243 Point-of-View ... 182, 183 Cheat-Cut 148, 189

Still VS.Motion Picture . 198 Subjective 182 Cutting on

Suspenseful ,,,,,,. 238 To Comment 183, 184 Camera Movement 160. 161

To Cue Audience . 183

Types of Balance.... 210 How to Eliminate Jump-Cuts 167-168

To Distract Audience . 184 Protection Shots 164, 165

Umy . 213

To Motivate 184

Variety . 240 Reaction Shots . . 179

To ReplaceGruesome or Shot Arrangement \_\_ 147

COMPOSITIONAL LANGUAGE 200-209 Expensive Scenes 184 Shot Selection \_ 147

Sound Flow . . 167, 168

CONDITIONAL TIME CUT-IN CLOSE-UPS 177-182

Sound Problems ..... 166. 167

Continuity \_ . 72.73 How to Establish 181. 182

Timing .. ... 147

How to Use 179. 180

CONTINUITY 66-145 Objective 177

Bridging Time & Space 136

Over-the-Shoulder 175. 176 E

& Cutting\_\_ \_ 158

Point-of-view .... 178. 179, 182. 183

Conditional Time . 72,73 EDITORIAL REQUIREMENTS 168-170

To Magnify SmallAction ..\_\_ 179

Controlled Action 74 Esthetic ... 169

To Play Up Highlights \_ 179

Narrative 169, 170

Establishing Direction 86 To Provide Time lapse 179, 180  
 Map Direction ..\_\_\_. 103 Technical ...168  
 To Substitute for  
 Master Scene . 75-80  
 Hidden Action ..... 180, 181 ENTRANCES& EXITS \_ \_\_100, 101  
 Master Scene vs. Triple-Take\_\_85,86  
 Screen Direction. Dynamic ..\_.\_\_87-92 CUTTING ..... 146-171 EXTREME CLOSE-UPS . 174  
 Screen Direction, Static .... 109-136 Cameraman Can Learn From 170-171 EXTREME LONG SHOT 25,26  
 Space .. 73,74 & Composition.. 159, 160  
 EYE SCAN \_219-222  
 Time . .. 68-73 Compilation ... 152  
 Time & Space ..\_\_68,74 & Continuity .. 158  
 Transitional Devices ..... 13f).145 Continuity 149 F  
 'rnp-te-Take 80-83 Cross 154 FADES ..\_.\_.. 137  
 Typesof Action \_ 74 Dissolves \_ . \_165, 166  
 Uncontrolled Action 74.75 Editorial Requirements 168-170 FILMING TECHNIQUES. .... 75  
 Master Scene .75-80  
 CONTINUITY CUTTING . 149-152 Loose CameraShots . . 163  
 Multiple Cameras.. \_ \_ 76.85  
 Moving & Static Shots .. 160-161  
 CONTINUITY SPACE .. 73-74 SingleCamera... . 76, 78,86  
 On Action..... 157  
 Triple-Take Technique .80-85  
 CONTINUITYTIME ..... ....68-73 Protection Shots 164, 165  
 Future Time\_\_\_.71, 72 Sound Editing Problems \_\_166, 167 Master Scene V\$. Triple-Take \_85, 86  
 Past Time 69-71 Sound Flow \_ 167,168 FLASHBACK 70  
 Present Time 69 Timing Moving Shots 161-163 Advantages . 70  
 Time & Space \_ . 68,74 Types of\_\_ 149 Disadvantages 70  
 247  
 INDEX  
 THE FIVEC's  
 FLASHFORWARD 72 M ODD NUMBERS,  
 Advantages 72 For Informal Balance 212  
 MAP DIRECTION . 103  
 Disadvantages .\_\_ 72

OVER-THE-SHOULDER

MASSSES .20.4,205

FORMAL BALANCE ...210 CLOSE-UPS ... 175, 176

MASTER SCENE . 75-80

FORMS, COMPOSITIONAL .203, 204 Advantages 77, 78

P

FRAMES 234-238 Disadvantages 79,80

Can Aid Story-Telling.\_\_\_\_\_. 237 For Staged Action 76 PAST-TIME CONTINUITY 69-71

Distinct Separation For Uncontrolled Actton.. 76 PERSPECTIVE 227-230

Necessary . 235,236 Technique 76 Aerial 228

Focus Requirements \_\_ 236 vs Triple-Take Technique 85-86 How to Increase Effects 228-230

Movement 236, 237 With Multiple Cameras 76-80 linear 227

Partial 236 With Single Camera \_ .76-80

PICTORIAL TRANSITIONS 136-142

Pictorial Requirements 235

MATCHING LOOK How to Use \_... 140-142

FUTURE TIME CONTINUITY .71.72 See Look To Bridge Space . . 136

MATCHING SHOTS To Bridge Time 136

G With Master Scene 75-80 With Introductory Titles \_ 136, 137

GRAVITY With Triple-Take Technique ..\_ 80-85 PLANNED SCREEN TRAVEL .. 104-108

Influences Balance 212,213

MEDIUM SHOT 27 PLAYER MOVEMENT INTO

& OUT OF CLOSE-UPS 192

H MONTAGE TRANSITIONS \_ 138-140

HEAD-ON SHOTS 90-92 MOVINGSHOTS PLAYER OBSERVING

MOVING ACTION 102

& Static Shots, How to

HIGH ANGLES 37-40

Inter-Cut 160, 161 POINT-OF-VIEW CAMERA ANGLES\_\_ 22

How to Time.. 161-163

POSITION, CENTER

How to Time to Sync-Sound

OF INTEREST \_\_ 214-219

IMAGE PLACEMENT.\_ 223.224 or Narration 162

IMAGE SIZE\_ ..... 224,225 vs. Straight Cuts .. 162 PRESENT TIME CONTINUITY \_ 69

INFORMAL BALANCE \_ .211 MOVEMENT PROBLEM CAMERA ANGLES.. 63



Camera 160, 161

With Odd Numbers \_ 212 PROGRESSIVECAMERA ANGLES. 50

Into & Out of Close-ups\_\_ . . .192

INSERTS 32 PROTECTION SHOTS 164, 165

MOVEMENTS

INTERIORS, LOCATION 103, 104 Compositional 205, 206

R

L REACTION SHOTS \_ 167

N

LEVEL ANGLES\_\_ 35·37 All Purpose . . . . . 168

NEUTRAL LOOK \_\_\_\_\_ 114, 115 For over-the-shoulder

LINES, COMPOSITIONAL\_\_ 200,201

NEUTRAL SHOTS Close-Ups ... 167,168

LOCATION INTERIORS 103, 104 Enter or Exit Both Sides 91, 92 For Switching

LONG SHOT.. \_\_26, 27 Exit Top or Bottom of Frame\_\_ 91 Screen Direction 102

For Greater Impact 92 REPETITIOUS CAMERA ANGLES 51

LOOK 110-136

For Reversing Screen

How to Match \_ .. 110 Direction 102, 103 RE-POSITIONING ACTION AXIS

How to Match for For Background effect.. 130, 131

For Visual Variety \_ 92

Speaker & Audience 122-126 Head-On & Tail-Away \_ 90 REVERSE SHOTS . 132·136

How to Match with

Single Player 118-121 High or low Angle.. 91 REVERSING SCREEN

How to Track 90, 91 DIRECTION \_\_\_\_\_ 99, 101

How to Match on

lens Covered & uncovered.. 90 On Corners \_ \_\_\_\_\_ 97,98

Master Scene.. \_ 116, 117

To Distract Audience.. 92 On Curves \_ 96

How to Match on

Toward or Away From Lens..... 90·92

Moving Players 116

When to Use . 92

Matching on Group at Table 129, 130 S

NON-THEATRICAL FILMS 76-80

Matching on Stock Shots SCENE, SHOT & SEQUENCE\_ 13

& Production Scenes 130·132 Multiple Cameras 76-80

Neutral .. 114, 115 Single Camera 76·86 SCREEN DIRECTION

Constant ... 87, 88

On Both Sides of Lens 112·114

Contrasting 89,90

O

LOOSE CAMERA SHOTS \_ ... 163,164 Dynamic ... 87·108

LOWANGLES 141·144 OBJECTIVECAMERA ANGLES. 13 How to Plan 104·107

248

THE FIVE C's INDEX

How to Reverse ....96·99. 101 SPACE, HOWTO BRIDGE. ,...136 THREEPLAYERS,

Neutral 90-92 ACTION AXIS 126·129

STATICSCREEN DIRECTION ... 109·136

Static . .... 109·133 Matching look 110-112 TIME&.SPACECONTINUITY 68-74

SEQUENCEOPENER TIMECONTINUITY 68·73

STATIC SHOTS

CLOSE-UP 194. 195

& MOVING SHOTS 160, 161 TIME

SOUND EDITING PROBLEMS. 166. 167 How to Bridge \_ \_\_, .136

STILL COMPOSITION .. 198

SOUND FLOW.. 167.168 TIME& SPACE

SUBJECT ANGLE \_\_\_\_\_ \_ 34. 35 How to Bridge 136

SOUND TRANSITIONS 142·145

How to Introduce 142·145 SUBJECT SIZE 214 TIMING MOVING SHOTS 161-163

How to Segue 144 SUBJECTIVE CAMERA ANGLES .. 14·21 TRANSITIONS 136·145

Monologue ... 143 Appropriate 145

Narration 142. 145 SUSPENSEFUL COMPOSITION 238 Montage 138·140

To BridgeMovement .. 144,145 SYNC·SOUND EDITING 166·168 Pictorial 136-142

To Bridge Space . 144, 145 Sound .142·145

To Bridge Time 143. 144

T

With Music . 144 U

With Rad.c & Television 144 TAIL-AWAY SHOTS . \_.....•..90-92

UNITY \_\_. 213

With Sound Effects .. . 144

## TELEVISION FILMS

With Telephone . . 144 Multiple cameras.. 76.BO V

SPACE CONTINUITY 73.74 Single Camera 76 VARIETY, COMPOSITION 240

249